Strategy | Content | SEO + AI Search | Paid Media | Social | Email | Video | Conversion | Local | Analytics

SECOND EDITION

Business Transformation

Through AI-Powered Marketing

The Field Guide for Small Businesses and Marketing Teams

Mike Huber
with Loren Ankarlo

Second edition of *Business Transformation Through Digital Marketing*

Business Transformation Through AI-Powered Marketing

The Field Guide for Small Businesses and Marketing Teams

SECOND EDITION OF *BUSINESS TRANSFORMATION THROUGH DIGITAL MARKETING*

Mike Huber
with Loren Ankarlo

REVIEW DRAFT

Thank you for reading.

This is the updated designed draft of the second edition (October 7). Your comments will shape the final book.

New in this update. The book is now in its final order: 25 chapters, each with its own color-coded Field Guide. Keywords now follows SEO and AI Search, to match the website. Two new chapters are reserved and being written: Chapter 15, AI and Your CRM, and Chapter 17, SMS and Text Messaging. Two more are new since the last draft: Chapter 18, Keep, Grow and Get Referred (retention, loyalty and referrals), and Chapter 23, Marketing Within the Rules (privacy, consent and compliance). Every cross-reference has been updated to the new chapter numbers.

Also new. Chapters 5, 8 and 13 cover the FTC rule on fake reviews. Chapter 16 has a Texting rules box. Chapter 22, Leading People Through Change (formerly Business Tools), opens with Loren's section on leading through the AI revolution. Every chapter opens with the first edition's opener style: the big chapter word, a question, and a box showing what's in the chapter and where AI helps.

What you're looking at. Every chapter in its final order and design. A few things are still in progress:

- To come marks information we're still gathering, such as case study results.
- Dashed boxes mark graphics that will be built for the final layout.
- Photos, page numbers and some charts will change in the final version.

What helps most. Anything that's unclear, wrong or missing. Where a chapter drags or where it moves too fast. Any example or story from your own experience that would make a point stronger.

How to comment. Mark up this PDF, or send notes by page number to Mike Huber.

PLACEHOLDER · FROM THE FIRST EDITION
These endorsements were written for the first edition. Ask each person to approve reuse on the 2nd edition, or for a fresh quote after they read the review draft.

PRAISE

Fist bumps.

"A terrific overview of the many pieces of the puzzle, the workbook elements of Business Transformation Through Digital Marketing make it incredibly practical and useful!"

Jay Baer · best-selling author of The Time To Win and Hall of Fame Keynote Speaker

"In today's fast-paced, attention-scarce digital landscape, I specialize in helping businesses craft compelling, binge-worthy videos that drive revenue growth. Mike has masterfully translated this concept into the pages of his book, offering a visually-rich experience packed with images, charts, graphics, lists, and expert insights. Whether you prefer a quick skim, selective skipping, or a deep-dive approach, you'll find 'build-book' forms that guide you through creating a robust digital marketing strategy, covering content marketing, video production, optimization, promotion, and all facets of modern marketing. I wholeheartedly recommend this book to any marketer aiming to unlock exponential revenue growth."

Todd Hartley · Author of the #1 Bestseller Accelerating YES! and a Tony Robbins Business Mastery Faculty Speaker

"Whether a neophyte at a start-up in a small business, or an advanced digital marketing professional, these practical tools, templates, timelines and techniques will align your team strategically and tactically to achieve desired results. You have operationalized years of consulting and agency work into a comprehensive "how-to" resource manual, replete with analytics and eye-popping statistics."

Orville Ankarlo · Former President & CEO, Riviera, Inc. (International Eyewear Wholesaler)

"This book is a great tool for companies seeking to enhance their marketing in today's competitive media markets. The book has easy to understand plans and realistic approaches that all organizations can use."

T.J. Cole, JD, PhD

"In the complicated world of digital marketing with more perilous rabbit holes than Alice in Wonderland, Mike's step-by-step approach makes it easy to keep you and your budget out of harm's way. Business Transformation Through Digital Marketing is a must addition to your How To library."

Park Howell · Founder of The Business of Story

"This is a marketing agency in a book. A clear step-by-step guide to success."

Jim McCloskey · President, American Real Estate College, LLC

"Mike Huber's Business Transformation Through Digital Marketing is an invaluable gem for anyone seeking to conquer the digital realm. This interactive workbook is a masterclass in crafting a winning digital marketing strategy, brimming with practical exercises and insightful guidance. The incorporation of numerous helpful graphics elevates the learning experience, making it engaging and easy to grasp complex concepts. Huber's expertise shines through, making this an indispensable tool for businesses aiming to stay ahead in this competitive market."

Arnie Kuenn · CEO, Vertical Measures

"Business Transformation is an immersive workbook, perfect as a follow-up to The Customer Journey (2019). It lives up to its title, distilling Mike's decades of experience in traditional advertising and digital marketing. This book is granular in its detail and nuts-and-bolts in its practical efficacy. It presents a roadmap for devising successful digital marketing campaigns based on wide-ranging, real-world, heuristic case studies. Mike's native talent shines in deconstructing a complex mosaic of disparate concepts and describing concisely and clearly the prerequisites for achieving quantifiable, targeted goals. Key among them are recognizing the tripwires of one's own unique marketing challenges and tailoring strategies to user expectations and predictive behavior. This book is an essential reference."

John Rehfeld · MBA Professor, USD and Pepperdine

PLACEHOLDER · FROM THE FIRST EDITION
Updated for 2026 from the first edition's "Legal Mumbo-Jumbo" page. Add the new ISBNs and Library of Congress number.

LEGAL MUMBO-JUMBO

Business Transformation Through AI-Powered Marketing
The Field Guide for Small Businesses and Marketing Teams
Second Edition of *Business Transformation Through Digital Marketing*

Published by Huber & Associates, Inc., Hollywood, South Carolina

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Using the interactive PDF: Open it in Adobe Acrobat Reader (free at get.adobe.com/reader) so totals and scores calculate automatically. Other PDF apps, including Mac Preview and web browsers, let you type in the fields but may not calculate.

Also by Mike Huber: *The Customer Journey: How an Owned Audience Can Transform Your Business* (2019); *Business Transformation Through Digital Marketing* (2023)

Author links: mikehuber.com · mike@mikehuber.com · Loren Ankarlo's contact (confirm)

The companion workbook, templates and printables are free at mikehuber.com/book.

Review draft, October 2026. Not for distribution.

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PLACEHOLDER · FROM THE FIRST EDITION
From the first edition's introduction and "We're Here To Help!" pages. Update the wording for the AI edition.

WELCOME

This book meets you where you are.

In the digital marketing space, every organization finds itself at a unique point on a continuum. Some marketers are beginners, taking their first steps, while others have already gained valuable experience and seek to elevate their efforts to the next level.

Wherever you stand on your continuum, this book is designed to meet you where you are. It offers a wealth of information and insights that you can tailor to your specific needs, goals and aspirations. Whether you choose to dive in and implement everything or selectively focus on certain areas, the choice is yours.

One thing is certain: embarking on a digital marketing transformation requires making crucial real-time decisions. Restructuring, talent acquisition, process management, accountability, training, budgeting, and more will be on your agenda. Along the way, you will encounter conflicts, face setbacks, and experience fits and starts. However, rest assured that the journey will be well worth the effort as you transform your marketing department and your organization.

We're here to help

As you embark on your journey of business transformation, our collaboration as authors brings together a fusion of skills. One author brings 25+ years of hands-on experience in digital marketing. The other brings 35+ years of expertise in orchestrating organizational change, training leaders, and cultivating high-performing, self-directed teams.

Our combined skill set isn't just about knowledge; it's about empowerment. We can demystify complex marketing strategies and guide you through the intricacies of change management. Our aim is not just to provide information, but to be your partners in transformation: harnessing the potential of new tools, including AI, training your leaders and team members to adapt and thrive, and providing consulting rooted in a deep understanding of both the technology and the human dynamics of change.

This book is more than a manual. It's our commitment to be your mentors, facilitators and partners throughout this transformative journey.

PLACEHOLDER · FROM THE FIRST EDITION
Mike's bio from his 2026 CV and speaker bio. Loren's bio from his author insert and resume (Oct 7).

ABOUT THE AUTHORS

About the authors.

Mike Huber

Mike Huber is a digital marketing strategist, speaker, trainer and author with more than 25 years in marketing and advertising. He began in newspaper advertising, where he built The Arizona Republic's online sales division and managed accounts generating more than $48 million a year. He went on to serve as VP of Sales and Marketing at Alliance Reservations Network, Director of Client Services at Vertical Measures, where he led a team of 30, and Director of Strategy and Education at Investis Digital, where he doubled average new-client revenue.

Through Huber & Associates, Inc., Mike helps organizations put digital marketing, content, SEO, video and generative AI to work. He has been using AI in marketing for more than four years, and he brings that hands-on experience to every session.

For more than 15 years he has spoken at events including Digital Summit, Content Marketing World and AMA Phoenix. He has taught as a guest lecturer in MBA marketing programs at UC San Diego and Hult International Business School, and trained teams at organizations such as the United States Marine Corps, John Deere and Medtronic.

Mike is the lead author of *The Customer Journey: How an Owned Audience Can Transform Your Business* (2019) and the author, with Loren Ankarlo, of *Business Transformation Through Digital Marketing* (2023). He holds a B.S. in Business Administration from the University of Arizona.

Loren Ankarlo

Loren Ankarlo leads leaders to turn strategic alignment into coordinated action. His consulting, facilitation and training focus on organizational transformation, how to coach teams, leadership development, communication and conflict resolution.

His CareerTrack programs include *Implementing Self-Directed Work Teams*, *9 Traits of Highly Successful Work Teams* and *Managing Today's Nonprofit*. He has also written private-label training and field books for IBM, McDonald's, Olive Garden, the Department of Defense and universities.

Loren is the co-author, with Mike, of *Business Transformation Through Digital Marketing* (2023), and contributes the people and change-management perspective to this second edition. He is based in Colorado.

START HERE

Are you ready to transform?

In this chapter »

Read it. Build it. Then let AI help you move faster.

— **HOW TO USE THIS FIELD GUIDE**
Read it, build it, then let AI help you move faster

— **WHAT'S CHANGED SINCE 2023**
AI, search and buyers have all moved. Here is what it means for you

— **PEOPLE, PROCESS AND PLATFORMS**
What to expect, and the AI ground rules for your team

— **THE SIX STAGES**
Success won't happen overnight: Foundation to Ongoing

— **REVIEWS AND ALIGNMENT**
Quarterly business reviews, and getting sales and marketing on one team

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
10 AI Tips, from sorting your problems into focus areas to building your six-quarter roadmap

How to Use This Field Guide

This book doesn't just tell you what to do. It makes you do it. Every chapter ends with exercises, and by the last page you'll have a working digital marketing strategy, a set of tactics and a plan to put them in motion. You'll also have a plan for the people side: how your leaders will lead the change, how your team will build new skills, including AI, and how you'll keep everyone moving in the same direction.

In the first edition, the process had two steps: read the chapter, then fill in the blanks. This edition adds a third step, and it changes everything.

STEP 1

Read

Each chapter gives you the background, the best practices and the real-world lessons behind a tactic. These are the methods we've used for more than 25 years to grow traffic and revenue for clients across dozens of business categories.

STEP 2

Build

Fill in the form fields. Use the interactive PDF in Adobe Acrobat, or write directly in the printed book. Your answers are the raw material of your plan: your goals, your customers, your competitors, your strengths. Look for the shaded boxes: every one is yours to write in, or to type in on the interactive PDF.

STEP 3

Accelerate with AI

This is the new part. The answers you write in this field guide are exactly what an AI assistant needs to do good work for you. Generic prompts get generic answers. Prompts loaded with your goals, your personas and your data get answers that sound like they came from someone who knows your business. Each chapter gives you AI Tips with ready-to-use prompt templates that turn your field guide answers into first drafts, analyses and action plans.

You think. AI drafts. You decide.

We call this the **Field Guide + AI loop**. The thinking and the deciding stay with you. AI handles the heavy lifting in between.

Tools for working through change. Everything you need to transform your business is in this book, including business facilitation tools, drawn from Loren Ankarlo's change-management work, to help you and your team work through change. If you're serious about your transformation, you will run into conflict. Some stakeholders will slow-walk the change to protect the status quo. Some team members will be fearful. Processes will need to be created, adapted, optimized and some even eliminated. From Frustration to Success, later in this chapter, shows you how to lead through it.

Copy the templates, then make them yours. Every table and worksheet in this book is also in the companion workbook, an Excel file you can download, open in Google Sheets or copy straight into an AI prompt. Totals, budgets and assessment scores calculate automatically. One caution: the templates are a structure, not a

strategy. They only work once you replace the examples with your own goals, numbers, customers and competitors. Download it free at mikehuber.com/book: fill in a short form and the workbook and resource bundle are yours.

↓ Companion workbook and resource bundle

Bought the printed book? The interactive PDF is yours too. Fill it in on screen, and the totals and scores calculate for you. Go to marketingfieldguide.ai/pdf and enter the code printed on the copyright page.

Two ways to use this book

In the first edition, we said you could dive in and do everything, or focus on the areas you need. That's still true. This edition makes the second path easier.

The full transformation. Work through every chapter in order. You'll set your strategy, check your skills and see where you stand, then work through the channels, and finish with measurement, priorities and a plan your team can run. The six stages in the Transformation chapter spread the work over about 18 months.

What this book doesn't cover, and why. Radio, TV, newspapers, magazines, billboards, direct mail and events are all viable ways to market a business. We chose to focus on digital marketing because that's where AI is changing the work the most, and where a small business can measure every dollar. Traditional media works best when it's connected to digital: a short web address, a tracked phone number, a page built for that audience. Chapter 12 shows how, channel by channel.

Pick your focus areas. Every chapter stands on its own. Start with the problem you need to solve, find it in the table below, and use those chapters first. Come back for the rest when you need them.

Whichever path you choose, do two things first. Set the ground rules in this chapter, and write at least a one-year goal and a description of your ideal customer (Strategy). Every other chapter assumes you know what you're aiming for and who you're selling to. Without them, the AI Tips have nothing to work with.

IF THIS SOUNDS LIKE YOU	START WITH THESE CHAPTERS
We don't have a plan, or everyone has a different one	Strategy; SWOT and the OODA Loop; Ranked Scoring
We're not sure our team has the skills, especially for AI	Skills; Leading People Through Change
Buyers can't find us on Google or in AI answers	SEO and AI Search; Keywords
We serve a local area and lose to competitors down the street	Local SEO and Reviews
We publish content, but nothing happens	Content; Hub and Spoke; Social Media and Distribution; Video
We spend on ads and can't tell if they work	Paid Media and Promotion; Measurement and Analytics
We get traffic, but not enough leads	Website and Conversion; The Customer Journey
Leads come in, but they don't become customers	Lead Nurture; The Customer Journey
We can't tell what's working	Measurement and Analytics

IF THIS SOUNDS LIKE YOU	START WITH THESE CHAPTERS
We have too many ideas and not enough time or money	Ranked Scoring; Transformation
The team is resisting the change	Leading People Through Change
We're ready to build AI into how we work	Skills (the AI fluency ladder); Leading People Through Change (AI usage policy and AI agents); the AI Tips in every chapter

Our focus areas: the three problems we'll solve first, and the chapters we'll use. [FORM FIELD]

PRO TIP

Fix the leak before you add water. If leads already come in and go nowhere, start with Lead Nurture and your website before you spend more on traffic. And pick no more than three focus areas at a time.

AI TIP

Not sure where to start? Let AI sort your problems into focus areas

```
Context: Our business: [what you sell, to whom, where]. Our one-year goal: [paste it]. The problems we're dealing with: [list them in your own words]. The chapters in this book: Strategy; Skills; SWOT and the OODA Loop; The Customer Journey; SEO and AI Search; Local SEO and Reviews; Content; Hub and Spoke; Video; Paid Media and Promotion; Social Media and Distribution; Website and Conversion; Keywords; Lead Nurture; Measurement and Analytics; Ranked Scoring; Transformation; Leading People Through Change.

Role: Act as a marketing consultant helping a small business decide where to focus first.

Ask: Group our problems by root cause and recommend the three chapters we should work through first.

Format: A table with the problem, the likely root cause, the chapter to start with and why. Then a one-paragraph recommendation.

Tighten: Favor fixes closest to revenue. Ask me up to three questions before you recommend.
```

A real business, in real time

In *The Customer Journey* (2019), we followed Sophia, a fictional student, as she chose a university for her MBA. This book takes a different approach. Our examples come from real businesses.

The one you'll see most often is Wild West Custom Pools, a custom pool builder in the Austin, Texas, metro area. The owner, Dan Huber, is a client and also my younger brother. That makes it easy to share the whole story, including the numbers most clients would rather keep private (Chapter 4 explains more). In June 2026, we started applying the tools in this book to his business with AI: competitor research, a new position in the market, a SWOT analysis, a new website and an advertising plan. You'll see that work in the chapters where it fits.

This isn't a book about pools, and it isn't a book about Dan. Wild West is simply a real business going through the same steps you are, and it was available to us. Where it doesn't fit a topic, we use other public examples.

Because it's real, the story has gaps. Some work isn't finished. Some results aren't in yet. Some things haven't been tried. We don't fill those gaps with made-up numbers. Where we have real results, we show them. Where we don't, we say so and show what we'd recommend. That's what a transformation looks like while it's happening, and it's what yours will look like too.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

The Field Guide + AI loop — Read → Build → Accelerate with AI → Decide → back to Build

Let's Get Started

Where do you see your organization one year from now? In your preferred future state, what will be different? For example: "Increase revenue by 30% within 18 months, with 40% of new leads coming from organic search and AI search."

YOUR TURN

What Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) do you need to track to measure the success of your transformation, and what targets will you set for each?

Where is your team on AI today? Check the one that fits best.

- ☐ We haven't started
- ☐ A few of us experiment with ChatGPT or similar tools on our own
- ☐ We use AI regularly for some tasks, but there's no shared process
- ☐ AI is built into our workflows, with guidelines and shared prompts

PRO TIP

Write your answers before you open an AI tool. AI is a great editor of your thinking and a poor substitute for it. If you let it answer "where do we want to be in a year," you'll get a plan for an average company — not yours.

AI TIP

Once you've filled in your one-year goal and KPIs, paste them into your AI assistant with this prompt:

```
Context: Our one-year goal: [paste your answer]. The KPIs and targets we chose: [paste your answer].
Our business: [one or two sentences on what you sell, to whom, and your annual marketing budget].

Role: Act as a senior digital marketing strategist reviewing a client's goals.

Ask: Evaluate whether these KPIs actually measure progress toward the goal.

Format: (1) Targets that look unrealistic for a business our size. (2) KPIs that are vanity metrics.
(3) Important measures we're missing. (4) Your recommended changes.

Tighten: Ask me up to five questions before you give your final recommendations.
```

WHAT'S CHANGED SINCE 2023

Five things changed. One thing didn't.

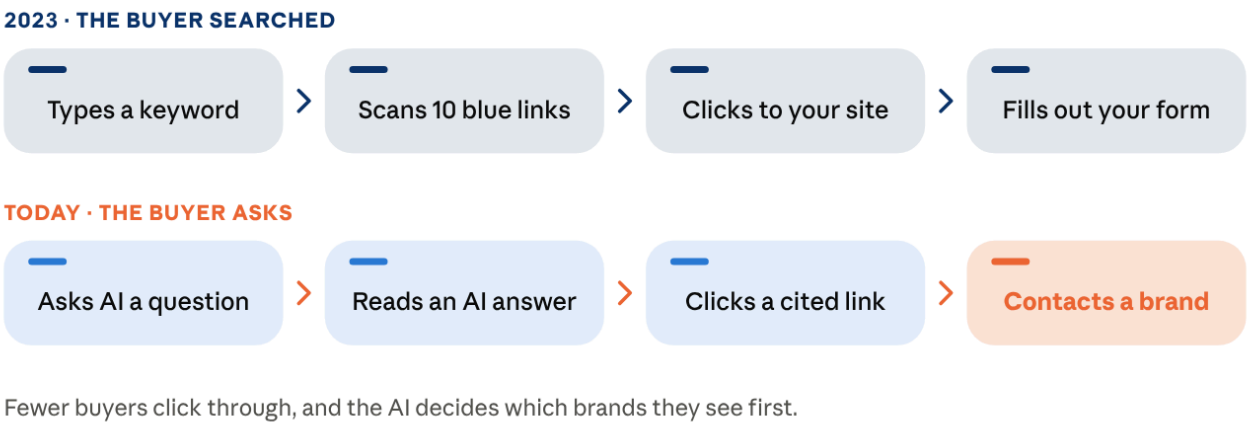
Search, content, advertising, AI and measurement all moved since the first edition. Strategy still comes first.

> **Assume this is the worst AI you will ever use.**
>
> — Ethan Mollick, Co-Intelligence (2024)

When we wrote the first edition, AI was a promising set of tools on the side of your marketing. Today it sits between your business and your buyers. Here's what changed, and where this book addresses it.

Buyers now ask AI before they reach your website.

How a buyer finds a business, then and now.



Fewer buyers click through, and the AI decides which brands they see first.

how a buyer finds a business · 2023 vs. today

Search became a conversation. At Google I/O in May 2026, Google said its AI Overviews reach more than 2.5 billion people a month and that AI Mode passed 1 billion monthly users in its first year (Google I/O 2026 recap). ChatGPT reported 900 million weekly users in February 2026 (user data roundup). Many buyers now get an answer without clicking any link. Ranking still matters, but being cited and recommended by AI matters too. → *SEO, Keywords and Content chapters, plus a new chapter on AI search visibility.*

Content got cheap. Trust got expensive. Anyone can generate a thousand blog posts with AI, so the internet is flooded with average content. Google's guidance is to reward helpful content no matter how it's produced, and the content that stands out shows real experience: original data, customer stories and expert opinion. → *Content and Hub and Spoke chapters.*

Ad platforms automated themselves. Google's Performance Max and Meta's Advantage+ campaigns use AI to choose audiences, placements and creative. Your job shifted from pulling levers to feeding the machine good inputs: strong creative, clean conversion data and clear goals. → *Paid Media and Promotion chapter.*

AI started doing, not just answering. AI agents can now research, compare options and take actions such as booking appointments, filling forms and running multi-step workflows. Your website and data need to work for these agents as well as for people. → *New section on AI agents in the Leading People Through Change chapter.*

Measurement changed. Google retired Universal Analytics in 2023, and privacy changes keep shrinking what platforms can track. First-party data — the email list, CRM and customer relationships you own — is worth more than ever. → *Measurement and Lead Nurture chapters.*

What hasn't changed: strategy still comes first. Knowing your customer, mapping their journey and creating something genuinely useful are still the foundation. AI rewards businesses that do the fundamentals well and exposes the ones that don't.

AI TIP

See how AI describes your business today

```
I'm a [type of buyer] in [city or region] looking for [your product or service].

Which companies would you recommend, and why?
```

Run this in two or three AI assistants, such as ChatGPT, Gemini and Perplexity. Then ask each: "What do you know about [your company name]?" Record the results below. You'll use them as your baseline in the SEO chapter.

AI ASSISTANT	WERE WE MENTIONED?	COMPETITORS MENTIONED	WHAT IT SAID ABOUT US

WHAT TO EXPECT

Transformation moves on three wheels.

People, process and platforms have to move together. Pull on one without the others and nothing moves.

"People, ideas, hardware — in that order."

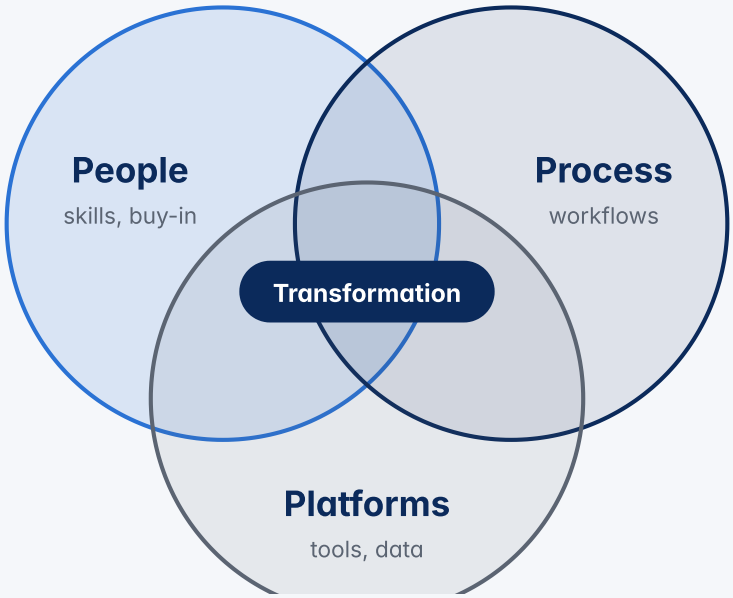
COLONEL JOHN BOYD

quoted in Robert Coram, Boyd: The Fighter Pilot Who Changed the Art of War (2002)

A digital marketing transformation changes your marketing, and in the process, it changes your organization. Success depends on three things moving together: your people, your processes and your platforms. Pull on one without the others and nothing moves.

People, process and platforms.

Transformation happens where all three overlap.



People — expect conflict. Change is hard, and some resistance is guaranteed. Some stakeholders will slow-walk the change to protect the status quo. **And some of your team will be afraid.** Many will wonder, quietly or out loud, whether AI is coming for their jobs. That fear is reasonable: AI will change roles. Don't wait for people to ask. Honest communication, real investment in training and visible buy-in from leadership are your best tools. From Frustration to Success, later in this chapter, shows you how.

Process — expect to rebuild workflows. You'll need clear processes for content creation, SEO and AI search, social media, paid media, email and lead nurture, local listings and reviews, and analytics. AI raises the stakes here. A team that bolts AI onto broken processes just produces more mediocre work, faster. The win comes from

redesigning a workflow with AI built in: who drafts, who reviews, who approves and what the AI is and isn't allowed to do.

Platforms — expect to consolidate before you add. Most teams we audit are paying for tools they barely use. Before you buy anything new, list what you already have. Your CRM, email platform, website builder and design tools have likely added AI features since you bought them. Use those first.

Team building ties it together. Identify the skills you need — strategy, content, SEO and AI search, paid media, social media, email and marketing automation, video, website and conversion optimization, local SEO and reviews, and analytics, with AI fluency running across all of them — then decide whether to train, hire or outsource. Paid media often calls for specialist help: the ad platforms change constantly, and mistakes cost real money every day they run. The new skill on everyone's list is working well with AI: briefing it, checking its work and knowing when not to use it. Build a culture of collaboration and continuous learning so your team adapts as the tools keep changing.

PRO TIP

Name an owner for every process before you launch it. "Marketing will handle it" means nobody will. Use the RACI model (Responsible, Accountable, Consulted, Informed) in the Leading People Through Change chapter.

AI TIP

Audit your tool stack before you buy anything new

Turn on web search before you run this prompt. Without it, the AI may rely on out-of-date training data for what each tool can do today.

```
Context: The marketing and sales software we pay for, with the monthly cost of each: [paste list]. Our team size: [number]. Our main marketing activities: [list].

Role: Act as a marketing technology advisor for a business our size.

Ask: Audit our tool stack before we buy anything new.

Format: For each tool: (1) the AI features it has added in the last two years, (2) any tools whose functions overlap, (3) keep, consolidate or cancel, with the reason. Then (4) gaps: free tools we should try before buying anything new.

Tighten: If any monthly costs are missing, ask me for them before you decide. Note anything you're unsure about so I can verify it with the vendor.
```

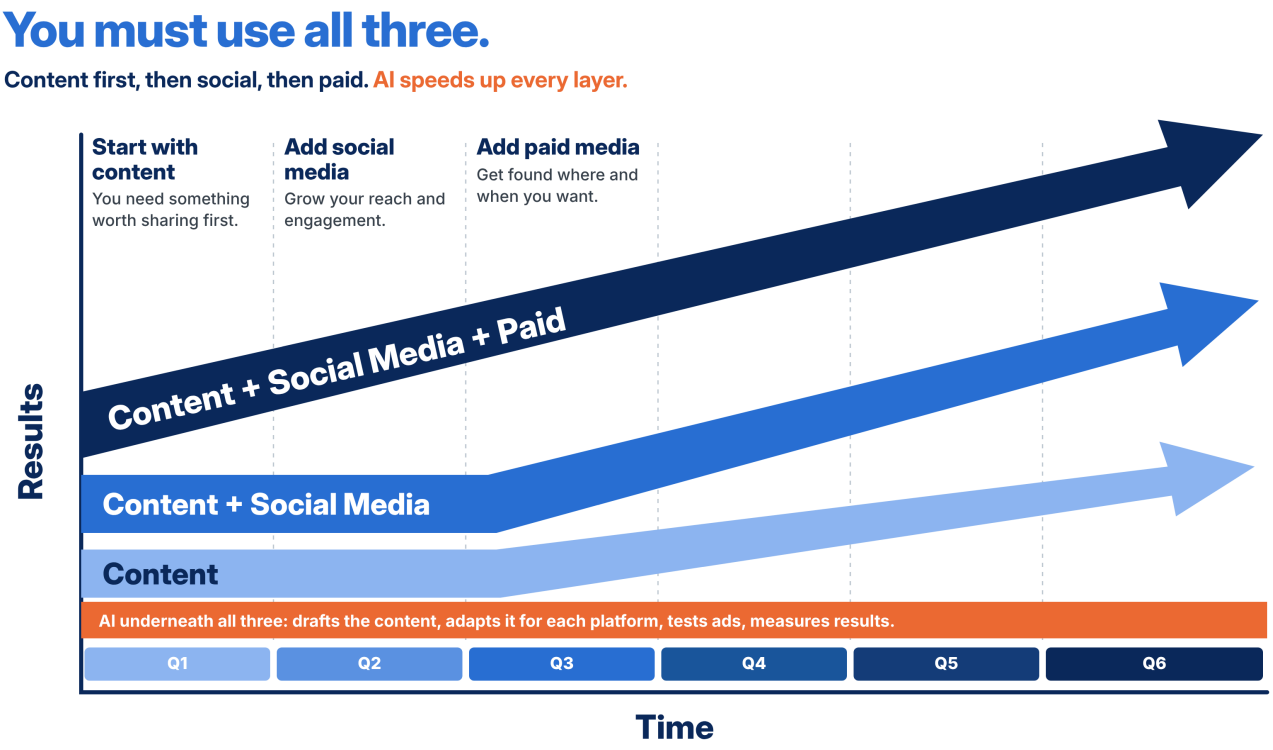
Note: AI assistants can be out of date on product features. Treat the answer as a checklist to verify, not a final verdict.

You must use all three

Content, social media and paid media work best together, and in that order.

- **Start with content.** You need something worth sharing before social media or paid media can do anything for you. Content is the fuel.
- **Add social media** to grow your reach and build engagement with your target audience.
- **Add paid media** to get your content found where and when you want, by the people most likely to buy.

Each one multiplies the others. Content alone grows slowly. Content shared on social media grows faster. Content shared on social media and promoted with paid media grows fastest. It's the same order you'll follow in the six stages later in this chapter, and AI now runs underneath all three: helping you create the content, target the audience and measure the results.



WORKING WITH AI

Better prompts start with five letters.

Most disappointing AI output comes from a thin prompt. Every prompt in this book follows the CRAFT framework.

"You must choose. But choose wisely."

THE GRAIL KNIGHT
Indiana Jones and the Last Crusade (1989)

In the first edition, this page was a list of about 70 AI tools. Since then, a number of them have pivoted, rebranded or been overtaken by the big AI assistants. That's the lesson: tools change every quarter, but the skill of working with AI doesn't. This section teaches the skill. The tools live in **Appendix A: Choosing the Right AI**, which we keep current on the book's website.

The CRAFT prompt framework

Most disappointing AI output comes from a thin prompt. Picture handing a new agency hire a one-line brief and expecting a finished campaign. Every prompt in this book follows five parts:

LETTER	STANDS FOR	WHAT TO INCLUDE	EXAMPLE
C	Context	Your business, audience, goals and data — usually pasted from your field guide answers	"We're a residential roofing company in Denver. Our buyers are homeowners aged 35–65..."
R	Role	Who the AI should act as	"Act as a senior SEO strategist."
A	Ask	One clear task	"Write ten blog topics that answer questions buyers ask before choosing a roofer."
F	Format	The shape of the answer	"A table with topic, target question and journey stage."
T	Tighten	Your follow-up instructions after the first draft	"Cut the generic ones. Make three of them about insurance claims."

The last step matters most. Treat the first answer as a first draft from a fast junior employee. Push back, ask for alternatives and tell it what's wrong. Two or three rounds of tightening is normal.

How to use an AI Tip

Every AI Tip in this book is a CRAFT prompt, ready to use. Words in **[blue brackets]** are yours to replace.

1. **Fill in the field guide first.** The best answers come from your own facts, so most tips ask you to paste in answers you've already written.
2. **Copy the prompt into your AI assistant.** In the interactive PDF, select the prompt text and copy it. With the paperback, copy it from the prompt library download instead of retyping it.
3. **Replace every [bracket] with your details.** Delete any you can't fill rather than leaving them in. The more specific you are, the better the answer.
4. **Take out anything confidential,** such as customer names or private financial data, unless your AI usage policy and the tool's settings allow it.
5. **Treat the first answer as a draft.** Use Tighten: push back, ask for options and correct what's wrong.
6. **Check the facts, then decide.** You think, AI drafts, you decide.
7. **Save what works** in your prompt library, later in this chapter.

↓ The AI Tip prompt library: every AI Tip in the book

Choose the right AI for the job

No single AI is best at everything. Some are strongest at long-form writing and analyzing large documents. Others are better at live web research with citations, image and video creation, or working inside tools you already use, like Microsoft 365 and Google Workspace. Appendix A matches common marketing tasks to the AI that handles them best.

How we used AI to update this book

We updated this edition the way we're asking you to work. We did the thinking, AI did much of the drafting and checking, and we made the decisions.

As we rebuilt each chapter, we had AI read the first edition page by page and check it the way a sharp editor would: every chapter, worksheet and scoring table. It found problems we had missed in our own editing:

- **Typos.** Small errors we'd read past more than once, like "Putttting," "comarisons" and "aready," and a glossary definition that repeated its own words.
- **Math and scoring errors.** A keyword worksheet showed a ".02%" opportunity that should have been 2%. A change-styles assessment had a scoring band no one could land in. A ranked scoring matrix contradicted its own instructions.
- **Duplicate content.** A conversion checklist repeated the paid media deliverables, and a measurement chapter asked the same question twice.
- **Inconsistencies.** One term had two different definitions in the same chapter, and a planning matrix used different stages than the chapter it was built on.
- **Outdated facts.** Statistics from studies more than a decade old, and a list of about 70 AI tools that aged faster than anything else in the book.
- **Quotes we couldn't trace.** Several are widely repeated online, but we couldn't find where the person actually said them. We cut them or put the idea in our own words.

AI changed how we did the research. When we wrote the first edition, much of the background behind a statistic, a survey or a business model was hard to find with ordinary web searches. We'd often see a number repeated on dozens of sites and never find where it came from. This time, we could ask AI direct questions: Who ran this study? When? How many people did it survey? Has it been updated? Is there newer research? The answers were more complete and came with links to the original sources. That's how we traced the Three Horizons model back to its original 1999 source and found McKinsey's 2026 version for AI (Chapter 21), and how we replaced a 2011 study on lead response time with one from 2026 (Chapter 16).

AI also helped us draft new sections and build the companion workbook. The first edition took six months to write. This edition took one week to reach a first draft. Updating it by hand would have taken another six months, and the result wouldn't have been as good. Realistically, AI saved us months.

It made mistakes of its own, too, which is why every fact in this book was checked against its original source. The PRO TIP below shows what that looks like. That's the loop this book teaches: you think, AI drafts, you decide.

Ground rules for using AI in your marketing

These apply to every AI Tip in the book. They're the short version of an AI usage policy, and your team needs one before anyone uses AI on real work.

1. **A human approves everything that goes public.** AI drafts; people publish.

2. **Verify facts, numbers and quotes.** AI can state wrong information with total confidence.
3. **Protect sensitive data.** Don't paste customer lists, financials or confidential information into an AI tool until you've checked its data and privacy settings. Business plans usually offer stronger protections than free accounts.
4. **Keep your voice.** Give the AI samples of your best writing and a short brand voice guide. Edit until it sounds like you.
5. **Add what AI can't.** Your experience, your customer stories and your opinions are what make content worth reading — and worth ranking.

Do this first: write your AI usage policy. Don't wait until you reach the Leading People Through Change chapter (Chapter 22) near the end of the book. Turn to its AI usage policy template now, fill it in with your team and agree on it this quarter. It answers the questions your team is already asking: which tools are approved, what data stays out of AI, who reviews AI-assisted work before it goes public and how AI will change their jobs. Agreeing on it up front prevents the mistakes that are hardest to undo, like confidential data pasted into a free tool or AI content published without review.

↓ AI usage policy template

PRO TIP

Check the source, not the summary. While updating this book, we asked an AI search tool for the latest data on how AI answers affect clicks. It returned four statistics, each with a source. When we opened the original reports, two of the four were credited wrongly. One figure was attributed to a university study but came from an agency's report. Another combined two older studies into a range that neither one reported. Researchers at Washington University in St. Louis found the same problem in Google's AI Overviews: about 11% of the claims they checked weren't supported by the sources cited, or contradicted them (WashU, 2026). Before a number goes into anything you publish, open the original source and find it there. The Keywords chapter (Chapter 7) has another example: a popular statistic that an AI tool credited to the wrong study, and that the original researchers' own update no longer supports.

Your prompt library

The best teams save prompts that work and share them. Start yours here, and add to it as you work through the book.

TASK	PROMPT THAT WORKED	AI USED	NOTES

PRO TIP

Use AI where you lack resources and skills. It's easy to go down the rabbit hole and waste weeks learning tools you'll never use. Start with one or two tasks that eat the most time each week.

PRO TIP

Pick one AI assistant as your team's default and get good at it before you add more. Depth beats breadth.

AI TIP

Let AI find your best opportunities to use AI

```
Context: How our marketing team spends a typical week, by person and task: [list each person, their main tasks and rough hours per task].

Role: Act as a marketing operations consultant.

Ask: Identify the five tasks where AI could save the most time without hurting quality.

Format: For each task: how AI would fit into the workflow, what a human must still review, and the estimated hours saved per week. Rank them from easiest to hardest to implement.

Tighten: Be realistic about our team's skills. Flag any task where AI could hurt quality or put customer data at risk.
```

FROM FRUSTRATION TO SUCCESS

It gets harder before it gets better.

Every transformation follows the same emotional curve. Knowing that ahead of time is half the battle.

“The best way out is always through.”

ROBERT FROST
"A Servant to Servants" (1914)

Every transformation we've led has followed the same emotional pattern. Knowing the pattern in advance won't make the hard parts painless, but it will keep your team from mistaking a normal dip for failure.

The transformation curve.

Excitement, then the dip, then momentum. Expect all five stages.



1. Excitement and learning. Everyone is eager. Teams attend training, test new tools and absorb new ideas. With AI, this phase often comes with a burst of experiments: everyone tries a chatbot and shares the funniest result in Slack.

2. Reality check and frustration. The excitement fades and the real work shows up. New strategies take time to produce results. AI output that looked impressive in a demo needs heavy editing in real life. Doubts creep in about whether any of this will pay off.

3. Overwhelmed and searching for blame. People are stretched thin, balancing their day jobs with new responsibilities. Frustration looks for a target: the new tools, the consultant, the boss who started this. Recognize this as a natural phase and address conflicts directly and constructively.

4. Turning point with team alignment. The pieces come together. People understand their roles, the new workflows start to feel normal, and the first measurable wins appear.

5. Momentum and success. Results compound. KPIs improve, engagement grows and the organization sees the return. The early frustration starts to look like the price of admission — and it was.

The AI factor: fear, resistance and restructuring

This section draws on Loren Ankarlo's 30 years of leading organizational change.

AI adds a layer of resistance that the first edition didn't have to address: people worry about their jobs. Ignore that fear and it goes underground, where it turns into slow-walking, quiet sabotage and your best people updating their résumés.

Resistance to AI usually shows up in one of four ways:

WHAT YOU'LL HEAR	WHAT'S OFTEN UNDERNEATH	WHAT HELPS
"AI content is garbage."	Pride in craft, fear of being devalued	Put the skeptic in charge of quality standards for AI output

WHAT YOU'LL HEAR	WHAT'S OFTEN UNDERNEATH	WHAT HELPS
"We don't have time to learn this."	Overload, fear of looking incompetent	Protected learning time and one small, useful first task
"Is this going to replace me?"	Job security	An honest answer about how roles will change, and a reskilling plan
Silence, then nothing changes	Disengagement, waiting it out	Clear expectations, named owners and visible leadership use of AI

What works, from experience:

- **Tell the truth about roles.** Don't promise "no one's job will change." Roles will change. Say how, and what you'll do to prepare people for the new version of their job. Vague reassurance destroys trust faster than hard news.
- **Invest in people alongside tools.** Every dollar for AI software should come with time and training for the people who will use it. Climbing the AI fluency ladder takes practice, not a login.
- **If restructuring is coming, lead with transparency.** Share the reasoning, the timeline and the support available. Rumors fill every silence.
- **Involve the team in redesigning their own workflows.** People resist what's done to them and support what they help build.
- **Recruit AI champions.** Find the early adopters on each team and give them time to help their peers. Peer learning beats top-down training.
- **Lead by example.** When leaders openly use AI and share what worked and what didn't, it signals that learning is safe.
- **Celebrate time saved, then reinvest it.** If AI saves your writer five hours a week, show what those hours now go toward: strategy, interviews, better creative work.

To come: Loren: a real example from a transformation you've led. How did the team react to the change, and what changed their minds?

Quick Start

How can we effectively communicate the size and importance of this transformation, including the role AI will play?

What support can we provide, and what roadblocks can we remove, as we start this transformation?

What fears about AI do we expect from our team, and how will we address each one honestly?

PRO TIP

Plan for the dip. Tell your team and your leadership up front that phases 2 and 3 are coming. When frustration arrives on schedule, it confirms the plan instead of undermining it.

PRO TIP

Decide who runs the room. A complete transformation changes who owns what. Some people will hold on to the budgets, projects and areas they're responsible for. That's human. It's also why the leader shouldn't always run the meeting. When the stakes are high, such as setting priorities, cutting programs, redrawing roles or working through conflict, a neutral facilitator keeps the discussion fair and lets everyone, including the boss, take part. That can be a trusted colleague from another part of the business or an outside consultant. Later chapters point out the moments where an outside view helps most.

AI TIP

Draft an honest internal announcement and FAQ

```
Context: We're a [type of business] with a marketing team of [number] people. We're starting a digital
marketing transformation that includes using AI for [list the specific tasks]. How roles will change:
[describe honestly]. Support we will provide: [training, time, tools].

Role: Act as an internal communications advisor experienced in change management.

Ask: Write (1) a short announcement from [leader's name and title] and (2) an FAQ with the ten
toughest questions employees are likely to ask, including "Will AI replace my job?"

Format: The announcement in under 250 words, then the FAQ as question-and-answer pairs.

Tighten: Answer each question honestly and without corporate jargon. Flag any question where we need
to make a decision before we can answer. If I haven't told you how roles will change, ask me before
you write. Don't guess, and don't promise anything I haven't said.
```

PRO TIP

Have HR and someone with a change-management lens review the FAQ before it goes out. Make the open decisions first, and send the announcement at least two weeks before the work starts, so people hear it from their leader, not the rumor mill. A confident promise you can't keep, like "no one will lose their job," does more damage than an honest "we haven't decided yet, and here's when we will."

Success won't happen overnight.

A real transformation takes about six quarters. Each stage builds on the one before it.

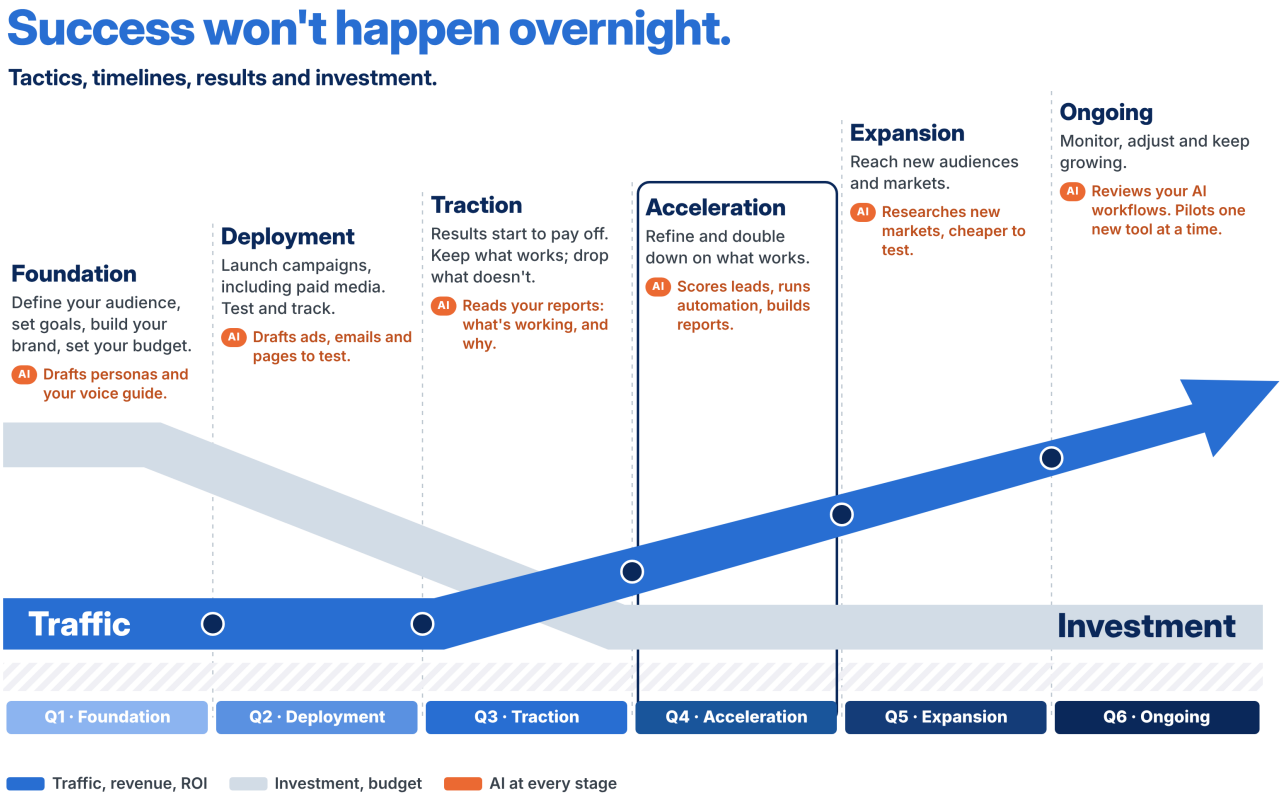
"We tend to overestimate the effect of a technology in the short run and underestimate the effect in the long run."

ROY AMARA
Institute for the Future (known as Amara's Law)

A real transformation takes about six quarters. Your investment is heaviest at the start, while traffic and revenue build slowly, then accelerate. AI can shorten some stages, but it can't skip them. You still need the foundation before the results compound.

Notice that the stages don't list all ten core disciplines every quarter. That's deliberate. Each discipline appears where it matters most: your Google Business Profile, CRM and consent records in Q1, paid media and texting in Q2, reviews, referrals and video in Q3, automation and loyalty in Q4. The stages sequence the work. Trying to do everything at once is one of the fastest ways to stall a transformation.

Your team grows with the stages, too. A realistic pace on the AI fluency ladder from Chapter 3: experimenting in Q1, using AI regularly by Q2 and Q3, and integrated (Level 4) by Q4. AI agents come after that, in Q6 and beyond.



In the first quarters, you're spending more than you're getting back. Around the Traction stage, results catch up with investment. From there, traffic, revenue and ROI keep climbing while your investment levels off.

Q1 — Foundation Stage

Build a strong foundation: define your audience, set your goals and establish your brand.

1. **Develop buyer personas.** Profile your ideal customers: demographics, pain points, buying behavior and where they look for answers — now including which AI assistants they use.
2. **Set SMART-ER goals.** Specific, measurable, achievable, relevant and time-bound. Then evaluate and readjust.
3. **Craft a content strategy.** Map content to your customer journey, choose formats and channels and build a calendar.
4. **Optimize your website.** Keyword research, site speed, mobile experience and structure that both search engines and AI can read. Claim and complete your Google Business Profile, too.
5. **Strengthen your brand identity.** Logo, voice and messaging, consistent across every channel.
6. **Set up your CRM, tracking and consent records.** One record per customer, with how and when each person agreed to hear from you. Check your sign-up forms and privacy policy, and get analytics and conversion tracking working before you spend on ads. See Chapters 15, 19 and 23.
7. **Check your team's skills.** Run the skills assessments in Chapter 3 and note where each person stands on the AI fluency ladder. Plan training from the gaps.

Add AI: Use AI to draft personas from your customer data and sales notes, analyze competitors' websites and messaging, and turn your brand voice into a written guide you can give every AI tool. Agree on your team's AI usage policy this quarter, before anyone publishes AI-assisted work. Use the template in the Leading People Through Change chapter.

Q2 — Deployment Stage

Launch campaigns, test strategies and track performance.

1. **Create a cohesive brand message** across your website, social media and email.
2. **Launch paid media** — search, social and video ads — to reach your ideal customers where they're already looking. Start with a test budget, track every conversion and scale what works.
3. **Build email and text marketing** with personalized, segmented workflows that grow your database. Text only the people who opted in to texts, starting with reminders and quick follow-ups (Chapters 16 and 17).
4. **Optimize for conversions** with clear calls to action, less friction and A/B testing.
5. **Invest in SEO** — for traditional search and AI search.

Add AI: AI drafts first versions of ads, emails, landing pages and social posts, and generates multiple variations to test. Your team edits, approves and publishes. This is where AI saves the most hours early on. Save the prompts that work in a shared prompt library. It's the first piece of your AI marketing system (Chapter 25).

Q3 — Traction Stage

You should start seeing results. Find out what's working, and drop what isn't.

1. **Launch a referral program** that rewards customers for sending new business, and ask every happy customer for an online review (Chapters 8 and 18).
2. **Plan what happens after the sale.** Onboard new customers, check in at set times and track who comes back (Chapter 18).
3. **Step up video** at every stage of the customer journey, on YouTube, Instagram, LinkedIn and TikTok.
4. **Run retargeting campaigns** for people who visited your site or consumed your content.
5. **Consider influencer marketing** with credible voices in your industry.
6. **Monitor and analyze data:** traffic, engagement, conversion rates and ROI. Then use Ranked Scoring (Chapter 20) to decide what to do more of.

Add AI: Hand AI your performance reports and ask what's working, what isn't and why. Use AI video tools to repurpose one long video into short clips, captions and translations.

Q4 — Acceleration Stage

Double down on what works and eliminate what doesn't.

1. **Use data analytics** to find the channels with the highest ROI. Data answers the question "What do we do next?"
2. **Make A/B testing an ongoing process**, not a one-time campaign.
3. **Implement marketing automation.** As momentum grows, you can't do everything manually. Connect your CRM, email and texts so lead nurture runs on its own, with a person checking it (Chapter 16).
4. **Personalize** your messaging and content for each audience segment.
5. **Expand retargeting** to recover abandoned visits and carts.
6. **Grow customer value.** Add a loyalty program or a win-back campaign if the numbers support it (Chapter 18).

Add AI: Build AI into your automation: personalized email content, AI-driven lead scoring and automated reporting. Let ad platforms' AI optimize but review its choices every month. Turn the prompts your team uses most into reusable skills and workflows. This is where most teams reach Level 4 (Chapter 25).

Q5 — Expansion Stage

Scale to new audiences and new markets.

1. **Create localized content** for each region you serve, in the local language and culture.
2. **Expand on social media** with content built for each platform.
3. **Use influencers** with followings in your new markets.
4. **Develop strategic partnerships** with businesses that share your audience.
5. **Check the rules in each new market.** Privacy, texting and review rules differ by state and country (Chapter 23).

6 **Double down on video.** It's the easiest content to consume, and it brings your brand's personality to life.

Add AI: AI translation and localization make new markets affordable to test. AI can also research new markets and audiences before you commit budget. Have a native speaker review anything customer-facing. Give your AI tools your knowledge base so every new market starts with what you've already learned.

Q6 and Beyond — Ongoing Priorities

Stay ahead of the curve and keep improving.

1 **Embrace new technology**, including AI agents that can run multi-step tasks (Chapter 25).

2 **Monitor industry trends** through events, publications and your network.

3 **Test and refine** continuously.

4 **Invest in training** so your team's skills keep pace with the tools. Repeat the skills assessments once a year (Chapter 3).

5 **Review your rules every year.** Update your AI usage policy and check privacy, consent and platform rules for changes (Chapters 22 and 23).

6 **Focus on customer experience** across every touchpoint.

Add AI: Review your AI workflows every quarter. Retire prompts and tools that aren't earning their keep, and pilot one new AI capability at a time with a clear success measure.

PRO TIP

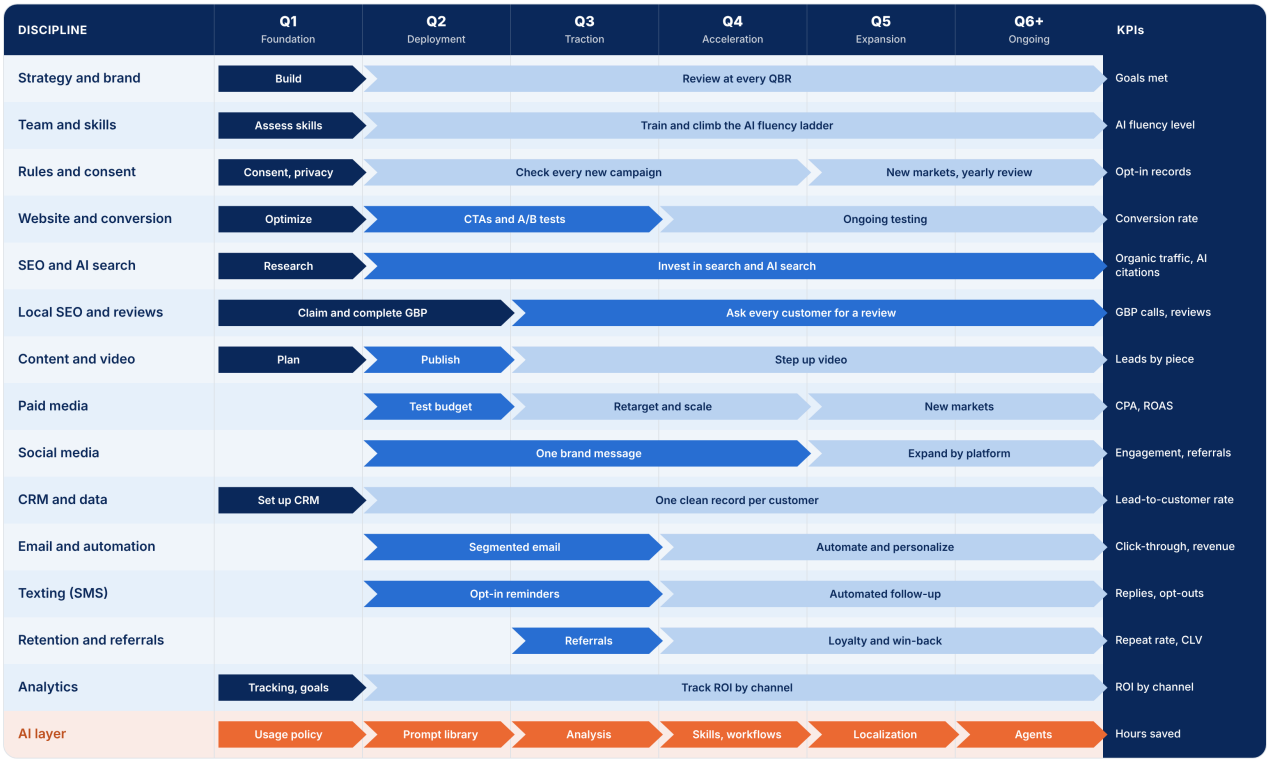
Don't try to do all 36 tactics. Pick the three to five per stage that matter most for your business and do them well. The Ranked Scoring and Effort vs. Impact tools in Chapters 20 and 21 will help you choose.

Your six quarters at a glance

YOUR SIX-QUARTER ROADMAP

Six quarters. Each discipline when it matters most.

The stages sequence the work. AI runs through every one.



Review progress at a QBR at the end of every quarter.

AI TIP

Build your six-quarter roadmap

```
Context: Our one-year goal and KPIs: [paste from your field guide]. Our team: [size and skills]. Our monthly marketing budget: [amount]. Our current strengths and gaps: [paste or summarize].

Role: Act as a digital marketing strategist building a transformation roadmap.

Ask: Using the six stages (Foundation, Deployment, Traction, Acceleration, Expansion, Ongoing), recommend three to five priority tactics per stage.

Format: A table: stage, tactics, where AI can help with each, and the milestone that tells us we're ready for the next stage.

Tighten: Be realistic about what a team our size can actually execute.
```

Notes

QUARTERLY BUSINESS REVIEWS

What to review each quarter.

Answer three questions with data, not opinions: What's working? What isn't? What do we change?

Every quarter, stop and ask three questions: What's working? What isn't? What do we change? A Quarterly Business Review (QBR) is where you answer them with data instead of opinions and make the course corrections that keep your transformation on track.

AI makes QBRs faster and sharper. What used to take a week of pulling reports and building slides can now take an afternoon. AI can summarize the data, spot trends you'd miss and draft the narrative, leaving your team's time for the part that matters: deciding what to do next.

What to review each quarter

Website performance. Traffic trends, engagement rate, conversions and conversion rate by source and device. Use Google Analytics 4 or your analytics platform of choice. Check site speed and mobile experience.

AI search visibility (new). Your buyers now ask ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity and Google's AI answers for recommendations. Track whether your brand is mentioned or cited when people ask the questions you want to own, and how much traffic arrives from AI platforms. The SEO chapter shows you how.

SEO. Organic traffic, keyword rankings, click-through rates from search, top pages, backlinks and technical errors. Compare against your top competitors.

Content marketing. Which pieces drive engagement, leads and revenue? Which formats and topics work best? What should you create more of, update or retire?

Local search and reviews. Google Business Profile views, calls, direction requests and website clicks; local map rankings; number of new reviews, average rating and how quickly you respond. For many small businesses, this is the most important source of leads on the list.

Paid media. Spend, click-through rate, cost per click, conversion rate, cost per acquisition and return on ad spend (ROAS). With AI-driven campaign types, also review which audiences, placements and creative the platform chose, and whether you agree.

Email marketing (lead nurture). Click-through rate, conversions, unsubscribes and revenue per email. Treat open rates with caution; privacy features in email apps have made them unreliable.

Social media. Engagement, reach, follower growth, referral traffic, conversions and brand sentiment.

Return on investment. Cost per lead, customer acquisition cost, customer lifetime value and ROI by channel. This is where budget decisions get made.

Your QBR scorecard: what to track, and where AI helps

AREA	KEY DATA POINTS	HOW AI HELPS	ACTION PLAN
Website	Total traffic and trend; traffic by source; engagement rate; conversions and conversion rate by source and device; page speed	Finds the pages, sources and devices where conversions dropped, and suggests fixes to test	
AI search visibility	Brand mentions and citations in AI answers for your priority questions; AI referral traffic; how AI describes your brand vs. competitors	Runs your priority questions in the major AI assistants, logs who gets cited, and compares how each one describes you and your competitors	
SEO	Organic traffic; keyword rankings; search click-through rate; top pages; backlinks; crawl errors; competitive share	Groups keywords by topic, finds pages losing clicks, drafts new titles and descriptions, and ranks crawl errors by priority	
Local search and reviews	Google Business Profile views, calls and direction requests; local map rankings; new reviews; average rating; response time	Sums up what reviewers praise and complain about, drafts replies for your approval, and compares your profile with the top map competitors	
Content	Pieces published by format; views and time on page; leads and conversions by piece; shares and backlinks	Ranks pieces by leads, finds customer questions you haven't answered, and suggests what to update, combine or retire	
Paid media	Total spend; top ads; click-through rate; cost per click; conversion rate; cost per acquisition; ROAS; impression share	Spots wasted spend and search terms to exclude, flags ads that are wearing out, and drafts new versions to test	

AREA	KEY DATA POINTS	HOW AI HELPS	ACTION PLAN
Email and automation	Click-through rate; conversion rate; unsubscribe rate; revenue generated; segment performance; lead conversion	Compares segments and subject lines, finds the weakest step in each automated sequence, and drafts tests for it	
Social media	Engagement rate; reach and impressions; follower growth; click-through and conversion rate; sentiment; influencer engagement	Sums up comment themes and sentiment, finds your best formats and posting times, and drafts next quarter's test ideas	
Video	Views and watch time; average view duration; where viewers drop off; clicks and leads from video; YouTube search traffic	Finds where viewers drop off, drafts titles, descriptions and chapters, and suggests short clips to cut from your best videos	
ROI	Cost per lead; customer acquisition cost; customer lifetime value; ROI by channel	Pulls every channel into one table, calculates CAC, lifetime value and ROI by channel, and flags numbers that don't match across reports	

The AI-assisted QBR in five steps

1. **Export.** Pull last quarter's reports from each platform as spreadsheets or PDFs.
2. **Summarize.** Give them to your AI assistant with the one-year goal and KPIs you set in Let's Get Started, earlier in this chapter. Ask for a summary of performance against each target.
3. **Challenge.** Ask the AI what's surprising, what's declining and what the data doesn't explain. Then verify anything you plan to act on against the source reports.
4. **Decide.** Meet as a team. Use the AI summary as the starting point and spend the meeting on decisions, not reading numbers aloud.
5. **Record.** Write the decisions in the action plan column above, with an owner and a due date for each.

PRO TIP

Hold the QBR on the calendar for the whole year now. The quarter you skip is always the quarter you needed it.

AI TIP

Turn raw reports into a QBR briefing

```
Context: Our goals and KPI targets: [paste from your field guide]. Attached are last quarter's reports
from [list platforms].

Role: Act as a marketing analyst preparing a quarterly business review.

Ask: Turn these reports into a QBR briefing.

Format: (1) Performance against each KPI target: on track, at risk or off track. (2) The three biggest
wins and three biggest problems, with the numbers. (3) Trends or anomalies, and anything the data
can't explain. (4) Up to five actions for next quarter, ranked by expected impact.

Tighten: Show your calculations so I can check them. Don't invent numbers that aren't in the reports.
```

SMARKETING

Sales and marketing win together.

When both teams share goals, data and buyers, leads stop falling through the cracks.

"Smarketing" is HubSpot's term for integrating your sales and marketing teams around shared goals, shared data and a shared view of the customer journey. When the two teams work as one, leads move faster, fewer fall through the cracks and the customer has one consistent experience from first click to signed contract.

AI has made alignment easier and more important. Easier, because AI can now capture and summarize what happens on every sales call and connect it to marketing data. More important, because buyers do more of their research alone — increasingly with AI assistants — before they ever talk to a salesperson.

Note: Most of this alignment happens in your CRM. If your team runs Salesforce, HubSpot or another CRM, Chapter 15, AI and Your CRM, shows how to put AI to work inside it: cleaning your data, scoring leads, summarizing sales calls, drafting follow-up and asking pipeline questions in plain English.

The KPIs your Smarketing team should share

KPI	WHAT IT MEASURES	HOW SALES AND MARKETING WORK TOGETHER ON IT
Lead-to-customer conversion rate	The share of marketing leads that become customers	Jointly define a qualified lead and refine lead scoring together
Revenue from marketing	Revenue from customers first acquired through marketing	Marketing shares source data on every deal; sales confirms it in the CRM
Customer lifetime value (CLV)	Total revenue a customer generates over the relationship	Marketing targets ideal customer profiles; sales feeds back what great customers have in common

KPI	WHAT IT MEASURES	HOW SALES AND MARKETING WORK TOGETHER ON IT
Customer acquisition cost (CAC)	The full cost of winning a new customer	Both teams review budget allocation and cut what doesn't convert

How to align your teams

- **Shared goals and KPIs.** Both teams work toward the same numbers, reviewed in the same meeting.
- **Regular communication.** Hold joint meetings at least monthly, and include sales in your QBR.
- **Feedback loops.** Sales reports on lead quality; marketing reports on which content and messages help close deals.
- **Shared personas.** Build customer personas with input from both teams. Sales hears objections marketing never sees.
- **Lead scoring and qualification.** Define it together and revisit it every quarter.
- **Integrated technology.** Your CRM and marketing automation platform should share data in both directions.
- **Sales enablement.** Give sales the content, training and tools to use marketing's work in their conversations.
- **Closed-loop reporting.** Track every customer from first touch to closed deal so both teams can see what works.
- **Clear documentation.** Use the RACI model to define who owns each step of the lead handoff.
- **Celebrate wins together.** Recognize shared wins, whether a big deal or a campaign that filled the pipeline.

Where AI strengthens Smarketing

- **Call intelligence.** AI meeting tools record, transcribe and summarize sales calls. Marketing can mine those transcripts for the exact questions, objections and words customers use — the raw material for better content and ads.
- **Smarter lead scoring.** Many CRMs now offer AI-driven lead scoring based on which leads actually became customers, rather than points someone assigned by guesswork.
- **Faster follow-up.** AI can draft personalized follow-up emails from call notes in seconds. The salesperson reviews, edits and sends.
- **Sales enablement on demand.** Load your case studies, product details and objection responses into an AI assistant so salespeople can get accurate answers and draft proposals quickly.
- **A shared prompt library.** Give both teams the same approved prompts so messaging stays consistent.

PRO TIP

Make sales a co-owner of the content calendar. The best content ideas come from questions customers ask on sales calls.

AI TIP

Turn sales conversations into a content plan

```
Context: Notes or transcripts from [number] recent sales calls: [paste]. Our ideal customer: [paste persona from your field guide].

Role: Act as a content strategist working closely with our sales team.

Ask: Turn these sales conversations into a content plan.

Format: (1) The most common questions and objections, with how often each came up. (2) The exact phrases customers used to describe their problems. (3) For each top question or objection, a piece of content (article, video, case study or FAQ) that would answer it before a sales call.

Tighten: Mark which items need a salesperson's input to answer accurately.
```

Note: Remove customer names and confidential details before pasting call notes into an AI tool, unless your company's AI policy and the tool's settings allow it.

AI TIP

Build a lead scoring model from your real wins

```
Context: Data on our last [number] closed deals and [number] lost or unqualified leads, with their source, company size, pages viewed, emails clicked and days to close: [paste or attach, with names removed].

Role: Act as a revenue operations analyst.

Ask: Identify which characteristics and behaviors best separate leads that became customers from those that didn't, and propose a simple lead scoring model.

Format: A scoring table that adds up to 100 points, with the reasoning for each weight, ready for sales and marketing to review together.

Tighten: Flag where our sample is too small to be reliable.
```

Smarketing build

What do sales and marketing currently disagree about most?

How will we define a qualified lead?

Which sales conversations will we capture and share with marketing, and how?

STRATEGY

Do you have one?

In this chapter »

Get this right and you'll save time, trouble and money for years.

— **STRATEGY ALWAYS COMES FIRST**
Why strategy comes before tactics, and your strategy on a page

— **ELEMENTS OF YOUR STRATEGY**
The eleven questions every complete strategy answers

— **HOW MUCH SHOULD YOU SPEND?**
Budget benchmarks by type of business, and how to build yours

— **BUILD, HIRE, OUTSOURCE OR AUTOMATE**
Who owns each deliverable: your team, a partner or AI

— **STRATEGY QUESTIONS**
Answer them with your team. Your answers become your strategy

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
5 AI Tips, from pressure-testing your value proposition to turning your answers into a strategy draft

Strategy comes first. Everything else follows.

Get it right and you'll save time, trouble and money for years.

"Efficiency is concerned with doing things right. Effectiveness is doing the right things."

PETER DRUCKER
Management: Tasks, Responsibilities, Practices (1974)

In marketing, strategy makes sure you're doing the right things. Tactics make sure you're doing them right. Get the strategy wrong and every tactic after it is wasted effort, no matter how well it's executed. Get it right and you'll save time, trouble and money for years.

Your strategy is your roadmap. It sets your objectives, defines your audience, picks the channels most likely to reach them and decides where your budget goes. It keeps every campaign, every piece of content and every dollar pulling in the same direction, so your customers get one consistent experience of your brand.

Your strategy is your competitive edge

Almost everyone has a strategy now. In the Content Marketing Institute's 2026 research, 97% of B2B marketers said they have a content strategy. But only 12% said their marketing was highly effective — exceeding its goals (CMI, 2026).

So having a strategy isn't the edge anymore. Having a *good* one is. Among marketers whose content strategy improved, 74% credited refining the strategy itself. Only 51% credited new technology. The winners didn't buy their way to better results; they thought their way there.

A strong strategy helps you:

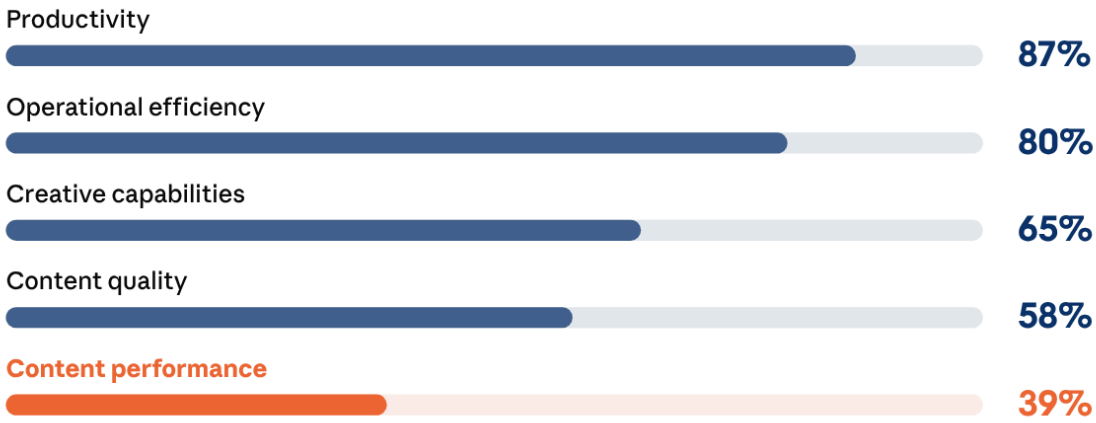
- **Focus** on the channels and tactics most likely to work for your business, and say no to the rest.
- **Differentiate** by building on the strengths competitors can't easily copy.
- **Adapt** quickly when markets, algorithms or technology change.
- **Measure** progress against clear goals and make data-driven course corrections.

Why AI makes strategy matter more, not less

It's tempting to think AI can replace strategy. Just ask the chatbot for a marketing plan and start executing. Here's what the data says happens when teams lead with tools instead of strategy:

87% got more productive with AI.
Only 39% saw better performance.

Share of B2B marketers using AI for content who say each area improved



CMI and MarketingProfs, B2B Content and Marketing Trends: Insights for 2026 · 1,015 B2B marketers, surveyed June–August 2025

AI makes you faster. It does not, by itself, make you better.

Point AI at a weak strategy and you'll produce more mediocre content at record speed. Point it at a clear strategy — a defined audience, a real point of view, specific goals — and it multiplies what your team can accomplish.

That's why this chapter comes before every chapter about tactics and tools.

Your competitors have a digital marketing strategy — and they're using AI to execute it faster. Do you have one worth accelerating?

PRO TIP

Write your strategy down, keep it short and share it. A two-page strategy everyone has read beats a 40-page plan that lives in a folder. If your team can't explain the strategy in two sentences, it isn't working yet.

A complete strategy answers eleven questions.

You'll work through each one in this book. This is the checklist.

A complete digital marketing strategy answers eleven questions. You'll work through each of them in this book; this is the checklist.

1. **Audience.** Who are your ideal customers? Build buyer personas that guide your messaging and content. *(Customer Journey chapter)*
2. **Goals.** What will you achieve, by when, and how will you measure it? Set clear, quantitative goals. *(Chapter 1)*
3. **Competition.** Where do you stand against your competitors? Run a SWOT analysis. *(SWOT chapter)*
4. **Position.** Why should a customer choose you? Define a value proposition and a point of view only you can claim.
5. **Channels.** Which channels will you prioritize — SEO and AI search, local search and reviews, social media, paid media, email and marketing automation, video — based on your audience and goals? Your website is where they all convert.
6. **Content.** What will you create, for whom, at which stage of the journey? Plan it on a content calendar. *(Content chapter)*
7. **Budget and resources.** What will you invest, and who will do the work? *(This chapter)*
8. **Measurement.** Which KPIs will you track, with what tools, and how often will you review them? *(Measurement chapter and QBRs)*
9. **Optimization.** How will you test, learn and improve continuously? *(Conversion Rate Optimization chapter)*
10. **Process and workflows.** How will the work actually get done — who does what, in what order, with which tools, and who approves it? *(New — see below)*
11. **AI.** Where will AI accelerate your strategy, where do people stay in charge, and how will roles change? *(New — see below)*

Process and workflows: where strategy meets execution

A strategy is only as good as the system that carries it out. Many marketing plans that fail don't fail on strategy; they fail on process. Content sits for three weeks waiting for approval. Leads arrive and nobody follows up. Reports get built and nobody reads them.

Process answers the practical questions your strategy leaves open: who does what, in what order, with which tools, and who signs off. Written workflows make your marketing repeatable, so results don't depend on one person remembering how things are done.

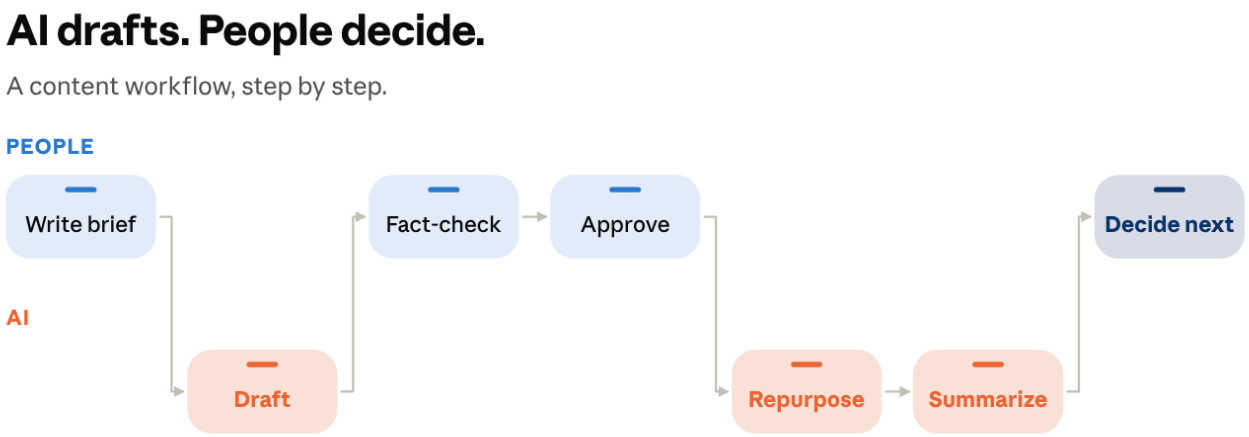
Start by defining the four workflows almost every marketing team runs:

- **Content production** — from idea to published piece.
- **Campaign launch** — from brief to live ads, emails and landing pages.

- **Lead handoff** — from form fill to a sales conversation (see Smarketing in Chapter 1).
- **Reporting** — from raw data to decisions at your QBR.

AI changes workflows, not just tasks

The biggest gains from AI don't come from doing the same steps faster. They come from redesigning the workflow, so AI handles the production steps and people own the judgment steps. Here's what that looks like for content:



example content workflow · 7 steps, people and AI

People own the beginning (the brief), the judgment in the middle (fact-checking and approval) and the end (deciding what to do next). AI handles the production work in between.

Map your own core workflows below. For each, name an owner and decide where AI helps and where a person must approve.

WORKFLOW	KEY STEPS	OWNER	WHERE AI HELPS	WHO APPROVES
Content production				
Campaign launch				
Lead handoff				
Reporting				

PRO TIP

If a workflow isn't written down, it isn't a workflow; it's a habit, and habits leave when people do. Document one workflow this month, test it for a few weeks, fix what breaks, then document the next.

AI TIP

Redesign a workflow with AI

```
Context: How our team currently handles [workflow name], step by step, with who does each step and how long it takes: [describe]. Our tools: [list]. Our AI ground rules: [paste or summarize].

Role: Act as a marketing operations consultant.

Ask: Redesign this workflow so AI handles the steps it can do reliably and people own the steps that need judgment, approval or customer relationships.

Format: A numbered list of the new workflow, with an owner (person or AI) for each step, the estimated time saved and the quality checks we need.

Tighten: Flag any step where using AI would create risk.
```

The AI layer of your strategy

The eleventh element is also new to this edition. Without it, AI use spreads by accident: one person uses one tool, another uses a different one, nobody checks the output and nobody measures whether it's working. Decide on purpose instead.

For each area of your marketing, decide what AI does and what people own:

AREA	AI CAN DO	PEOPLE OWN
Research	Market, competitor and keyword research; summarizing customer feedback	Deciding which insights matter
Content	First drafts, outlines, variations, repurposing, editing	Point of view, expertise, stories, final approval
Creative	Images, video edits, ad variations, mockups	Brand standards and creative direction
Campaigns	Audience targeting and bid optimization in ad platforms	Goals, budgets, offers and guardrails
Customer contact	Chatbots, email personalization, follow-up drafts	Relationships, negotiation, anything sensitive
Analysis	Report summaries, trend spotting, forecasts	Decisions and accountability

Then answer three questions in your strategy:

- **Where will AI save us the most time?** Start there.
- **What will we never hand to AI?** Write it down.
- **How will we know AI is helping?** Measure results, not just output volume.

The people side of AI

There's a question many people won't ask out loud in a strategy meeting: "Is AI going to take my job?"

When leadership announces an AI strategy, some of your team will hear it as a plan to replace them. That fear is understandable, and it's costly to ignore. People who are afraid for their jobs rarely embrace the tools they're afraid of. They slow-walk adoption, quietly avoid the new workflows or start looking for another job.

The honest answer is that AI will change most marketing roles. Some tasks will shrink or disappear. New responsibilities will grow: briefing AI, reviewing its work, analyzing results and doing more of the strategic and creative work that used to get squeezed out. Whether that feels like a threat or an opportunity depends largely on how leadership handles it.

Yet few companies are investing in that transition. In the Content Marketing Institute's 2026 research, 45% of B2B marketers planned to increase investment in AI tools, but only 9% planned to increase investment in their people — salaries, training and development (CMI, 2026).

Your strategy should address this directly:

- **Say how roles will change.** Vague reassurance ("nothing will change") destroys trust faster than honest news.
- **Invest in people alongside tools.** Budget for training every time you budget for a new AI tool.
- **Show where the saved time goes.** If AI saves your team ten hours a week, show what those hours go to next.
- **Involve the team.** People support the workflows they help design.

Add a fourth question to your AI plan: How will AI change our people's roles, and how will we support them through it?

Chapter 1 (From Frustration to Success) covers managing fear and resistance in depth, and Chapter 3 (Skills) covers retraining.

Your strategy on a page

Summarize your strategy in one page your whole team can read in two minutes. Come back and complete it as you finish each chapter.

ELEMENT	OUR STRATEGY
Our ideal customer	
Our one-year goal and how it grows the business	
Why customers choose us	

ELEMENT	OUR STRATEGY
Our top competitors	
Our priority channels	
What we won't do	
Our content focus	
Our annual marketing budget (most businesses invest 7%–10% of revenue; see the benchmarks below)	
Our core workflows and owners	
How AI accelerates our plan	
How we'll support our people through the change	
How we measure success and keep improving	

Strategy on a page.

Your whole plan on one sheet. Pin it up and revisit it every quarter.

1. **Our ideal customer**
2. **Our one-year goal and how it grows the business**
3. **Why customers choose us**
4. **Our top competitors**
5. **Our priority channels**
6. **What we won't do**
7. **Our content focus**
8. **Our annual marketing budget**
   Most businesses invest 7%–10% of revenue.
9. **Our core workflows and owners**
10. **How AI accelerates our plan**
11. **How we'll support our people through the change**
12. **How we measure success and keep improving**

↓ Strategy on a Page template

Strategy is as much about what you won't do as what you will.

PRO TIP

Every channel you add divides your budget and your team's attention. A small business doing three channels well beats one doing eight badly.

AI TIP

Pressure-test your value proposition

```
Context: What we sell: [product or service]. Who we sell to: [ideal customer]. Our value proposition:
[paste your draft]. Our top three competitors: [names and websites].

Role: Act first as a skeptical buyer, then as a competitive strategist.

Ask: As the buyer, would this value proposition make you choose us over the competitors? As the
strategist, compare our claims with what the competitors say on their websites.

Format: (1) The buyer's verdict: what's vague, generic or unbelievable. (2) The strategist's
comparison. (3) Three sharper positions we could credibly own.

Tighten: If you can't access the competitors' websites, say so and work from what I provide.
```

HOW MUCH SHOULD YOU SPEND?

Most businesses invest 7% to 10% of revenue.

Start with a benchmark for your type of business, then adjust for your goals, stage and competition.

Most established businesses spend between 7% and 10% of revenue on marketing. The CMO Survey (Duke University, Deloitte and the American Marketing Association) put the average at 9.0% of revenue in its Spring 2026 report. Gartner's 2026 CMO Spend Survey, which leans toward larger companies, put it at 7.8% (benchmark summary; Gartner and CMO Survey comparison).

The best starting point is a percentage of gross revenue, adjusted for your type of business:

TYPE OF BUSINESS	MARKETING BUDGET, % OF REVENUE
B2C product (consumer goods, e-commerce)	12.0%
B2B services (agencies, consulting, professional services)	10.1%
B2C services (home services, healthcare, local businesses)	7.2%
B2B product (manufacturing, distribution, software)	7.0%
All companies (average)	9.0%

Source: The CMO Survey, Spring 2026, as reported by CMO.Works.

B2C product brands spend the most.

Marketing budget as a share of revenue. The dark line marks the 9.0% average.



Source: The CMO Survey, Spring 2026.

Three things move your number up or down from the benchmark:

- **Growth goals.** If you're trying to grow fast, enter a new market or launch a product, expect to spend above the benchmark. Maintaining your position costs less than gaining ground.
- **Stage.** Young companies spend a higher share of revenue because they're building awareness from zero.
- **Competition.** A crowded category costs more to be heard in.

What are your competitors spending?

You can't see a competitor's budget, but you can see a lot of their activity. Look up their ads in the Meta Ad Library (facebook.com/ads/library) and Google's Ads Transparency Center (adstransparency.google.com). Both are free. Use an SEO platform such as Semrush or Ahrefs to estimate their search traffic and paid search spend. Count how often they publish content, send email and post video. Together, these tell you whether they're outspending you, and where.

Establishing your budget

Annual revenue	
Marketing budget as % of revenue	
Total annual marketing budget	

Compared to our competition, our marketing investment is:

- ☐ Higher
- ☐ About the same
- ☐ Lower

Where the money goes

Your "all-in" budget covers more than ads. Include:

- **People** — salaries, benefits and training for your internal team.

- **Agencies and freelancers** — outside expertise and production.
- **Paid media** — search, social, video and display ads.
- **Content and creative** — writing, design, video and photography.
- **Technology** — your website, CRM, email platform, analytics and AI tools.

AI tools are usually one of the smallest lines in this budget. Business plans for the leading AI assistants cost about $20 to $30 per person per month. ChatGPT Business and Claude Team are $20 a seat billed annually, or $25 monthly (OpenAI, Anthropic). Microsoft 365 Copilot Business is $21 for companies with up to 300 people (Computerworld). So a team of 10 pays about $200 to $300 a month. Heavy users may need premium seats at about $100 a month. Prices change often, so check them before you budget.

The payoff can be large, but only on the right tasks. In a Harvard and BCG study of 758 consultants, those using AI finished 12.2% more tasks, 25.1% faster and at more than 40% higher quality on tasks AI handles well. On a task outside its strengths, they were 19 percentage points less likely to get the right answer (Dell'Acqua et al., 2023).

The bigger cost is training. In BCG's 2025 survey of more than 10,600 workers, only 36% felt adequately trained in AI. People with five or more hours of training were significantly more likely to become regular users (BCG, 2025). Budget time for training, not just licenses.

PRO TIP

Use the 70/20/10 rule. Put about 70% of your budget into proven channels, 20% into promising ones you're scaling and 10% into experiments. The experiments are where you'll find next year's 70%.

AI TIP

Build and stress-test your budget

```
Context: We're a [type of business] with [annual revenue] in revenue and a marketing team of [number].
Our one-year goal: [paste from your field guide]. Our proposed annual marketing budget: [amount]. What
we spent last year by category, and the results: [paste].

Role: Act as a fractional CMO.

Ask: Recommend how to allocate the budget across people, agencies, paid media, content and technology,
and tell me whether it's realistic for our goal.

Format: A table of the allocation with your reasoning; what we'd need to cut or add if the budget
isn't realistic; and a 70/20/10 split of proven, scaling and experimental spending.

Tighten: List any assumptions I should verify.
```

RESOURCES

Build it, hire it, outsource it or automate it.

Every deliverable needs an owner. The smartest teams mix all four.

Every deliverable in your strategy needs an owner. In the first edition, the choice was internal team or outside agency. Now there's a third option for many tasks: an internal team member working with AI. The smartest teams mix all three.

Resource checklist — Strategy

For each deliverable, check who will own it. Many will have more than one check: AI drafts, a team member refines, an agency advises.

I = internal team · **E** = external: agency, freelancer or partner · **AI** = AI-assisted

DELIVERABLE	I	E	AI	OWNER AND NOTES
Set clear objectives	☐	☐	☐	
Plan strategic initiatives	☐	☐	☐	
Define hard and soft goals	☐	☐	☐	
Develop buyer personas	☐	☐	☐	
Conduct data analysis	☐	☐	☐	
Map the customer journey	☐	☐	☐	
Benchmark current state (SWOT)	☐	☐	☐	
Gap analysis (content, SEO and AI search, paid media, social, local, website, tech)	☐	☐	☐	
Content inventory and audit	☐	☐	☐	
Competitor research and audit, including their ads	☐	☐	☐	
AI search visibility baseline	☐	☐	☐	

DELIVERABLE	I	E	AI	OWNER AND NOTES
Content ideation and creation	☐	☐	☐	
Content calendar	☐	☐	☐	
Paid media plan, budget and campaign management	☐	☐	☐	
Social media plan and community management	☐	☐	☐	
Email and marketing automation setup	☐	☐	☐	
Website and conversion optimization	☐	☐	☐	
Google Business Profile, local listings and review management	☐	☐	☐	
Brand voice guide	☐	☐	☐	
AI usage policy	☐	☐	☐	
RACI framework	☐	☐	☐	

Hiring an internal team

It's hard to know how a new hire will turn out. Vet every candidate carefully; it saves time, trouble and money in the long run. Once your team is in place, set aside a real budget for training. Digital marketing changes constantly, and AI has made that pace faster.

When you hire now, test for AI fluency. Give candidates a realistic task and let them use AI. Watch how they brief it, check its work and add their own judgment. Someone who can do that well will outproduce someone who can't by a wide margin.

Use current pay data to budget realistically. National median wages, May 2025:

ROLE	MEDIAN ANNUAL WAGE	IN PLAN?
Marketing manager	$166,790	☐
Public relations manager	$146,910	☐
Advertising and promotions manager	$133,660	☐

ROLE	MEDIAN ANNUAL WAGE	IN PLAN?
Web developer	$92,650	☐
Market research analyst or marketing specialist	$78,760	☐
Public relations specialist	$74,750	☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐
		☐

Source: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics, May 2025 (summary of BLS data). Wages vary widely by region; marketing managers' average pay ranged from about $121,000 in Mississippi to $213,000 in Massachusetts. Budget an additional 20–30% for benefits and training.

Hiring an agency

An agency gives you specialized skills and capacity without adding headcount. To get your money's worth:

- **Inspect** what you expect. As the client, it's your job to review the work.
- **Hold** the agency accountable for what it contracted to deliver.
- **Communicate** regularly and frequently.

Ask every agency how it uses AI. You want a partner that uses AI to deliver more value, not one that bills you senior-strategist rates for lightly edited AI output. Good questions: Which tasks do you use AI for? Who reviews AI-assisted work before we see it? How do you protect our data? How has AI changed your pricing?

Automating with AI

AI doesn't replace a strategist, but it can take on a large share of the research, drafting and reporting work that used to take more people or more agency hours. What you do with that is a leadership decision, and it affects people, so make it in the open. Before you hire or outsource a task, ask whether someone already on your team could handle it with good AI tools and training. Ask them, too. The people doing the work know best what AI can and can't take on. Sometimes the answer is yes, sometimes no, but always ask. When AI frees up time, decide what that time goes to, such as customers, new work or training, and tell your team.

PRO TIP

Never outsource your strategy entirely. Agencies and AI can inform it, challenge it and execute it, but the strategy must be owned by someone inside your business who will be there next year.

AI TIP

Decide build, hire, outsource or automate

```
Context: Our completed resource checklist: [paste the deliverables and who owns each]. Our current
team and their skills: [list]. Our budget for people and agencies: [amount].

Role: Act as a marketing operations consultant.

Ask: For each deliverable, recommend whether to handle it internally, hire, outsource or have a team
member do it with AI assistance.

Format: A table: deliverable, recommendation, trade-offs, and estimated time or cost.

Tighten: Flag any deliverable where relying on AI would be risky.
```

STRATEGY QUESTIONS

Your answers become your strategy.

Answer these with your team before you move on. Aim for honest answers, not perfect ones.

“Plans are worthless, but planning is everything.”

DWIGHT D. EISENHOWER
remarks to the National Defense Executive Reserve Conference (1957)

Answer these with your team before you move on. Don't aim for perfect answers. Aim for honest ones. You'll refine them as you work through the rest of the book, and they become the raw material for the AI Tip at the end of this chapter.

1. Objectives. What are the main objectives of our digital marketing? What do we want to achieve, in measurable terms?

2. Audience. Who is our target audience? What are their interests, needs and pain points? Where do they go for answers, including AI assistants?

3. Channels. Which channels should we focus on — SEO and AI search, local search and reviews, social media, paid media, email and marketing automation, video or a combination? Why those?

4. Presence and reputation. What is our current online presence and reputation? What do search results, review sites and AI assistants say about us today?

5. Competition. What are our competitors doing in digital marketing? What can we learn from their successes and failures?

6. Resources. What resources do we have — budget, people, skills, tools? How will we allocate them?

7. Content. What content should we create? What can we offer that's genuinely more useful than what's already out there, including what AI can generate in seconds?

8. Measurement. How will we measure success? Which metrics will we track, and how often will we review them?

9. Optimization. How will we keep improving? What tests and experiments will we run?

10. Business alignment. How does our marketing strategy support our overall business strategy? How can digital marketing help transform and grow the business?

11. AI (new). Where will AI accelerate our strategy? What will we never hand to AI? How will we know it's helping?

PRO TIP

Answer these questions as a team, not alone. Include sales, customer service and leadership. The disagreements you surface now are much cheaper than the ones you'll discover six months into execution.

AI TIP

Turn your answers into a strategy draft

This is the most important prompt in the chapter. It takes everything you've written and produces a first draft of your strategy document.

```
Context: Our answers to the eleven strategy questions: [paste your answers to questions 1–11]. Our budget and resource checklist: [paste].

Role: Act as a senior digital marketing strategist with agency experience working with businesses like ours.

Ask: Using only this information, write a two-page digital marketing strategy.

Format: Sections for Objectives, Target Audience, Positioning, Priority Channels, Content Focus, Budget and Resources, AI Plan, Measurement, and the Top Five Priorities for the Next 90 Days. Then, separately, any contradictions or gaps in our answers, and the five questions you'd need answered to make the strategy stronger.

Tighten: Don't fill gaps with generic advice. Mark anything you assumed.
```

Run it, answer its questions, and run it again. Then edit the result until it sounds like your business — not like a template. That edited version goes into your Strategy on a Page.

SKILLS

Do you have them?

In this chapter »

Where are the gaps in your team's skills and knowledge?

— **SKILLS AND KNOWLEDGE**
What a digital transformation asks of your team

— **THE SKILLS ASSESSMENTS**
Individual and team assessments to find your gaps

— **THE AI SKILLS EVERY TEAM NEEDS**
Six AI skills, and where your team stands today

— **CLOSING THE GAPS**
Train, hire, outsource or automate, and a plan to get there

— **SKILLS QUESTIONS**
Questions for leaders and for every team member

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
3 AI Tips, including a personal AI coaching plan and turning assessment scores into a training plan

SKILLS

Skills: Do You Have Them?

> **You're not going to lose your job to an AI, but you're going to lose your job to someone who uses AI.**
>
> Jensen Huang, CEO of Nvidia, Milken Institute Global Conference (2025)

Many organizations start a digital transformation without the skills to finish it. They set ambitious goals, buy new tools and then discover that no one on the team knows how to run a paid search campaign, read an attribution report or brief an AI tool well.

Your people are the most important factor in your transformation. Everyone on your team has strengths, weaknesses and gaps. Knowing where those gaps are tells you whether to train your current team, hire new people or bring in outside help.

Skills beat tools

The Content Marketing Institute's 2026 research makes the point clearly. When B2B marketers with effective programs were asked what made the difference, the top two answers were content quality (65%) and team skills and capabilities (53%). Technology and tools came in fourth, at 43% (CMI, 2026).

Yet the same research found that only 9% of B2B marketers planned to increase investment in their people — salaries, training and development — in 2026. AI tools topped the list at 45%. Most companies are buying the tools and skipping the training.

That's a gap you can turn into an advantage. Nearly everyone is using AI: 95% of B2B marketers said their organizations use AI-powered applications. But only 8% described their AI use as advanced or industry-leading. The difference between those two numbers is skill.

The core disciplines

Throughout this book, these are the disciplines a complete digital marketing team needs to cover, whether in-house, through partners or with AI help:

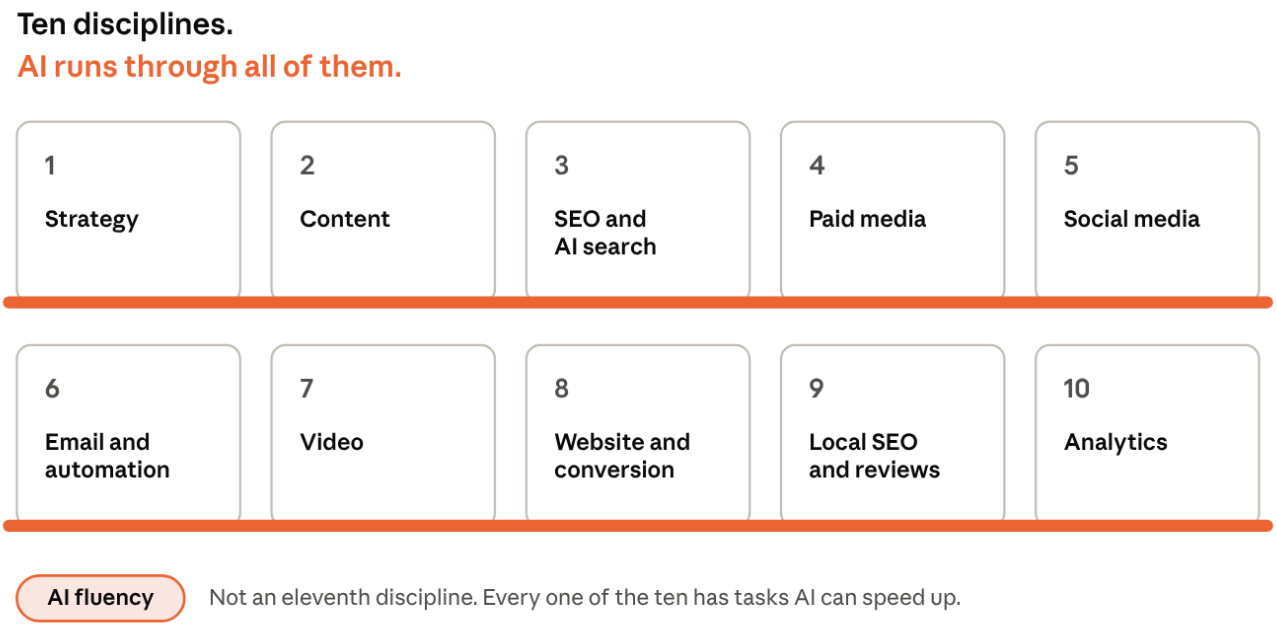
1. **Strategy** — goals, positioning, budget and priorities.
2. **Content** — articles, guides, case studies and everything else you publish.
3. **SEO and AI search** — getting found in search engines and recommended by AI assistants.
4. **Paid media** — search, social and video advertising.
5. **Social media** — publishing, community and engagement.
6. **Email and marketing automation** — nurturing leads and customers through your CRM.
7. **Video** — the format buyers prefer at every stage of the journey.
8. **Website and conversion optimization** — turning visitors into leads and customers.
9. **Local SEO and reviews** — your Google Business Profile, listings and online reputation.

10 **Analytics** — measuring what works and deciding what's next.

AI fluency isn't an eleventh discipline. It runs through all ten: every one of them now has tasks AI can speed up and judgment calls that still need a person.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Ten discipline tiles with an AI fluency band running across them



the ten core disciplines · AI fluency runs through all of them

How AI changes the skills you need

AI doesn't eliminate marketing skills. It shifts where they matter:

- **Less time producing, more time judging.** When AI writes the first draft, the valuable skill is knowing what's good, what's wrong and what's missing.
- **Strategy and taste matter more.** AI can generate a hundred options. Someone must know which one fits the brand and the buyer.
- **Data skills matter more.** AI can summarize a report, but someone must ask the right questions and spot when an answer doesn't add up.
- **Craft still matters.** You can't evaluate AI-written copy if you can't write. You can't judge an AI-generated ad if you don't understand advertising. AI raises the floor; experts raise the ceiling.

Before you begin, remember that your internal team already has full-time jobs. Every new task in your transformation lands on top of what they're already responsible for. AI can free up some of that time — but only after people have learned to use it well, which takes time too.

PRO TIP

Use the assessments in this chapter twice: once now, and again at your fourth-quarter QBR. The change in scores is one of the clearest measures of whether your transformation is working.

THE SKILLS ASSESSMENTS

The Skills Assessments

There are two assessments. The first is for each individual on your team. The second is for your organization as a whole. Have every team member complete the individual assessment on their own, then complete the organizational assessment together.

How to score. Rate each item from 1 to 5. Add up your ratings, then divide by the number of items to get your average score. In the interactive PDF, this is calculated for you.

AVERAGE SCORE	LEVEL	WHAT IT MEANS
1.0–1.7	Novice	Little or no experience. Start with training basics.
1.8–2.5	Beginner	Some exposure, but you need guidance to execute.
2.6–3.3	Intermediate	You can execute independently in most areas.
3.4–4.1	Advanced	You execute well and can teach others.
4.2–5.0	Expert	You set the standard and lead strategy.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Rating scale bar with the five levels and the original edition's face icons

Your personal digital marketing maturity

SKILL	RATING (1–5)
Overall understanding of digital marketing	
Knowledge and expertise in content marketing	
Keyword research and on-page SEO, including optimizing for AI search	
Creating and implementing backlink and digital PR strategies	
Planning and managing paid media campaigns (search, social and video ads)	

SKILL	RATING (1–5)
Developing and managing social media campaigns across channels and formats	
Planning and producing video	
Managing a Google Business Profile, local listings and online reviews	
Analyzing and measuring campaigns, including attribution	
Assessing channels and prioritizing campaigns based on goals	
Identifying target audiences and creating personas	
Creating and optimizing landing pages	
Using marketing automation tools	
Creating and running lead nurture campaigns, including content and workflows	
New: Writing effective prompts and getting quality output from AI tools	
New: Reviewing AI output for accuracy, brand voice and quality	
Total ÷ 16 = Average score	

Notes

Your organization's digital marketing maturity

Rate how true each statement is for your organization today.

STATEMENT	RATING (1–5)
We continuously monitor and measure the ROI of our digital marketing.	
We keep up with emerging digital marketing trends and technology.	

STATEMENT	RATING (1–5)
Leadership actively supports and resources digital marketing.	
Our marketing team is trained in current digital marketing tactics.	
We use an omnichannel approach to create, distribute and promote content.	
Our decisions are driven by data.	
Comprehensive keyword research informs our SEO strategy.	
Our paid media is planned, tracked to conversions and optimized regularly.	
We post consistently on social media and engage with our community.	
We actively manage our Google Business Profile and customer reviews.	
We test and optimize our website and landing pages for conversions.	
We have clear definitions for KPIs such as CPA, CPL, LTV and ROAS.	
We produce high-quality video that resonates with our audience.	
We optimize content, titles, H1 tags, meta descriptions and images for search.	
We repurpose content to maximize its reach and impact.	
We use triggers and segmented workflows in our lead nurture programs.	
New: We have written guidelines for how our team uses AI.	
New: AI is built into our workflows, not just used by individuals on their own.	
New: We track how our brand appears in AI search and AI assistants.	
Total ÷ 19 = Average score	

Notes

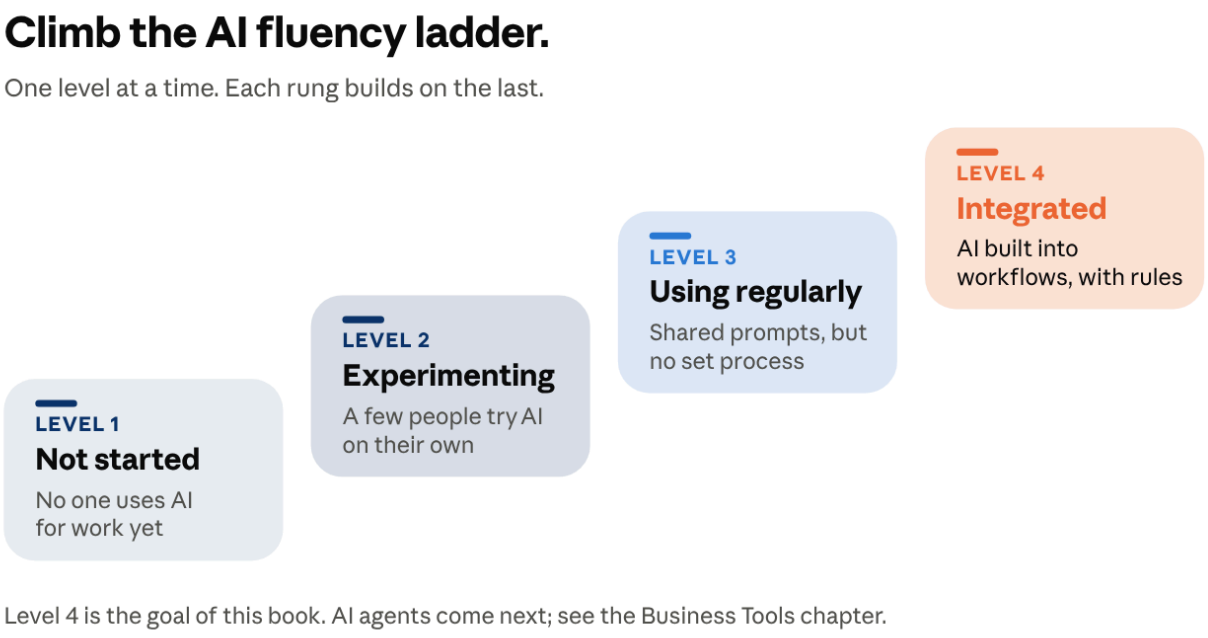
PRO TIP

Compare the individual scores with the organizational score. If individuals score high and the organization scores low, your problem is process and leadership, not talent. If the organization scores higher than its people, you're probably relying on one or two stars — a risk if either one leaves.

THE AI SKILLS EVERY MARKETING TEAM NEEDS

The AI Skills Every Marketing Team Needs

In Chapter 1, you checked where your team stands on AI today. Those four answers are the four rungs of the AI fluency ladder. Most teams don't need to jump to the top; they need to climb one rung at a time, with each level built on solid habits from the one below.



AI fluency ladder · four levels

Which level is your team on today? [FORM FIELD] Which level will you reach in two quarters? [FORM FIELD]

Six AI skills to build

These are the skills that separate teams that get real value from AI from teams that just generate more content. None of them require a technical background.

SKILL	WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE
Briefing	Gives AI full context (audience, goal, voice, examples) using the CRAFT framework, instead of one-line requests
Evaluating	Spots factual errors, generic thinking and off-brand language quickly; knows when output is good enough
Iterating	Pushes back and refines in two or three rounds instead of accepting the first draft
Choosing	Picks the right AI for the task (see Appendix A), and knows when not to use AI at all
Protecting	Keeps confidential and customer data out of tools that aren't approved for it
Systematizing	Turns a prompt that works into a reusable template, a shared workflow or a checklist

Add one more for team leaders: **redesigning work.** The biggest gains don't come from doing the same tasks faster. They come from rethinking the workflow — who does what, in what order — now that AI can handle parts of it.

Your AI fluency self-assessment

Rate yourself on each of the six skills from 1 to 5.

AI SKILL	MY RATING (1–5)	ONE THING I'LL PRACTICE THIS MONTH
Briefing		
Evaluating		
Iterating		
Choosing		
Protecting		
Systematizing		

PRO TIP

The fastest way to build AI skill is to use it on real work every day, not to take a course about it. Pick one recurring task this week, do it with AI, and compare the result and the time with doing it the old way.

AI TIP

Get a personal AI coaching plan

```
Context: My role: [title and main responsibilities]. My AI fluency self-assessment: [paste your six ratings]. The tasks that take most of my week: [list].

Role: Act as an AI skills coach for marketing professionals.

Ask: Create a four-week practice plan.

Format: For each week: one real task from my own job to do with AI, the skill it builds, a sample prompt to start from, and how I'll know I did it well.

Tighten: Keep each week's practice under two hours.
```

CLOSING THE GAPS

Closing the Gaps

“Great things in business are never done by one person. They're done by a team of people.”

STEVE JOBS
60 Minutes, CBS (2003)

Your assessment scores show you where the gaps are. Now decide how to close each one. You have four options, and Chapter 2 covers the cost side of each:

- **Train** your current team. Best for skills you'll need permanently and that your people have the aptitude to learn.
- **Hire** new people. Best when you need deep expertise every day, such as a full-time content lead or paid media manager.
- **Outsource** to an agency or freelancer. Best for specialized or occasional work: technical SEO, video production, a website rebuild.
- **Automate** with AI. Best for repetitive tasks where AI is reliable and a trained team member can review the output.

Make training real

Training is where most transformations underinvest. A few things that work:

- **Use free platform training first.** Google, Meta, LinkedIn, HubSpot and most major marketing platforms offer free courses and certifications for their own tools. AI companies offer free learning resources for their assistants, too.

- **Protect learning time.** In 2025, the average employee got about 17 hours of formal training, or roughly 1.5 hours a month (ATD, 2026). Building AI skills takes more than that. Put two to four hours a month on every team member's calendar, and defend it.
- **Learn on live work.** Assign a real project alongside every course. Skills that aren't used within a week fade.
- **Teach back.** Have each person who completes a training teach the highlights to the team. It doubles the value of every course.
- **Run an AI show-and-tell.** Once a month, have each team member share one AI workflow that saved time and one that failed. Add the winners to your prompt library.

Hire for judgment, not just skills

When you hire, look for a growth mindset and a habit of learning, not just a list of tools on a résumé. Tools change every year. Curiosity, judgment and the ability to work across functions don't. Test candidates with a realistic task, and let them use AI so you can see how they think.

Your skills-gap action plan

List your three to five biggest gaps from the assessments, and decide how you'll close each one.

SKILLS GAP	PRIORITY (HIGH/MEDIUM/LOW)	TRAIN, HIRE, OUTSOURCE OR AUTOMATE?	OWNER	TARGET DATE

PRO TIP

Building an internal team takes a significant investment of time and money: hiring the right people, training them and giving them the right tools. You will almost certainly need to add resources to your current team. Plan for it now rather than discovering it in month four.

AI TIP

Turn your assessment scores into a training plan

```
Context: Our team's individual assessment scores, by person and skill: [paste]. Our organizational assessment scores: [paste]. Our strategy's top priorities for the next two quarters: [paste]. Our training budget: [amount]. Time available: [hours per person per month].

Role: Act as a marketing team development consultant.

Ask: Identify the skills gaps that matter most for our priorities, and for each, recommend whether to train, hire, outsource or automate with AI.

Format: The gaps in priority order, each with your recommendation and specific free or low-cost training approaches. Then a six-month training calendar as a table.

Tighten: Ignore gaps that don't affect our priorities.
```

SKILLS QUESTIONS

Skills Questions

For each team member: your digital marketing maturity

1. What are my strongest digital marketing skills, and where do I most need to improve to help the team succeed?

2. Which channels and tactics do I know best, and which do I need to learn to support the team's goals?

3. Which training programs or resources — from the company, platforms or industry associations — will I use to improve?

4. What opportunities can I seek out to gain more experience and broaden my skills?

5. How will I stay current with trends and best practices, and how will I share what I learn with the team?

6. Which tools or technologies do I need to master to be more effective in my role?

7. Which metrics should I monitor to measure the effectiveness of my work, and how will I use that data to improve?

8. Which collaboration and communication skills do I need to work well with teammates and stakeholders?

9. Which of my tasks could AI help with, and which of my skills will matter more as AI takes on routine work?

10. What goals will I set to keep improving, and when will I check my progress?

For leadership: building your marketing team

1. What is our current digital marketing maturity, and which areas must improve to execute our strategy?

2. What core competencies does our marketing team need, and do we have them?

3. Which work should we keep in-house, and which should we outsource or automate?

4. What budget do we need for our team, including salaries, benefits, training and tools?

5. What is our hiring plan, and how will we attract and keep top talent?

6. What training will we provide so our team stays current, including on AI?

7. How will we measure our team's success, and which KPIs will we use?

8. How will marketing work with sales, customer service and other departments?

9. What role will agencies, consultants and freelancers play, and how will we manage them?

10. How will roles on our team change as AI takes on more work, and how will we prepare people for that change?

PRO TIP

Is your organization aligned with your marketing team? Assess the organization's skills and commitment, not just the marketing team's. A skilled team without leadership support will stall.

AI TIP

Write role descriptions for an AI-era marketing team

```
Context: Our current marketing roles and responsibilities: [list each role and its tasks]. Our
strategy priorities: [paste]. Our AI fluency level: [Level 1–4 from the ladder].

Role: Act as a marketing leader who has restructured teams around AI.

Ask: For each role, rewrite the responsibilities to reflect how the work should be done with AI.

Format: For each role: what the person should own, what AI should assist with, and what new skills the
role needs.

Tighten: Flag any role whose work changes significantly, so we can plan training and conversations
with that person thoughtfully and honestly.
```

SWOT

Do you know where you stand?

In this chapter »

See your business clearly. Then decide and act faster than your competitors.

— **SWOT**
Strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats

— **YOUR SWOT ANALYSIS**
Run the exercise with your team

— **COMPETITIVE ANALYSIS WITH AI**
See what your competitors promise, and where they fall short

— **THE OODA LOOP**
Observe, orient, decide and act faster than the competition

— **CASE STUDY: SWOT IN ACTION**
How Wild West Custom Pools found its new position

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
4 AI Tips, including a competitor audit and turning your SWOT into an action plan

SWOT

SWOT: Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities and Threats

A SWOT analysis is one of the most useful exercises in your transformation. It tells you where you stand before you decide where to go.

Strengths and weaknesses are internal: things your organization controls, such as your team, website, content and budget. Opportunities and threats are external: things you can't control, such as competitors, algorithms, customer behavior and new technology. The goal is to build on your strengths, fix or work around your weaknesses, seize your opportunities and prepare for your threats.

A good SWOT becomes a roadmap for decisions. It tells you where to invest, what to fix first and what to watch.

Before you start

Know your goals first. Bring your one-year goal and KPIs from Chapter 1 and your strategy draft from Chapter 2. A SWOT done without goals produces a long list of observations. A SWOT done against goals produces priorities.

How AI changes the SWOT

In the first edition, most of a SWOT's effort went into gathering information: pulling analytics, reviewing competitors' websites, reading industry news. AI can now do much of that pre-work in hours. It can summarize your analytics, audit competitors' sites and ads, scan reviews of you and your competitors and list emerging trends in your industry.

That frees the meeting for what only people can do: deciding what the information means and what to do about it. AI can tell you a competitor has more reviews than you do. It takes your team to decide whether reviews are worth fighting for.

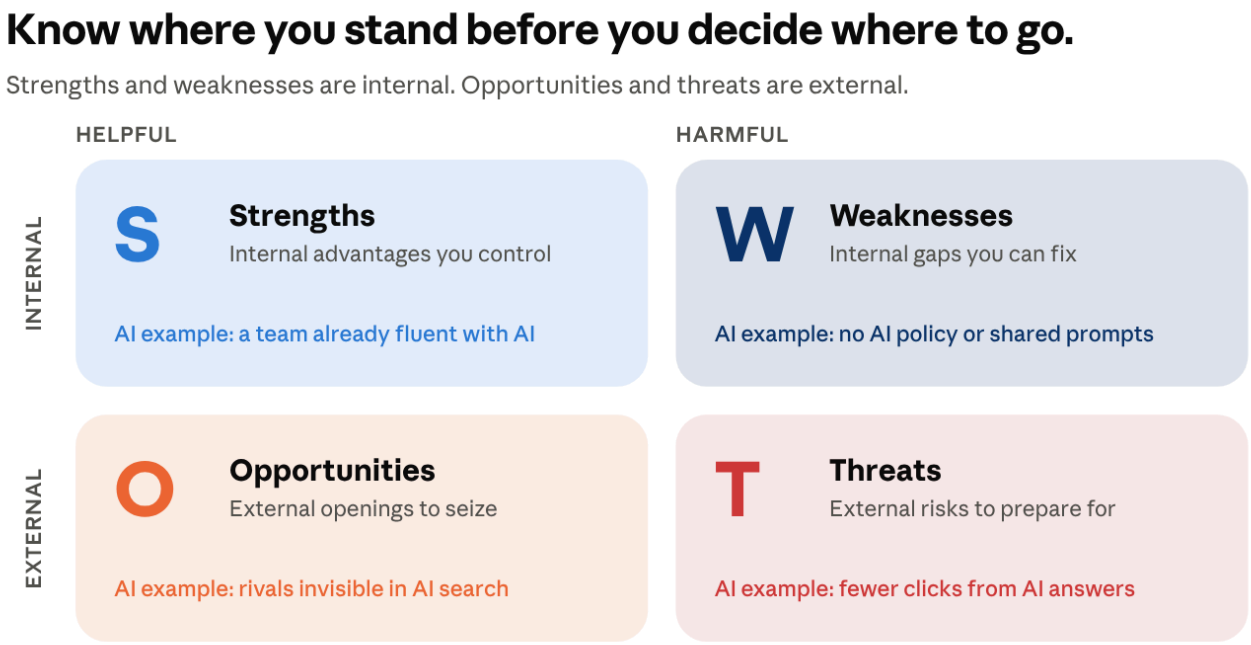
One caution: AI can be confidently wrong about competitors, especially small or local ones it knows little about. Treat AI research as a starting point and verify anything you'll act on.

PRO TIP

Involve a diverse group. Include people from sales, customer service and finance, not just marketing. If you can, add outside voices too: customers, partners or an industry expert. A small, like-minded group will miss things a mixed group will catch. This is one of the moments where an outsider can help (see Decide who runs the room, Chapter 1). A neutral person with no stake in the answers can draw out what people might not say in front of their boss or their own team.

YOUR SWOT ANALYSIS

Your SWOT Analysis



the SWOT framework · internal vs. external, helpful vs. harmful

Examples to get you started

Weaknesses are usually your longest list. That's normal, and it's useful: it shows you where to invest.

STRENGTHS	WEAKNESSES
Skilled, experienced marketing team	Limited digital marketing budget
Strong reviews and local reputation	Lack of expertise in key platforms or paid media
Fast, well-designed website that converts	Outdated processes; no written workflows
Strong rankings in search	Inconsistent branding across channels
Owned audience: a large email list and active social following	Poor tracking and measurement
Rich customer data in a CRM	Not enough content creation capacity
Original expertise and stories competitors can't copy	No AI guidelines; AI used ad hoc, if at all
Team already fluent with AI tools	Invisible in AI search answers

OPPORTUNITIES	THREATS
AI search: competitors not yet showing up in AI answers	Fewer clicks as AI answers questions directly
AI-assisted content, video and localization at lower cost	Competitors using AI to produce more, faster
New channels and platforms your audience is moving to	Changing algorithms and ranking factors
Personalization through email, automation and AI	Rising ad costs and automated ad platforms that are harder to control
Partnerships with complementary businesses	Privacy rules and tracking limits
Underserved local markets or segments	Negative reviews and AI summaries of them
Video and live content	Cybersecurity threats and data breaches
Customers frustrated with competitors (read their reviews)	Changing customer expectations and behavior

Your SWOT

List your top five items in each quadrant, in priority order.

STRENGTHS	WEAKNESSES
1. [FORM FIELD]	1. [FORM FIELD]
2. [FORM FIELD]	2. [FORM FIELD]
3. [FORM FIELD]	3. [FORM FIELD]
4. [FORM FIELD]	4. [FORM FIELD]
5. [FORM FIELD]	5. [FORM FIELD]

OPPORTUNITIES	THREATS
1. [FORM FIELD]	1. [FORM FIELD]
2. [FORM FIELD]	2. [FORM FIELD]
3. [FORM FIELD]	3. [FORM FIELD]
4. [FORM FIELD]	4. [FORM FIELD]
5. [FORM FIELD]	5. [FORM FIELD]

↓ SWOT template

How to run your SWOT meeting

Who to invite (5 to 12 people): senior decision-makers; marketing leaders; digital, website and paid media specialists; a data analyst; finance; sales; customer service; and an outside consultant if you have one. Invite them well ahead, and hold the meeting in a private room without interruptions.

What to bring: sticky notes and markers (or a shared digital whiteboard), a large wall or screen, your goals and KPIs, last quarter's data and the AI pre-work below.

1. **Do the AI pre-work (before the meeting).** Run the competitor audit and SWOT prompts in this chapter. Share the results with attendees a few days ahead, marked as draft input to challenge, not conclusions. *Time: 2 to 3 hours, one person.*
2. **Open the meeting (30 minutes).** Welcome divergent thinking. Define the purpose and scope: digital marketing only. Explain SWOT and walk through the examples above.
3. **Brainstorm strengths (1 hour).** Break into groups of two to four. Write one idea per sticky note, and generate as many as you can. Then collect, group and rank them.
4. **Repeat for weaknesses, opportunities and threats (about 1 hour each).** For opportunities and threats, look at competitors, budget, technology, skills, data, regulations, trends and customer research.
5. **Let AI organize the output.** Photograph the sticky notes or export the whiteboard. Ask your AI assistant to group duplicates, name the themes and draft a clean summary. Review it as a group.
6. **Prioritize and assign (2 hours).** Take the top three to five items in each quadrant and assign a small work group to each. Each action plan needs a responsible person, a timeline with milestones, success metrics, the resources required, a senior sponsor and the likely roadblocks. Decide how a win will be recognized and celebrated.

PRO TIP

Run the meeting well.

- **Come prepared.** Share data and the AI pre-work before the meeting, not during it.
- **Stay on objective.** Keep the conversation on digital marketing and your goals.
- **Get everyone talking.** Don't let one person dominate. Small groups help.
- **Use visuals.** Charts and diagrams help people understand and remember the data.
- **Stay open-minded.** Unconventional ideas often become the best opportunities.
- **Prioritize ruthlessly.** Twenty priorities means no priorities.
- **Assign owners and follow up.** A SWOT without owners and deadlines is just a list.

AI TIP

Do the SWOT pre-work

```
Context: Our business: [what we sell, to whom, where]. Our goals: [paste from Chapter 1]. Our current marketing: [channels, budget, team, recent results]. Our competitor audit results: [paste].

Role: Act as a digital marketing consultant preparing for a client's SWOT meeting.

Ask: Draft a SWOT analysis with five to eight items in each quadrant, covering all ten core disciplines and AI.

Format: For each item, the evidence behind it and your confidence level. Then ten questions our team should debate in the meeting.

Tighten: Label this clearly as a draft for discussion, not a conclusion.
```

COMPETITIVE ANALYSIS WITH AI

Competitive Analysis with AI

Your opportunities and threats come largely from your competitors. Before your SWOT meeting, audit your top three competitors across the ten core disciplines. In 2023, this was days of manual work. With AI and a few free tools, it takes an afternoon.

Where to look

DISCIPLINE	WHAT TO CHECK	WHERE TO FIND IT
Strategy and positioning	Their main promise, who they target, how they price	Homepage, About page, pricing page
Content	What they publish, how often, which topics	Blog, resources, newsletters
SEO and AI search	Keywords they rank for; whether AI assistants recommend them	An SEO platform; ask ChatGPT, Gemini and Perplexity
Paid media	Which ads they run and where	Meta Ad Library, Google Ads Transparency Center
Social media	Platforms, posting frequency, engagement	Their social profiles
Email and automation	What happens after you subscribe or fill out a form	Sign up and watch your inbox
Video	Formats, frequency and views	YouTube, social profiles

DISCIPLINE	WHAT TO CHECK	WHERE TO FIND IT
Website and conversion	Speed, calls to action, offers, forms	Their website on desktop and phone
Local SEO and reviews	Google Business Profile, review count, rating, responses	Google Maps, review sites
Analytics (estimated)	Rough traffic and trends	An SEO or traffic estimation platform

Your competitor scorecard

Rate each competitor, and yourself, from 1 to 5 in each discipline.

DISCIPLINE	US	COMPETITOR A	COMPETITOR B	COMPETITOR C
Strategy and positioning	☐	☐	☐	☐
Content	☐	☐	☐	☐
SEO and AI search	☐	☐	☐	☐
Paid media	☐	☐	☐	☐
Social media	☐	☐	☐	☐
Email and automation	☐	☐	☐	☐
Video	☐	☐	☐	☐
Website and conversion	☐	☐	☐	☐
Local SEO and reviews	☐	☐	☐	☐
Analytics (estimated)	☐	☐	☐	☐
Total	[calculated]	[calculated]	[calculated]	[calculated]

Competitor names: A [FORM FIELD] B [FORM FIELD] C [FORM FIELD]

Where you score lower than a competitor, you've found a weakness or a threat. Where you score higher, you've found a strength to build on. Where everyone scores low, you may have found your biggest opportunity.

PRO TIP

Study competitors' weaknesses, not just their strengths. Read their worst reviews. The complaints their customers repeat most often are the promises you can make, and keep.

AI TIP

Run a competitor audit

```
Context: We're a [type of business] in [market or region]. Our website: [URL]. Our top competitors:
[names and URLs].

Role: Act as a competitive intelligence analyst.

Ask: For each competitor, analyze their website and publicly available information, then compare them
with us.

Format: For each competitor: their positioning and main promise; who they target; their content and
SEO approach; their offers and calls to action; and what customers praise and complain about in
reviews. Then our three biggest competitive advantages and three biggest gaps.

Tighten: Mark clearly anything you couldn't verify or are inferring, so I can check it myself.
```

Note: Use an AI assistant with web browsing or research turned on for this prompt. Without it, the AI can only work from what it already knows, which may be out of date, especially for smaller and local businesses. Even with research turned on, check every figure at its source before you rely on it (see "Check the source, not the summary" in Chapter 1).

THE OODA LOOP

The OODA Loop



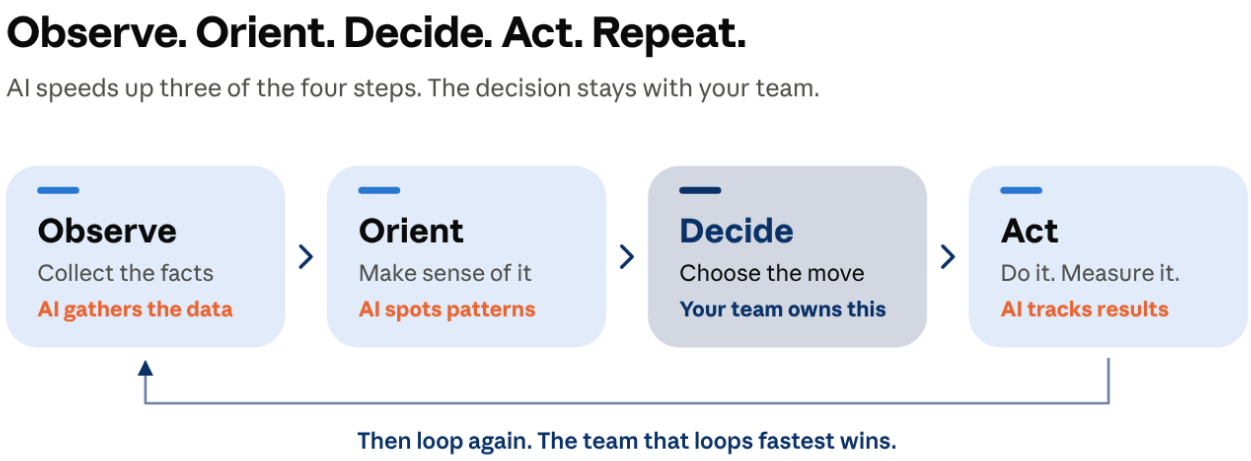
“A good plan violently executed now is better than a perfect plan next week.”

GENERAL GEORGE S. PATTON
War As I Knew It (1947)

A SWOT tells you where you stand. The OODA Loop helps you decide what to do about it, quickly, and keep deciding as conditions change.

The OODA Loop is a rapid decision-making model developed by U.S. Air Force Colonel John Boyd. Its insight is simple: whoever cycles through decisions faster gains the advantage. In business, that means the marketing team that observes, decides and adjusts faster than its competitors wins, even with a smaller budget.

Use it when your team is stuck. Use it when your team is too slow. Use it after your SWOT to turn findings into action.



the OODA Loop · four steps, repeated

Step 1: Observe

Collect data from every available source: your analytics, competitors, the market, customer behavior, reviews, costs and results. Gather as much as you can, as quickly as you can — but never hold a decision hostage to waiting for more data.

With AI: This is where AI saves the most time. It can summarize your reports, scan competitors' websites and ads, read hundreds of reviews and monitor industry news continuously.

> ***"The art of being wise is the art of knowing what to overlook."* — William James**

YOUR TURN

Step 2: Orient

Make sense of what you've gathered. Where do you stand compared with competitors? Which patterns, trends and openings do you see, now and coming? This is your SWOT, applied.

With AI: Ask AI to find patterns across your data and challenge your assumptions. Then verify what matters before you act on it.

> ***"If you don't know where you come from, then you don't know where you are, and if you don't know where you are, then you don't know where you're going."*** **— Terry Pratchett**

YOUR TURN

Step 3: Decide

Make the call as a team. Play to your strengths, seize opportunities, shore up weaknesses and address threats. Use a quick multi-vote, the Effort vs. Impact grid or the Ranked Scoring tool later in this book to prioritize.

This step stays human. AI can lay out options and trade-offs, but the decision — and accountability for it — belongs to your team.

> ***"In any moment of decision, the best thing you can do is the right thing, the next best thing is the wrong thing, and the worst thing you can do is nothing."*** **— attributed to Theodore Roosevelt**

YOUR TURN

Step 4: Act

Make the changes you decided on. Then monitor results against your KPIs, and run the loop again.

With AI: AI dashboards and automated reports can flag changes in your results daily instead of quarterly, so you know when it's time for the next loop.

YOUR TURN

PRO TIP

Speed beats perfection. A decision made this week with 80% of the information usually beats a perfect decision made next quarter. Set a deadline for every loop.

AI TIP

Run a fast OODA Loop on a problem

```
Context: The problem we're facing: [describe it, e.g., "leads dropped 30% this quarter"]. The data we have: [paste or attach reports]. What we know about competitors and the market: [summarize].

Role: Act as a strategic advisor using Colonel John Boyd's OODA Loop.

Ask: Work through the problem one step of the loop at a time.

Format: Observe: what the data shows, and what's missing. Orient: three possible explanations, ranked by likelihood, with evidence. Decide: three options with trade-offs. Act: for each option, the first three steps and the metric that tells us within 30 days whether it's working.

Tighten: Don't choose for us. The decision is ours.
```

SWOT ANALYSIS QUESTIONS

SWOT Analysis Questions

Dig deeper with these questions after your SWOT meeting.

1. Strengths. What are our key digital marketing strengths? What sets us apart from competitors? Which resources can we build on?

2. Weaknesses. Where are we struggling to gain traction or see results? Which skills or resources do we lack?

3. Opportunities. Where can we expand our digital marketing? Which new markets, segments or channels could we reach?

4. Threats. What external factors — competitors, market changes, regulations, AI-driven shifts in search — could hurt our results?

5. Target audience. Who are we trying to reach? What are their pain points and needs, and where do they look for answers?

6. Channels. Which of the core disciplines should we focus on to reach that audience? Are we using the most effective ones today?

7. Content. What content should we create to engage our audience? Does what we publish now resonate?

8. Messaging. What messages will set us apart? Would a buyer comparing us with competitors see a clear difference?

9. Branding. Is our brand communicated consistently across every channel, including how AI assistants describe us?

10. Metrics. How will we measure success? Which KPIs will we track, and how will we use the data to adjust?

CASE STUDY

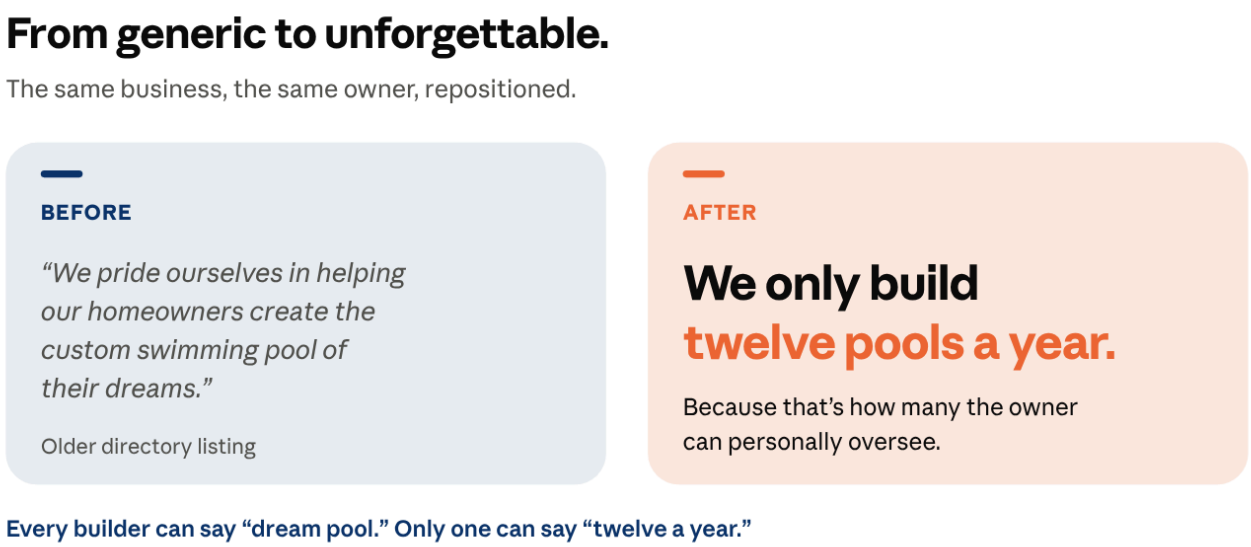
Case Study: SWOT in Action

Wild West Custom Pools: from general builder to "twelve a year"

Dan Huber, my younger brother and a client, had been running Wild West Custom Pools as a general-market pool builder in the Austin, Texas area. Over several conversations, I challenged him on who he was chasing: the lower-end buyer who had to finance a pool, rather than the client who could write a check. He decided to change course and become a boutique luxury builder for high-net-worth homeowners in Austin, Round Rock, Pflugerville and Hutto. He also needed a website, built from scratch, that would generate consultation requests.

You'll see Dan's business throughout this book, and here's why. In my agency work, the best results were often the hardest to share. Clients don't want their numbers, strategies and tactics in print, and they're right to protect what gives them an edge. Dan is different. He's a client, but he's also my brother, and he's comfortable letting us show the whole story: the decisions, the work and the results as they come in, good or bad.

The raw material was strong. Dan is a hands-on owner and builder. He partners with a separate designer who has more than 20 years of custom pool design experience. He deliberately limits himself to 10 to 12 pools a year, with projects from $90,000 to more than $350,000. But his message didn't show any of that. Like most builders, he described himself in terms any competitor could use.



Wild West Custom Pools · positioning before and after

The whole project ran through Claude, in Claude Cowork. It started with one prompt:

> ***"The owners want to move from being a general pool builder to a boutique builder doing only 10–12 pools a year targeting high net-worth individuals — can you look at competitors and come up with an HTML/JS website that generates leads?"***

There was no website builder or template. AI wrote every line of the site's code, and the first version was built in less than a workday. Here's how it came together.

Five steps. Each one accelerated by AI.

How Wild West Custom Pools went from general builder to boutique brand.



Wild West Custom Pools · the five-step AI-assisted makeover

STEP 1: RESEARCH THE COMPETITION.

AI researched how custom pool builders in the Austin area positioned themselves online. It also studied national boutique builders to set a standard for best-in-class. Most Austin competitors:

- Emphasized scale: large crews and many builds a year
- Used generic "quality craftsmanship" language
- Didn't mention the owner's personal involvement
- Had websites that felt template-driven, not boutique

The best national boutique builders had something in common: scarcity, personal service and an emphasis on the client relationship. The key finding from AI's analysis: *"No competitor owns the 'owner on-site + only 12 pools a year' angle."*

STEP 2: FIND A POSITION WORTH OWNING.

We tested five positioning angles against the research. The generic ones fell away fast:

Five angles tested. Two survived.

The positioning options, and why each one won or lost.

“Quality craftsmanship”	Every builder claims this	Rejected
“20-year design experience”	Accurate, but not ownable	Supporting point
“Austin luxury pool specialist”	A luxury signal, but still generic	Too generic
“Only 12 pools a year, by choice”	Scarcity and intentionality	Chosen
“Owner on-site every step”	Personal accountability	Chosen

The winners were combined into one promise. No Austin competitor was making it.

Wild West Custom Pools · positioning options considered

The two survivors became one promise: **"We only build 12 pools a year — because every one of them deserves the owner's full attention, from excavation to first swim."**

The insight behind it came from experience, not from AI. Hiring a pool company is stressful. Every homeowner has heard the stories. Mike's brief for the website copy put it this way: *"You don't have to submit a ticket; you can call the owner directly because you will have his phone number."* Every common fear about pool builders has a direct answer in the new promise:

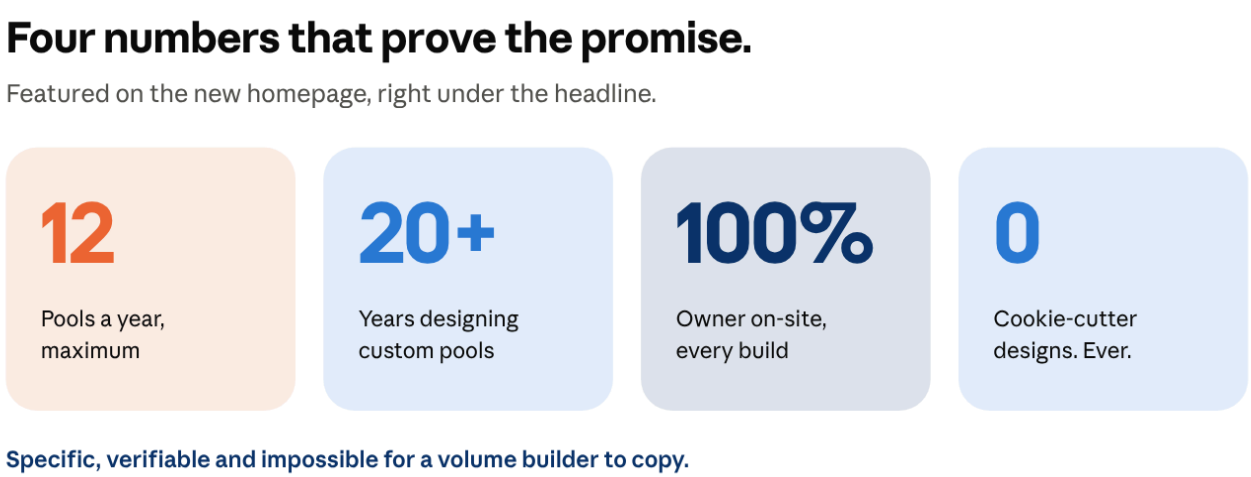
Buyers’ biggest fears became the promise.

What homeowners dread about pool builders, and the Wild West answer.

WHAT BUYERS FEAR	THE WILD WEST ANSWER
The owner vanishes after you sign	**The owner is on-site, start to finish**
Permits drag on for months	**Permit expertise, actively followed up**
Trades show up on their own schedule	**Owner present to hold trades accountable**
Rework: the designer never saw the build	**Work directly with a 20-year designer**
Questions go to a call center	**Call or text Dan directly**

Wild West Custom Pools · buyer fears vs. the brand promise

Then the promise needed proof on the homepage:



Wild West Custom Pools · homepage proof points

STEP 3: TURN FINDINGS INTO A SWOT.

AI drafted the SWOT from the research; we refined it with what we knew about the business.

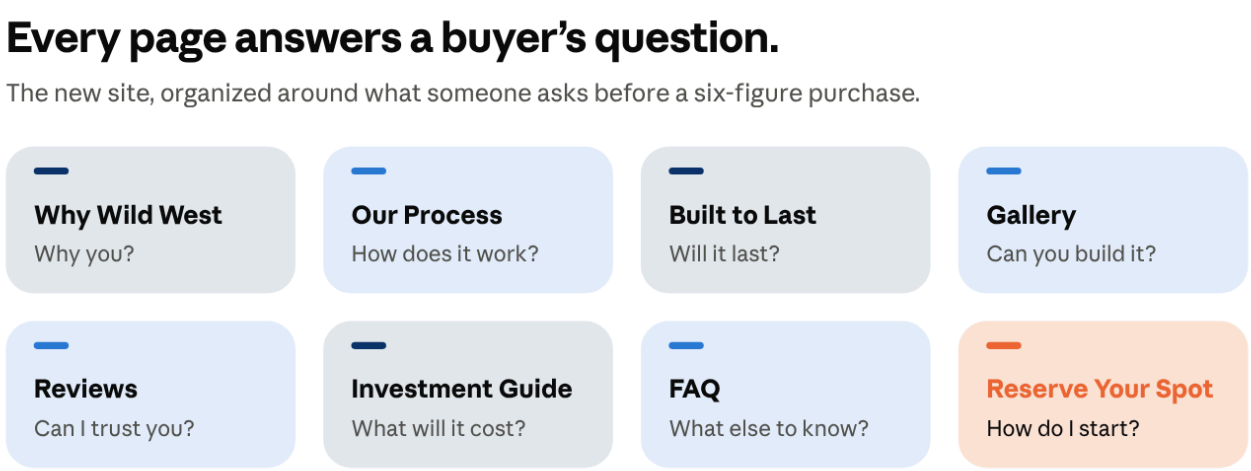
- **Strengths:** A hands-on owner; an experienced designer; real scarcity at 12 pools a year; strong Google reviews from real clients; a Zoom-first design process that suits busy buyers.
- **Weaknesses:** A new brand with no web presence; only seven pools photographed at launch; no video.
- **Opportunities:** One of the fastest-growing luxury home markets in the U.S.; no local competitor owns "boutique and owner-present"; Google reviews as a low-cost lead source; every finished pool as a neighborhood referral.
- **Threats:** Larger builders who can outspend on Google Ads; seasonal demand; permit and supply delays outside Dan's control.

STEP 4: BUILD, IN NINE ROUNDS.

AI produced the first complete website in a single pass. Then came nine rounds of review and revision, and that's where people mattered most.

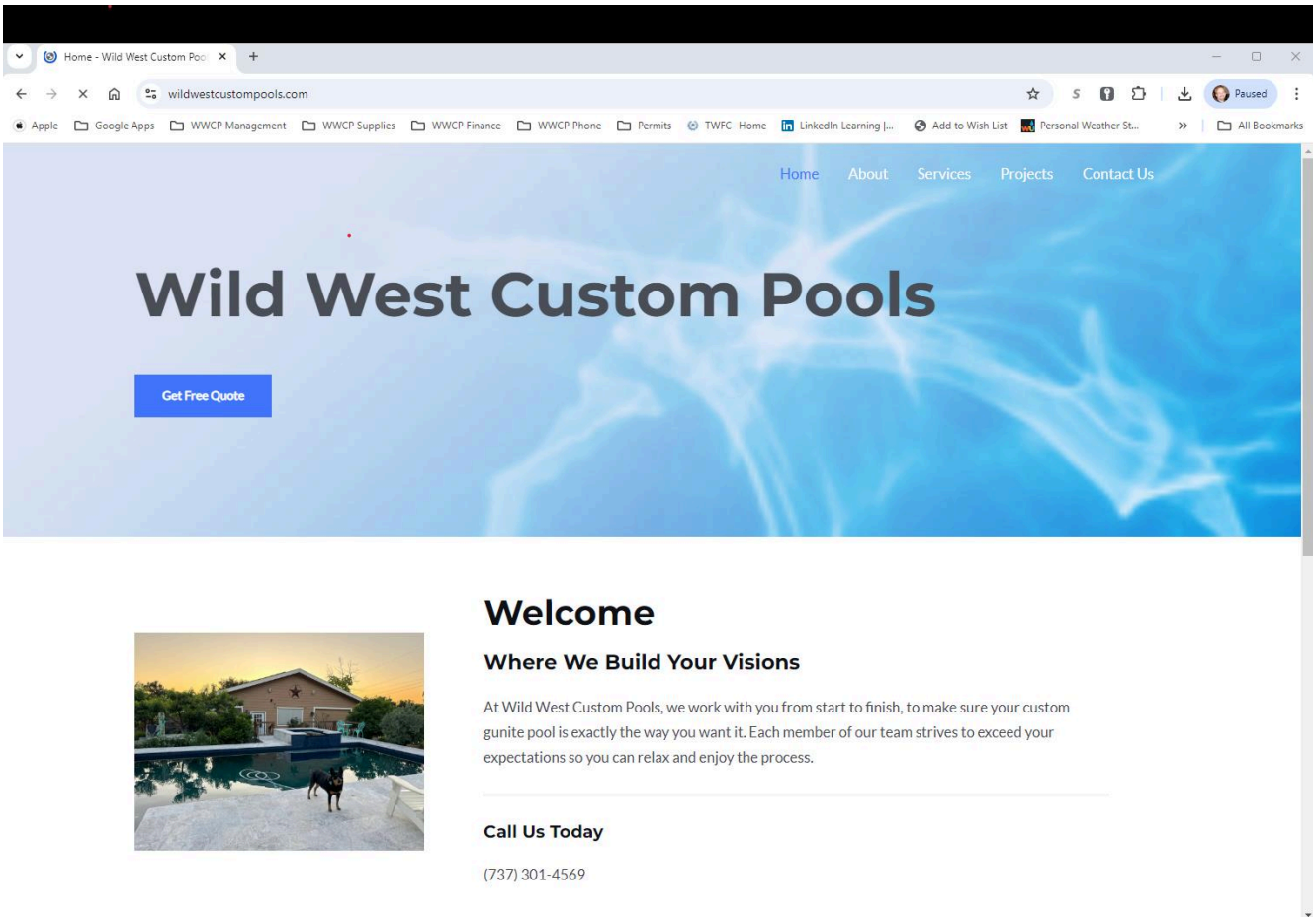
- **Fact-checking the copy.** AI's first draft claimed that Dan personally designs every pool. He doesn't; he works with a dedicated designer. Small wording changes mattered too: "every day" became "every step of the way," and "final swim" became "first swim." AI is fast, but it isn't fact-checked. A person who knows the business must read every word.
- **Real proof replaced placeholders.** Real pool photos, a hero image of an infinity pool overlooking the Austin skyline, eight real Google reviews and real pricing tiers.
- **Different AI tools for different jobs.** Dan's photo originally showed him in a baseball cap. An AI image tool swapped it for a Stetson that fits a Texas brand. (If you edit photos of real people with AI, get their consent first, and never change what makes the photo true.)
- **Technical issues took persistence.** The contact form took about seven rounds of troubleshooting before inquiries reliably reached Dan's inbox. After launch, a review found server log files containing visitors' personal information that were publicly accessible; they were deleted. When spam started arriving, invisible spam protection was added. AI builds fast, but someone must check security and privacy.

The result is a site where every page answers a question buyers ask before spending six figures:

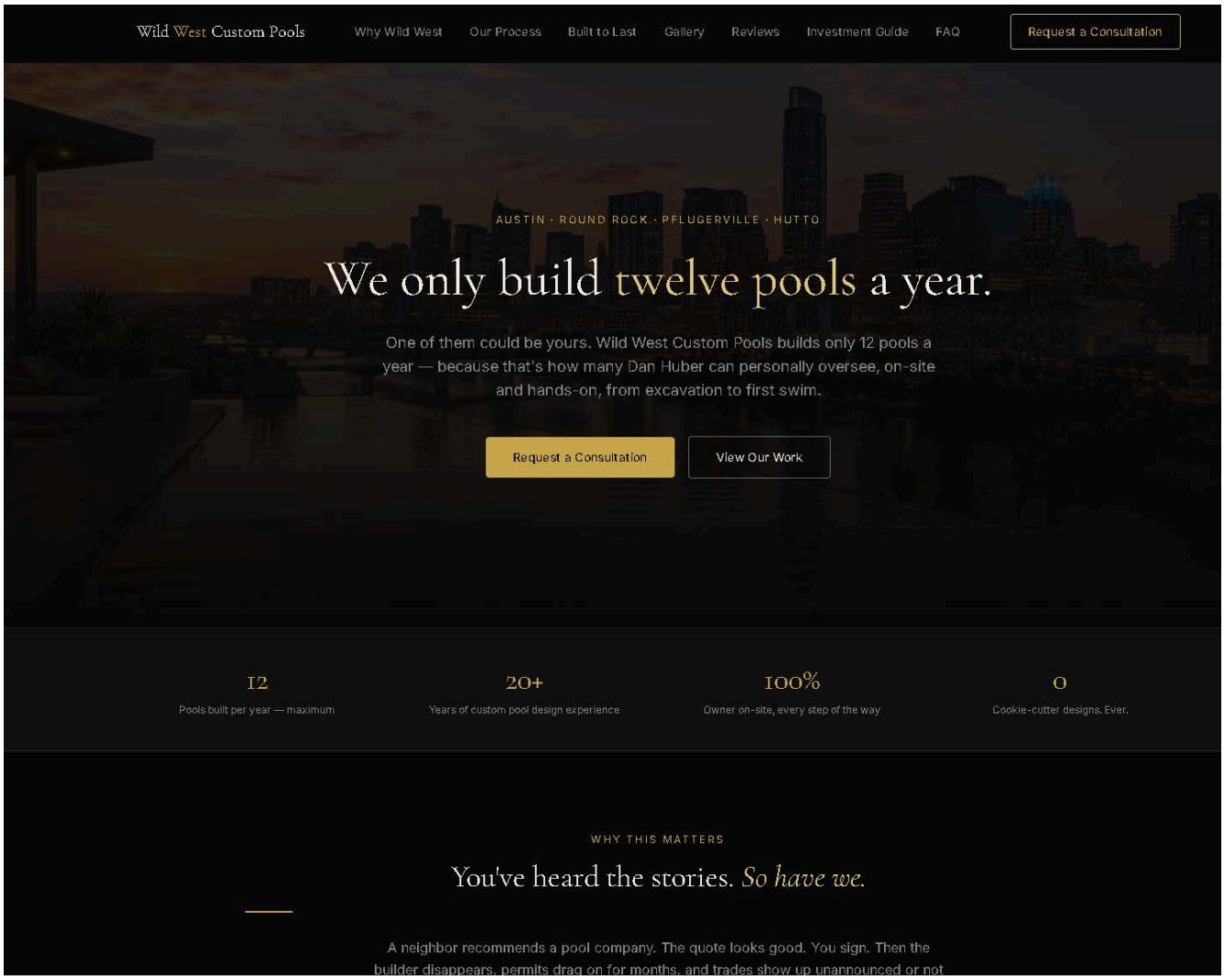


Wild West Custom Pools · site structure

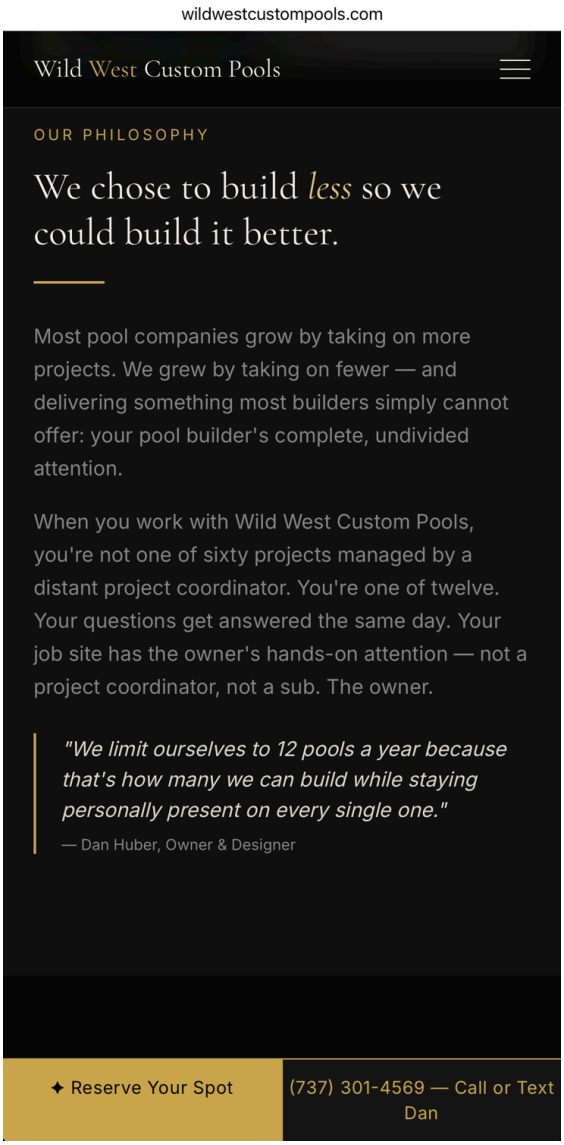
Before and after.



Before, September 2024: a template site with a stock pool photo and a generic headline, "Where We Build Your Visions."



After, 2026: the position leads the page. "We only build twelve pools a year," with the owner on-site from excavation to first swim.



On a phone, October 2026: the About page states the position in one line. "We chose to build less so we could build it better."

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

In the final layout, set the two home pages side by side, with the phone screenshot of the About page beside them. Caption: wildwestcustompools.com, September 2024 and 2026.

See the live site at wildwestcustompools.com.

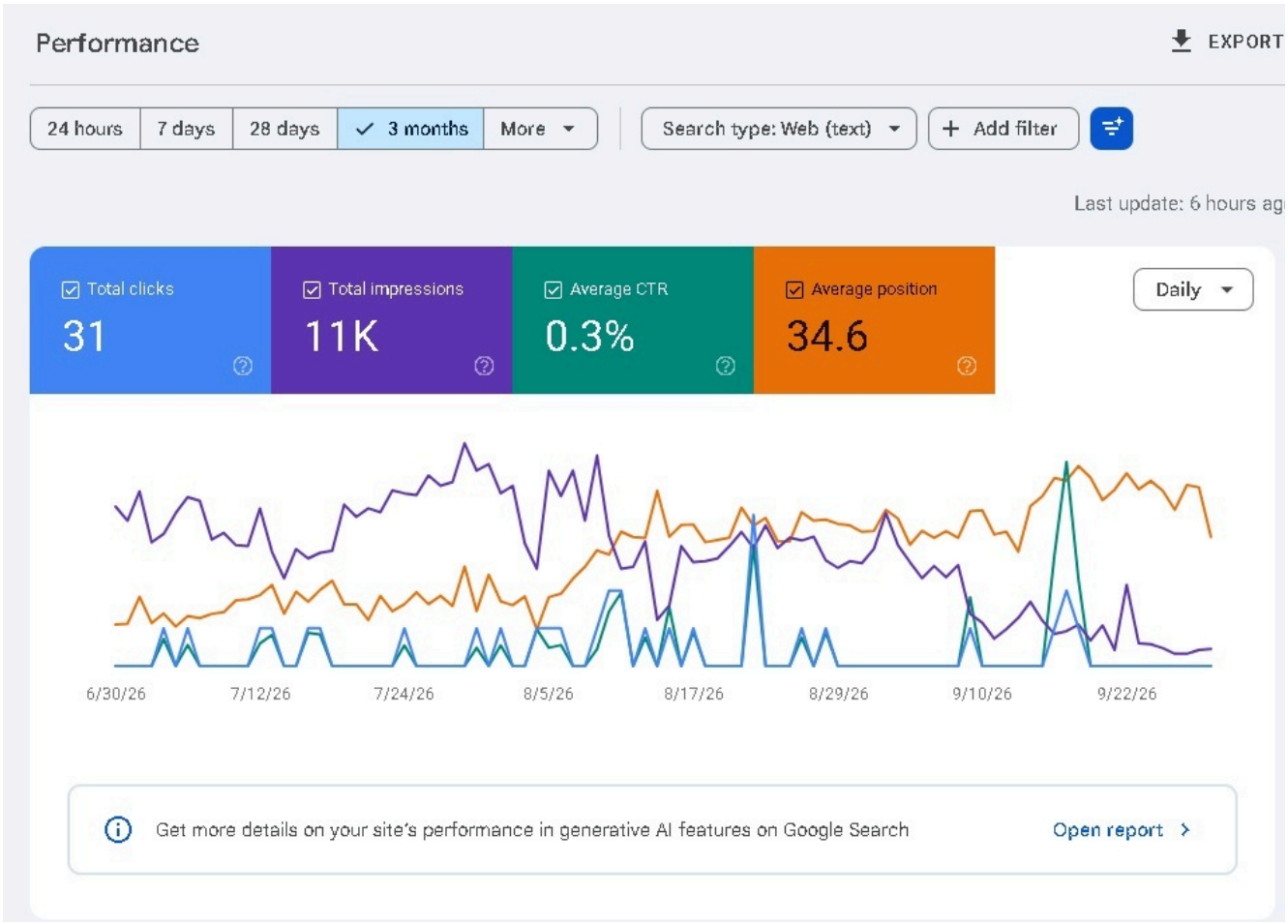
STEP 5: PROMOTE.

AI then drafted an advertising playbook for a $500 to $1,000 monthly budget: the free Google Business Profile first, Google

Search ads as the main paid channel, Facebook and Instagram second, and Nextdoor later, once finished pools are visible in neighborhoods. It wrote three search ads and three social ads, plus target and negative keyword lists, all built on the same position:

↗ Wild West Custom Pools · three Google search ads from the ad playbook

The results so far: it's too early to tell. The site launched in June 2026, and the early signs are in search. In its first three months, the site appeared in Google search results about 11,000 times and earned 31 clicks. Its average position over those three months was 34.6, up from an average of 43 in July alone. That's still around page 4 of the results. It tells us Google is finding the new pages, testing them and moving them up. It doesn't yet mean new business.



Google Search Console, three months from June 30, 2026: 31 clicks, 11K impressions, 0.3% average click-through rate, average position 34.6.

A custom pool that starts at $90,000 is a long, careful decision. As of October 2026, Dan is working a promising lead. There's no contract yet, but they've met a couple of times and are now discussing sample project plans and timelines. That's how this kind of sale moves: buyers take their time before they sign. This buyer looked over Dan's profile on the Better Business Bureau website first, then viewed the new site. That's the pattern to plan for: buyers check you in more than one place, and a trust signal somewhere else, like an A+ rating, sends them to your site. The site must finish the job.

We're telling you this plainly because most case studies only report the wins. The repositioning, the website and the ad plan are done. Whether they pay off is still being decided, one consultation at a time.

Follow the results. We'll report how Wild West Custom Pools does, good or bad, in our monthly newsletter, along with new AI prompts and tool updates as they change. Sign up at mikehuber.com/book. [NEWSLETTER: sign-up link in the PDF; the typed short URL and a QR code in print]

“We limit ourselves to 12 pools a year because that's how many we can build while staying personally present on every single one.”

DAN HUBER
owner, Wild West Custom Pools (About page, wildwestcustompools.com)

What AI changed: A custom-coded website, which traditionally takes weeks of design and development, was built in less than a workday. Competitive research, positioning options, page copy, ad copy and keyword lists that would have taken an agency team several weeks were drafted in hours. AI didn't supply the strategy. The decision to move upmarket came from our conversations about who to sell to, and Dan's way of working supplied the position. People made every decision, caught every wrong fact and approved every word.

Your best position may already be hiding in how you work.

The lesson for your business: Use AI to study your competitors and test angles quickly. Then build a site where every page answers a buyer's question — and keep a person in charge of facts, security and privacy.

PRO TIP

Revisit your SWOT every two quarters, at your QBR. Strengths fade, weaknesses get fixed and new threats appear. In AI-driven markets, a SWOT older than six months is probably out of date.

AI TIP

Turn your SWOT into an action plan

Context: Our goals: **[paste from Chapter 1]**. Our completed SWOT, with the top five items in each quadrant: **[paste]**.

Role: Act as a digital marketing strategist.

Ask: Using the TOWS method, recommend strategies in four groups: Strength-Opportunity (use our strengths to seize opportunities), Weakness-Opportunity (fix weaknesses by pursuing opportunities), Strength-Threat (use strengths to defend against threats) and Weakness-Threat (reduce our exposure where we're weak and threatened).

Format: A table of the top five strategies, ranked by expected impact and effort, with an owner and first step for each.

Tighten: Base every strategy on an item in our SWOT, not generic advice.

JOURNEY

Do you know your buyer's path?

In this chapter »

Meet buyers where they are, at every stage.

— **THE CUSTOMER JOURNEY**
Why buyers move in stages, and what they need at each one

— **THE FIVE STAGES**
From awareness to advocacy

— **MAP YOUR CUSTOMER JOURNEY**
Build a journey map for each persona

— **THE AI LAYER ON YOUR JOURNEY**
Where AI answers now meet your buyers, and how to avoid dead ends

— **JOURNEY MAPPING QUESTIONS**
Answer them with your team

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
7 AI Tips, including building a journey map for one persona and checking for AI dead ends

The Customer Journey

“There is only one valid definition of business purpose: to create a customer.”

PETER DRUCKER
The Practice of Management (1954)

Every step a buyer takes on the way to a purchase, and beyond it.

Your customers don't buy in a straight line. But they do buy in predictable ways. They notice a problem. They research. They compare. They decide. If you treat them well, they come back and send their friends.

The customer journey maps those steps. It shows you where buyers find you, what they need to know at each point, and where they drop out. Every piece of content you publish should serve one stage of that journey and move the buyer to the next one.

In this chapter you will:

- Define the stages of your own customer journey
- Score how well your marketing supports each stage
- Find the dead ends where buyers fall out
- Map the touchpoints for each of your personas
- List the questions your buyers need answered

What AI changed

The stages are the same as they were in 2023. What changed is where the early stages happen.

More of your buyer's research now happens inside an AI answer. They ask Google, ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini or Perplexity a full question and get a summary back. They may form an opinion of you before they ever reach your website.

The numbers show it. Seer Interactive tracked 5.47 million searches for 53 brands from January 2025 to February 2026. In February 2026, when a Google AI Overview appeared, 2.36% of organic impressions turned into a click. When none appeared, 3.82% did. Questions are the most likely to get an AI answer: a Washington University in St. Louis study of 55,393 Google searches in spring 2026 found AI Overviews on about 65% of searches phrased as questions, compared with 13.7% of all searches.

The companies' own data points the same way. In a September 2026 court filing, publishers suing OpenAI and Microsoft cite internal Microsoft data showing that clicks to The New York Times's websites were 87% to 93% lower from Bing Chat than from regular Bing search. They also quote a 2023 message from an OpenAI engineer: "No matter how prominently we show the links, users won't click" (Search Engine Journal, 2026). These are claims in an ongoing lawsuit, not a court finding, but they match what independent research shows.

The consideration stage is hit hardest. In Seer Interactive's 2026 data, 95.4% of comparison searches showed an AI Overview (Seer Interactive, 2026). When a buyer is weighing options, an AI answer is now usually standing between you and them.

That matters for the journey in two ways:

- **Awareness and consideration can happen without a visit.** The AI answer may be your first touchpoint. You don't control it, but you can feed it. Clear, specific, consistent facts about who you serve, where, and at what price give AI tools something accurate to say.
- **Your buyers ask questions.** The first edition said the customer journey is nothing more than a series of questions that must be answered. That is truer now. The searches most likely to get an AI answer are the ones written as questions. The business with the clearest answers wins the mention.

The AI Search Visibility section of the SEO chapter (Chapter 6) goes deeper on how to earn those mentions. This chapter makes sure your journey has no gaps for AI, or a buyer, to fall into.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Hero graphic.

THE FIVE STAGES

The five stages

Most journeys follow five stages. Yours may have more or fewer, and you'll define your own later in this chapter. Start here.

STAGE	WHAT THE BUYER IS ASKING	EXAMPLE TOUCHPOINTS
Awareness	"I have a problem. What are my options?"	AI answers, search results, social posts, video, PR, events, word of mouth, paid ads
Consideration	"Who can solve it, and how do they compare?"	Blog posts, comparison pages, reviews, case studies, webinars, retargeting ads, email
Decision	"Can I trust them? What does it cost? What happens next?"	Pricing pages, landing pages, FAQs, guarantees, demos, chat, a phone call
Retention	"Did I make the right choice?"	Onboarding, how-to content, check-ins, loyalty offers, personalized email
Advocacy	"Who should I tell?"	Review requests, referral programs, user-generated content, social sharing, surveys

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Redraw the first edition's journey wave (p.

Questions to ask at each stage

Each stage is a set of questions your buyer needs answered. Before you can answer theirs, answer these. Work through them with your team, and use what you know from real customers, not guesses.

Awareness. The buyer has a problem, or is about to. They don't know you yet. Ask:

- What problem sends people looking for a business like ours, and what happens just before they start looking?
- What words do they use to describe it, in search, in AI assistants and to friends?
- Where do they go to learn about it?
- What could we publish that helps them, even if they never hire us?
- What would make them want to know more about us?

Your Awareness answers:

Consideration. The buyer knows what they need and is comparing options. Ask:

- What are they comparing us with, including doing it themselves or doing nothing?
- What do they read, watch or ask while they compare?
- What trade-offs do they see between their options?
- When an AI assistant compares businesses like ours, what does it say about us?

Your Consideration answers:

Decision. The buyer has a short list, and we're on it. Ask:

- What finally tips the choice: price, proof, timing, trust or something else?
- What do customers who chose us say made the difference?
- What doubts are still in the way, and where do we answer them?
- What do they expect to happen after they say yes?

Your Decision answers:

Retention. The buyer has paid and is asking, “Did I make the right choice?” The first few weeks decide whether they buy again, and whether they'll ever recommend you. Ask:

- What does a new customer need in the first 30 days to feel they made the right choice?
- What questions or problems come up after the sale, and how fast do we answer them?
- How and when do we check in, and who owns it?
- What would make them buy from us again, or buy more?

Your Retention answers:

Advocacy. Happy customers can bring you the next ones, if you make it easy. Ask:

- Which customers are most like the buyers we want more of?
- What part of their experience would persuade someone like them?
- What questions could they answer better than we can?
- How will we ask for their review or story, and where will we share it?

Your Advocacy answers:

Your answers show where each stage is strong and where buyers get stuck. Use them to plan the content, pages and follow-up that move a buyer from one stage to the next, until they buy again and bring others with them.

AI TIP

Answer the stage questions with your customers' own words

```
Context: We sell [product or service] to [type of customer] in [market]. Below are real customer words: [paste reviews, emails, sales-call notes, chat logs or survey answers, with names and personal details removed].

Role: Act as a customer research analyst.

Ask: Using only this material, draft answers to the customer journey questions for the [Awareness, Consideration, Decision, Retention or Advocacy] stage.

Format: A table with three columns: the question, the draft answer, and the customer quote that supports it. Then a list of the questions this material can't answer.

Tighten: Don't guess. If the material doesn't answer a question, say so. Keep my customers' wording where you can.
```

The questions AI can't answer are your research list. Take them to your customers, your sales team and whoever answers your phone.

Some journeys are fast, some are slow

The stages are the same for every buyer. The time it takes to move through them is not. Someone buying hiking boots or a printer may go from Awareness to Decision in an afternoon. Someone buying a car, project-management software for a whole company or a custom pool may take months, with many touchpoints and more than one decision maker along the way.

The longer the journey, the more content and follow-up it needs, and the more places a buyer can fall out. A Wild West Custom Pools project starts at $90,000. Nobody buys that on a first visit. That's one reason the site publishes its price tiers early: it answers a Decision question while the buyer is still in Consideration.

How long is your typical journey, from first contact to purchase? Is it the same for every persona? _____

Beware the dead-end journey

A dead end is any point where a buyer is ready for the next step and finds nothing there.

The first edition's example still holds. A buyer finds you, learns about your product, decides it solves their problem and clicks to buy. The product is out of stock. Momentum gone. Often the buyer goes to a competitor.

Dead ends are usually quieter than that:

- A blog post with no next step or call to action
- A service page with no pricing range, so the buyer can't tell if you fit their budget
- A form that nobody answers for three days

- A happy customer who is never asked for a review

There is now a new kind: **the AI dead end.** A buyer asks an AI assistant about your category in your city. The answer names three competitors, not you. Or it names you with old prices, the wrong service area or a service you dropped. The buyer never reaches your site to find out otherwise. You can't fully control what AI tools say. You can make sure your website, your Google Business Profile and your review profiles all state the same clear, current facts.

PRO TIP: Audit for dead ends the way your buyer travels. Don't audit page by page. Pick one persona and walk the whole journey as them, from the first search to the thank-you email after the sale. Every time you hit a page with no clear next step, write it down. That list is your fix-it list.

The opposite mistake: pushing too soon

Dead ends lose buyers by giving them nothing. You can also lose them by giving them too much, too early.

Picture downloading a guide and getting a sales call before you've finished the first page. Most buyers don't want that. In Gartner's survey of 632 B2B buyers, 73% said they actively avoid suppliers who send irrelevant outreach, and 61% said they would rather buy without talking to a sales rep at all (Gartner, 2025). A call that comes too early isn't help. It's a reason to go elsewhere.

The lesson: match your follow-up to the buyer's stage. A first download is Awareness or early Consideration. Nurture it with more useful content. Watch for signs that a buyer is getting ready: repeat visits, a look at your pricing page, a second or third download, a direct question. Save the sales call for that buyer, or for the one who asks for it. A simple question on your form, such as "Would you like someone to contact you?", lets buyers tell you themselves.

Match your follow-up to the buyer's stage, not your sales target.

(Chapter 16, Lead Nurture, covers how to score leads and when to hand them to sales.)

Score your touchpoints

Score how well your marketing supports each stage of the journey. Use one score per box.

Score each box 0–5 **0** not used at this stage · **1–2** just beginning · **3–4** in use, results unclear · **5** in use, results clear

Add across for each discipline's total (up to 25). Add down for each stage's total (up to 50). The grand total is out of 250.

DISCIPLINE	AWARENESS	CONSIDERATION	DECISION	RETENTION	ADVOCACY	TOTAL
Strategy (personas, positioning, messaging)						
Content						
SEO and AI search						
Paid media (search, social, display, retargeting)						
Social media						
Email and marketing automation						
Video						
Website and conversion optimization						
Local SEO and reviews						
Analytics						
Total by stage						/ 250

The AI layer. Now score how far AI is built into your workflows at each stage. Use the AI fluency ladder from Chapter 3. This row is scored separately and does not count toward your 250-point total.

- **Level 1, Not started:** no AI at this stage
- **Level 2, Experimenting:** someone tries AI here now and then
- **Level 3, Using regularly:** AI is used here most weeks, by habit, not by process
- **Level 4, Integrated:** AI is a written step in the workflow, with a person approving the output

	AWARENESS	CONSIDERATION	DECISION	RETENTION	ADVOCACY
AI in our workflows (Level 1–4)					

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

In the final layout, set this row directly under the scorecard.

Offline and in-person touchpoints you rely on (events, trade shows, direct mail, phone calls, in-store visits, sales outreach): _____

Touchpoint scorecard in the companion workbook. Stage totals

What your total score reveals

TOTAL SCORE	WHAT IT MEANS
0–50	We need help. Start with one stage and one discipline.
51–100	You're a beginner, with dead-end gaps.
101–150	You're getting there, with room to improve.
151–200	You're strong in many areas. Look for the gaps.
201–250	You cover the whole journey. Keep testing and improving.

A perfect score isn't the goal. Not every discipline belongs in every stage. Paid media may matter little in Advocacy, and review requests matter little in Awareness. The question is whether a low score sits in a stage where your buyers expect to find you. Look at the stage totals first. The lowest stage total is usually your biggest dead end.

Customer journey checklist

- **Look at your lowest stage.** Which stage scored lowest? What would a buyer at that stage need from you that they can't find today?
- **Look for zeros.** Which disciplines are you not using at all? Decide whether each one is a real gap or simply not relevant to your buyers.
- **Look at your lowest AI stage.** What's one workflow at your lowest AI stage you could take to Level 4 this quarter? The AI layer table later in this chapter shows where to start.
- **Check your resources.** Low scores often point to missing skills, not missing effort. Compare this scorecard to your skills assessment in Chapter 3.
- **Document your needs.** A completed scorecard is evidence. Use it to show leadership where you need budget, people or training.

As you consider your total score: Where are your gaps? What will you fix first, and what resources will it take?

MAP YOUR CUSTOMER JOURNEY

Map your customer journey

Now build your own. You'll define your stages, check your content mix, list your buyers' questions and map the journey for each persona.

PRO TIP: Put yourself in your customer's shoes. Map the journey from their side, not yours. At each stage, ask what they are trying to get done, what they are feeling, and what they'll do next because of that feeling.

A buyer who just found you wants information. A buyer who just paid wants reassurance.

PRO TIP: Build the map with the people who talk to customers. Get stakeholder buy-in first. Then hold discovery meetings with sales, customer service and anyone else on the front line. They hear the real questions every day. Check what they tell you against your analytics, so you have both the numbers and the reasons behind them. Then align sales and marketing on the stages, so both teams use the same map.

Step 1: Define your stages

My customer journey stages (start with the five above; rename, add or combine to fit how your buyers really buy):

Step 2: Check your content mix

Each piece of content should help a buyer at one stage take the next step, or skip a step. Count the content you have published in the last 12 months and sort it by stage. Then set a goal.

YOUR TURN

STAGE	CURRENT % OF CONTENT	GOAL % OF CONTENT
Awareness		
Consideration		
Decision		
Retention		
Advocacy		
Total	**100%**	**100%**

Need a starting goal? In our 2019 book, we suggested putting 50% of your content into Awareness, 30% into Consideration, 15% into Decision and 5% into Advocacy. Two things have changed since then. AI answers now take many of the clicks that Awareness content used to earn (see "What AI changed" earlier in this chapter, and Chapter 6). And this edition adds Retention as its own stage. Here's an updated starting point:

STAGE	2019 STARTING POINT	2026 STARTING POINT
Awareness	50%	30%
Consideration	30%	25%
Decision	15%	25%
Retention	(not a separate stage)	10%
Advocacy	5%	10%

The research points the same way. Buyers want to make up their own minds. In Gartner's survey of 632 B2B buyers, released in June 2025, 61% said they prefer to buy without talking to a sales rep, and 73% actively avoid suppliers who send irrelevant outreach (Gartner, 2025). A year later, Gartner found that buyers used an average of seven information sources during a purchase, and 45% used AI tools to research vendors and products (Gartner, 2026). If buyers are deciding on their own, your pricing, comparisons, FAQs and proof must be there when they look.

Keeping customers pays, too. Acquiring a new customer costs five to 25 times more than keeping one, and Bain's Frederick Reichheld found that a 5% increase in retention increases profits by 25% to 95% (Harvard Business Review, 2014).

These percentages are starting points, not rules. Adjust them for your industry, your buyers and the length of your sales cycle.

My years of experience have shown that most businesses are heavy in Awareness and thin in Decision and Retention. Decision content (pricing, comparisons, FAQs, proof) is often what closes the sale.

Step 3: List the questions your buyers ask

The customer journey is nothing more than a series of questions that must be answered. Your buyers now type those questions, word for word, into AI tools and search engines.

What are the top questions buyers must have answered before they buy from you? Note the stage for each.

QUESTION	STAGE	WHERE WE ANSWER IT TODAY (PAGE OR ASSET)

Any question without an answer in the third column is a dead end.

Step 4: Map the journey by persona

Different buyers take different paths. A homeowner and a property manager may buy the same service for different reasons, through different channels. Map one journey per persona, using the personas you defined in Chapter 2.

Persona name: _____

STAGE	WHAT THEY NEED	TOUCHPOINTS AND CHANNELS	CONTENT WE HAVE	CONTENT WE NEED
Awareness				
Consideration				
Decision				
Retention				
Advocacy				

Repeat for a second persona.

Same product, two journeys. In our 2019 book, we used a home solar company to show how two personas can buy the same product for different reasons. One homeowner wants to cut their utility bill. The other wants to go green. Each needs different content at every stage:

STAGE	PERSONA 1: WANTS TO SAVE MONEY	PERSONA 2: WANTS TO GO GREEN
Awareness	"4 things raising your utility bill you didn't know about"	"10 ways to make your home greener"
Consideration	"Tax credits for homeowners who add solar"	"The best U.S. cities for generating your own solar power"
Decision	"Why buying solar panels saves more than leasing"	"How to choose an environmentally responsible solar installer"

When you build your own map, every blank square is a content gap. If you leave it blank, a competitor will fill it.

Questions to ask at each stage. Use your answers to the stage questions earlier in this chapter as you fill in the map.

↓ Persona journey map and question list in the companion workbook

Step 5: Plan how you'll ask for reviews

Reviews sit at the end of one buyer's journey and the start of the next. In BrightLocal's 2026 survey of 1,002 U.S. consumers, 97% said they read reviews for local businesses. The same survey found that the share of consumers using ChatGPT and other AI tools for local recommendations jumped from 6% to 45% in a year, and those tools draw on what your reviews say (BrightLocal, 2026).

Most happy customers won't write a review unless you ask. But when asked, most do: 83% of the people asked to leave a review in BrightLocal's survey went on to leave one. So ask, and make it easy:

- Ask in person when the job is done, then follow up with a short email or text with a direct link to your review page. Your Google Business Profile can generate that link.
- Give them a few questions to answer, so they aren't facing a blank box: What did you buy from us? What did you like best? Why did you choose us over the alternatives? Would you recommend us, and to whom?
- Respond to every review, good or bad, in your own voice. Use negative reviews as training. Look for patterns and fix the cause.
- Ask every customer, not just the ones you expect to be happy. Google prohibits selectively asking for positive reviews. Never pay for a review or offer anything in exchange for one. It's now federal law, not just platform policy: the FTC's rule on consumer reviews took effect in October 2024, and in December 2025 the FTC began sending warning letters, with civil penalties of up to $53,088 per violation (see Chapter 8, Local SEO and Reviews).

When and how will we ask each customer for a review? Who owns it? _____

AI TIP

Draft your review request

```
Context: I run [business name], a [business type] in [city]. A customer, [first name only], just
finished [project or purchase]. Our review link is [link].

Role: Act as a customer service lead who writes warm, short messages.

Ask: Write a review request I can send by email and a shorter version for text. Thank them for
something specific about their project, ask for a review, and include three easy questions they can
answer: what they bought, what they liked best and why they chose us.

Format: Email under 120 words with a subject line; text under 300 characters.

Tighten: No pressure, no incentives, no exclamation points. It should sound like me, not like a
template.
```

Let AI do the first draft

You think, AI drafts, you decide. The answers you just wrote are the context AI needs. Paste them in.

AI TIP: Draft your journey stages and buyer questions

Context: I run [business type] serving [customer type] in [market or location]. Our main offer is [product or service] at [price range]. Here are notes from our sales and service team on what buyers ask: [paste notes, FAQs or anonymized emails]. Role: Act as a customer journey strategist who has mapped journeys for small and mid-size businesses. Ask: Propose the stages of our customer journey, from first awareness to advocacy. For each stage, list the top five questions our buyers ask. Format: A table with columns: Stage, Buyer's goal, Top questions, Emotion at this stage. Tighten: Use our buyers' own words where the notes allow. Flag any question you added that isn't in my notes.

AI TIP: Build a journey map for one persona

Context: Here is our persona: [paste persona from Chapter 2]. Here are our journey stages and the channels we use: [paste stages and channels, including paid media]. Role: Act as a digital marketing strategist. Ask: Map this persona's journey. For each stage, give their need, the three touchpoints most likely to reach them, and one piece of content that would move them to the next stage. Format: One table, one row per stage. Tighten: Only recommend channels from my list. Mark any touchpoint where we have no content today.

AI TIP: Find what your customers feel at each stage

Context: Here are [number] customer reviews, survey answers and support emails, with names and personal details removed: [paste text]. Role: Act as a customer research analyst. Ask: Sort each comment by journey stage. Find the top pain points, worries and moments of delight at each stage. Format: A table by stage with pain points, worries and delights, each with one short example quote. Tighten: Quote only from the text I gave you. Don't invent customer quotes. Tell me which stages have too little feedback to judge.

Protect your data: remove names, emails, phone numbers and account details before you paste customer feedback into any AI tool. Check your company's AI policy for what can be shared.

The AI layer on your journey

“You've got to start with the customer experience and work backwards to the technology.”

STEVE JOBS
Apple Worldwide Developers Conference (1997)

AI can help at every stage. It drafts, sorts, tests and personalizes. People still approve everything public, check the facts and add what AI can't: real experience, real proof and judgment.

STAGE	WHERE AI HELPS	WHAT STAYS WITH PEOPLE
Awareness	Turning buyer questions into content ideas; drafting ad variations for paid media; checking what AI assistants say about your category	Choosing which questions you can answer best; final approval of every ad and post
Consideration	Drafting comparison pages and FAQs; summarizing reviews into themes; building retargeting audiences inside ad platforms	Real case studies, real numbers, your point of view
Decision	Website chat that answers common questions; drafting landing pages; testing headlines and offers	Pricing, guarantees and promises; the sales conversation
Retention	Personalizing onboarding and follow-up emails; spotting customers who have gone quiet	The relationship; how you handle problems
Advocacy	Drafting review requests and referral emails; sorting feedback by theme	Asking in person; thanking people; responding to reviews in your own voice

AI TIP: Check for AI dead ends

Context: I run [business name], a [business type] in [city or region]. We serve [customer type] and our prices run [price range]. Role: Act as a buyer researching this category for the first time. Ask: Answer these as you normally would: "Who are the best [category] providers in [city]?" "How much does [service] cost in [city]?" "What should I look for when hiring a [category]?" Format: Your normal answers, then a list of every business you named. Tighten: Run the same prompt in two or three AI tools and in Google. Record whether you appear, what is said about you, and whether it is accurate. Repeat every quarter.

This AI TIP is a test, not a fix. If you don't appear, or the facts are wrong, the fix is on your own properties: your website, Google Business Profile and review profiles. The AI Search Visibility section of Chapter 6 covers how.

AI TIP: Audit your content for dead ends

Context: Here are our journey stages: [paste stages]. Here is a list of our web pages, blog posts, emails and ads, with a one-line description of each: [paste list]. Role: Act as a conversion strategist auditing a customer journey. Ask: Assign each item to a stage. Then find the gaps: stages with little or no content, and pages with no clear next step. Format: A table of items by stage, then a numbered list of the ten most important gaps, each with one suggested fix. Tighten: Base the audit only on the list I gave you. Rank the gaps by how close the buyer is to buying, with Decision-stage gaps first.

AI TIP: Turn your scorecard into an action plan

Context: Here is our touchpoint scorecard, scored 0 to 5 by discipline and stage: [paste scorecard]. Our team is [team size and roles] and our monthly marketing budget is [amount]. Role: Act as a marketing director planning the next 90 days. Ask: Find our three biggest gaps and propose a 90-day plan to close them. Format: A table with Gap, Why it matters, Action, Owner, Cost, and How we'll measure it. Tighten: Stay within our budget and team. Include paid media where it fits. Tell me what you would not do yet, and why.

Example: Wild West Custom Pools

Wild West Custom Pools builds custom pools in the Austin metro. In June 2026 the company repositioned from a general builder to a boutique luxury builder, using Claude for the research, positioning, website and ad plan. (Chapter 4 tells the full story.) The new site and ad plan were built around the journey of a high-end homeowner.

STAGE	THE BUYER'S REAL QUESTION	WHAT WILD WEST BUILT
Awareness	"Who builds luxury pools near me?"	Google Search ads on luxury and local pool-builder keywords; a Google Business Profile set up first; Facebook and Instagram ads with the best pool photos
Consideration	"Will this builder disappear on me?"	A message aimed straight at that fear: the owner is on-site from excavation to first swim, and clients get his direct number. A gallery of real pools. Eight real Google reviews.
Decision	"Can I afford this, and how does it work?"	Three published price tiers ($90K–$150K, $150K–$350K, $350K+), an FAQ, a clear consultation process with Zoom design meetings, and a contact form tested until every inquiry arrived
Retention and Advocacy	"Who should I tell?"	Planned: each finished pool becomes a visible referral in its neighborhood, with Nextdoor added once enough pools are built

Two choices stand out. First, the site publishes prices. That answers the Decision question early and keeps buyers who don't fit the budget from becoming dead-end leads. One of the Google ads does the same: it leads with "Custom Pools From $90K." Second, a retargeting ad follows site visitors who didn't inquire. It brings Consideration-stage buyers back instead of losing them.

We asked Dan what buyers ask most in the first meeting. He named two questions: "How much is this going to cost?" and "When can we swim?" Both are Decision-stage questions, and buyers bring them to the very first conversation. The published price tiers answer the first one before a buyer ever calls. Dan's answer to the second: a custom gunite pool typically takes 12 to 16 weeks to build once excavation begins, depending on the design and permitting. An honest answer like that belongs on the site, too, so buyers don't have to wait for a meeting to hear it.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Wild West journey strip: five rounded cards.

CUSTOMER JOURNEY MAPPING QUESTIONS

Customer journey mapping questions

Answer these with your team. Then paste your answers into your AI assistant with the action-plan AI TIP above.

1. How do customers become aware of us? Which channels do they use to find us: search, AI assistants, social media, paid ads, referrals or something else? [FORM FIELD]
2. When we ask AI assistants about our category and city, do we appear? Is what they say accurate? [FORM FIELD]
3. What key factors do buyers weigh when they evaluate us? What information do they need to decide? [FORM FIELD]
4. What does the path to purchase look like? What barriers or friction could stop a buyer from buying? [FORM FIELD]
5. Do we have content that answers our buyers' pain points and needs at every stage? Where are the dead ends? [FORM FIELD]
6. What can we do to reduce friction in the purchase? Are our pricing and payment options clear? [FORM FIELD]
7. Are we using the right mix of channels, including SEO and AI search, paid media, social media, email and content? [FORM FIELD]
8. How can we create a customer experience good enough to earn loyalty? [FORM FIELD]
9. How do we turn satisfied customers into advocates? What are our touchpoints for reviews and referrals? [FORM FIELD]
10. Which metrics will we track at each stage? Examples: search and AI visibility, website traffic, engagement, conversion rate, cost per lead, repeat purchases and review volume. [FORM FIELD]

All Chapter 5 worksheets in the companion workbook: touchpoint scorecard

SOURCES

Sources

- Seer Interactive, "AIO Impact on Google CTR: 2026 Update," April 24, 2026.
- Washington University in St. Louis, "WashU research finds gaps in Google AI Overview citations, claims," September 2026.
- Gartner, "Gartner Sales Survey Finds 61% of B2B Buyers Prefer a Rep-Free Buying Experience," June 25, 2025 (632 B2B buyers, surveyed August–September 2024).
- Gartner, "Gartner Survey Finds 69% of B2B Buyers Turn to Sales Reps to Validate AI-Generated Insights," May 20, 2026 (645 B2B buyers, surveyed August–September 2025).
- Amy Gallo, "The Value of Keeping the Right Customers," Harvard Business Review, October 29, 2014.
- BrightLocal, "Local Consumer Review Survey 2026," February 11, 2026 (1,002 U.S. adults).

SEARCH

Can buyers and AI find you?

In this chapter »

Get found in search. Get cited in AI answers.

— **HOW YOU GET FOUND NOW**
Search results and AI answers start in the same place

— **ON-PAGE AND TECHNICAL SEO**
Make every page count, and make sure it can be reached, read and loaded

— **AUTHORITY**
Why should anyone trust this page?

— **AI SEARCH VISIBILITY**
Get cited, not just ranked

— **MEASURE, THEN BUILD**
Measuring SEO, and a worksheet to build an optimized page

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
7 AI Tips, from auditing a page before you publish to running an AI visibility check

OPTIMIZE TO GET FOUND

Optimize to Get Found

Search engine optimization (SEO) is how buyers find you when they're ready to look. It's still the highest-intent traffic most businesses will ever get: the person typed the problem you solve.

What changed is who answers the question. Google now puts AI Overviews and AI Mode above the links, and many buyers ask ChatGPT, Gemini or Perplexity before they search at all. Pew Research tracked the Google searches of 900 U.S. adults in March 2025. When an AI summary appeared, people clicked a regular search result on 8% of visits. When it didn't, they clicked on 15% (Pew Research Center).

The AI companies' own data points the same way. In a September 2026 court filing, publishers suing OpenAI and Microsoft cite internal Microsoft data showing that clicks to The New York Times's websites were 87% to 93% lower from Bing Chat than from regular Bing search. They also quote a 2023 message from an OpenAI engineer: "No matter how prominently we show the links, users won't click" (Search Engine Journal, 2026). These are claims in an ongoing lawsuit, not a court finding, but they match the independent research.

That sounds like bad news for SEO. It isn't. AI answers are built from pages that search engines can crawl, understand and trust. Google says there are no extra requirements to appear in AI Overviews or AI Mode, and no special files or markup to create; the same SEO best practices apply (Google Search Central). Good SEO is now the entry ticket to both the links and the answers.

This chapter covers the foundation:

- **On-page SEO** — what's on the page, and how it's labeled
- **Technical SEO** — whether search engines and AI crawlers can reach, read and load it
- **Authority** — why anyone should trust it
- **AI search visibility** — how to get AI assistants to find you, describe you accurately and cite you
- **Measurement** — how you know it's working

Keyword research has its own chapter later in the book, and so do local SEO and reviews. Here, we build the pages they all depend on, then show what to add so AI assistants cite them.

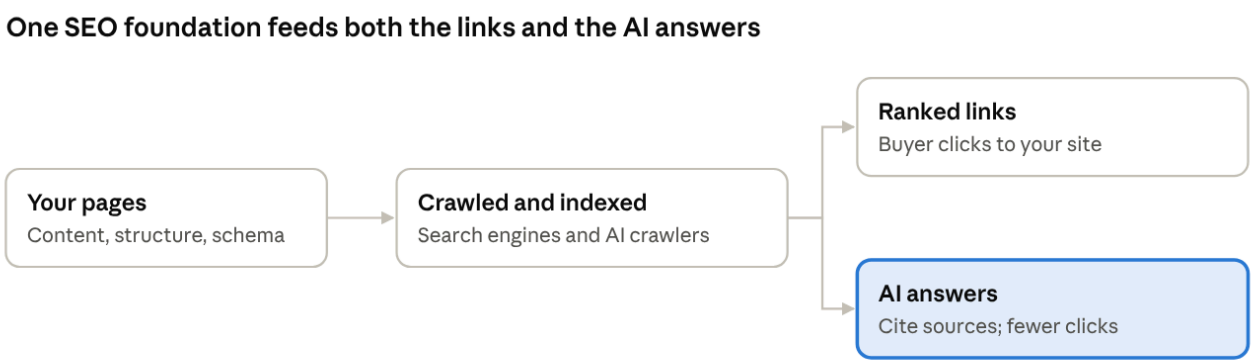
PRO TIP

Optimize before you publish, not after. Think about the hours your team spends creating a valuable piece of content. Then spend 10–15 minutes optimizing it so search engines and AI can find it. It will be time well spent.

HOW YOU GET FOUND NOW

How You Get Found Now

There are now two ways a buyer finds you through search, and both start in the same place.



how a page reaches buyers · links and AI answers

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

final print version — the AI answers path

The links. The classic results page still matters. When a buyer clicks through from search, they arrive with a question you can answer and a reason to act.

The answers. AI Overviews, AI Mode and AI assistants read pages, summarize them and cite a few sources. Your page can shape the answer even when nobody clicks. Google says clicks from results pages with AI Overviews are higher quality, and that they're counted in your Search Console traffic with everything else (Google Search Central).

AI answers now show up often, and they take clicks. A Washington University in St. Louis study of 55,393 Google searches in March and April 2026 found AI Overviews on 13.7% of all searches and on about 65% of searches phrased as questions (WashU, 2026). When one appears, the top-ranking page gets 58% fewer clicks on average, according to an Ahrefs study of 300,000 keywords (Ahrefs, 2025). Being cited softens the loss. Seer Interactive found that brands cited in an AI Overview earn 120% more organic clicks per impression than brands that are left out, though still about 38% fewer than when no AI Overview appears (Seer Interactive, 2026).

The goal is no longer just to rank. It's to be the source the answer cites.

What this means for you:

- **The basics matter more, not less.** If a page can't be crawled, read and trusted, it can't rank or be cited.
- **Answer real questions clearly.** AI tools pull the clearest answer to a specific question. Vague pages get skipped.
- **Show first-hand experience.** Anyone can generate a generic page. Your projects, photos, data and opinions are what AI can't copy.

- **Measure more than rankings.** Track leads and conversions from search, and check how AI describes you. You set your AI visibility baseline in Chapter 1.

PRO TIP

Don't chase every new acronym. GEO, AEO and LLMO all describe the same goal: being the source AI trusts. That goal starts with good SEO. AI Search Visibility, later in this chapter, shows you what to add on top.

ON-PAGE SEO

On-Page SEO: Make Every Page Count

On-page SEO is everything on the page itself: the content, and the labels that tell search engines and AI what it's about. You control all of it.

Start with content worth finding

The quality of the content is still the biggest on-page factor. Google's guidance is to create helpful, reliable content made for people, not to manipulate rankings (Google Search Central).

There's no magic length. Google says content length alone doesn't matter for ranking, with no word count target, minimum or maximum (SEO Starter Guide). Cover the topic fully, answer the questions your buyer actually asks, and stop.

Title tags

The title tag is the clickable headline in search results, so it shapes whether people click. Google builds that headline mostly from your title tag, but it can also use your H1, other prominent text on the page or links pointing to it (Google Search Central). Write a title Google won't want to rewrite:

- Describe the page clearly and concisely. Avoid vague titles like "Home."
- Lead with the topic your buyer searches for.
- Make every page's title unique.
- Add your brand name at the end, separated by a hyphen or pipe, where it fits.
- Don't repeat keywords. It looks spammy and doesn't help.

Meta descriptions

The meta description is the short summary that often appears under your title in search results. It doesn't affect rankings, but it's a pitch for the click (SEO Starter Guide). Keep it short and unique to the page, include the most relevant points and end with a reason to act.

Headings

Use one H1 that states the page's main topic, then H2s and H3s to organize the rest. Google says heading order doesn't affect Search, but a clear hierarchy helps readers scan and helps screen readers (SEO Starter Guide). It also helps AI tools find the specific answer to a specific question.

URLs

Keep URLs short, readable and descriptive. Use hyphens between words, and avoid long strings of numbers and parameters. Don't bother stuffing keywords in: Google says keywords in a URL have hardly any effect beyond appearing in breadcrumbs (SEO Starter Guide). A clean URL is for people.

Images

Optimized images help pages load faster and can show up in image search.

- **Use descriptive file names.** "bisbee-vintage-taxi.jpg," not "IMG_4521.jpg."
- **Write real alt text.** Describe the image for someone who can't see it. That's what alt text is for, and it's also how search engines understand the image.
- **Compress images** to cut load time without visible loss of quality.
- **Use responsive images** that resize for phones, tablets and desktops.
- **Add captions and context** so the image supports the page.



ALT TEXT

```
alt="Vintage taxicab outside an old gas station in Bisbee, Arizona, just down the street from the
Breakfast Club Cafe"
```

Photo by Mike Huber

Internal links

Link to related pages on your own site using descriptive anchor text, not "click here." Internal links help visitors find their next step and help search engines understand which pages matter most.

Duplicate content

When several pages carry the same or nearly the same content, search engines have to guess which one to show, and they may show none of them well. Find duplicates with a site crawler or a tool like Siteliner, and check the Page indexing report in Google Search Console, which flags duplicate pages and the canonical version Google chose. Then fix them: merge pages, rewrite them or add a canonical tag that tells search engines which version is the original.

PRO TIP

Write the title and the first paragraph last. Once the page is done, you know exactly what it promises. Put that promise in the title, and answer the main question in the first two sentences.

AI TIP

Audit a page before you publish it

```
Act as a senior SEO strategist reviewing a page before it goes live.

Our business: [one or two sentences on what you sell, to whom, and where]

The buyer this page is for: [paste persona from your field guide]

The main question this page answers: [question]

Here is the page, including the title tag, meta description, URL and headings:

[paste page]


Check the page against on-page SEO best practices. For each issue, explain

the problem and give the fix. Then rewrite the title tag (three options)

and the meta description (two options). Flag anything that claims a fact,

number or result I should verify before publishing.
```

AI TIP

Write alt text for a batch of images

```
Act as an accessibility specialist and SEO editor.

The page these images appear on is about: [topic]

For each image below, write one short sentence of alt text that describes

what a person would see, in plain language, and a descriptive file name

using hyphens. Don't start with "image of" or "picture of."

[upload images or describe each one]
```

Structure pages so AI can quote them

AI tools quote pages that answer a question cleanly. You don't need special code or a new style of writing: Google says there are no additional requirements, and no special structured data, needed to appear in AI Overviews or AI Mode (Google Search Central). What helps is structure: a clear answer, specific facts and a predictable layout. Three writing rules do most of the work.

1. **Lead with the answer.** Put the conclusion or the key number in the first sentence of each section, then explain.
2. **Name things.** Write "your Google Business Profile" instead of "it," and "a 40-foot saltwater pool" instead of "the project." Specific names and numbers are easier to quote and harder to copy.
3. **Cut the warm-up.** Delete openers like "In today's fast-paced digital world." They give a reader, or an AI, nothing to use.

Three page types come up again and again. Use these templates as a starting point, then fill them with your own experience and data. The template gives the page its shape. Your experience is what makes it worth citing.

Template 1: The quick answer box. For any page that answers a question. Place it directly under the H1.

AI TIP

```
Quick answer: [The question, in the buyer's own words]

- What it is: [One plain sentence, 25 words or fewer]

- Why it matters: [The most common reason buyers ask]

- The number to know: [A specific fact from your own data or a named source, with the year]

- What to do next: [One sentence that leads to your call to action]
```

The rest of the page expands on each line in normal prose. The box is a summary of the page, not a replacement for it.

Template 2: The fair comparison. In Seer Interactive's 2026 data, 95.4% of comparison searches showed an AI Overview (Seer Interactive, 2026). A page that compares the options honestly gives the AI something to quote and a reason to credit you. A pool builder, for example, might compare concrete, fiberglass and vinyl pools.

AI TIP

```
[Option A] vs. [Option B]: [The main trade-off, in a few words]


| | [Option A] | [Option B] |
| Price range | | |
| Timeline | | |
| Best for | | |
| Main drawback | | |


Bottom line: [Who should choose A and who should choose B, in two sentences]
```

Include your own drawbacks. Buyers trust a comparison that admits trade-offs. If you name competitors, every fact about them must be accurate and current, so check it before you publish and review it every quarter.

Template 3: The step-by-step guide. For "how to" searches and any process with a clear order.

AI TIP

```
How to [do the task] in [number] steps
Before you start: [What you need] · [How long it takes] · [Skill level]


1. [Verb + what to do]: [One or two sentences on exactly what to do and what to expect]
2. [Verb + what to do]: [...]
3. [Verb + what to do]: [...]


If it goes wrong: [The most common mistake and how to fix it]
```

Use a numbered list with a short, action-first label for each step. Google retired how-to rich results in 2023 (Google Search Central), so the structure readers see on the page matters more than the markup behind it.

Example: the templates filled in for Wild West Custom Pools

Here's how the three templates look for the boutique pool builder from Chapter 4. Facts in [brackets] still need Dan's confirmation.

Quick answer box for a page titled "How much does a custom pool cost in Austin?"

AI TIP

```
Quick answer: How much does a custom pool cost in Austin?

- What it is: Wild West Custom Pools builds custom pools in the Austin

metro in three ranges: $90,000–$150,000, $150,000–$350,000 and $350,000+.

- Why it matters: Size, shape, finishes and features like [spas or infinity

edges] decide where a project lands.

- The number to know: Wild West builds only 12 pools a year, by choice,

so every project gets the owner's full attention. [Most 2026 projects

fell in the $___ range.]

- What to do next: Book a free on-site consultation. Design meetings

after that happen on Zoom.
```

Fair comparison for a page titled "Boutique pool builder vs. high-volume pool builder"

AI TIP

```
Boutique builder vs. high-volume builder: personal attention vs. speed and scale


| | Boutique (Wild West) | High-volume builder |

| Pools built a year | 12, by choice | [Typical volume] |

| Who you talk to | The owner, on his direct line | [A project manager or office] |

| Price range | $90,000 to $350,000+ | [Typical Austin range] |

| Best for | Buyers who want the owner | Buyers who want the earliest |

| | on-site every step | start date or a lower price |

| Main drawback | Limited build slots each year | [Less direct owner contact] |


Bottom line: If you want one person accountable from excavation to first

swim, choose a boutique builder. If the start date or the price matters

most, a high-volume builder may fit better.
```

Notice the comparison names Wild West's own drawback, limited build slots, and compares approaches rather than naming competitors.

Step-by-step guide for a page titled "How to plan a custom pool build in Austin"

AI TIP

How to plan your custom pool build in 5 steps

Before you start: **[Your property survey and any HOA rules]** ·

[___ months from first visit to first swim] · No experience needed

1. Book an on-site visit: Dan walks your yard and talks through how you'll use the pool.
2. Design it on Zoom: Work with a designer who has 20+ years of custom pool design experience, without leaving home.
3. Choose your range and sign: Pick the price range that fits the design and lock in your build slot.
4. Get permits: **[How long permits usually take in your city.]**
5. Build it: Dan is on-site from excavation to first swim, and you have his direct number the whole way.

If it goes wrong: **[The most common delay, such as permits or weather, and how Wild West keeps you updated.]**

↓ The three page templates

TECHNICAL SEO

Technical SEO: Can They Reach It, Read It and Load It?

Technical SEO is the plumbing. Nobody notices it when it works. When it doesn't, your best content never shows up. Most small teams don't need to become technical experts, but they do need to know what to check and who will fix it.

Crawling and indexing

A page must be crawled and indexed before it can rank or be cited.

- **Set up Google Search Console** and submit your XML sitemap. Check the Page indexing report monthly for pages that can't be indexed, and why.
- **Check your robots.txt file.** One wrong line can block search engines from your whole site. Google says pages must be indexed and eligible for regular search snippets to appear in AI Overviews and AI Mode (Google Search Central).
- **Decide on AI crawlers on purpose.** AI companies run their own crawlers, and you can allow or block them separately. OpenAI, for example, uses OAI-SearchBot to show sites in ChatGPT search and GPTBot to train its models. It recommends allowing OAI-SearchBot if you want to appear in ChatGPT search results (OpenAI). Blocking a training crawler and allowing a search crawler is a reasonable middle ground for many businesses.
- **Keep important content in text.** Words locked inside images, PDFs or scripts are harder for search engines and AI to read.

Speed and page experience

Google measures real-world page experience with three Core Web Vitals. In March 2024, Interaction to Next Paint (INP) replaced First Input Delay (FID) as the responsiveness measure (web.dev).

CORE WEB VITAL	WHAT IT MEASURES	GOOD SCORE
Largest Contentful Paint (LCP)	How fast the main content loads	2.5 seconds or less
Interaction to Next Paint (INP)	How fast the page responds when someone taps or clicks	200 milliseconds or less
Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS)	How much the page jumps around while loading	0.1 or less

Source: web.dev. Google measures these at the 75th percentile of visits, on mobile and desktop separately.

The usual fixes: compress images, cut unneeded scripts and plugins, use good hosting and a content delivery network, and reserve space for images and ads so the page doesn't jump. Design for phones first. That's how most of your buyers will see the page, and it's how Google indexes it.

Structured data (schema)

Structured data is code that labels the facts on a page — your business name, address, hours, products, prices, reviews and events — so search engines and AI don't have to guess. It can also earn rich results, like star ratings and event dates, in search.

The rules have changed since the first edition. Google cut back HowTo rich results in 2023, and FAQ rich results stopped appearing in Google Search in May 2026 (Search Engine Journal). Existing FAQ markup won't hurt you, but don't expect it to change how your listing looks.

Where schema still pays off for most small businesses:

- **LocalBusiness** — name, address, phone, hours and service area
- **Organization** — your logo, website and social profiles
- **Product and Offer** — for e-commerce: price, availability and reviews
- **Review and AggregateRating** — where Google's review rules allow

- **Event** — for workshops, webinars and open houses

Keep structured data accurate and matched to what's visible on the page. Google lists accurate structured data among its best practices for AI features too (Google Search Central).

Social sharing tags. Open Graph tags and X Cards control the title, description and image when someone shares your page on social media or in a messaging app. They don't affect rankings, but they affect clicks.

PRO TIP

Ask who owns technical SEO before something breaks. In many small businesses, the answer is "the web developer we used three years ago." Put a name next to Search Console, the sitemap, hosting and site speed.

AI TIP

Generate schema markup for a page

```
Act as a technical SEO specialist.

Create JSON-LD structured data for this page using schema.org types that

Google supports. Page type: [home page, service page, product page, event]

Business details: [name, address, phone, hours, service area, website,

logo URL, social profiles]

Page details: [products, prices, events or other facts shown on the page]


Only include facts I've given you. Mark any field you'd recommend adding but

couldn't fill. Then tell me how to test it with Google's Rich Results Test.
```

Note: Always test AI-generated schema before you publish it. Invalid or inaccurate markup is worse than none.

Your turn: technical health check

Check what's in place today. Write who owns each item.

ITEM	IN PLACE?	OWNER
Google Search Console set up and verified	☐ Yes ☐ No	
XML sitemap submitted	☐ Yes ☐ No	
Page indexing report reviewed in the last 30 days	☐ Yes ☐ No	
robots.txt reviewed, including AI crawlers	☐ Yes ☐ No	

ITEM	IN PLACE?	OWNER
Core Web Vitals passing on mobile	☐ Yes ☐ No	
Site secured with HTTPS	☐ Yes ☐ No	
LocalBusiness or Organization schema added and tested	☐ Yes ☐ No	
Open Graph and X Card tags on key pages	☐ Yes ☐ No	

AUTHORITY

Authority: Why Should Anyone Trust This Page?

Search engines and AI assistants both try to send people to sources they can trust. Authority is how you earn that trust, and it's the hardest part of SEO to fake.

Links and AI citations are earned the same way: create something worth citing.

E-E-A-T: experience, expertise, authoritativeness and trust

Google uses E-E-A-T to describe what makes content credible. Trust is the most important part; the other three contribute to it (Google Search Central).

	WHAT IT MEANS	HOW TO SHOW IT
Experience	The creator has first-hand or life experience with the topic (Search Engine Journal)	Your own photos, project details, results and lessons learned
Expertise	The creator knows the subject	Author bios, credentials and years in the field
Authoritativeness	Others recognize you as a go-to source	Links, mentions, awards, media coverage and industry roles
Trust	The content and the business are accurate, honest and safe	Clear contact details, real reviews, sources for claims, a secure site

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

E-E-A-T with Trust at the center and Experience, Expertise and Authoritativeness around it

YMYL: Your Money or Your Life

Some topics can affect a person's health, finances or safety: medical advice, financial guidance, legal information and similar. Google holds these "Your Money or Your Life" pages to a higher standard. If your business works in these areas, cite trusted sources, name qualified authors and show trust signals such as reviews, certifications and licenses.

AI content and authority

Google doesn't ban AI-assisted content. It rewards helpful content however it's made and treats content made mainly to manipulate rankings as spam. In March 2024, it named the problem "scaled content abuse": many pages generated for the primary purpose of manipulating rankings and not helping users, no matter how they're created (Search Engine Journal).

Google also suggests thinking about Who, How and Why: who created the content, how it was created (including whether AI was used, where readers would wonder) and why it exists (Google Search Central).

The practical rule: use AI to draft and organize, then add what AI can't. Your experience is the authority.

Links and mentions

Links from other reputable websites are still one of the clearest authority signals. Mentions of your brand on trusted sites, even without a link, help both search engines and AI tools understand who you are.

Good ways to earn them:

- **Create something worth citing:** original data, a useful tool, a thorough guide or a strong opinion backed by experience.
- **Reach out to relevant sites** in your industry or community and offer content their readers would value.
- **Get listed** in the directories, associations and chambers of commerce your buyers trust.
- **Contribute expertise** to industry publications, podcasts and local media.
- **Promote your best content.** A small paid social or search budget can put a strong piece in front of the people most likely to share or link to it. Ads don't improve rankings directly, but they speed up discovery.
- **Show up where buyers ask each other.** Take part in the forums and communities your buyers use, such as Reddit, industry groups and local Facebook groups. Google's AI Overviews draw heavily on user forums: in an Ahrefs study of 76.7 million AI Overviews from June 2025, Reddit was one of the five most-cited sites (Ahrefs). Answer questions as a helpful expert, say who you are and skip the sales pitch. Communities spot self-promotion fast.

Avoid buying links or joining link schemes. They break Google's spam policies and can cost you more than they earn.

Reviews

Reviews are proof from real customers, and they matter for local search and for AI recommendations. Chapter 8, Local SEO and Reviews, covers how to earn them and respond to them.

PRO TIP

Build high-quality backlinks to your website. Reach out to other websites and bloggers in your niche to see if they would be willing to link to your content.

AI TIP

Find link and mention opportunities

```
Act as a digital PR strategist for a [type of business] in [city or region].

Our best content and expertise: [list two to five pages or topics]

Our competitors: [list two or three]


Suggest 15 realistic link and mention opportunities: industry publications,

associations, local organizations, podcasts and partner businesses. For each,

explain why they'd care and draft a two-sentence pitch. Don't invent

specific contacts, editors or URLs. I'll research and verify each one.
```

AI SEARCH VISIBILITY

AI Search Visibility: Get Cited, Not Just Ranked

GEO (generative engine optimization) and AEO (answer engine optimization) are two names for one job: making sure AI assistants can find you, describe you accurately and cite you. There's no secret code. It's the SEO in this chapter, plus five steps.

1. Let the right crawlers in

AI tools can only cite pages their crawlers are allowed to read. Check your robots.txt file, and ask your web developer or hosting company whether a firewall or security setting blocks AI crawlers.

- **Google.** AI Overviews and AI Mode use the same crawler as Google Search. A separate control, Google-Extended, decides whether your content can be used for Gemini. Google says it "does not impact a site's inclusion in Google Search nor is it used as a ranking signal" (Google Search Central).
- **ChatGPT.** To appear in ChatGPT search results, allow OpenAI's search crawler, OAI-SearchBot. Its training crawler, GPTBot, is separate, so you can block training and still be found in search (OpenAI). OpenAI also asks you to confirm that your host or content delivery network allows its crawler's traffic (OpenAI).

- **Skip llms.txt for now.** It's a proposed file that summarizes a site for AI tools. Google's John Mueller said in June 2025 that "no AI system currently uses llms.txt" (Search Engine Roundtable). Spend the time on your pages instead.

2. Be in the sources AI already trusts

AI assistants build their answers from search indexes and from what other sites say about you.

- **Don't ignore Bing.** Microsoft Copilot and Bing's AI summaries draw on Bing's index. Verify your site in Bing Webmaster Tools and submit your sitemap, the same as in Google Search Console.
- **Make your facts match everywhere.** Your name, services, service area, prices, hours and phone number should be the same on your website, Google Business Profile, directories, review sites and social profiles. When sources disagree, an AI answer can repeat the wrong one. Chapter 8, Local SEO and Reviews, shows how to audit them.
- **Earn mentions.** Links and mentions on trusted sites, and helpful answers in the forums your buyers use, feed AI answers too (see Links and mentions, above).

3. Keep your key facts current

An AI answer built on an old page repeats old facts. Update prices, services, service areas and team details on your site as soon as they change, and show the date a page was last reviewed. Then use the page templates in Structure pages so AI can quote them, above, so the current facts are easy to find and quote.

4. Check what AI says about you every month

In Chapter 1, you asked AI assistants about your business and recorded a baseline. Make it a monthly habit. Use the same five to ten prompts each time, written the way your buyers ask, and run them in the assistants your buyers use.

PROMPT	ASSISTANT	WERE WE MENTIONED?	WERE WE CITED WITH A LINK?	WAS IT ACCURATE?	WHAT WE'LL FIX
[A question your buyers ask]	[ChatGPT, Gemini, Copilot, Perplexity or Google AI Mode]				

↓ AI visibility tracker (companion workbook)

One caution: AI answers change from day to day and differ from one person to the next. A single check is a snapshot, not a ranking. Run the same prompts every month and watch the trend.

5. Measure AI traffic and citations

- **AI referral traffic.** In Google Analytics 4, look for visits referred by chatgpt.com, perplexity.ai, gemini.google.com and copilot.microsoft.com. ChatGPT adds utm_source=chatgpt.com to the links it sends, which makes its visits easy to spot (OpenAI).

- **Citations in Microsoft's AI answers.** Bing Webmaster Tools added an AI Performance report in February 2026, in public preview. It shows how often your pages are cited in Microsoft Copilot and Bing's AI summaries, which pages are cited and the searches that led to them (Bing Webmaster Blog).
- **Google's AI features.** Clicks from AI Overviews and AI Mode are counted in your regular Search Console totals, not reported separately (see Measuring SEO, below).
- **Ask every lead how they found you.** It's still the clearest signal of what AI is doing for you.

AI TIP

Run an AI visibility check

```
Context: Our business: [what we sell, to whom, where]. Our website: [URL]. The questions our buyers ask before they choose a company like ours: [list five to ten]. What AI assistants said about us last month: [paste, or "first check"].

Role: Act as an AI search visibility analyst.

Ask: Review the answers I paste from [ChatGPT, Gemini, Copilot, Perplexity or Google AI Mode] for each question, and tell me where we're missing, misdescribed or outranked.

Format: A table: question, assistant, mentioned (yes/no), cited with a link (yes/no), errors about us, competitors named, and the page or listing we should create or fix.

Tighten: Use only the answers I paste. Don't guess what an assistant would say, and mark anything you can't confirm.
```

Check every fact the assistants state about you, and fix it at the source: your site, your Google Business Profile or the directory that has it wrong (see Chapter 1).

MEASURING SEO

Measuring SEO

Rankings are a means, not the goal. Measure whether search brings you the right visitors and whether they become leads and customers.

What to track

MEASURE	WHERE TO FIND IT	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Impressions, clicks and click-through rate by query	Google Search Console	Which searches show your pages, and whether your titles earn the click
Average position for priority topics	Google Search Console or an SEO tool	Whether you're gaining or losing ground
Organic sessions and engagement	Google Analytics 4	Whether search visitors stay and explore

MEASURE	WHERE TO FIND IT	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Leads and conversions from organic search	Google Analytics 4 and your CRM	Whether SEO pays
Indexed pages and indexing errors	Search Console Page indexing report	Whether your pages can be found at all
Core Web Vitals	Search Console Core Web Vitals report	Whether page experience is holding you back
AI referral traffic and AI mentions	Google Analytics 4 referrals; your AI visibility baseline from Chapter 1	Whether AI assistants send you visitors and describe you accurately

AI Overviews and AI Mode traffic is counted inside your regular Search Console totals, not reported separately (Google Search Central). Watch the trend in clicks and conversions, not just rankings.

Ask every lead how they found you. Analytics often misses the influence of AI answers. A buyer who reads about you in ChatGPT may search your name later or type your address directly, and analytics credits that visit to search or direct traffic. Add a "How did you hear about us?" field to every form, include "ChatGPT or another AI assistant" as an option, and ask the same question on the first call. It costs nothing, and it's often the clearest view you'll get of what AI is doing for your leads. Tools that track how often AI assistants mention your brand are changing quickly, so we keep a current list in Appendix A on the book's website.

PRO TIP

Look for pages with lots of impressions and few clicks. They already rank. A better title and description is often the fastest SEO win you'll get.

AI TIP

Find quick wins in your Search Console data

```
Act as an SEO analyst.

Attached is a Google Search Console export of queries and pages for the

last three months, with clicks, impressions, CTR and average position.

Our most important services or products: [list]


1. List the 10 pages with the most impressions and the lowest CTR, and

suggest a better title and meta description for each.

2. List queries where we rank in positions 5 to 20 that match our priority

services. These are our best chances to move up.

3. Flag queries that bring traffic but don't match what we sell.

Show the numbers behind each recommendation. Don't invent data.
```

SEO resource checklist

The deliverables a working SEO program needs. Check what you have.

- ☐ Keyword and topic map for priority services (Keywords chapter)
- ☐ Optimized title tags and meta descriptions for key pages
- ☐ On-page SEO checklist used before every publish
- ☐ Google Search Console and Google Analytics 4 set up
- ☐ XML sitemap and reviewed robots.txt
- ☐ Structured data on key pages, tested
- ☐ Google Business Profile claimed and complete (Chapter 8, Local SEO and Reviews)
- ☐ Content calendar tied to search topics (Content chapter)
- ☐ Link and mention outreach plan
- ☐ Paid search and paid social plan to promote priority content (Paid Media and Promotion chapter)
- ☐ Monthly SEO report with leads and conversions

YOUR TURN

SEO team resources

SEO touches several skills. Few small businesses have all of them in-house. Decide who covers each one: train, hire or outsource.

ROLE OR SKILL	WHAT THEY DO FOR SEO	WHO COVERS IT?
SEO strategist	Sets priorities, keyword strategy and reporting	
Content writer and editor	Creates and updates pages that answer buyer questions	
Web developer	Fixes technical issues, site speed and structured data	
Designer	Creates images and graphics, and keeps them optimized	
Paid media specialist	Uses search and social ads to promote content and test titles and offers	
Local SEO and reviews owner	Manages Google Business Profile, listings and review responses	
Analyst	Tracks rankings, traffic, leads and AI visibility	
AI workflow lead	Builds and maintains the team's SEO prompts and checks AI output	

YOUR TURN

Your Turn: Build an Optimized Page

The optimized page checklist

Use this before you publish any important page.

↓ Optimized page checklist

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

an annotated page showing where each element lives — title, URL, H1, first paragraph, images, internal links, schema, call to action

Uniquely valuable content

- ☐ Answers the buyer's main question in the first two sentences

- ☐ Shows first-hand experience: your photos, projects, data or opinion
- ☐ Includes at least one of: case study, original data, expert quote, how-to steps or a comparison
- ☐ Facts, numbers and quotes checked against their sources

Search and AI focus

- ☐ One clear topic and the main question it answers
- ☐ Topic and related terms used naturally in the title, H1 and body
- ☐ No keyword stuffing
- ☐ Sections that each answer one specific question

Labels

- ☐ Unique, descriptive title tag
- ☐ Meta description with a reason to click
- ☐ One H1, with H2s and H3s in a logical order
- ☐ Short, readable URL with hyphens
- ☐ Descriptive file names and alt text on every image
- ☐ Canonical tag set if similar pages exist

Crawling and experience

- ☐ Page is indexable and in the XML sitemap
- ☐ Important content is in text, not only in images or PDFs
- ☐ Loads fast and passes Core Web Vitals on mobile
- ☐ Easy to read on a phone, with no intrusive pop-ups
- ☐ Two or more internal links to and from related pages

Structured data and sharing

- ☐ LocalBusiness, Organization, Product or Event schema where it fits, tested
- ☐ Open Graph and X Card tags with a strong image
- ☐ Social sharing buttons where people are likely to share

Conversion and promotion

- ☐ One clear call to action
- ☐ Plan to promote the page through email, social media and paid media

On-Page SEO Worksheet

Pick one page you want to rank — a service, product or location page. Build it here.

Write a short summary of the page: who it's for, and what question it answers.

YOUR TURN

1 Create the URL.

YOUR TURN

1 Write the title tag.

YOUR TURN

1 Write the meta description.

YOUR TURN

1 Write the H1.

YOUR TURN

1 Write the first paragraph. Answer the main question in the first two sentences.

YOUR TURN

1 Write one internal link and one external link, with their anchor text.

YOUR TURN

1 Write alt text for a photo and for a graphic.

YOUR TURN

1 Write a bulleted or numbered list for the page.

YOUR TURN

1 Write the call to action.

YOUR TURN

1 What first-hand experience will you add that a competitor couldn't copy?

YOUR TURN

AI TIP

Turn your worksheet into a finished draft

```
Act as an SEO copywriter who writes in a plain, direct voice.

Here is my completed On-Page SEO Worksheet: [paste answers 1–10]

Our brand voice: [paste your voice guide or two samples of your writing]

The buyer: [paste persona from your field guide]


Write the full page using my URL, title, H1, first paragraph, links, list

and call to action. Keep my first-hand experience details exactly as I wrote

them. Mark with [brackets] anywhere you need a fact, number or example from me.

Don't invent results, statistics or customer quotes.
```

Search engine optimization questions

What topics and questions are our buyers searching for, and how will we answer them on our site?

How can we optimize for local search, including location pages, Google Business Profile and reviews?

How fast does our site load on mobile, and what will we fix first?

Which pages most need better titles, descriptions, headings and content?

Which structured data should we add, and who will test it?

Which buyer questions could we answer clearly enough to be cited in AI answers and search features like "People also ask"?

How easy is our website to use and navigate on a phone?

What links and mentions can we earn from trusted sites in our industry and community?

How will we use social media, email and paid media to get our best content seen?

How will we measure SEO success — rankings, traffic, leads, conversions and AI visibility — and how often will we adjust?

Notes

KEYWORDS

Do you know the words buyers use?

In this chapter »

Find the words buyers use. Then answer them better than anyone.

— **YOUR KEYWORD PORTFOLIO**
Research before you plan content

— **CONTENT THAT GETS FOUND**
Turn keywords into pages that answer better than anyone

— **STRIKING DISTANCE KEYWORDS**
The fastest wins come from pages you already have

— **MEASURING KEYWORDS**
What to watch when rankings change daily

— **YOUR KEYWORD PLAN**
Answer the questions with your team

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
6 AI Tips, including grouping keywords into topics and building your striking distance list

Keywords

Keywords are the words your buyers type, or say, when they need what you sell. They're the bridge between the question in a buyer's head and the page on your website. Get them right, and your content shows up for the people most likely to buy. Get them wrong, and you can write great content that nobody finds.

Keyword research tells you three things:

- **What buyers call it.** You may say "residential aquatic installation." Your buyers say "pool builder near me."
- **What they want to know.** The questions they ask at each stage of the journey, from "How much does a pool cost?" to "Who's the best pool builder in Austin?"
- **Where you can win.** Which searches you could realistically rank for, and which ones are already close.

Every search is a question. Your job is to be the best answer.

What AI changed

Searches are getting longer. People type, and now speak, to AI tools the way they'd talk to an expert. Google says queries in AI Mode are three times longer than traditional searches, and nearly one in six AI Mode queries now use voice or images (Google, 2026). Short keywords still matter, but the real opportunity is in the full question.

Questions trigger AI answers. A Washington University in St. Louis study found AI Overviews on about 65% of Google searches phrased as questions (WashU, 2026; see Chapter 6). The searches you most want to answer are the ones where AI answers first. That's why the page has to be worth citing, not just worth ranking. Chapter 6 covers how to structure pages so AI can quote them.

Topics matter more than single keywords. Search engines and AI tools understand meaning, not just matching words. One strong page that covers a topic and its related questions well will usually do better than five thin pages that each chase a slightly different phrase.

AI makes research faster, not more accurate. AI can brainstorm hundreds of keyword ideas and sort them by theme in minutes. It can't tell you how many people actually search for them.

One caution: AI tools will happily invent search volumes and rankings that sound precise. Never use an AI's numbers for search volume or difficulty. Get them from Google Keyword Planner, Google Search Console or a dedicated SEO tool.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

The same buyer, three ways to search. What kind of pool can we build, and who should we talk to?"

Build Your Keyword Portfolio

Start keyword research before you plan content, not after. Your keyword portfolio is the list of searches you want to be found for, sorted by how important they are and how close you are to winning them.

Where to find your keywords

- **Your customers.** The words they use in emails, calls, reviews and sales meetings. Write them down exactly.
- **Your sales and service team.** The questions they answer every week.
- **Google Search Console (free).** The searches that already show your pages, with clicks, impressions and average position.
- **Google Keyword Planner (free with a Google Ads account).** Search volume ranges and related ideas.
- **The results page itself.** Google's autocomplete, "People also ask" and related searches show what real people type.
- **Paid tools.** Ahrefs, Semrush and similar tools add competitor keywords, difficulty scores and more precise volumes.
- **AI tools.** Good for brainstorming and grouping ideas. Not a source of search data.

Match the keyword to the buyer's intent

Every search has a purpose. Sort your keywords by what the searcher wants, and you'll know what kind of page to build:

INTENT	THE SEARCHER WANTS TO...	EXAMPLE	BEST PAGE
Learn	Understand a problem or option	"how long does it take to build a pool"	Guide, FAQ, video
Compare	Weigh choices	"gunite vs fiberglass pool"	Comparison page
Buy	Find a provider and act	"custom pool builder Round Rock"	Service or location page
Find	Reach a specific business	"Wild West Custom Pools reviews"	Home, about or reviews page

Go long-tail

PRO TIP

Focus on long-tail keyword phrases. Instead of trying to rank for short, general terms, focus on longer, more specific phrases that match what your buyers need. They have less competition, and the people searching for them are further along and more likely to buy. Instead of "shoes," target "women's running shoes with arch support." Instead of "pools," target "custom pool builder for sloped backyard Austin."

Long-tail isn't about word count. It's about being specific. A five-word phrase can still be broad, and a three-word phrase can be very specific.

PRO TIP

Use keywords naturally. Put your main phrase in the title, the H1, the first paragraph and a few subheads, then write for people. Stuffing keywords in looks like spam to search engines and to readers.

Your keyword worksheet

Pick three to five priority topics, the products or services that matter most to your business. For each one, fill in the worksheet:

PRIORITY KEYWORD	2–3 WORD PHRASES	4–6 WORD PHRASES	LONG-TAIL QUESTIONS

Then turn your best long-tail phrases into content titles posed as questions. You'll use them in the next section.

Our top five long-tail questions, written as content titles.

AI TIP

Brainstorm keywords from your customers' words

```
Context: We are [business] selling [offer] to [buyer] in [location]. Here are real phrases from our
customers' emails, reviews and sales calls: [paste, with names removed]. Our priority topics are
[list].

Role: Act as a keyword researcher who thinks like a buyer.

Ask: Generate keyword ideas for each priority topic, including the questions buyers ask at each stage
of the journey.

Format: For each topic, a table: keyword or question, intent (learn, compare, buy, find), journey
stage, and suggested page type.

Tighten: Use the buyer's words, not industry jargon. Don't include search volumes or difficulty
scores; I'll get those from Google Keyword Planner and Search Console.
```

AI TIP

Group keywords into topics

```
Context: Here is our keyword list with search volumes from [Keyword Planner/Search Console/tool name]: [paste].

Role: Act as an SEO strategist.

Ask: Group these keywords into topics that one strong page could cover, and recommend which page on our site should own each topic.

Format: A table: topic, the keywords in it, total volume (from my data only), existing page that should own it or "new page needed."

Tighten: Use only the volumes I provided. Don't split one topic across several pages. Flag keywords that don't fit what we sell.
```

CREATE CONTENT THAT GETS FOUND

Create Content That Gets Found

A keyword list is only useful when it turns into pages that answer the question better than anyone else. Here's the process the first edition introduced, updated for AI search.

Step by step

1. **Search your question.** Type your long-tail question into Google exactly as a buyer would. Look at the whole page, not just the top link.
2. **Read the results page.** Note five things: the AI Overview (if there is one) and the sources it cites; the top three results; "People also ask"; the related searches at the bottom; and any videos, forums or local results.
3. **Study what's winning.** Click the top results and the pages the AI answer cites. Ask: Do they answer the question fully? Are they current? Do they show real experience, or are they generic?
4. **Find the gap.** If nobody answers the question directly, or the answers are thin, out of date or written by people who've never done the work, that's your opening.
5. **Write the better answer.** Answer the question in the first two sentences. Then go deeper with your own experience, photos, numbers and examples. Cover the related "People also ask" questions on the same page.
6. **Optimize and publish.** Use the question, or a close version of it, as your title and H1. Add images, video, lists and a clear next step. Use the optimized page checklist from Chapter 6.
7. **Monitor and update.** Check rankings, clicks and AI citations each month. Refresh the page when the facts change.

The first edition taught a simple test: if nobody has written content with the exact title a buyer searches for, that's an opportunity. It still works, with one update. Matching the words gets you noticed. Being the most useful answer is what gets you ranked and cited.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

An annotated results page, redrawn from the first edition: 1. the search question; 2. the top organic result; 4. People also ask; 5. related searches. Caption: "Read the whole page. It tells you what buyers want and what's missing."

Content that works best

The first edition named four types of content that consistently attract buyers. They still do, and they answer the same questions buyers now ask AI tools:

- **"Best" or "top" pages.** Do the heavy lifting for buyers: "The 10 best men's waterproof hiking boots." Be honest and specific about who each option is for.
- **"Versus" pages.** Buyers will compare you with alternatives anyway. Let them do it on your site, with a fair comparison that admits trade-offs.
- **Price pages.** "How much does a custom pool cost in Austin?" Many businesses won't publish prices. That's a mistake. Buyers want to know, and if you don't tell them, someone else will. No price, no conversion.
- **Resource pages.** In-depth guides that bring together everything a buyer needs on one topic, including links to trusted outside sources. These attract links from other sites.

PRO TIP

Optimize your titles. Your title is the first thing people see in search results. Make it specific, use the buyer's words and give a reason to click. A question in the title doesn't earn more clicks by itself: Backlinko's 2025 study of about 4 million Google results found that question and non-question titles get a similar click-through rate. Write the title that best matches what the searcher is looking for, and don't promise what the page doesn't deliver.

A fact-check from writing this book. While updating this chapter, we came across a popular statistic: titles phrased as questions get a 14.1% higher click-through rate. We asked an AI search tool where it came from. The answer was confident and detailed. It named BuzzSumo and described a study of millions of headlines. But the number came from a different study, a 2019 analysis by Backlinko and ClickFlow, and Backlinko's updated 2025 study no longer finds the effect. One confident answer had three problems: the wrong source, details we couldn't confirm and a finding that's out of date. That's why the AI ground rule is to verify facts, and to check the source, not the summary (Chapter 1).

Plan when and where each piece will be published with the editorial calendar in Chapter 9, and plan how you'll repurpose it with Chapters 10 and 13.

AI TIP

Analyze a search results page

```
Context: I searched for "[your long-tail question]". Here is what I found: the AI Overview text and its cited sources, the top three results with their titles and a summary of each, and the "People also ask" questions: [paste].

Role: Act as an SEO content strategist.

Ask: Tell me what the current results do well, what they miss, and how our page could be the best answer to this question.

Format: (1) What searchers seem to want. (2) Gaps in the current results. (3) An outline for our page with the H1, the two-sentence answer, the H2 sections and the related questions to cover. (4) What first-hand experience or data we should add.

Tighten: Base everything on what I pasted. Don't invent statistics. Mark where we need to add our own facts, photos or examples.
```

AI TIP

Turn long-tail questions into content titles

```
Context: We are [business] serving [buyer]. Here are our top long-tail questions: [paste]. Our content types are [guides, comparison pages, price pages, FAQs, videos].

Role: Act as a content editor who writes for search and for people.

Ask: Write three title options for each question and recommend the best content type for each.

Format: A table: question, three title options, recommended content type, and the one-sentence answer the page should open with.

Tighten: Keep titles under 60 characters where possible. Use the buyer's words. No clickbait; every title must match what the page will actually deliver.
```

The first three pages we'll create or improve, with the question each one answers.

Striking Distance Keywords

The fastest keyword wins usually come from pages you already have. Striking distance keywords are searches where your site already ranks in positions 4 to 20: near the top of page one, or on page two. You've done the hard work. A focused push can move them into the top three, where most of the clicks are.

How to find and improve them

1. **Find them.** In Google Search Console, open the Performance report, show queries with average position, and filter for positions 4 to 20. Sort by impressions. The searches with the most impressions are your biggest opportunities.
2. **Keep the ones that matter.** Cross off searches that don't match what you sell. Keep the ones that bring buyers.
3. **Check the page.** For each keyword, look at the page that ranks. Does it answer the question in the first two sentences? Is it current? Does it use the buyer's words in the title, H1 and subheads? Does it beat the pages ranking above it?
4. **Improve the content.** Add what's missing: a clearer answer, more depth, your own examples, photos and data, an FAQ section, a better title.
5. **Add internal links.** Link to the page from your other relevant pages, using descriptive words. You'll pass along authority you already have.
6. **Earn outside links and mentions.** A few relevant, trusted sites linking to the page can make the difference (Chapter 6).
7. **Measure.** Track position, clicks and click-through rate for each keyword monthly.

PRO TIP

Work on a short list. Ten striking distance keywords improved well beat fifty touched lightly.

Do the opportunity math

Before you start, estimate what moving up could be worth. Use your own numbers:

Extra monthly visits × conversion rate × close rate × average sale = extra monthly revenue

Here's an example with sample numbers. Say your striking distance keywords could bring 2,000 extra visits a month if they reached the top three. At a 2% conversion rate, that's 40 leads. If you close one in four, that's 10 sales. At an average sale of $10,000, that's $100,000 a month in new revenue from pages you already have.

To estimate extra visits, look in Search Console at the click-through rate your site already earns on queries where it ranks in the top three, and apply it to the impressions of your striking distance keywords. The companion workbook tab for this chapter does the math.

Striking distance worksheet

Example: where Wild West Custom Pools stands

Striking distance only works once you rank somewhere close. In the three months after its new site launched, Wild West Custom Pools' Search Console showed 31 clicks, about 11,000 impressions, a 0.3% click-through rate and an average position of 34.6 (Chapter 4). In plain terms, Google is showing the site for relevant searches, but mostly on pages three and four, where few people look.

That's normal for a new site, and it sets the priority. The first job is to move the most important searches into striking distance: location pages for Austin, Round Rock, Pflugerville and Hutto; answers to the questions buyers ask most, such as cost and build time (Chapter 5); more reviews; and links from local sites. Then the striking distance work begins.

AI TIP

Build your striking distance list

```
Context: Attached is a Google Search Console export of queries and pages for the last three months,
with clicks, impressions, CTR and average position. We sell [offer] to [buyer] in [locations].

Role: Act as an SEO analyst.

Ask: Find our striking distance keywords (average position 4 to 20) that match what we sell, and rank
them by opportunity.

Format: A table: query, ranking page, position, impressions, current clicks, and the one improvement
most likely to move it up. Then the top ten to work on first.

Tighten: Use only the data in the export. Don't invent search volumes or click-through rates. Exclude
queries that don't match our offer.
```

Our top ten striking distance keywords, the page for each and the improvement we'll make.

MEASURING KEYWORDS

Measuring Keywords

MEASURE	WHERE TO FIND IT	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Impressions by query	Search Console	Whether Google shows you for the right searches

MEASURE	WHERE TO FIND IT	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Average position	Search Console	How close you are to page one
Clicks and click-through rate	Search Console	Whether your titles earn the click
Conversions from organic search	Google Analytics	Whether the searches bring buyers
AI mentions and citations	Your own checks in ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity and AI Overviews	Whether AI answers include you for your key questions (Chapter 1)

Rankings change daily. Judge your keyword work on monthly trends, and on leads, not positions alone.

YOUR KEYWORD PLAN

Your Keyword Plan

Answer these questions with your team. Then use the AI TIP at the end to turn your answers into a 90-day keyword plan.

What are our priority topics, and the primary and secondary keywords for each?

Which long-tail questions do our buyers ask at each stage of the journey?

Which tools will we use for keyword data (Search Console, Keyword Planner, a paid tool), and who owns the research?

Which page on our site should own each priority topic, and which pages do we still need to create?

Are our titles, meta descriptions and H1s specific, written in the buyer's words and worth clicking?

What keywords do our competitors rank for that we don't, and where are the gaps?

Which location-based keywords matter for us, and do we have pages for each area we serve?

How can reviews, FAQs and customer questions help us use the words buyers actually search for?

Which of our searches are in striking distance (positions 4 to 20), and what will we improve first?

How will we track rankings, clicks, conversions and AI mentions each month?

AI TIP

Turn your answers into a 90-day keyword plan

```
Context: Here are our answers to the keyword questions: [paste answers]. Our top striking distance
keywords are [list], and our priority topics are [list].

Role: Act as an SEO strategist building a plan for a small team.

Ask: Turn our answers into a 90-day keyword and content plan.

Format: (1) A one-paragraph summary. (2) Striking distance pages to improve in month one. (3) New
pages to create in months two and three, each with its target question. (4) The three numbers we'll
report at day 90.

Tighten: Start with pages we already have. Be realistic about our team's time. Use only keyword data I
provided; mark anything that needs checking.
```

Keyword plan template

SOURCES

Sources

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- Wild West Custom Pools: Chapters 4 and 5 of this book, and Dan's Search Console data (three months from June 30, 2026).

LOCAL

Do you win the map?

In this chapter »

Win the searches that happen near you.

— **HOW LOCAL SEARCH WORKS**
What Google looks at when it ranks local results

— **YOUR GOOGLE BUSINESS PROFILE**
The free listing that wins the map

— **LISTINGS AND CITATIONS**
Keep your name, address and phone consistent everywhere

— **REVIEWS**
Ask every customer, reply to every review, and follow the FTC rule

— **LOCAL PAGES AND MEASUREMENT**
Service and area pages, a worked example and the numbers to track

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
6 AI Tips, including writing your review request and drafting a reply to a review

Local SEO and Reviews

When someone searches for "pool builder near me," "plumber in Round Rock" or "best Italian restaurant downtown," Google shows a map and a short list of businesses before it shows a single website. Those businesses are chosen by local search, and buyers choose among them largely by their reviews.

If your business depends on local customers, this is some of the most direct marketing you can do. The people searching are nearby, they need something now, and much of the work is free.

Why it's worth the effort

BrightLocal's 2026 Consumer Search Behavior study surveyed 1,227 U.S. consumers who had recently searched for a local business:

- **Google is where most local searches start.** 52% started their most recent local search on Google, and 71% used Google at some point along the way.
- **Buyers check you in more than one place.** 75% used more than one channel, such as Google, Maps, social media, review sites or AI tools, before choosing. That's why consistent listings matter.
- **Reviews decide who gets cut.** Of the consumers who rejected a business, 65% did so for a review-related reason: negative reviews, a low rating, or no recent reviews.
- **AI is a new door, not yet the main one.** 23% used an AI tool during their search. But of those, 43% then checked Google, and only 18% felt ready to contact a business based on the AI's recommendation alone.

And buyers say where they want to go: in BrightLocal's 2025 study, 46% said they always or often add "near me" to their local searches.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Source line: BrightLocal, 2026.

Your next customer will meet your reviews before they meet you.

Reviews are read by almost everyone. In BrightLocal's 2026 Local Consumer Review Survey of 1,002 U.S. consumers, 97% said they read reviews for local businesses, and 68% said they need a business to have at least four stars before they'll use it.

What this chapter covers

This chapter covers four things:

1. **How local search works,** so you know what you can influence.
2. **Your Google Business Profile,** the most important local asset you have.
3. **Listings and citations** across the rest of the web.

4 **Reviews:** how to earn them, how to respond and the rules you must follow.

What AI changed

AI now reads your reviews for the buyer. In the same BrightLocal survey, 45% of consumers said they use ChatGPT or other AI tools to check reviews of local businesses, up from 6% a year earlier. And 82% said they read the AI-generated review summaries that now appear in search results.

Google Maps answers questions with AI. In 2026, Google replaced the questions-and-answers section of Business Profiles with Ask Maps, a Gemini-powered feature that answers buyers' questions using your profile, your reviews, your website and other sources. What you write in those places is now what the AI says about you.

Being found by AI depends on being consistent everywhere. In Whitespark's 2026 Local Search Ranking Factors survey of 47 local SEO experts, citations (your business information on other sites) ranked as the most important group of factors for appearing in AI search answers, ahead of your own website and your reviews.

The good news: the work that helps you in Google Maps is the same work that helps you in AI answers. Accurate information, a complete profile, steady reviews and helpful pages.

One caution: AI makes fake reviews and fake replies easy to produce at scale. Don't. Fake reviews are illegal in the U.S., and buyers are quick to spot replies that sound generic. Use AI to draft, then make every reply personal (see Reviews, below).



HOW LOCAL SEARCH WORKS

How Local Search Works

Google says its local results are based mainly on three things:

- **Relevance:** how well your Business Profile matches what someone is searching for.
- **Distance:** how far your business is from the person searching, or from the location in their search.
- **Prominence:** how well-known your business is, based on information from across the web, including links, articles, and the number of reviews and your rating.

Google is also clear about what doesn't work: there is no way to pay for a better local ranking. Local ads are a separate, paid placement (Chapter 12).

You can't change your distance from a buyer. You can make your business more relevant and more prominent, and that's what this chapter is about.

Three places buyers find you

WHERE	WHAT IT IS	WHAT MATTERS MOST
The map pack	The map and short list of businesses at the top of local searches, and Google Maps itself	Your Business Profile, reviews and how people interact with your listing
Local organic results	The regular search results below the map	Your website: a page for each service and area, strong links and clear content (Chapter 6)

WHERE	WHAT IT IS	WHAT MATTERS MOST
AI answers	AI Overviews, Ask Maps, ChatGPT, Gemini and other assistants	Consistent information across the web, helpful pages and reviews

The weights below come from Whitespark's 2026 Local Search Ranking Factors survey of 47 local SEO experts. They're expert estimates, not figures from Google, but they show where to put your effort.

FACTOR GROUP	MAP PACK	LOCAL ORGANIC	AI ANSWERS
Reviews	17%	14%	16%
Behavior (clicks, calls, direction requests)	16%	13%	12%
Google Business Profile	15%	10%	11%
Citations (listings on other sites)	12%	10%	18%
Your website's content	12%	24%	17%
Links	11%	21%	14%
Personalization	10%	5%	5%
Social	7%	3%	7%

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Each shows its top two factor groups as large numbers (Map pack: Reviews 17%, Behavior 16%; Local organic: Website 24%, Links 21%; AI answers: Citations 18%, Website 17%).

The top single factors for the map pack in the same survey were your primary Business Profile category, your distance from the searcher, keywords in your business name, a physical address in the city being searched and whether you're open at the time of the search. For local organic results, the top factor was a dedicated page for each service.

PRO TIP

Keywords in your business name help rankings, but don't add them unless they're part of your real business name. Google's guidelines don't allow extra words in the name field, and competitors can report you. A profile that gets suspended loses everything, including its reviews.

PRO TIP

Keep your hours accurate, including holidays. Being open when someone searches is now one of the strongest map pack factors. If you take calls after hours, say so in your hours.

Your Google Business Profile

Your Google Business Profile is the free listing that appears in Google Search and Maps. For many buyers, it's the first thing they see about you, and sometimes the only thing before they call. It also feeds Ask Maps and other AI answers. Treat it like a second home page.

Business Profile checklist

Set up

- ☐ Claim and verify your profile at business.google.com. If someone else (a former employee or an old agency) controls it, request ownership.
- ☐ Use your real business name, exactly as it appears on your signage and paperwork. No extra keywords, cities or slogans.
- ☐ Choose the most specific **primary category** that describes your main service. Add secondary categories for other services you really offer.
- ☐ Enter your address only if customers come to you. If you serve customers at their homes or businesses, set up as a **service-area business**: hide your address and list the cities or areas you serve.
- ☐ Don't use a P.O. box or a virtual office as your address, and don't create more than one profile for the same business.
- ☐ Add your main phone number and website. Link to the most relevant page, and add tracking so you can see visits from your profile in your analytics (Chapter 19).
- ☐ Set your hours, plus special hours for holidays.

Complete

- ☐ Write a description that says what you do, who you serve, where you serve and what makes you different. Plain language, no keyword lists.
- ☐ List your services or products, with a short description of each.
- ☐ Add the attributes that apply, such as women-owned, veteran-owned, wheelchair accessible or online appointments.
- ☐ Add photos and videos of real work, your team, your vehicles and your location. Add new ones regularly.
- ☐ Turn on messaging or booking only if someone will answer quickly.

Keep it active

- ☐ Post updates, offers, events and recent projects at least monthly.
- ☐ Ask for reviews and respond to every one (see Reviews, below).
- ☐ Check your profile monthly for edits suggested by Google or the public. Anyone can suggest a change to your listing, and Google sometimes accepts them.
- ☐ Review your Performance report monthly: calls, website clicks, direction requests and the searches that found you.

Google Business Profile checklist

Answer buyers' questions before they ask

Google has replaced the old questions-and-answers section of Business Profiles with Ask Maps, an AI feature that answers buyers' questions directly (in the U.S. and India on mobile, as of 2026). It builds its answers from your profile, your reviews, your website and other sources. So the best way to shape what it says is to make sure those places answer the questions buyers ask: prices or price ranges, service areas, timelines, warranties, what happens first.

List the ten questions you hear most often. Make sure each is answered on your website (an FAQ page works well; see Chapter 6) and, where it fits, in your profile's description, services and posts.

PRO TIP

Search for your own business on Google Maps every month, on your phone, logged out. Check your name, hours, phone number, photos and what the AI summary says about you. Fix anything that's wrong at the source.

AI TIP

Write your Business Profile description and services

```
Context: Our business: [name, what we do, who we serve]. Our service area: [cities or neighborhoods].
What makes us different: [two or three points from our positioning]. Our services: [list]. Questions
buyers ask most: [list].

Role: Act as a local SEO specialist who writes Google Business Profile content.

Ask: Write our profile description and a short description for each service.

Format: (1) A description under 750 characters. (2) A table: service name, description under 300
characters. (3) Five ideas for monthly profile posts.

Tighten: Plain, specific language that sounds like us. No keyword stuffing, no superlatives we can't
prove, no claims about price or timing I haven't given you. Flag anything I should confirm.
```

LISTINGS AND CITATIONS

Listings and Citations

A citation is any mention of your business name, address and phone number (often called NAP) on another website: directories, review sites, maps apps, social profiles, your chamber of commerce. Citations help search engines and AI tools confirm that your business is real, where it is and what it does. When your details are the same everywhere, they trust them. When they conflict, they're less sure, and so are buyers.

Citations also do something simpler: they put you where buyers already look. Some buyers check the Better Business Bureau before they hire a contractor. Others start on Apple Maps, Yelp or an industry directory.

Where to be listed

TYPE	EXAMPLES	PRIORITY
Maps and search	Google Business Profile, Apple Business Connect (Apple Maps), Bing Places	Every business
Social profiles	Facebook, Instagram, LinkedIn	Every business, on the platforms you use (Chapter 13)
Review and trust sites	Yelp, Better Business Bureau, Trustpilot	Where your buyers look
Industry directories	Houzz and Angi for home services; Healthgrades for doctors; Avvo for lawyers; TripAdvisor for hospitality	The two or three that matter in your industry
Local organizations	Chamber of commerce, business associations, local media, sponsorships	Two or three that fit your community

You don't need hundreds of listings. You need the important ones to be complete and correct.

Run a citation audit

1. Write down your exact business name, address (or service area), phone number, website and hours. This is your master record.
2. Search for your business name, and for your phone number, on Google and Bing. List every site that shows your business.
3. Compare each listing with your master record. Note anything that's wrong: an old address, an old phone number, a misspelled name, a closed location, a duplicate listing.
4. Fix the most important listings first: Google, Apple, Bing, Facebook, then your industry and trust sites.
5. Repeat every six months, and any time you move, change your phone number or rename the business.

SITE	LISTED?	NAME CORRECT?	ADDRESS OR AREA CORRECT?	PHONE CORRECT?	FIXED (DATE)
Google Business Profile					
Apple Business Connect					
Bing Places					
Facebook					

SITE	LISTED?	NAME CORRECT?	ADDRESS OR AREA CORRECT?	PHONE CORRECT?	FIXED (DATE)
[Industry or trust site]					

Citation audit

PRO TIP

Paid listing services can push your details to many directories at once. They save time if you have several locations. For one location, fix the important listings yourself first, and know that some services remove your listings when you stop paying.

AI TIP

Plan your citation audit

```
Context: Our business: [name, type of business, city or service area]. Our master record: [name, address or service area, phone, website, hours]. Listings we know about: [list].

Role: Act as a local SEO specialist.

Ask: Help me find and prioritize the listings that matter for a business like ours.

Format: (1) The 10 to 15 most important directories and review sites for our industry and area, with why each matters. (2) A checklist for auditing each one. (3) The order to fix them in.

Tighten: Only suggest sites you're confident exist and are relevant to our industry. Mark any you're unsure of so I can check. Don't recommend paid services.
```

REVIEWS

Reviews

Reviews are the most important local factor you control. They help you rank, they help buyers choose and, more and more, they're what AI tools quote when someone asks about you.

Buyers care about more than your star rating. In BrightLocal's 2026 survey:

- **Rating:** 68% of consumers need at least four stars, and 31% will only use a business with 4.5 stars or more.
- **Recency:** 74% only pay attention to reviews from the last three months.
- **Responses:** 80% say they're likely to use a business that responds to all its reviews, and 42% won't use one that ignores them. Half are put off by generic, templated replies.

The lesson: a steady flow of recent reviews, each with a real reply, beats a big pile of old ones.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Source line: BrightLocal, 2026.

How to get more reviews

1. **Ask every customer.** Not just the happy ones. Asking only customers you expect to be happy (sometimes called review gating) is against Google's policies.
2. **Ask at the right moment:** when the job is done and the customer is pleased. For a contractor, that might be the final walk-through; for a restaurant, the end of the meal; for a service business, after the problem is solved.
3. **Ask in person, then follow up in writing** with a direct link to your review form. Your Business Profile gives you a short review link and a QR code.
4. **Make it a process, not a favor.** Build the request into your follow-up emails or texts (Chapter 16), and name one person responsible.
5. **Keep it steady.** A few reviews every month is better than a burst once a year.
6. **Suggest what to mention,** without telling people what to say: "If you can, mention the type of project and the area you're in." Specific reviews help buyers and search engines more than "Great job!"

The rules

These aren't just good manners. Some are Google policy, and some are U.S. law.

- **No incentives.** Google prohibits offering discounts, gifts or anything else in exchange for reviews.
- **No fake reviews.** The FTC's rule on consumer reviews, finalized in 2024, bans fake reviews, including AI-generated ones, and buying or selling them. It also bans paying for reviews that express a particular opinion.
- **No undisclosed insider reviews.** Reviews from owners, managers or employees must disclose the connection, under the FTC rule. Google removes reviews with a conflict of interest, including from current or former employees.
- **No review suppression.** The FTC rule bans using threats, intimidation or groundless legal action to get negative reviews removed. Google also prohibits discouraging negative reviews.

The rule is now being enforced. The FTC's rule took effect on October 21, 2024. On December 22, 2025, the FTC sent its first warning letters under it to 10 companies, citing practices such as paying employees for getting five-star reviews from friends and family, and asking people with no real experience of the business to leave reviews. Recipients had five business days to send a compliance plan. Civil penalties run up to $53,088 per violation (Covington, Inside Privacy, 2026).

What that means for a small business:

- **Ask every customer.** Don't screen customers first and send the review link only to the happy ones. Google prohibits selectively asking for positive reviews, and the FTC rule targets suppression of negative ones.
- **No rewards tied to reviews.** No discounts, gifts or contest entries in exchange for a review, and never anything tied to a positive one.
- **No staff quotas or bonuses for five-star reviews.** Make asking a process for the whole business, not a target for one person.

- **Disclose connections.** Reviews from employees, family members or business partners must say so.

This isn't legal advice. If you're unsure whether a review program is allowed, check with your attorney before you launch it.

How to respond

Respond to every review, positive and negative, ideally within a few days.

Positive reviews: thank them by name, mention something specific from their review and keep it short. Don't paste the same reply every time.

Negative reviews:

1. Take a breath. Don't reply while you're angry.
2. Thank them for the feedback and acknowledge their experience, even if you see it differently.
3. Don't argue in public, and never share private details about the customer or the job.
4. Explain briefly what you've done or will do, if anything.
5. Offer to talk directly, with a name and a phone number or email.

You're not writing to the reviewer alone. You're writing to every future buyer who reads the exchange. A calm, helpful reply to a bad review can build more trust than another five-star review.

If a review is fake or breaks Google's policies (for example, it's from someone who was never a customer, or it's offensive), report it through your Business Profile. Don't threaten the reviewer.

One caution: AI can draft a reply in seconds, and that's exactly the problem: readers recognize AI-sounding replies. Use AI for a first draft, especially for a difficult negative review, then rewrite it in your own words with details only you know.

PRO TIP

Read your reviews for patterns, not just ratings. If three customers mention slow communication, that's not a marketing problem; it's an operations problem. Reviews are free customer research. Share them with your team.

AI TIP

Write your review request

Context: We're a **[type of business]** in **[area]**. The best moment to ask is **[when]**. We'll send it by **[text, email or both]** after **[the event]**. Our review link: **[link]**.

Role: Act as a customer experience writer for a small local business.

Ask: Write a short review request we can send to every customer.

Format: (1) A text message under 300 characters. (2) An email with subject line, under 120 words. (3) A one-line follow-up for customers who haven't responded after a week.

Tighten: Warm and personal, in our voice. Ask for their feedback, not a five-star review. No incentives of any kind. Suggest mentioning the type of project and area, without scripting what they say.

AI TIP

Draft a reply to a review

Context: Here is a review of our business: **[paste]**. What we know about this customer and job, without private details: **[facts]**. What we've done or will do about it: **[actions, if any]**. Our contact for follow-up: **[name, phone or email]**.

Role: Act as a calm, experienced customer service manager.

Ask: Draft a public reply to this review.

Format: Under 100 words. Two versions: one shorter, one more detailed.

Tighten: Thank them, acknowledge their experience and stay specific to what they wrote. Don't argue, don't make excuses, don't reveal private information and don't promise anything we haven't agreed to. I'll rewrite it in my own words before posting.

Our review process: when we ask, how we ask, who's responsible and our goal for new reviews each month.

Local Pages and Content

Your Business Profile wins the map. Your website wins the local results below it, and gives AI tools something to quote. In Whitespark's 2026 survey, the single most important factor for local organic rankings was having a dedicated page for each service.

Service pages

Give every main service its own page. A plumber needs separate pages for water heaters, drain cleaning and repiping, not one "Services" page that lists them all. Each page should answer the questions buyers ask about that service: what it is, what it costs or what affects the cost, how long it takes, what happens first and why they should choose you (Chapter 6).

Area pages

If you serve several towns or neighborhoods, a page for each main area can help you appear in searches for that area. But only if each page is useful. A page that copies the same text and swaps the city name helps no one, and Google treats it as low quality.

A good area page includes something specific to that place:

- Projects you've completed there, with photos
- Reviews from customers in that area
- Local details that matter to buyers, such as permits, regulations, soil, climate or HOA rules
- How you serve that area: response times, travel, who they'll work with

If you don't have anything specific to say about an area yet, list it on your service area page instead, and add a dedicated page once you have real work to show.

Service-area businesses

If you go to your customers (contractors, cleaners, mobile services), Google ranks you mainly near your business address, even when that address is hidden. You'll usually appear in the map pack close to your base and less often in towns farther away. Your website and area pages carry more of the load there, along with paid media (Chapter 12).

Make your local details easy to read

- Put your business name, phone number and service area (or address) on every page, usually in the footer, matching your master record exactly.
- Add LocalBusiness structured data (Chapter 6), including your service area.
- Embed a Google map on your contact page if customers visit you.

Local content and links

The best local links and mentions come from being part of your community: sponsorships, local associations, partnerships with related businesses, events and coverage in local media (Chapter 6). Local content such as project stories, neighborhood guides and seasonal advice gives people a reason to link to you and share you.

AI TIP

Write a service or area page

```
Context: Our business: [name, what we do]. The service or area for this page: [name]. Real details we can include: [projects completed, reviews from this area, local permits or rules, timelines, price ranges]. Questions buyers ask: [list].

Role: Act as a local SEO copywriter who writes pages for real buyers, not search engines.

Ask: Draft this page.

Format: Title tag, meta description, H1, then sections with H2 headings: what we do here, what it costs or what affects cost, how the process works, recent work, reviews, FAQ, call to action.

Tighten: Use only the details I gave you. Where a section needs facts I haven't provided, write [ADD: what's needed] instead of inventing them. No copied boilerplate; this page must be specific to this service or area.
```

EXAMPLE

Example: Wild West Custom Pools

Wild West Custom Pools builds pools at customers' homes across the Austin metro area: Austin, Round Rock, Pflugerville, Hutto and Lago Vista. That makes it a service-area business. Here's where its local presence stands, and what's next.

What's in place

- **Real reviews.** Dan has strong Google reviews from real clients. Eight of them appear on the new website, with a button that links to the rest on Google (Chapter 4).
- **A trust signal beyond Google.** Dan has an A+ rating with the Better Business Bureau. His most recent lead looked at his BBB profile first, then visited the website (Chapter 4). That's a citation doing its job: buyers check you in more than one place.
- **Google Business Profile first.** The advertising playbook put the free Business Profile ahead of any paid channel (Chapters 4 and 12).

What's not done yet

- **A citation audit.** Dan's business appears on Google, BBB, Facebook and LinkedIn (Chapter 13).

- **Area pages.** The website has no pages for Round Rock, Pflugerville, Hutto or Lago Vista. Following this chapter's advice, each should get a page once there's a finished pool there to show: photos, the project story and, ideally, a review from that client.
- **A review process.** The natural moment to ask is the first swim, when the client sees the finished pool.

The numbers we still need

- Current Google star rating and number of reviews: [ ]
- Is the profile set up as a service-area business, with the address hidden? [ ]
- Business Profile Performance, last three months: calls [ ], website clicks [ ], direction requests [ ], top searches [ ]

For a business that builds 12 pools a year, every review is precious. That's why the process matters more than the tactics: ask every client, at the right moment, and reply to every review in Dan's own voice.

MEASURING LOCAL RESULTS

Measuring Local Results

Track these monthly and review them at your quarterly business review (Chapter 1). Measure results, not activity: the goal isn't more reviews for their own sake, it's more calls and more customers.

WHAT TO TRACK	WHERE TO FIND IT	LAST MONTH	THIS MONTH	GOAL
Calls from your Business Profile	Business Profile Performance			
Website clicks from your profile	Business Profile Performance; your analytics (with tracking on the link)			
Direction requests (if customers visit you)	Business Profile Performance			
New reviews	Business Profile			
Average star rating	Business Profile			
Reviews answered (%)	Business Profile			
Map pack position for your top three searches	Search in each area you serve, or a local rank tracker			

WHAT TO TRACK	WHERE TO FIND IT	LAST MONTH	THIS MONTH	GOAL
Leads that mention Google, Maps, reviews or BBB	Your "How did you hear about us?" question (Chapter 19)			

Local results tracker

Check what AI says about you

Once a month, ask two or three AI assistants the questions your buyers would ask, such as "Who are the best [your service] companies in [your area]?" and "What do customers say about [your business]?" Note whether you're mentioned, what's said and which sources are cited. If an answer is wrong, fix the source it came from: your profile, your website or a listing.

PRO TIP

Map pack rankings change with the searcher's location. A search from your office will flatter you. Check from different parts of your service area, or use a rank tracker that shows results on a map grid.

AI TIP

Review your local results

```
Context: Here are our local numbers for the last three months: [paste from the tracker]. Our service area: [list]. Our top searches: [list]. Recent reviews: [paste the last ten, without customer names].

Role: Act as a local SEO analyst reviewing a small business's results.

Ask: Tell me what's working, what isn't and what to do next.

Format: (1) Three findings from the numbers. (2) Themes in the reviews: what customers praise and what they complain about. (3) Three actions for next month, in priority order.

Tighten: Base everything on the data I gave you. Say where the data is too thin to draw a conclusion.
```

LOCAL SEO AND REVIEWS

Local SEO and Reviews: Questions

Is our Google Business Profile claimed, verified and complete? What's missing?

Are we set up correctly as a storefront or a service-area business, with the right primary category?

What are the ten questions buyers ask most, and where are they answered on our website and profile?

Which listings matter most for our industry and area, and are our name, address or service area and phone number the same on all of them?

What's our current star rating, review count and number of new reviews per month? What's our goal?

When and how will we ask every customer for a review, and who is responsible?

Who responds to reviews, and how quickly?

Which services and areas need their own pages, and what real details can we put on each?

What do AI assistants say about us today, and what do we need to fix?

Local SEO and reviews

SOURCES

Sources

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CONTENT

Is yours worth finding?

In this chapter »

Your best salesperson works around the clock.

— **CONTENT CREATION**
What good content does: audience, value, found and seen

— **WHO WILL CREATE IT**
Roles, resources and the checklist a content program needs

— **WHO YOUR CONTENT SPEAKS TO**
Personas built from real customers

— **THE CONTENT AUDIT**
Inventory, categorize and score what you already have

— **FROM AUDIT TO ACTION**
Turn what you found into your next content plan

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
6 AI Tips, including turning an expert interview into a first draft

CONTENT

Content: Your Best Salesperson

“People don't want to buy a quarter-inch drill. They want a quarter-inch hole!”

THEODORE LEVITT
quoting Leo McGinneva, The Marketing Imagination (1983)

Content is the salesperson that works for you 24 hours a day, seven days a week. It answers the buyer's questions before they're ready to talk to you, and it's still working when you're asleep. Articles, guides, case studies, videos, social posts and emails are all content. So is every page of your website.

In the first edition, the hard part was producing enough of it. That problem is gone. In the Content Marketing Institute's 2026 research, 89% of B2B marketers said they use AI to create or optimize written content. Most said it made them more productive. Only 39% said it improved how their content performed, and only 12% said their marketing was highly effective (CMI, 2026).

That gap is the point of this chapter. When everyone can publish unlimited content, more content isn't an advantage. Better content is: content that answers a real buyer's real question, shows experience nobody else has, and leads the reader to a next step.

The drill and the hole

Levitt's line is the oldest rule in marketing, and it's the first rule of content. Buyers don't care about your product. They care about the problem it solves. A pool buyer isn't searching for "gunite construction." They're searching for "how long does it take to build a pool" and "what happens if the builder disappears." Write about the hole, and the drill sells itself. Write about the first swim, and the gunite sells itself.

What only you can add

AI can write a competent page on almost any topic in seconds. So can every one of your competitors. What AI can't produce is your experience. These are the ingredients that make content worth reading, worth citing and hard to copy:

- **Customer stories** — a real problem, what you did and what happened, with the customer's permission.
- **Original data** — your own numbers: average project time, survey results, before-and-after results.
- **Photos and video of your work** — not stock images.
- **Opinions** — what you'd tell a friend, including when *not* to buy from you.
- **Lessons from mistakes** — what went wrong and what you changed.

This is what Google means by experience in E-E-A-T (see Chapter 6), and it's what AI answers look for when they choose a source to cite.

PRO TIP

Interview before you write. Spend 20 minutes asking your best salesperson, installer or customer service lead what customers asked them this week. Record it (with permission), have AI transcribe it, and you'll have a month of content ideas in their words, not yours.

List three things your business knows from experience that a competitor or an AI tool couldn't easily copy.

CONTENT CREATION

Content Creation

Good content does four things: it knows its audience, gives real value, gets found and gets seen. Miss any one and the other three are wasted.

- **Know your audience.** Write for one persona at one stage of the journey. If you can't name who a piece is for, it's for no one. (Personas are built in Chapter 5.)
- **Give real value.** Teach, solve, compare or entertain. Every piece should leave the reader knowing something they didn't, or one step closer to a decision.
- **Get found.** Answer the question in the first two sentences, use the words buyers use and structure the page so search engines and AI tools can quote it. Chapter 6 covers this, including three page templates.
- **Get seen.** Publishing is half the job. Share it through email and social media, and put a small paid media budget behind your best pieces so the right people see them. More on this in the Distribution and Paid Media chapters.

Match content to the journey

Most businesses have plenty of decision-stage content (pricing, services, contact pages) and almost nothing for buyers who are just starting to look, or who already bought. Use this table to plan a balance. Your Chapter 5 content mix shows where you are today.

STAGE	WHAT THE BUYER NEEDS	CONTENT THAT WORKS	WHERE AI HELPS
Awareness	Understand the problem	How-to guides, checklists, short videos, social posts	Topic research, first drafts, repurposing one piece into many
Consideration	Compare options	Comparison pages, buying guides, webinars, FAQs	Structuring comparisons, summarizing reviews, drafting FAQs
Decision	Trust you enough to buy	Case studies, pricing pages, testimonials, demos	Drafting case studies from interview transcripts

STAGE	WHAT THE BUYER NEEDS	CONTENT THAT WORKS	WHERE AI HELPS
Retention	Get the most from the purchase	Onboarding emails, tips, customer-only guides	Personalizing emails, answering common questions
Advocacy	Share their experience	Review requests, referral programs, customer spotlights	Drafting review requests and spotlight stories

Tell stories

Facts inform; stories persuade.

A case study that starts with a customer's problem, shows what you did and ends with what changed is the most useful decision-stage content you can make. Start with your brand's story: why you started, what you do differently and who you do it for. Then tell your customers' stories the same way.

Make it easy to watch

Buyers increasingly expect video at every stage. Short videos, photos and simple graphics make content easier to take in and easier to share. You don't need a studio. A phone, good light and a clear point beat a polished video with nothing to say. The Video chapter goes deeper.

The AI content workflow

Here's how most teams now work. AI does the heavy lifting in the middle; people own the beginning and the end.

1. **Brief (person).** Choose the persona, the question, the stage and the one action you want the reader to take.
2. **Draft (AI).** Give AI the brief, your voice guide and your raw material: interview notes, data, photos.
3. **Add what only you can (person).** Insert the story, the numbers and the opinion. Cut anything generic.
4. **Check and approve (person).** Verify every fact and quote at its source. A person approves every public word.
5. **Publish, promote and refresh (both).** Share it, measure it and update it when it ages. AI can flag pages that need a refresh.

PRO TIP

Focus on storytelling. Start by finding your brand's own story, then use it to create content that connects with your audience on an emotional level. People forget features. They remember stories.

AI TIP

Build a content plan by journey stage

```
Act as a content strategist for a [type of business] serving [audience]
in [market].
Our persona: [paste persona from Chapter 5]
Our content mix today: [paste the Ch5 Content Mix tab]
The questions buyers ask at each stage: [paste the Ch5 Buyer Questions tab]
What we know from experience that competitors don't: [your three answers
from this chapter]

Create a 90-day content plan: 3 pieces per journey stage, each with a
working title, format, the buyer question it answers, the first-hand
material it needs from us, and one call to action. Put it in a table.
Flag any stage where we have nothing today.
```

CONTENT RESOURCE CHECKLIST

Content Resource Checklist

These are the deliverables a working content program needs. Check what you have today. Anything unchecked goes on your skills gap plan from Chapter 3.

- ☐ Personas for each main buyer, with the questions they ask at each stage (Chapter 5)
- ☐ A brand voice guide with two or three samples of your best writing, ready to paste into AI prompts
- ☐ A content plan mapped to the five journey stages
- ☐ An editorial calendar with owners and due dates
- ☐ A library of first-hand material: customer stories, project photos, your own data
- ☐ A brief template every piece starts from
- ☐ A review and approval step before anything is published, including a fact check
- ☐ On-page SEO checklist from Chapter 6, used on every page
- ☐ A distribution plan for each piece: email, social media and paid media
- ☐ A refresh schedule for your most important pages
- ☐ Monthly reporting on traffic, leads and conversions by piece
- ☐ A saved library of tested AI prompts (the Ch1 Prompt Library tab)

Which three unchecked items would make the biggest difference in the next 90 days?

Content resource checklist

WHO WILL CREATE YOUR CONTENT

Who Will Create Your Content

The first edition named three roles: content strategist, content creator and content marketer. All three still matter. What's changed is how much one person can do with AI, and which skills matter most. A small business may have one person covering all of these. A larger team splits them up. Either way, someone must own each job.

ROLE	WHAT THEY DO	KEY SKILLS NOW	HOW AI CHANGES THE JOB
Content strategist	Plans what to create, for whom and why; owns the calendar and the results	Audience insight, SEO and AI search, analytics	AI speeds research and gap analysis; judgment about what's worth making stays human
Content creator (writer, designer, videographer)	Produces articles, graphics, video and social posts	Writing and editing, storytelling, visual sense, interviewing	AI drafts; the creator adds experience, voice and accuracy, and edits hard
Content marketer	Gets content seen through email, social media and paid media	Channel knowledge, paid media, testing	AI writes variations and spots patterns; people set budgets and approve ads
Editor and fact checker	Reviews every piece before it's published	Accuracy, brand voice, source checking	More important than ever: AI states wrong facts with confidence
Subject matter experts	Supply the stories, data and opinions	Expertise, willingness to be interviewed	AI turns a 20-minute interview into a first draft

Note the new row. The editor's job used to be polish. Now it's protection. Every team using AI needs one person whose job is to check facts, quotes and claims before anything goes public.

For each role, write who covers it today: a team member, an agency, a freelancer or nobody.

AI TIP

Turn an expert interview into a first draft

```
Act as a content writer who writes in a plain, direct voice.

Below is a transcript of a [length]-minute interview with [name and role]

about [topic].

Our persona: [paste persona]

The buyer question this piece answers: [question]

Our brand voice: [paste voice guide or two writing samples]


Write a [format and length] draft. Lead with the answer to the buyer's

question. Use the expert's stories and examples, quoting them exactly.

Don't add facts, numbers or claims that aren't in the transcript. Mark

with [brackets] anywhere you need more detail from us.


Transcript:

[paste transcript]
```

WHO YOUR CONTENT SPEAKS TO

Who Your Content Speaks To

Personas are short profiles of your ideal customers: who they are, what they're trying to do, what worries them and where they look for answers. You built them in Chapter 5 as part of your customer journey. This section uses them for content: what each persona wants to read, watch and ask, and where they'll find it.

Whether you're B2B or B2C, a small business or an enterprise, you have a specific audience. Some businesses serve a narrow one; others cover a broad range. Either way, write for a person, not a market. A piece written for "homeowners" speaks to no one. A piece written for "a Round Rock couple with two kids, planning a pool before next summer and worried about the builder disappearing" speaks to every buyer like them.

Three principles from the first edition still hold:

- **Base personas on research, not guesses.** Use customer interviews, sales call notes, reviews, website analytics and surveys.
- **Focus on what matters to your business.** Demographics help, but goals, fears and buying behavior help more.

- **Keep them current.** Review personas at every second QBR. Buyers change, and so do the places they look. Two years ago, few of your buyers asked an AI assistant for recommendations. Now many do.

PRO TIP

Make your personas detailed and realistic. Give each one a name, a short backstory and a personality. Then list their goals, pain points, motivations and the questions they ask. A persona your team can picture is one they'll actually write for.

AI TIP

Find what your customers really care about

```
Act as a customer research analyst.

Below are [number] customer reviews, sales call notes or survey answers

from our [type of business].

Our current persona: [paste persona from Chapter 5]


1. List the 10 questions, worries and goals that come up most often, in

the customers' own words, with how many times each appears.

2. Note anything that contradicts our persona.

3. Suggest five content ideas that would answer the most common questions.

Only use what's in the material below. Don't invent quotes.


Material:

[paste reviews, notes or survey answers, with names removed]
```

Note: Remove customer names, emails and other personal details before you paste anything into an AI tool (see the ground rules in Chapter 1).

Creating Personas: Questions 1–10

Answer these for each main persona. Your Chapter 5 persona journey has the starting point.

1. Who are the primary and secondary audiences for our products or services?

2. What are their demographics: age, income, location, role, company size or other factors that matter for us?

3. What do they value, and what are their attitudes toward buying something like what we sell?

4. What problems and frustrations push them to start looking?

5. What do they need to believe before they'll buy from us?

6. How will we keep learning about them: interviews, surveys, sales call notes, reviews or analytics?

7. Which formats do they prefer: articles, short video, long video, podcasts, email or tools like calculators?

8. Where do they look for answers: search engines, AI assistants, social media, forums, email, events or friends?

9. What words do they use for their problem, and what words do they never use? (Your content should sound like them.)

10. Who influences their decision, such as a spouse, a boss, a committee or an online community, and what does that person need from our content?

CONTENT MARKETING

Content Marketing: Questions 1–10

Answer these with your team before you build your content plan.

1. What three or four themes do we want to be known for?

2. How will our content be different from competitors'? What perspective or experience can only we offer?

3. What does our brand sound like? Is our voice guide written down and ready to paste into an AI prompt?

4. Which first-hand material do we already have (customer stories, project photos, data), and who will collect more?

5. What will AI do in our content process, what will people do, and who approves every piece before it's published?

6. How will each piece be distributed: email, social media, paid media or partners? Which pieces deserve a paid budget?

7. Which buyer questions will we answer so clearly that search engines and AI assistants cite us? (See Chapter 6.)

8. How can we use customer reviews, testimonials or interactive content like calculators and quizzes?

9. How often can we realistically publish good content, and how will we keep that pace?

10. How will we measure what works (traffic, leads, conversions and AI citations) and how often will we review it?

THE CONTENT AUDIT

The Content Audit

A content audit is an inventory of everything you've published, scored against your goals. It shows what's working, what's out of date, what's missing and what should go. Most businesses that run one find two surprises: much of their content gets almost no traffic, and whole stages of the customer journey have nothing at all.

AI has made audits far faster. The first edition's audit meant days in a spreadsheet. Now a crawl tool gathers the data, and AI can sort, label and summarize it in minutes. The judgment calls are still yours.

Four steps

1. **Set goals and KPIs.** Decide what your content is for: traffic, leads, sales or customer retention. Use the goals and KPIs from Chapter 1, so the audit measures what matters.
2. **Gather and score your content.** Crawl your site and export every URL. Add traffic and conversions from Google Analytics 4, and clicks and impressions from Google Search Console. Score each page: keep, update, combine or delete.
3. **Find the gaps.** Compare your content to your personas, your buyer questions and your competitors. Where are buyers asking questions you don't answer? Which journey stages are empty?
4. **Build the action plan.** List what to refresh, create, combine and remove, with an owner and a date for each.

Tools

We still use and recommend **Screaming Frog SEO Spider**. It runs on your computer and crawls a website the way a search engine does, listing every page with its title, description, headings, word count and errors. The free version crawls up to 500 URLs, which covers most small business sites. Export the results to Excel or Google Sheets. Then crawl two or three competitors' sites the same way and compare.

↓ Screaming Frog SEO Spider

Pair the crawl with your own data:

- **Google Search Console** — which pages appear in search, for which queries, and how often they're clicked.
- **Google Analytics 4** — which pages bring visitors who convert.
- **An AI assistant** — to categorize pages, spot duplicates and draft recommendations (see the AI TIP below).

PRO TIP

Approach your audit from your buyer's point of view. Pick a persona, list the questions they ask at each stage and check whether your site answers each one, clearly and accurately. Then review existing content to make sure it's current and engaging, and check that you're publishing it in the channels your buyers use.

PRO TIP

Refresh before you create. Updating a page that already has some traffic and links is usually faster, and often pays off sooner, than starting a new one. Check your top 20 pages first.

AI TIP

Audit your content against your buyer's questions

```
Act as a content strategist running a content audit.

Attached is a crawl export of our website with URL, title, meta

description, H1 and word count, plus clicks and impressions from Google

Search Console for the last 6 months.

Our personas: [paste]

The questions buyers ask at each journey stage: [paste Ch5 Buyer Questions]

Our goals: [paste from Chapter 1]


1. Label each page by content type and journey stage.

2. Mark each page Keep, Update, Combine or Delete, with a one-line reason.

3. List buyer questions that no page answers, by stage.

4. List pages that compete with each other for the same topic.

Put the results in tables. Use only the data provided; flag anything you

had to assume.
```

CATEGORIZE YOUR CONTENT

Categorize Your Content

Label every page in your audit by content type and journey stage. The labels show your gaps at a glance. Most businesses find the largest share of their content sits in the decision stage, with little for buyers who are just starting to look or who have already bought. Aim for a balance across the whole journey.

The first edition's list of content types still works as a starting point: About us, blog posts, calculators, careers, contact, events, FAQs, gallery, home page, landing pages, leadership and team pages, portfolio, press, pricing, privacy policy, products and services, quizzes, resources, search results, success stories, surveys, terms and conditions, testimonials and videos. Add two that matter more now: comparison pages and quick-answer pages (Chapter 6).

CONTENT TYPE	MAIN STAGE	HOW MANY WE HAVE	GAP OR ACTION
How-to guides and blog posts	Awareness		
Videos	Awareness / Consideration		
Comparison and buying guides	Consideration		
FAQs and quick-answer pages	Consideration		
Products and services pages	Decision		
Pricing	Decision		
Case studies and success stories	Decision		
Testimonials and reviews	Decision / Advocacy		
Gallery or portfolio	Decision		
Onboarding and customer guides	Retention		
Customer newsletter	Retention		
Referral and review requests	Advocacy		

Fill in the table from your audit. The Ch9 Content Inventory tab in the companion workbook totals pages by stage automatically.

FROM AUDIT TO ACTION

From Audit to Action

An audit is only useful if it changes what you publish. Turn your findings into four kinds of action.

- **Refresh and optimize.** Update old posts with current information, remove dated content, improve product and service pages, and apply the Chapter 6 on-page checklist. Rank the list by impact on your goals.
- **Create.** Fill the gaps your audit found, starting with the journey stages that have nothing. Add each piece to the editorial calendar with an owner and a date.
- **Distribute.** Decide where each piece will be seen: email, social media, paid media or partners. Every new long piece can become several social posts, a short video and an email.
- **Govern.** Write down who creates, who reviews, who approves and how often each page gets checked. Without this, the audit's gains fade within a year.

Find ideas you already have

Answer these to fill your calendar for the next quarter.

Name five experts in your industry you could interview for an article, video or podcast.

YOUR TURN

List customers you could interview for a case study or video.

YOUR TURN

List guides, case studies, webinars, podcasts, videos or e-books you could create in the next quarter.

YOUR TURN

List recent content and presentations you could repurpose.

YOUR TURN

Governance: who is accountable?

JOB	OWNER	HOW OFTEN
Approves the content plan		Quarterly
Writes or produces content		Weekly
Reviews facts and approves publishing		Every piece
Promotes content (email, social, paid)		Every piece
Refreshes top pages		Quarterly
Reports results		Monthly

↓ Content editorial calendar template

AI TIP

Turn one piece into a week of content

```
Act as a content marketer.

Below is a [type of content] we published: [paste or link it].

Our persona: [paste]

Our channels: [list, e.g., LinkedIn, Facebook, email newsletter, YouTube]


Create a one-week plan that reuses this piece: three social posts (each

with a different angle), one email to our list, one 60-second video

script, and two headline and description options for a paid social ad.

Keep our facts exactly as written. Mark anything that needs a photo or

clip from us.
```

CONTENT AUDIT

Content Audit: Questions 1–10

1. What is each piece of content for, and does it support our goals?

2. Which pieces have done best for traffic, leads and conversions, and why?

3. Which formats are we missing or short on, such as video, comparison pages, case studies or long-form guides?

4. Which existing pieces can we update, combine or repurpose to make them more useful?

5. Which journey stages have the least content, and what will we create first?

6. Which buyer questions does no page on our site answer?

7. Which pages should we delete or redirect because they're outdated, thin or duplicated?

8. Which channels work best for distributing our content, including paid media, and how should we adapt content for each?

9. When AI assistants answer our buyers' questions, which sources do they cite, and why isn't it us? (Check with the Chapter 1 AI visibility test.)

10. How will we measure content results, and how often will we repeat this audit?

AI TIP

Research what's missing in your market

```
Act as a content strategist with web research turned on.

We are a [type of business] in [market]. Our main topics: [list].

Our competitors: [list 3 websites].


Find the questions buyers in our market are asking that our competitors

answer poorly or not at all. For each, give the question, where you saw

it asked (with a link), which competitor covers it best and what a

better answer would include. List 10.
```

Note: Check every source and figure the AI gives you at its source before you rely on it (see "Check the source, not the summary" in Chapter 1).

Notes

SOURCES

Sources

- Content Marketing Institute and MarketingProfs, B2B Content and Marketing Trends: Insights for 2026 — 1,015 B2B marketers, surveyed June–August 2025
- Theodore Levitt, *The Marketing Imagination* (Free Press, 1983)
- Screaming Frog SEO Spider

HUB & SPOKE

Do you own your audience?

In this chapter »

Build an audience you own.

— **HOW IT WORKS**
One hub, six spokes, one list

— **GATED OR OPEN?**
When to ask for an email, and when not to

— **THE AI LAYER**
From one big piece to a month of spokes

— **YOUR CAMPAIGN ABSTRACT**
A one-page plan before you create anything

— **A SIX-MONTH CAMPAIGN**
An example schedule, plus hub and spoke questions

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
2 AI Tips: turn your hub into a month of spokes, and draft the nurture emails

Hub and Spoke: Build an Audience You Own

Hub and spoke is a simple idea. You create one valuable, in-depth piece of content, the **hub**, and a set of smaller pieces, the **spokes**, that point people to it. The hub earns attention. The spokes spread it. And when a reader trades their email address for the hub, you've added someone to an audience you own.

That last part matters more now than it did in 2023. In Chapters 5 and 6 you saw how AI answers are taking clicks from websites. Social platforms change what they show your followers. Ad prices rise. An email list is different: it's yours, you can reach it whenever you want and no algorithm decides whether your message is seen. Your list is also first-party data, the most valuable kind as privacy rules tighten (Chapter 1).

An email list is the one audience no algorithm can take away.

Now that you've worked through strategy, your customer journey, SEO and content, a hub and spoke campaign is where it comes together into one plan you can launch.

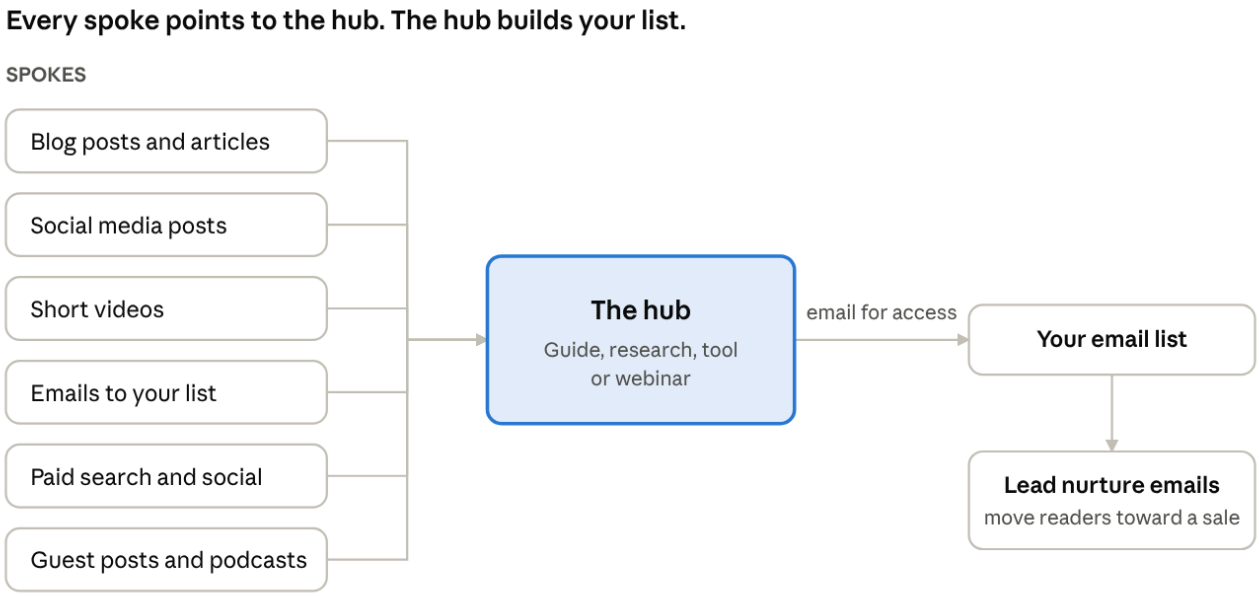
Treat a hub like a product launch

A hub isn't a blog post. It deserves the planning, promotion and follow-up you'd give a new product or service. Publish spokes on a regular schedule and promote the hub for months, not days. A pace of at least one new hub each quarter will grow your owned audience steadily.

Good hubs include:

- **Guides** — "The Austin Pool Buyer's Guide" or "How to Choose a Fractional CMO."
- **Original research** — a survey of your customers or industry, with results only you have.
- **Case study collections** — three to five customer stories on one problem.
- **Interactive tools** — calculators, quizzes and assessments that give the reader a personal result.
- **Webinars and video series** — recorded, so they keep working after the live date.
- **Templates and checklists** — practical tools the reader will use and keep.

How It Works



hub and spoke · six spokes, one hub, one list

The hub is your most valuable piece of content on one topic: a guide, research report, tool, case study collection or webinar. It's worth enough that a reader will give you their name and email address to get it.

The spokes are shorter pieces that each cover one part of the hub and point to it: blog posts, social posts, short videos, emails, paid ads and guest appearances. Each spoke should be useful on its own, even for people who never download the hub.

The list is what the hub builds. Everyone who signs up gets a short series of nurture emails that move them along the customer journey. The Lead Nurture chapter covers those emails in depth.

Plan the spokes when you plan the hub, not after. As you outline the hub, mark which sections can become a post, a graphic for LinkedIn, a short video for YouTube or an email. You'll save time, and every spoke will fit the whole.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Final print graphic of the hub and spoke, with the hub at the center and spokes around it, in.

GATED OR OPEN?

Gated or Open?

In the first edition, the hub sat behind a form: no email, no content. That trade still works for some hubs. But it has a cost that's grown since 2023. Search engines can't read content behind a form, so a gated hub can't rank, and AI assistants can't quote it or cite you as the source. For a business trying to be found in AI answers (Chapter 6), locking up your best content can work against you.

The first edition also offered a variation, and for most businesses it's now the better default. Publish the hub as an open page that anyone can read, and offer a downloadable version, a PDF, a checklist or a bonus template in exchange for an email address. Our own example was a long article, "The OODA Loop: How to Turn Uncertainty Into Opportunity," with no form in the way. Throughout the article, a call to action said: "This is a long article. If you prefer, you can download it as a PDF to read later." Read it on Medium.

The open version does three things:

- **No barrier.** Anyone can read it, so more people do.
- **A natural reason to sign up.** A great article is one people want to save.
- **Search and AI visibility.** The page can rank, and AI answers can cite it.

CHOOSE THIS	WHEN
Open hub with a download offer (the default)	You want search and AI visibility, and the topic is one buyers research on their own
Gated hub	The hub is truly exclusive (original research, a tool, a template) and your goal this quarter is leads, not reach
Both	Publish a summary of the research openly, and gate the full report or the tool

PRO TIP

Ask for as little as you need. Every extra form field costs sign-ups. For most hubs, a first name and an email address are enough. You can learn the rest through your nurture emails.

THE AI LAYER

The AI Layer

Hub and spoke used to be a lot of work for a small team: one big piece, then weeks of cutting it into smaller ones. AI changes the math in three places.

- **Spokes in hours, not weeks.** Give AI your finished hub and it will draft a month of spokes: posts, video scripts, email copy and ad variations. Your job is to pick the best, add your examples and approve every word.

- **Interactive hubs are within reach.** Calculators, quizzes and assessments used to need a developer. AI can now help you build a simple one, like a pool budget estimator or a marketing readiness score. Tools give readers a personal result, which makes them some of the most valuable hubs you can offer.
- **Nurture that fits the reader.** AI can draft different nurture email paths for different personas or interests, so a reader who downloaded a buying guide hears something different from one who used the budget calculator.

What AI can't do is make the hub worth downloading. The research, the experience and the point of view still come from you (see "What only you can add" in Chapter 9).

AI TIP

Turn your hub into a month of spokes

```
Act as a content marketer planning a hub and spoke campaign.

Our hub: [title, format and a summary, or paste the full text]

Our persona: [paste persona]

Our channels: [e.g., blog, LinkedIn, Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, email,

Google Ads]


Create a four-week spoke plan in a table: week, channel, format, working

title or hook, which section of the hub it draws from, and the call to

action that sends people to the hub. Include at least two short-video

ideas and two paid ad variations. Then draft the first three spokes.

Use only facts from the hub.
```

AI TIP

Draft the nurture emails for your hub

```
Act as an email marketer.

Our hub: [title and summary]

Who downloads it: [persona and journey stage]

What we want them to do next: [e.g., book a consultation]

Our brand voice: [paste voice guide]


Write a four-email series spaced over three weeks after the download.

Email 1 delivers the hub and one quick tip. Emails 2 and 3 each answer a

common question at the next journey stage and link to one useful page.

Email 4 makes a clear, low-pressure offer. For each: subject line,

preview text, body under 150 words and one call to action. Mark with

[brackets] anywhere you need a fact or story from us.
```

YOUR TURN

Your Turn: The Hub and Spoke Campaign Abstract

Before you create anything, write a one-page abstract. It keeps the team aligned and gives AI everything it needs to help. Here's an example, then your version.

Example: Wild West Custom Pools

This is an illustration built from the Chapter 4 case study, not a campaign Dan has run.

ELEMENT	EXAMPLE
Business goal	Generate consultation requests from Austin-area homeowners planning a $90,000+ pool in the next 12 months
Persona	A Round Rock or Austin couple planning their first custom pool, worried about builders who disappear and permits that drag on

ELEMENT	EXAMPLE
Hub title	The Austin Pool Buyer's Guide: Costs, Timelines and 10 Questions to Ask Any Builder
Format	An open web page, plus a downloadable PDF checklist for an email address
Who creates it	Dan supplies the experience and photos; AI drafts; Mike edits; the designer lays out the PDF
Spoke ideas	A blog post on each of the 10 questions; short videos of Dan answering one question on-site; Facebook and Instagram posts with pool photos; a Google Ads campaign on "custom pool cost Austin"
Lead nurture	Four emails: the checklist, how the build process works, a customer story, and an invitation to an on-site consultation

Your abstract

Business goal and background. What problem will this hub solve for the business, and what result do you want?

Target audience. Which persona, at which journey stage? Be specific. Your content must speak to this one person.

YOUR TURN

Hub topic, theme and title ideas. Base them on keyword research and the questions your buyers actually ask (Chapters 5 and 6).

YOUR TURN

Format. Guide, research, tool, case studies, webinar or template? Open, gated or both? The topic may decide the best format.

YOUR TURN

Who creates it. Roles to consider: content strategist, writer, graphic designer, videographer, editor, SEO specialist and lead nurture specialist. Which do you have in-house, and which do you need from a freelancer or agency?

Spoke ideas. Which sections become posts, graphics, videos, emails and ads? Bake them in now.

YOUR TURN

Lead nurture ideas. What will the emails after sign-up say, and where will they send people? A series of four emails over a few weeks is a good start.

YOUR TURN

↓ Hub and spoke abstract template

A Six-Month Hub and Spoke Campaign

Here's an example of six months of promotion for one hub. What do you like about it? What would you change? What content and formats would you add? Use the notes to plan your own.

Month 1: Plan and launch

- Research keywords and buyer questions, and write the campaign abstract.
- Publish the hub on your website, with the download offer and a short sign-up form.
- Publish two or three spokes that link to the hub.
- Set up the nurture emails before the first sign-up arrives.

Month 2: Spread it

- Publish one or two more spokes.
- Share sections of the hub on social media and in your email newsletter.
- Pitch a guest post or podcast appearance on a site your buyers trust, linking to the hub.

Month 3: Add formats

- Create a short video or graphic from the hub and share it on social media.
- Ask partners, industry voices or customers to share the hub.
- Update the hub with anything new you've learned from the questions readers ask.

Month 4: Add proof and paid reach

- Publish a case study or customer story tied to the hub topic.
- Run a paid search and paid social campaign to the hub, starting with a small test budget.
- Publish one or two more spokes.

Month 5: Go live

- Host a webinar or live Q&A on the topic, and promote it by email and social media.
- Pitch publications and sites to feature the hub and link to it.
- Refresh the hub again.

Month 6: Measure and decide

- Publish a short survey or results update related to the topic.
- Publish one or two more spokes.
- Review sign-ups, cost per lead from paid media, nurture email results and leads by source. Use AI to summarize what worked, then decide whether to keep promoting this hub or start the next one.

Notes for your six-month plan:

Six-month campaign planner

HUB CONTENT

Hub Content: Questions 1–5

1. Which topics or themes matter enough to our target audience that they'll want our hub?

2. How will we make the hub valuable enough to be worth an email address, and include experience or data only we have?

3. Which format will communicate the topic best and generate leads: a guide, research, a tool, case studies, a webinar or a template?

4. Will the hub be open, gated or both? If there's a form, how will we keep it as short as possible?

5. Which channels, including paid media, will we use to promote the hub so it reaches our target audience?

SPOKE CONTENT

Spoke Content: Questions 1–5

1. Which topics or themes will support the hub and make people want to read more?

2. Which formats and channels will drive the most people to the hub: blog posts, social posts, short video, email or ads?

3. How will we make sure each spoke is useful on its own, even for people who never download the hub?

4. Which metrics will we track for the spokes, such as clicks to the hub, sign-ups by source and cost per sign-up from paid media?

5. How will we keep improving our spokes over time, and how will AI help us create and test new ones?

Notes

VIDEO

Can buyers see the work?

In this chapter »

Let buyers see the work before they buy it.

— **WHY VIDEO**
The easiest content to consume, and a strong closer

— **VIDEO FOR EVERY STAGE**
Which videos fit each step of the journey

— **PRODUCING VIDEO**
Good video starts on paper

— **GETTING VIDEO FOUND**
Titles, descriptions, chapters and where to post

— **MEASURING AND PLANNING**
The numbers that matter, and your video strategy

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
6 AI Tips, from a script and storyboard to turning one long video into many

Video Content: Engage Your Audience and Close More Sales

Video is the easiest content to consume. Your buyer can watch you build, explain, demonstrate and answer questions without reading a word. Use it in every channel: your website, email, social media and paid media.

Video is also one of the most powerful ways to tell a story. In Chapter 9, we put it in four words: facts inform; stories persuade. A page can list your facts. A video can show a real customer, a real project and the person behind the work, in a few minutes your buyer is glad to spend.

The numbers back that up. In Wyzowl's 2026 survey, 91% of businesses use video as a marketing tool. 85% of people say they've been convinced to buy a product or service by watching a video. When people want to learn about a product or service, 63% say they'd most like to watch a short video (Wyzowl, 2026). Wyzowl makes explainer videos, so read its numbers as a strong signal, not the final word.

Video works because it does two things text can't. It shows. People love to see how the sausage is made, and a time-lapse of a build or a walk through your shop answers questions a page of copy can't. And it connects. A face, a voice and a real customer's story build trust faster than any claim on a web page.

One video can go a long way. Dollar Shave Club launched in 2012 with a single 93-second video that explained the product, the price and how to buy. The company reported more than 12,000 orders in the first 48 hours (Convince & Convert, 2018), and Unilever bought it for $1 billion four years later (Bloomberg, 2016). That's an outlier. But it shows what one clear, honest video can do.

Video lets buyers see the work before they buy it.

What AI changed

Two things changed since the first edition, and both work in your favor.

Video is now a source for AI answers. In Ahrefs' analysis of more than 3 million U.S. searches, YouTube was the most-cited website in Google's AI Overviews, ahead of Reddit (Ahrefs, September 2026). AI tools read your title, description, chapters and transcript. A well-labeled video that answers a buyer's question can now show up inside the answer, not just in a list of results. More on this in Getting video found, below.

Video is faster and cheaper to make. In Wyzowl's survey, 63% of video marketers have used AI tools to create or edit marketing videos (Wyzowl, 2026). AI can turn your notes into a script, draft a storyboard, write captions, clean up audio, cut a long video into short clips and resize it for each platform. The camera work, the people on screen and the story still come from you.

One caution: AI can also generate realistic people, voices and footage. Don't use AI to show a project, a customer or a result that didn't happen. YouTube requires creators to disclose realistic content that was made or meaningfully altered with AI, such as footage of events that never took place or a real person appearing to say something they didn't (YouTube Help). Using AI for scripts, captions, thumbnails or edits doesn't need a label. Faked footage breaks the first AI ground rule in Chapter 1: verify facts, and keep your voice.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Hero graphic.

TYPES OF VIDEO FOR EVERY STAGE OF THE JOURNEY

Types of Video for Every Stage of the Journey

Don't make video just to make video. Every video should serve one stage of your customer journey (Chapter 5) and move the viewer to the next one.

STAGE	VIDEO TYPES THAT WORK	WHAT THE BUYER GETS
Awareness	Social clips, short how-to videos, behind-the-scenes, video ads	A reason to notice you and a first answer to their problem
Consideration	Explainer videos, FAQ videos, comparisons, webinars, retargeting ads	Help weighing their options, and why you're different
Decision	Product and demo videos, customer testimonials, "meet the owner" or "meet the team"	Proof, trust and a clear picture of what happens next
Retention	Onboarding, how-to and "getting the most from it" videos	Confidence they made the right choice
Advocacy	Customer stories, user-generated video, thank-you videos	Something worth sharing, and a story the next buyer can trust

A few of these deserve a closer look.

Product and demo videos work like a salesperson who never takes a day off. They show what you sell and how it works. Start with what you already have: your sales sheets, brochures and the pitch your best salesperson gives every day.

Explainer videos replace a wall of text about what you do. They're good for services, and for ideas that are hard to show with a camera. Simple animation works well here.

FAQ videos are the easiest to make. Ask your sales and customer service teams what they hear every week, then answer one question per video. Buyers get answers outside business hours, and your team stops repeating itself. Each one answers a question buyers actually ask, which is exactly what AI answers look for.

Testimonial videos let a real customer say what you can't say about yourself. Make it easy: a short list of questions, a phone camera and five minutes. Never script a customer's words, and never use AI to create a customer who doesn't exist.

Video for paid ads. Most of the types above can be cut down for ads on social media, YouTube and display networks. Plan each shoot with more than one use in mind.

PRO TIP

Keep it short and focused. Be clear about the purpose of each video and stick to one message and one call to action. Hook viewers in the first few seconds and keep the pace up. In Wyzowl's survey, 71% of marketers said videos between 30 seconds and two minutes are the most effective (Wyzowl, 2026). Longer is fine for how-to videos and webinars when every minute earns its place.

PRO TIP

Match the production to the purpose. The quality of your video reflects the quality of your brand, so invest in good lighting, clear audio and clean editing for the videos that live on your home page or represent your brand in ads. But a how-to, a FAQ answer or a social clip shot on a phone can work just as well. Viewers forgive a plain picture. They don't forgive bad audio.

PRO TIP

Always ask for the next step. A video with no call to action is a sales pitch that never asks for the sale. Tell viewers what to do next: book a consultation, watch the next video, download the guide. Put the link in the description, on the screen and on the page where the video lives.

AI TIP

Turn your buyers' questions into a video plan

```
Context: I run [business type] serving [customer type] in [market]. Here are the questions our sales
and service teams hear most, with the journey stage for each: [paste your buyer questions from Chapter
5].

Role: Act as a video marketing strategist for small and mid-size businesses.

Ask: Turn these questions into a plan for 10 short videos. For each video, give the working title, the
journey stage, the video type (FAQ, how-to, demo, testimonial and so on), the ideal length, where it
will be used (website page, YouTube, social, email, paid media) and the call to action.

Format: A table, ordered by which video to make first and why.

Tighten: Favor videos we can shoot ourselves with a phone. Flag any video that needs professional
production. Don't invent facts about our business; put [brackets] where you need details from me.
```

Our first five videos (title, stage, type, call to action): _____

Producing Video

Good video starts on paper. A plan saves you from shooting the same scene three times, and it gives everyone, from your team to an outside crew, the same picture of the finished video.

Start with a storyboard

A storyboard is a simple sketch of your video, shot by shot.

1. **Outline the story.** Name the main message, who or what is on screen, and how you want viewers to feel when it ends.
2. **Break it into scenes.** Decide the order and how you'll move from one scene to the next. Mix wide shots, close-ups, b-roll and different angles to keep it interesting.
3. **Sketch each frame.** You don't need to be an artist; stick figures will do. Add notes on what's said, camera moves, music and on-screen text.
4. **Check the pacing.** Make sure the visuals keep up with the story and land the call to action at the end.

If you're making a video for a client or another department, build the storyboard with them. Their input up front saves you from reshooting a video that misses the mark.

↓ Video storyboard template

Build a b-roll library

B-roll is the footage that plays under someone talking: hands at work, the shop floor, a finished project, the team in action. It keeps a talking-head video moving, and you can reuse it in dozens of future videos. Make a shot list before every shoot and capture extra b-roll while the camera is out. You can also license stock footage, just like stock photos.

Find the right people for the camera

You can have the best equipment in the world, but if the person on screen isn't comfortable, viewers notice. Most businesses already have good presenters on the team; they just haven't been asked. Try a few people on short, low-stakes videos first. The owner is often the best choice for a small business, because buyers want to know who they'll be working with.

Use music with care

Music sets the mood and fills the gaps between talking points. Much of it is copyrighted, so use royalty-free or licensed music and check the terms before you publish. AI music tools are an option too; read their license terms, and remember that YouTube asks for a disclosure when AI-generated music is the main focus of a video.

Where AI helps in production

STEP	WHERE AI HELPS	WHAT STAYS WITH PEOPLE
Planning	Turning notes into a script, outlining a storyboard, writing a shot list	The message, the story and what you promise
Shooting	Teleprompter scripts, checklists for gear and shots	Being on camera; real projects, real customers, real places
Editing	Removing filler words and pauses, cleaning up audio, suggesting cuts	Final cut and approval
Versions	Cutting short clips from a long video, resizing for each platform, translating	Choosing which clips go where
Accessibility	Captions and transcripts	Checking names, numbers and technical terms

In-house, outsource or both?

If you'll make video every month, build the skill in-house. A phone, a microphone, a light and simple editing software will cover most how-to, FAQ and social videos, and AI tools have made editing much faster. If you only need a few high-stakes videos, such as a brand video for your home page, outsourcing may cost less. Many businesses do both: a professional crew for the flagship video, the team for everything else. If you hire a crew, watch how they set up shots and light a room. It's a free lesson.

AI TIP

Write a script and storyboard from your notes

```
Context: We're making a [length]-second [video type] for [audience] at the [journey stage] stage. The one message is: [message]. Here are my notes and the facts to include: [paste notes]. The call to action is: [call to action].

Role: Act as a video producer who writes for small business owners, not actors.

Ask: Write a script in plain, spoken language, then a storyboard with one row per shot.

Format: Script first. Then a table with shot number, what's on screen, what's said, b-roll or on-screen text, and approximate seconds.

Tighten: Open with a hook in the first five seconds. Keep it within [length] seconds. Use only the facts I gave you; put [brackets] where you need more.
```

AI TIP

Turn one long video into many

```
Context: Here is the transcript of our [length]-minute [video type], with timestamps: [paste transcript]. Our channels are [YouTube, Instagram, LinkedIn, Facebook, email, paid media].

Role: Act as a social video editor.

Ask: Find the 5 strongest moments that can stand on their own as short clips.

Format: A table with start and end timestamps, a hook line for the first three seconds, the on-screen caption, the best channel, and a call to action for each clip.

Tighten: Each clip under 60 seconds. Quote the transcript exactly; don't change what anyone said.
```

PRO TIP

Shoot for many uses. Every time the camera comes out, ask what else you can capture: b-roll, a 30-second answer to a common question, a quick customer comment. One well-planned shoot can fill a month of content.

GETTING VIDEO FOUND

Getting Video Found

A great video nobody finds is a wasted video. Plan where each one will live and how buyers, search engines and AI tools will find it before you shoot.

Label every video the way you'd label a page

Most search engines and AI tools still find a video through the words around it. Some, like Google's Gemini, can now analyze a video's pictures and sound too (Google AI for Developers). Either way, clear words do most of the work. Give them plenty:

- **Title.** Say what the video answers, in the words your buyers use: "How long does it take to build a custom pool in Austin?" beats "Our Process."
- **Description.** Open with the answer in two or three sentences. Then add a short summary of what the video covers, the chapter list and a link to the matching page on your site. Don't stop at a line or two: in a 2026 study of YouTube videos cited by AI tools, description length was the metadata most closely linked to being cited (OtterlyAI, 2026). That's a correlation, not proof, but a fuller description costs nothing.
- **Chapters.** Break longer videos into labeled sections with timestamps, and write each label the way a buyer would ask the question. Viewers jump to what they need, and Google can link searchers straight to that moment (Google Search Central). Google's AI answers use chapters too: in the same study, every AI citation that pointed to a specific moment in a video came from Google AI Overviews or AI Mode (OtterlyAI, 2026).

- **Captions and transcript.** Upload accurate captions, and publish the transcript on the page with the video. Some people watch with the sound off, and the transcript gives search engines and AI tools the full text of what you said. Check AI-generated captions for names, numbers and technical terms.
- **Thumbnail and testing.** A clear, real image of the subject, with a few words of text at most, at least 1280 × 720. On YouTube, Test & Compare lets you test up to three titles and thumbnails on the same video. YouTube picks the winner by watch time, not clicks, so the winner is the version that brings the right viewers (YouTube Help).

Give each important video its own page

Google indexes a video when it's the main content of a page, with its own title and description, on a page that's already indexed (Google Search Central). So for your most important videos, such as a service explainer or a key FAQ, build a page around the video: the video at the top, a short summary, the transcript, and a clear next step. Add VideoObject structured data so search engines can read the details, and Clip markup if you want to label the key moments yourself (Google Search Central). Your developer or your website platform can handle that (Chapter 6).

YouTube, your site, or both?

For most businesses, the answer is both. Upload to YouTube for reach: it's where people search for video, and it's the site Google's AI Overviews cite most (Ahrefs, September 2026). Then embed the YouTube video on the matching page of your own site, where the buyer can take the next step. Link from the YouTube description back to that page.

If you want no ads and more control over the viewer's experience, paid platforms such as Vimeo and Wistia host video on your site with detailed viewing data. Whichever you choose, make sure the video doesn't slow your page down. Load it only when the viewer presses play.

Make videos AI tools want to cite

AI answers cite YouTube more than almost any other site (Ahrefs, September 2026). The videos they cite follow a pattern. In OtterlyAI's study of more than 100 million AI citations, 94% of the YouTube videos cited were long-form. Shorts were under 6%. Views, likes and subscriber counts made almost no difference (OtterlyAI, 2026). A small business with 200 subscribers can be cited if its video answers the question best.

- **Make reference videos.** A clear answer to one buyer question, usually 5 to 20 minutes, with chapters. That's the format AI tools cite most.
- **Use Shorts for reach, not citations.** Cut Shorts from the long video and point viewers back to it.
- **Keep important videos current.** Update or replace a video when prices, services or facts change. In the same study, newer videos had a modest edge.
- **Check what AI says.** Ask AI assistants your buyers' questions and note whether your videos show up. Chapter 6 covers how to track this.

Search doesn't stop at Google

Buyers search inside social apps too. Since July 2025, public photos, videos and Reels from Instagram business and creator accounts can appear in Google search results (PPC Land, 2025). And 49% of U.S. consumers say they've used TikTok as a search engine (Adobe Express survey, reported by Search Engine Journal, 2026).

Treat a social video like a small web page:

- **Say the words buyers search for,** out loud and in on-screen text, in the first few seconds.
- **Write a caption that answers the question,** not just a list of hashtags.
- **Check your Instagram settings.** Use a professional account, and make sure "Allow public photos and videos to appear in search engine results" is on (Settings, Privacy).

Reach buyers in other languages

If you serve customers who speak another language, YouTube can now dub your videos for you. Auto-dubbing opened to all creators in February 2026, covering 27 languages. In December 2025, about six million viewers a day watched at least 10 minutes of auto-dubbed video (The Daily Ittefaq, 2026). Treat AI dubs like AI captions: have a fluent speaker check the first few, especially names, prices and anything that could mislead a buyer.

Distribute every video more than once

Publishing is the halfway point. Plan how each video will reach people:

- **Social media.** Post short clips natively on each platform, sized for that platform. Lead with the hook.
- **Email.** Use a thumbnail with a play button that links to the video page. Email is a strong place for testimonial and how-to videos.
- **Paid media.** Run video ads on YouTube, Meta, LinkedIn and connected TV to reach new buyers. Retarget people who watched most of a video with your next video or an offer.
- **Sales.** Give your sales team a library of short videos they can send after a call: the demo, the FAQ, the testimonial.

AI TIP

Write titles, descriptions and chapters for a video

```
Context: Here is the transcript of our video, with timestamps: [paste transcript]. The video answers this buyer question: [question]. The page on our site where it will live is [URL]. Our business is [business type] in [market].

Role: Act as a YouTube and video SEO specialist.

Ask: Write three title options, a description, chapter timestamps and a short summary for the web page.

Format: Titles under 70 characters, written in the buyer's words. A description that opens with a 2-to-3-sentence answer, then summarizes what the video covers, lists the chapters and ends with a link line. Chapters as timestamp and label, each label written the way a buyer would ask. A web summary of about 100 words.

Tighten: Use only what's said in the transcript. No clickbait, no claims we can't back up, no keyword stuffing.
```

PRO TIP

Answer one question per video. A video that clearly answers one specific question is easier to title, easier to find, easier for AI tools to cite and easier for your sales team to send. Save the "everything about us" video for your home page.

MEASURING VIDEO

Measuring Video

Views are the easiest number to find and the least useful on their own. Track the numbers that tell you whether a video did its job at its stage of the journey.

METRIC	WHAT IT TELLS YOU	WATCH IT FOR
Views and reach	How many people started the video. Each platform counts a "view" differently, and the rules change. Since March 2025, YouTube counts a Shorts view the moment it starts playing; the old count is now "engaged views." Meta's "Views" include repeat plays. Compare like with like, and don't mistake a counting change for a win.	Awareness videos and ads
Impressions and click-through rate	How often YouTube showed your thumbnail, and how often people clicked. Judge it alongside how long they watched. A falling click-through rate as impressions grow can simply mean YouTube is showing the video to new people.	YouTube titles and thumbnails
Play rate	The share of page visitors who pressed play. A low play rate means the video doesn't look relevant where it sits.	Videos on your website
Watch time and retention	How much of the video people watched, and where they stopped. A sharp drop early means the opening didn't hook them. YouTube's retention report shows how many are still watching at 30 seconds and compares each video with your recent videos of similar length.	Every video
Engagement	Shares, comments and saves, and whether the comments are positive or negative.	Social and YouTube videos

METRIC	WHAT IT TELLS YOU	WATCH IT FOR
Clicks and conversions	Who took the next step: a click, a form, a call, a purchase.	Consideration and Decision videos
Assisted conversions	Leads and sales where a video was one of the touchpoints along the way, even if it wasn't the last.	Your whole video library (Chapter 19, Measurement)
AI citations	Whether AI assistants cite or link to your video when someone asks your buyers' questions.	Reference, how-to and FAQ videos

Track video on your own site, too. YouTube Studio only sees what happens on YouTube. Google Analytics 4 can record when a visitor starts a YouTube video embedded on your site, passes 10, 25, 50 and 75 percent, and finishes it (Google Analytics Help). Ask your developer to make sure enhanced measurement is on and the embed allows it. Then you can see whether the people who watch go on to call or fill out a form.

Use what you learn. If viewers drop off at the 20-second mark, tighten the opening. If one FAQ video gets twice the watch time of the others, make more like it. Retarget people who watched most of a video; they've told you they're interested.

AI TIP

Find out what your video data is telling you

```
Context: Here is the performance data for our last [number] videos, exported from [YouTube Studio /
our video platform / our ad platform]: [paste or upload the data, with title, length, views (engaged
views for Shorts), impressions, click-through rate, average view duration, retention at 25/50/75%,
clicks and conversions].

Role: Act as a video marketing analyst.

Ask: Tell us which videos are working, which aren't and why. Look at length, topic, journey stage and
where viewers drop off.

Format: Three findings, each with the evidence behind it. Then three specific changes for our next
five videos.

Tighten: Base every finding on the data. If the data is too thin to support a conclusion, say so.
```

Example: a video plan for Wild West Custom Pools

Wild West Custom Pools sells a long, expensive journey: projects start at $90,000, and a build takes 12 to 16 weeks once excavation begins. Buyers need to trust the builder before they ever meet him. Wild West hasn't made any video yet, so this is a plan, not results. Here's the video plan we'd build from what we already know about the business and its buyers.

STAGE	VIDEO	WHY
Awareness	A one-minute time-lapse of a build, from excavation to first swim, cut into short clips for social media and YouTube ads	Shows the work, and the finished pool, in a way no photo can
Consideration	Two FAQ videos answering what buyers ask most in the first meeting: "How much is this going to cost?" and "When can we swim?"	Answers the two Decision questions (Chapter 5) before the first call, in Dan's own words
Decision	"Meet Dan": the owner, on site, explaining why the company builds only 12 pools a year	Puts a face on the promise that the owner is on site from excavation to first swim
Decision	A client walkthrough of a finished pool, filmed with the client's permission	Real proof from a real buyer, which no claim on a web page can match
Advocacy	A short "first swim" video the family can share	Turns a happy client into the start of the next buyer's journey

Each video would live on its matching page of the site (the FAQ videos on the pricing and process pages, "Meet Dan" on the About page) and on YouTube, with captions, chapters and a link back to the consultation form.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Wild West video strip: five rounded cards.

YOUR VIDEO STRATEGY

Your Video Strategy

A video strategy has ten elements. Check off each one as you decide it.

- ☐ **1. Set clear objectives.** What should video do for you: build awareness, drive traffic, generate leads, close sales or keep customers?
- ☐ **2. Define your audience.** Which personas (Chapter 2) and which journey stages (Chapter 5) will your videos serve?
- ☐ **3. Plan your content.** Which types of video, on which topics, in what order? Start with your buyers' most common questions.
- ☐ **4. Tell a story.** What's the message, and how will you make viewers feel something? Real people and real projects beat stock footage.
- ☐ **5. Match production to purpose.** Which videos need a professional crew, and which can your team shoot on a phone?

- ☐ **6. Use AI where it helps.** Where will AI speed up scripts, edits, captions and versions? Who approves the final cut?
- ☐ **7. Choose your channels.** Your website, YouTube, social media, email, paid media and sales. Tailor each video to the platform.
- ☐ **8. Optimize for search and AI.** Titles in your buyers' words, full descriptions, chapters, captions, transcripts and a page for each important video. Check whether AI tools cite them.
- ☐ **9. Ask for the next step.** One clear call to action in every video.
- ☐ **10. Measure and improve.** Track watch time, clicks and conversions, test titles and thumbnails, and make more of what works.

↓ Video strategy checklist and video plan

Video marketing questions

Answer these with your team. Then paste your answers into your AI assistant with the video plan AI TIP above.

What are the key messages we want our videos to convey? How will we use stories to connect with viewers?

Which topics and buyer questions will our videos cover, and how do they support our marketing goals?

Which formats will work best for our audience (how-to, FAQ, demo, testimonial, explainer, social clips), and how long should each be?

How will we use video at each stage of the customer journey? Who decides which videos we make for each stage?

What is our budget and timeline for video? Which videos will we make in-house, and which will we outsource?

Who on our team is good on camera? What equipment, software and AI tools do we need?

Where will we host and publish our videos: YouTube, our website, social media, email? How will we use paid media to promote them?

How will we optimize our videos for search engines and AI answers: titles, descriptions, chapters, captions and transcripts? Who will check AI-generated captions?

What are our rules for AI in video? What will we never fake, and when will we disclose AI-generated content?

What call to action will each video include?

Which metrics will we track (watch time, play rate, clicks, conversions), and how will we measure the return on our video investment?

AI TIP

Turn your answers into a 90-day video plan

```
Context: Here are our answers to the video marketing questions: [paste answers]. Our team is [team size and roles], and our monthly budget for video, including paid media, is [amount].

Role: Act as a marketing director planning video for a small business.

Ask: Build a 90-day video plan: which videos to make, in what order, who makes them, where each is published and promoted, and what we'll measure.

Format: A week-by-week table, followed by a short list of the tools and equipment we need.

Tighten: Start with videos we can make ourselves. Keep it realistic for our team size. Flag anything that needs outside help.
```

SOURCES

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PAID MEDIA

Is every click paying off?

In this chapter »

Buy attention when you need it. Then make every click count.

— **CHOOSING YOUR CHANNELS**
You don't need every channel

— **SEARCH ADS**
Reach people at the moment they ask

— **SOCIAL, VIDEO AND RETARGETING ADS**
Create demand, then follow up

— **MEASURING PAID MEDIA**
Look past what each platform says about itself

— **AN AD PLAYBOOK**
Wild West Custom Pools' plan, and your 90-day plan

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
8 AI Tips, including building a starting budget and finding the waste in your ad account

Paid Media and Promotion

SEO, content, social and video build over months. Paid media is the one discipline where you can buy attention today. You pay a platform to put your message in front of the people you choose, when you choose.

That speed is why so much money flows here. WPP Media forecasts global advertising will reach $1.3 trillion in 2026, and search alone, traditional and generative, will take about 21.8% of it (WPP Media, 2026). Most of the rest goes to social, video and retail platforms that sell ads the same way: by audience, by intent, by the click.

Speed cuts both ways. Ads send people to your site faster than anything else. If the page they land on is weak, you pay to show them that faster too.

Ads rent attention. Your pages must earn the sale.

PRO TIP

Don't run ads until the content is ready. The first edition called this the biggest mistake, and it still is: a business launches ads before it has a landing page that answers the buyer's questions, a clear offer and a way to track the inquiry. Build the page first (Chapters 6 and 9), test the form, then turn on the ads.

What AI changed

Three things changed since the first edition.

AI now does most of the buying. On Google, campaigns like Performance Max and AI Max decide which searches, placements and audiences to bid on based on your goals and your site. Meta is moving the same way. The Wall Street Journal reported in June 2025 that Meta plans to let brands create and target ads using only its AI tools by the end of 2026: the advertiser supplies a goal and a budget, and the system builds the campaign (MediaPost, 2025). Your job moves from pulling levers to giving the system the right goal, the right inputs and the right limits.

Ads now appear inside AI answers. Google shows text and shopping ads within AI Overviews. They come from existing Search, Shopping and Performance Max campaigns, and Google says they need broad match or AI Max to qualify. They're reported as top ads, and Google doesn't yet break them out separately (Google Ads Help, 2026). ChatGPT is now an ad channel too. OpenAI started testing ads for U.S. users on its free and Go plans in early 2026, and says ads don't influence ChatGPT's answers and conversations stay private from advertisers (OpenAI, 2026). In May 2026 it opened a self-serve Ads Manager in beta to U.S. businesses, added cost-per-click pricing and dropped the $50,000 minimum (Axios, 2026).

AI writes and tests the ads. Platforms now generate headlines, descriptions, image variations and video cuts from your site and brand assets. What used to take a designer a week takes minutes. The bottleneck is no longer making ads. It's knowing which message is right for which buyer, which is why your strategy (Chapter 2) and your customer journey (Chapter 5) matter more now, not less.

One caution: AI-run campaigns chase whatever you tell them to count. If you count every form fill as a win, the system will find you cheap form fills, including spam and poor-fit leads. Count the actions that matter (qualified calls, booked consultations, sales), set exclusions, and check the search terms and placements it chose. People approve the strategy and every ad that runs.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Three rounded cards: "AI buys the media," "Ads inside AI answers," "AI writes the ads." Below them, one card: "You set the goal, the inputs and the limits."

CHOOSING YOUR CHANNELS

Choosing Your Channels

You don't need every channel. You need the few where your buyers are, at the stage of the journey where you're losing them. Start with your customer journey map from Chapter 5. If buyers find you but don't compare you, spend on Consideration. If they compare you but don't call, fix the Decision stage first, and an ad may not be the answer.

CHANNEL	BEST FOR	JOURNEY STAGE	WHERE AI HELPS
Search ads (Google, Microsoft Bing)	Buyers already looking for what you sell	Consideration, Decision	Finds matching searches, writes ad variations, sets bids
Google Business Profile and local ads	Local services and stores	Decision	Drafts posts and review replies; matches ads to nearby searches
Social ads (Facebook, Instagram, LinkedIn, TikTok)	Reaching people before they search	Awareness, Consideration	Finds audiences, builds image and video variations
Video ads (YouTube, connected TV)	Showing the work, building trust	Awareness, Consideration	Cuts one video into many lengths and formats
Display and programmatic	Broad reach on sites and apps	Awareness	Chooses placements; needs close checking
Retargeting	Bringing back visitors who didn't act	Consideration, Decision	Builds audiences from site visits and video views
Ads in AI answers (Google AI Overviews, ChatGPT)	Showing up while buyers research	Awareness, Consideration	Matches your ad to the question. New: test small
Traditional (print, radio, direct mail, events)	Local reach and older audiences	Awareness	Drafts copy; QR codes and tracked URLs connect it to digital

Match the platform to the buyer, not to habit. LinkedIn reaches business buyers by job title and company. TikTok and Snapchat skew younger. Facebook and Instagram reach most adults and are strong for anything visual. Search catches people who already know they need you.

Don't drop traditional media just because it's hard to measure. Connect it instead. Put a QR code or a short, unique web address on every print ad, mailer and event sign, and send it to a page built for that audience. Now you can count it like any other channel. Traditional Media and Digital, Together, later in this chapter, shows how for each channel.

PRO TIP

Target the right audience before you spend a dollar. Every platform will happily show your ad to more people. More people isn't the goal. The right people are. Write down who your buyer is, where they live, what they search for and what they've already done on your site, then build every campaign from that list.

AI TIP

Choose your paid channels

```
Context: I run [type of business] in [location/market]. Our buyers are [describe them]. Our monthly ad budget is [amount]. Our customer journey map shows we're weakest at [Awareness/Consideration/Decision].

Role: Act as a paid media strategist who works with small businesses.

Ask: Recommend two or three paid channels to start with, and one to skip for now. For each, say which journey stage it serves and why it fits our buyers.

Format: A table with columns: channel, journey stage, share of budget, why it fits, what to test first. Then a short list of what must be ready before we launch.

Tighten: Stay within our budget. Don't recommend channels that need a large minimum spend. Flag anything you're unsure about instead of guessing.
```

Our top two or three paid channels, the journey stage each one serves, and the share of budget for each.

SEARCH ADS

Search Ads

Search ads reach people at the moment they ask for what you sell. That's why, for most small businesses, search is the first paid channel to try. Four pieces decide whether it works: targeting, the ad, the landing page and the measurement.

Targeting: keywords, and what's replacing them

You still start with keywords: the words buyers type when they're ready to act. Chapter 7 covers keyword research in depth. For ads, sort them into three lists:

- **Target keywords.** Searches that show buying intent: the service, the place, the problem. "Custom pool builder Austin" is a buyer. "How do pools work" usually isn't.
- **Negative keywords.** Searches you never want to pay for: "cheap," "DIY," "jobs," "repair" or whatever doesn't fit your offer. This list saves more money than any other setting.
- **Location and schedule.** Where and when your ads can run. A local business that serves four cities shouldn't pay for clicks from 400 miles away.

The platforms are moving past exact keywords. To qualify for ads inside AI Overviews, Google says you need broad match or AI Max, which read the meaning of a search rather than the exact words (Google Ads Help, 2026). That reaches more people. It also reaches more wrong people, so your negative keywords and your conversion goals matter more than ever. Check the search terms report every week for the first two months.

Writing ads that get the right click

The first edition's rules for effective ads still hold:

- **Headline.** Say what you do and who it's for. Include the words the buyer searched.
- **Description.** One benefit, one proof point, one call to action.
- **Consistency.** The ad, the landing page and the offer use the same words. A buyer who clicks "free consultation" should land on a page that offers a free consultation.
- **Test.** Run two or three versions and let results, not opinions, pick the winner.

One more rule for 2026: write ads that turn away the wrong buyer. If your price starts high, say so in the ad. Fewer people click, and the ones who do are the ones you want. A good click costs the same as a bad one.

The landing page does the selling

The ad's only job is to earn the click. The page must do the rest. Send each ad to the page that answers that search, not your home page. Use the optimized page checklist from Chapter 6, and make sure the page loads fast on a phone, repeats the ad's promise, shows proof, and has one clear next step. Chapter 14 covers conversion in depth.

Should you bid on your own name?

It's one of the oldest questions in paid search, and the research doesn't agree.

In a large field experiment, eBay turned off its brand search ads and found that organic results recovered nearly all of that traffic, about 99.5%. The researchers concluded that for a well-known brand, paying for its own name added almost nothing to short-term sales (Blake, Nosko and Tadelis, 2015). Google's own study of 390 ad pause tests found a different picture. When an advertiser already ranked first organically, about half of the ad clicks were lost, not replaced, when the ads stopped. When the advertiser ranked lower or had no organic result, nearly all of the ad clicks were lost (Chan et al., 2012).

Both studies are more than ten years old, and both have critics. What they agree on is the question to ask: if you turned this ad off, how many of these buyers would still find you?

The honest answer depends on your business. Bidding on your name usually makes sense when competitors bid on it, when you don't rank first for it, or when you have a new offer to promote. It may not when you're a well-known name with the top organic spot and no competitors on your terms. Don't guess. Pause your brand ads for two to four weeks, watch total inquiries from search (paid plus organic), and decide from your own numbers.

AI TIP

Write search ads that qualify buyers

```
Context: We are [business name], a [type of business] serving [locations]. Our position is [one sentence]. Our offer is [offer]. Our price starts at [price, if you publish it]. Our ideal buyer is [describe]. Buyers we don't want: [describe].

Role: Act as a Google Ads copywriter who writes for small, local businesses.

Ask: Write three responsive search ads, each with a different angle: one on our position, one on the buyer's frustration, one that qualifies by budget or fit.

Format: For each ad, give 5 headlines (30 characters max) and 2 descriptions (90 characters max), plus the landing page it should point to.

Tighten: Use only the facts I gave you. No superlatives we can't prove ("best," "#1"). Count characters and mark any line that runs over.
```

AI TIP

Build your keyword and negative keyword lists

```
Context: We sell [product/service] to [buyer] in [locations]. We don't offer [things you don't do]. Our search ads budget is [amount] a month.

Role: Act as a paid search specialist.

Ask: Build a starter list of target keywords grouped by theme, and a negative keyword list to block searches we shouldn't pay for.

Format: Two tables. Target keywords: keyword, theme, buying intent (high/medium/low). Negative keywords: keyword, reason to block.

Tighten: Favor high-intent, local searches. Don't invent search volumes. I'll check volumes in Google Keyword Planner myself.
```

Our first three ad groups: target keywords, negative keywords and the landing page for each.

Social, Video and Retargeting Ads

Search ads answer a question. Social and video ads interrupt. Nobody opened Instagram to find a pool builder, so the ad must earn a second look in a second or two.

Social and video ads

- **Lead with the picture.** Your best real photo or the first three seconds of your video does most of the work. Stock images look like ads, and people scroll past ads.
- **Your creative is now part of your targeting.** When the platform's AI chooses the audience, the image, the first line and the offer decide who stops. Make them speak to your buyer and no one else.
- **One message, one action.** Don't list every service. Pick the one thing this buyer needs to hear and the one step you want them to take.
- **Use the video you already have.** The b-roll, FAQ answers and project walk-throughs from Chapter 11 can be cut into 6-, 15- and 30-second ads.

Retargeting: bring them back

Most visitors leave without acting. Retargeting shows your ads to people who already visited your site, watched your video or engaged with your page. It's a good use of a small budget, because these people already know you.

- Match the message to what they saw. Someone who read your pricing page needs a different ad than someone who read a blog post.
- Cap how often they see it. Following people around for months stops being helpful and starts being creepy.
- Exclude people who already became customers or leads.
- Set a window that fits your sales cycle: weeks for a quick purchase, months for a considered one.

First-party data: the cookie story that didn't happen

The first edition warned of a "cookieless world." Google had promised to remove third-party cookies from Chrome. Then, in April 2025, it decided to keep them, and in October 2025 it shut down Privacy Sandbox, the technology meant to replace them (MarTech, 2025). Apple's Safari already blocks third-party cookies by default, and Mozilla's Firefox keeps each site's cookies walled off from the others (WebKit, 2020; Mozilla, 2022). Tracking is already patchy, and it won't get easier.

The advice doesn't change. Data you collect yourself, with permission, is still the most reliable thing you own. Platforms will keep changing the rules on everything else. Build these:

- **An email list and a CRM** that record who your customers and leads are and what they bought.
- **Clean conversion tracking** that tells the ad platforms which clicks became real leads and sales.
- **Consent management** that follows your local privacy laws and tells visitors plainly what you collect.
- **Customer lists** you can upload, through the platform's own tools, to build lookalike audiences and exclude existing customers.
- **Contextual targeting**: ads placed next to content about your topic, which needs no personal data at all.

- **Organic channels** (content, SEO, social, email, influencers and offline events) that keep working whatever happens to tracking.

Budget and testing

Start with what a customer is worth, not with what you can spare. Work backward:

> **Average sale value × close rate (leads to sales) = what one lead is worth.**

If a typical job is worth $[X] and you close one in [Y] leads, you know what you can afford to pay per lead and still make money. The companion workbook tab for this chapter does the math.

Then keep it simple:

- **Start with one channel** and give it 60 to 90 days. AI-run campaigns need time and data to learn, and small budgets learn slowly.
- **Change one thing at a time.** If you change the ad, the page and the budget in the same week, you won't know which one worked.
- **Put most of the budget on what's proven,** some on improving it and a little on new tests, like ads in AI answers.
- **Review weekly, decide monthly.** Weekly for wasted spend (bad search terms, broken pages). Monthly for bigger moves.

PRO TIP

Read the search terms, not just the dashboard. The dashboard tells you how much you spent. The search terms report tells you what you paid for. Fifteen minutes a week there, adding negative keywords, is the highest-return task in paid media.

AI ground rules for ads

The book's five AI ground rules apply to ads with extra force, because ads are public and they cost money with every click.

- **People approve everything public.** Review every AI-generated headline, image and video before it runs. Check platform settings that let the system apply its own recommendations or create new assets, and turn on review where you can.
- **Verify facts.** Prices, offers, guarantees, licenses, reviews and "#1" claims must be true and current. An ad that overpromises is a legal problem as well as a marketing one.
- **Protect data.** Don't paste customer lists into a chatbot. Upload them only through the ad platform's own secure tools.
- **Keep your voice.** AI-written ads drift toward the same generic phrases. Edit until it sounds like you.
- **Add what AI can't.** Your real photos, real projects, real customers and real people. That's what makes an ad believable.

AI TIP

Turn one idea into social ad variations

Context: We are **[business]** selling **[offer]** to **[buyer]**. Our position is **[one sentence]**. Our best proof is **[reviews, projects, results]**. The ad will run on **[Facebook/Instagram/LinkedIn/TikTok]** at the **[Awareness/Consideration]** stage.

Role: Act as a social media ad strategist and copywriter.

Ask: Write three ad concepts with different angles (the result, the buyer's frustration, the proof). For each, suggest the photo or video to use from what we have: **[list your real photos and videos]**.

Format: For each concept: primary text (125 characters for the first line, then the rest), headline, call to action button, image or video suggestion, and who it's for.

Tighten: Plain, direct language. No hype or claims we can't prove. Use only our real photos and video, never stock or AI images of work we didn't do.

AI TIP

Plan a retargeting sequence

Context: Our sales cycle is about **[length]**. Visitors usually look at **[key pages]** before they contact us. Our main objections are **[list]**.

Role: Act as a paid media specialist who builds retargeting for small businesses.

Ask: Design a retargeting sequence for visitors who didn't contact us, with a different message for each stage.

Format: A table: audience (who and which pages), time window, message, offer, frequency cap, and when to stop showing ads.

Tighten: Exclude existing customers and leads. Keep frequency respectful. Every message must answer a real objection from my list.

AI TIP

Build a starting budget

```
Context: Our average sale is worth [amount]. We close about [number] of every [number] qualified leads. We can spend [amount] a month on ads. Our channels are [list].

Role: Act as a paid media planner who is careful with small budgets.

Ask: Work out what we can afford to pay per lead and per sale, then split our budget across our channels for the first 90 days.

Format: Show the math step by step, then a table: channel, monthly budget, target cost per lead, what we're testing, and the result that tells us to keep or cut it.

Tighten: Use only my numbers. If something is missing, ask me instead of assuming.
```

Our monthly budget, what one lead is worth to us, and the most we'll pay per lead.

TRADITIONAL MEDIA AND DIGITAL, TOGETHER

Traditional Media and Digital, Together

Radio, TV, newspapers, magazines, billboards, direct mail and events still work. This book focuses on digital because that's where AI changes the work the most, and where a small budget can be measured dollar by dollar. But the best results usually come from using both. Traditional media builds reach and memory. Digital catches the interest it creates, and measures it.

Mike Huber started his career leading newspaper advertising teams and later built The Arizona Republic's online sales division, so he watched this shift from both sides.

The lines have blurred

Most "traditional" channels now have a digital side you can target and measure:

- **TV is now also streaming TV.** Streaming made up 48.5% of all U.S. TV viewing in June 2026, according to Nielsen's The Gauge (MediaPost). Connected TV ads can be bought by audience and zip code, like other digital ads.
- **Radio is now also streaming audio and podcasts.** Four in five U.S. adults have listened to or watched a podcast (Edison Research, 2026, via Tubefilter). Audio ads can now be targeted by audience, not just by station.
- **Newspapers and magazines sell digital too:** websites, e-editions, newsletters and sponsored content, often bundled with print.

- **Many billboards are now digital screens,** bought by location and time of day.
- **Direct mail can follow digital behavior,** such as a postcard to someone who asked for a quote but didn't book.
- **Events feed your CRM** when you capture leads with a form or a badge scan instead of a fishbowl of business cards.

How to connect each channel

CHANNEL	CONNECT IT TO DIGITAL	MEASURE IT
Radio and audio	A short, easy-to-say web address and a dedicated phone number. Run search ads on your brand name and the words you say on air.	Calls to the tracked number, visits to the web address, and brand searches during the run compared with before
TV and streaming TV	Use the same message and look as your social video ads. Send viewers to one simple next step.	Site visits and brand searches in the areas where it ran, compared with areas where it didn't
Newspapers and magazines	A QR code or short web address that goes to a page built for that reader, plus the publication's digital package	QR scans, page visits and offer codes
Billboards and outdoor	One brand name or web address people can remember at highway speed. Keep your Google Business Profile current.	Brand searches, calls and direction requests in that area during the run
Direct mail	A QR code to a page that matches the mailer. Mail people who took a step online, such as asking for a quote.	Response by list and offer code. Compare the mailing list with new customers (a matchback).
Events and sponsorships	Capture leads with a form or badge scan straight into your CRM. Follow up within two business days.	Leads, sales and cost per lead from the event list

Five rules for making both work

1. **One message everywhere.** The radio spot, the billboard, the search ad and the landing page should say the same thing, the same way.
2. **One easy next step.** A short web address, one phone number, one QR code. Not three options.
3. **Be ready before it runs.** Build the landing page, update your Google Business Profile and set up call tracking before the first ad appears.
4. **Expect more searches, and show up for them.** Offline ads send people to Google and AI assistants. In a 2024 Harris Poll for the Out of Home Advertising Association of America, 76% of adults said a recent digital billboard ad had prompted them to act. Among mobile users who acted on their phones, 44% searched online for the advertiser (OAAA, 2024). The survey was funded by the industry, so treat it as a direction, not a guarantee. Make sure you rank, and appear in AI answers, for your own name (Chapters 6 and 8).

5 **Measure with a comparison.** Run it in some areas or zip codes and not others, then compare calls, searches and sales. Larger advertisers can add marketing mix modeling (Chapter 19).

Budgeting for traditional media

- **Get the digital basics right first.** Traditional media sends people to your website, your Google Business Profile and your brand search results. If those are weak, you pay to send people to a dead end.
- **Test one channel at a time, long enough to judge it.** Traditional media works on repetition. A single week of radio or one mailer rarely tells you anything. Plan a run long enough for people to see or hear you several times.
- **Budget for tracking up front.** Call-tracking numbers, short web addresses and landing pages cost little next to the media itself.
- **Ask for audience data, not just a rate card.** Ask who listens, reads or drives by, and ask what digital extras (streams, websites, newsletters) come with the buy.
- **Compare cost per lead across every channel** in your scorecard, traditional and digital side by side.

PRO TIP

Ask every new customer "How did you hear about us?" and record the answer in your CRM. It's the cheapest measurement tool there is, and it catches what tracking misses, such as the customer who heard your radio spot and then searched your name.

PRO TIP

Before you print a web address on anything, say it out loud to someone and ask them to type it. If they can't, shorten it.

Example: connecting a home show to digital

This is an example plan, not a campaign Wild West Custom Pools has run. It shows how the pieces fit for a business that sells big, considered purchases.

- **Before the show:** update the Google Business Profile, build a show-only page with a design consultation request form, and email past inquiries an invitation.
- **At the booth:** show photos of finished pools, lead with the "We only build 12 pools a year" message, and capture every lead on a tablet form or a QR code to the show page.
- **After the show:** follow up within two business days, add show leads to a nurture sequence (Chapter 16), and show retargeting ads to people who visited the show page.
- **Measure:** leads, consultations and sales from the show list, and cost per qualified lead compared with Google Ads.

AI TIP

Connect a traditional campaign to digital

```
Context: We're running [radio / TV / print / billboard / direct mail / event] in [area] from [dates],
with a budget of [amount]. Our offer and message: [paste]. Our website and Google Business Profile:
[links]. Our current digital channels: [list].

Role: Act as a media planner who connects traditional and digital media for small businesses.

Ask: Build a plan that connects this campaign to digital and measures it.

Format: (1) The one next step we should ask people to take, with a short web address and call-tracking
setup. (2) Matching search, social and landing-page copy. (3) What to have ready before launch. (4)
How to measure it, including a comparison area if possible. (5) The questions to ask the media sales
rep.

Tighten: Keep the message identical across channels. Flag anything we can't measure, and suggest the
simplest way to estimate it.
```

Which traditional channels do we use, or are we considering, and what job do we want each one to do?

For each one, what's the single next step we'll ask people to take, and how will we track it?

MEASURING PAID MEDIA

Measuring Paid Media

Every platform reports its own results, and every platform gives itself credit. Google, Meta and the rest will each count the same sale if the buyer touched both. Your job is to measure from your side: how many real leads and sales came in, and what they cost.

MEASURE	WHAT IT TELLS YOU	WATCH FOR
Cost per click	What attention costs	Rising costs with no rise in leads
Click-through rate	Whether the ad speaks to the searcher	Low rates on your most important keywords

MEASURE	WHAT IT TELLS YOU	WATCH FOR
Conversion rate	Whether the page does its job	Clicks that don't turn into inquiries
Cost per lead	What a real inquiry costs	Leads that look cheap but don't qualify
Cost per sale and return on ad spend	Whether ads make money	The number that decides the budget
Lead quality	Whether sales wants these leads	Ask sales every month, in writing

Three habits make the numbers trustworthy:

- **Track every lead to its source.** Use tagged links (UTM parameters), call tracking and a "How did you hear about us?" question on every form and every call.
- **Send real outcomes back to the platforms.** If you mark which leads became sales in your CRM and share that with Google and Meta, their AI learns to find more buyers like those, not just more clicks.
- **Ask where the lead came from, and believe the answer.** Buyers rarely follow one path. Wild West's latest lead checked Dan's Better Business Bureau profile first, then looked at the new site (see Chapter 4). No ad platform would have reported that.

Chapter 19 covers measurement and attribution across all ten disciplines.

AI TIP

Find the waste in your ad account

```
Context: Attached is our [platform] search terms report and campaign report for the last [30/60/90]
days. We sell [offer] to [buyer] in [locations]. Our target cost per lead is [amount].

Role: Act as a paid media analyst auditing a small business ad account.

Ask: Find wasted spend and missed opportunities.

Format: Three lists: (1) search terms to add as negatives, with the cost of each; (2) keywords or ads
to pause, with the reason; (3) the three changes most likely to lower our cost per lead, in priority
order.

Tighten: Base every finding on the data in the report. Don't recommend raising the budget unless the
numbers support it. Remove customer names or personal data before you share the report.
```

WHO DOES THE WORK

Who Does the Work: Paid Media Resource Checklist

Paid media needs a strategist, someone to run the campaigns and someone to measure them. In a small business, that may be one person and an agency. In a larger team, it's three people. Check what you have.

In = in-house · **Out** = outsourced: agency, freelancer or partner · **Gap** = no one covers it yet

ROLE	WHAT THEY DO	WHERE AI HELPS	IN	OUT	GAP
Paid media strategist	Sets goals, budget and channel mix; ties ads to the customer journey and sales	Drafts plans, models budgets, summarizes competitors' ads	☐	☐	☐
Paid media specialist (search, social, video)	Builds and runs campaigns, keywords, audiences and ads; tests and optimizes weekly	Writes ad variations, builds keyword lists, flags waste	☐	☐	☐
Creative (design, video, copy)	Makes the images, video and words that stop the scroll	Cuts and resizes assets, drafts copy; people approve	☐	☐	☐
Analytics specialist	Sets up tracking, connects ads to leads and sales, reports results	Spots trends, drafts reports, checks tracking setups	☐	☐	☐

Our biggest paid media gap and how we'll fill it (hire, train, outsource or use AI with review).

↓ Paid media resource checklist

EXAMPLE

Example: Wild West Custom Pools' Ad Playbook

In Chapter 4, Claude helped Wild West Custom Pools build a new position: a boutique builder that only takes 12 pools a year, with the owner on-site from excavation to first swim. The last step in that project was an advertising playbook for a budget of $500 to $1,000 a month.

CHANNEL	MONTHLY BUDGET	PRIORITY
Google Business Profile	Free	Do first
Google Search ads	$350–$650	Main paid channel
Facebook and Instagram	$150–$350	Second
Nextdoor	$0 for now	Later, once finished pools are visible in neighborhoods

The three search ads each take a different angle, and all three come from the same position:

- **Position:** "Austin's Boutique Pool Builder / Only 12 Pools Per Year, By Choice"
- **Frustration:** "Tired of Pool Builders Who Disappear? / Call the Owner Directly. Always."
- **Budget qualifier:** "Custom Pools From $90K — Austin TX / Luxury Builds. Personal Service."

The third ad is the one to study. It publishes the starting price in the ad itself, so buyers who can't spend $90,000 don't click, and Dan doesn't pay for them. The negative keyword list does the same job from the other side, blocking searches like "above ground," "cheap," "DIY," "pool repair" and "jobs." A retargeting ad follows site visitors who didn't inquire: "Still thinking about a pool? We only take 12 projects a year."

Notice what the playbook doesn't do. It doesn't spread a small budget across six channels. It puts most of the money where buyers are already searching, and it waits on Nextdoor until there's something real to show the neighbors.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Wild West ad playbook on one page: four channel cards (Google Business Profile, Search, Facebook and Instagram, Nextdoor) sized by budget, with the "Custom Pools From $90K" ad shown as it appears on a phone.

YOUR PAID MEDIA PLAN

Your Paid Media Plan

Answer these questions with your team. Then use the AI TIP at the end to turn your answers into a 90-day plan.

What is the one business goal our paid media must serve this year (leads, sales, bookings, awareness)?

Which stage of our customer journey is weakest, and can ads fix it, or does the page or offer need fixing first?

Who exactly are we targeting: who they are, where they are, what they search for and what they've already done on our site?

Which two or three channels will we start with, and why those?

What is our monthly budget, what is one lead worth to us, and what is the most we'll pay per lead?

What are our target keywords and our negative keywords?

Which landing page will each campaign send people to, and does it pass the optimized page checklist?

What will our first ads say, and which angles will we test against each other?

How will we bring back visitors who didn't act (retargeting audiences, messages, time window)?

What first-party data do we collect today (email list, CRM, customer lists), and what will we add?

How will we track every lead and sale back to its source, and who reports results each month?

Who approves AI-generated ads before they run, and which platform settings will we review?

AI TIP

Turn your answers into a 90-day paid media plan

```
Context: Here are our answers to the paid media questions: [paste answers]. Our customer journey map
and strategy on a page are attached.

Role: Act as a paid media strategist building a first-quarter plan for a small team.

Ask: Turn our answers into a 90-day paid media plan.

Format: (1) A one-paragraph summary of the plan. (2) A launch checklist of what must be ready first.
(3) A week-by-week table for the first month, then month-by-month: channel, task, owner, budget, and
the metric we'll check. (4) The three results that tell us at day 90 whether to scale, fix or stop.

Tighten: Stay within our budget and our team's time. Use only our numbers. Mark any assumption you
make so we can check it.
```

Paid media plan template

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SOCIAL

Does your content get seen?

In this chapter »

Publishing is half the job. Distribution is the other half.

— **CHOOSING YOUR PLATFORMS**
You don't need to be everywhere

— **YOUR DISTRIBUTION PLAN**
Start with one strong piece, not a posting calendar

— **ENGAGEMENT AND YOUR CUSTOMERS' VOICES**
Influencers, partners, reviews and user content

— **SOCIAL MEDIA ASSESSMENT**
Score where you stand today

— **MEASURING DISTRIBUTION**
What to track beyond followers, plus a worked example

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
6 AI Tips, including turning one piece of content into a week of distribution

Social Media and Distribution

You can write the best guide in your industry, post it on your website and hear nothing. Most buyers will never visit your site on their own. You must take the content to where they already spend their time.

That's distribution: putting your content, your expertise and your reputation in front of buyers on platforms you don't own. Social media is the biggest part of it. So are online communities, email, partners and the review and directory sites people check before they call.

Publishing is half the job. Distribution is the other half.

The audience is there. In Pew Research Center's 2025 survey, 84% of U.S. adults said they use YouTube and 71% use Facebook. Half use Instagram, 37% use TikTok and about a quarter use Reddit (Pew Research Center, 2025). Your buyers are on at least one of these platforms. The question is which ones, and what they want from you there.

Social media still does the three jobs the first edition named:

- **Reach.** It puts your content in front of far more people than your website can reach alone, and every share extends it.
- **Engagement.** It lets you talk with buyers directly: answer questions, respond to comments and hear what they care about.
- **Targeting.** It lets you aim paid posts at very specific audiences (Chapter 12 covers paid social).

What AI changed

AI answers now draw on social and community platforms. Peec AI analyzed 30 million sources cited by ChatGPT, Google AI Mode, Gemini, Perplexity and AI Overviews. Reddit was the most-cited domain, followed by YouTube and LinkedIn (Peec AI, 2026, via Search Engine Land). When someone asks an AI assistant about your category, the answer may come from a Reddit thread, a YouTube video or a LinkedIn post, not from your website. Being present and helpful on those platforms is now part of being found.

AI makes repurposing fast. One article, video or webinar can become a dozen posts, clips, captions and emails in minutes. Making content is no longer the bottleneck. Making it good, and making it sound like you, is.

Feeds are run by AI, too. Platforms decide who sees each post based on how people respond to it, not just on who follows you. A post that gets people to stop, comment and share travels. A post that doesn't, won't, no matter how many followers you have.

One caution: It's easy to flood every channel with AI-generated posts. Don't. Buyers can tell, platforms reward real engagement, and generic content teaches people to scroll past your name. Use AI to adapt your best ideas, not to manufacture filler.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

A hub-and-spoke drawing: one piece of content in the center.

CHOOSING YOUR PLATFORMS

Choosing Your Platforms

You don't need to be everywhere. Two platforms done well beat six done badly. Pick the ones where your buyers already are, where your content fits the format and where you can show up consistently.

PLATFORM	WHO'S THERE	BEST FOR	WATCH FOR
YouTube	84% of U.S. adults	How-to, FAQ and project videos that keep getting found in search and AI answers	Needs steady video production (Chapter 11)
Facebook	71% of U.S. adults	Local businesses, groups, events and reaching adults of every age	Low organic reach for business pages; plan some paid support
Instagram	50% of U.S. adults	Anything visual: products, projects, before-and-afters, short video	Needs strong real photos and video; stock images fall flat
TikTok	37% of U.S. adults; 47% of 18- to 29-year-olds use it daily	Short, personal video and reaching younger buyers	Fast-moving trends; U.S. ownership changed in January 2026
LinkedIn	Business professionals	B2B: thought leadership, hiring, reaching decision-makers by title	Works best from people's profiles, not just the company page
Reddit	26% of U.S. adults	Honest answers in communities about your topic; heavily cited by AI	Self-promotion is unwelcome; help first, and follow each community's rules
X and Threads	X: 21% of U.S. adults. Threads: 8%	Real-time news, industry conversation, customer service	Fragmented audiences; test before you commit
Nextdoor	Neighbors in the same area	Local services, recommendations and word of mouth	Only useful once you have local customers and work to show

Sources: Pew Research Center (2025) for usage shares; Axios (2026) on TikTok's U.S. joint venture.

PRO TIP

Match the platform to the buyer, then to your content. A B2B software firm and a pool builder can both use video, but one belongs on LinkedIn and the other on Instagram and YouTube. Start with where your buyers are, then ask what format you can produce well, every week.

How to judge a new platform

The first edition covered the launch of Threads in July 2023, when Meta's new app signed up 100 million people in its first five days. It was the most exciting social launch in years, and many businesses rushed to join. By 2025, 8% of U.S. adults used it (Pew Research Center, 2025). It's a real platform, but it didn't replace the others.

The first edition's advice still holds. Before you add a new platform, ask:

- **Are our buyers actually there,** in numbers that matter to us?
- **Do we have the resources** to post regularly and respond quickly? The worst outcome is stretching your team thin and performing badly in a new channel.
- **Does it fit our strategy?** Will it build relationships with the buyers we want, or just give us one more thing to post to?

If the answer to all three is yes, test it for 90 days with a clear goal. If not, watch it and wait. There will always be another new platform.

AI TIP

Audit your platforms

```
Context: We are [business] selling [offer] to [buyer]. We're active on [platforms], posting about
[frequency]. Our goals for social media are [goals]. Attached are our last 90 days of platform
analytics: [paste or attach].

Role: Act as a social media strategist who works with small teams.

Ask: Tell us which platforms to keep, which to drop and which one, if any, to test next.

Format: A table: platform, keep/drop/test, why (with the numbers), and the one change that would
improve results most. Then a one-paragraph recommendation.

Tighten: Base it on our data and our buyers, not on general trends. If the data is too thin to judge,
say so.
```

Our two or three priority platforms, why our buyers are there and how often we can post well on each.

Build Your Distribution Plan

The best distribution plans start with one strong piece of content, not with a posting calendar. In Chapter 10 you built a hub: one in-depth piece with spokes around it. Distribution is how the hub and its spokes reach people.

One piece, many formats

Take one hub piece, such as a guide, a webinar or a project video, and plan everything it can become before you publish it:

FROM ONE PIECE	BECOMES
A 2,000-word guide	5 to 10 social posts, each with one idea; a LinkedIn article; an email to your list; answers to related questions in online communities
A 20-minute webinar or interview	6 to 10 short video clips; quote graphics; a blog post from the transcript; an FAQ page
A finished project	Before-and-after photos; a short walk-through video; a case study; a review request to the customer
A customer question	A short video answer; an FAQ entry; a social post; a reply on Reddit or in a local group

Adapt each piece to the platform. A LinkedIn post, an Instagram Reel and an email don't look or sound the same, even when they share the same idea.

Beyond your social accounts

Social media is only part of distribution. Plan for these too:

- **Email.** Your list is the one audience no algorithm controls (Chapter 10). Send your best content there first.
- **Communities.** Industry forums, Facebook and LinkedIn groups, Reddit and local groups. Answer questions well and people will find you.
- **Partners.** Suppliers, associations, complementary businesses and local media that will share your content with their audiences.
- **People.** Your team's own profiles can reach people your company page never will. Make it easy for them to share, and never force it.
- **Profiles and listings.** Google Business Profile, review sites, industry directories and the Better Business Bureau. Buyers check them before they call, and AI answers draw on them.

PRO TIP

Consistency is key. A steady presence builds recognition and keeps you top of mind. Post on a regular schedule you can keep up, with the same voice and look on every platform. Three good posts a week, every week, beats fifteen posts in one week and silence for a month.

Schedule it

Set a simple weekly rhythm and put it on your editorial calendar (Chapter 9). Scheduling tools such as Buffer, Hootsuite, Sprout Social or the platforms' own schedulers let you plan posts in advance. Leave room in the week to respond to comments and join conversations, which scheduling can't do for you.

Don't chase "the best time to post" from a generic chart. Your own analytics show when your audience is active. Test two or three time slots for a month and keep the winner.

AI TIP

Turn one piece of content into a week of distribution

```
Context: Here is our [article/transcript/video summary]: [paste]. Our buyers are [describe]. We post
on [platforms]. Our voice is [describe, or paste two of our best posts as examples].

Role: Act as a social media editor who repurposes content without losing its value.

Ask: Turn this piece into a week of distribution across our platforms and our email list.

Format: A table: day, platform, format (post, carousel, short video, email), the one idea it covers, a
draft of the post, and the link it points to.

Tighten: Each post must stand on its own and give something useful, not just "read our new blog."
Match each platform's style and length. Keep our voice. Use only facts from the source.
```

AI TIP

Find the questions to answer in communities

```
Context: We are [business] and our buyers are [describe]. Our main topics are [topics].

Role: Act as a community marketing researcher.

Ask: List the online communities where our buyers ask questions about these topics, and the questions
they ask most often.

Format: Two tables. Communities: name, platform, size or activity level if known, rules on self-
promotion. Questions: the question, where it's asked, and which of our existing pages or videos
answers it.

Tighten: Only list communities you're confident exist; mark anything I should verify. I'll check each
one before we post.
```

Our hub piece for the next quarter, and the ten pieces of distribution it will become.

Engagement, Influencers and Your Customers' Voices

Posting is broadcasting. Engagement is the conversation that follows, and it's where trust is built.

PRO TIP

Generate genuine engagement. Respond to comments and messages promptly, thank people who share your work and join discussions in your industry with useful answers, not sales pitches. An authentic, responsive presence builds loyalty, spreads by word of mouth and makes you the trusted name in your niche.

Respond like a person

- **Answer every real question,** publicly when the answer helps others, privately when it involves personal details.
- **Handle complaints in the open, then move them offline.** Acknowledge the problem, offer to fix it and give a direct contact. Others are watching how you respond.
- **Have a plan for a bad day.** Decide in advance who responds to a crisis or a wave of negative comments, what they can say and who approves it.

Influencers and partners

An influencer is anyone whose audience trusts them: a creator with a large following, an industry expert, a local personality or a respected supplier. For most small businesses, small creators with a loyal local or niche audience are a better fit than big names.

- Look for people whose audience matches your buyers, whose values match yours and whose content you'd be proud to share.
- Start with a relationship, not a request. Share their work and comment thoughtfully before you ask for anything.
- Put paid partnerships in writing, and make sure they're disclosed. In the U.S., the Federal Trade Commission requires creators to disclose paid endorsements clearly.

User-generated content

Your customers' photos, videos and reviews are often more persuasive than anything you make. Ask customers to share, make it easy (a hashtag, a photo request, a review link) and always ask permission before you repost. When you ask for reviews, ask every customer, and never offer anything in exchange for a review. Google bans review incentives, the FTC's rule on consumer reviews bans incentives tied to positive reviews, and the FTC began enforcing that rule in December 2025 (see Chapter 8, Local SEO and Reviews).

AI ground rules for social media

- **People approve everything public.** Don't let any tool post or reply automatically on your behalf. Review every post and every response before it goes out.

- **Verify facts.** Check every claim, statistic and name in an AI-drafted post.
- **Protect data.** Don't paste customers' private messages or personal details into an AI tool.
- **Keep your voice.** Give AI examples of your best posts and edit everything until it sounds like you.
- **Add what AI can't.** Real photos, real projects, real people and real opinions. Platforms require labels on realistic AI-generated images and video. TikTok, for example, requires creators to label content that is fully generated or significantly edited by AI (TikTok, 2026). The simplest path is to use your real work.

AI TIP

Build a response guide for comments and messages

```
Context: We are [business]. Here are 10 real comments and messages we received recently, with personal details removed: [paste]. Our tone is [describe]. Topics we never discuss publicly: [pricing exceptions, legal matters, etc.].

Role: Act as a community manager writing a response guide for a small team.

Ask: Create a response guide our team can use for the most common comments, questions and complaints.

Format: A table: type of comment, example, how we respond (draft reply), respond publicly or privately, and when to escalate to [name/role].

Tighten: Plain, warm and brief. No promises we can't keep. Every reply must be reviewed and personalized by a person before it's sent.
```

AI TIP

Find and approach the right partners

```
Context: We are [business] serving [buyers] in [location/niche]. Our values are [values]. We'd like to partner with [creators, experts, local businesses, associations].

Role: Act as a partnership and influencer marketing strategist for small businesses.

Ask: Describe the profile of partners who fit us, suggest where to find them and draft a first outreach message.

Format: (1) A partner profile checklist. (2) A list of places to look. (3) A short, personal outreach message with [brackets] for details. (4) Three questions to ask before we agree to work together.

Tighten: Don't name specific people or accounts unless you're sure they exist; I'll research them myself. Include the FTC disclosure requirement for any paid partnership.
```

Who responds to comments and messages, how fast, and who approves replies in a crisis.

Social Media Assessment

Score each statement from 1 to 5. Then add up your scores and divide by the number of statements to get your average. Be honest; this is for you.

1 Novice · **2** Beginner · **3** Intermediate · **4** Advanced · **5** Expert

#	STATEMENT	SCORE (1–5)
1	We have a clear social media strategy that supports our overall business goals.	
2	Our team consistently creates engaging, relevant content for our target audience.	
3	We actively monitor and respond to comments, messages and questions.	
4	We regularly review our social media metrics and use them to improve.	
5	We stay current with platform changes and adjust our approach.	
6	We have a defined process for planning, scheduling and publishing content.	
7	We work with other teams so our message is consistent on every channel.	
8	We have a plan for handling a crisis or a wave of negative comments.	
9	We work with influencers, partners or customers to extend our reach.	
10	We test different formats, topics and ads and keep what works.	
11	We use AI to repurpose and draft content, and a person reviews everything before it posts.	

Total score ÷ 11 = average score: ___

What your average means: 1.0–1.7 Novice · 1.8–2.5 Beginner · 2.6–3.3 Intermediate · 3.4–4.1 Advanced · 4.2–5.0 Expert. These are the same levels used in the Chapter 3 assessments. The companion workbook tab calculates your average and level automatically.

Our two lowest-scoring statements and what we'll do about each in the next 90 days.

MEASURING DISTRIBUTION

Measuring Distribution

Follower counts feel good and tell you little. Measure what shows buyers are paying attention and taking the next step.

MEASURE	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Reach and impressions	How many people saw your content
Engagement rate (comments, shares, saves ÷ reach)	Whether it was worth stopping for
Clicks to your site	Whether it moved people toward you
Leads and sales from social and communities	Whether it pays. Track with tagged links (UTM parameters) and "How did you hear about us?"
Mentions and reviews	What people say about you when you're not in the room
AI visibility	Whether AI assistants mention or cite you for your topics (use the AI visibility check from Chapter 1)

PRO TIP

Leverage data and analytics. Review what resonated every month: which topics, formats and platforms drove engagement and visits. Do more of what works, drop what doesn't and refine the rest.

EXAMPLE

Example: Wild West Custom Pools

In Chapter 4, Dan's latest lead didn't start on his website. The buyer looked over his Better Business Bureau profile first, then viewed the new site. No social post or ad platform would have reported that path. It's a reminder that distribution includes every place buyers check you, not just the accounts you post to.

Wild West's plan, from the advertising playbook in Chapter 12, follows the same thinking:

- **Profiles first.** The free Google Business Profile comes first. Dan's A+ BBB rating is already doing work, too, and it belongs on the site as a proof point.
- **Real photos, not stock.** Social posts and ads use photos of real Wild West pools and builds.
- **Fewer channels, done well.** Facebook and Instagram now. Nextdoor later, once finished pools are visible in neighborhoods and neighbors can see the work for themselves.
- **One piece, many uses.** Each finished project can become photos, a short video (Chapter 11), a post, a review request and a case study.

Today, Wild West shows up on Facebook, LinkedIn and its Better Business Bureau profile. Dan doesn't post on a fixed schedule. When a project is under way, he posts almost daily, so followers watch the build unfold. That's a natural rhythm for a builder: every project is a series with a beginning, a middle and a finished pool. The next step is to give those project posts a longer life. Collect them into a project story on the website, share the best photos on Instagram as the playbook plans, and keep something going between projects, such as design tips, finished-pool photos and answers to common questions, so the accounts don't go quiet.

YOUR DISTRIBUTION PLAN

Your Distribution Plan

Answer these questions with your team. Then use the AI TIP at the end to turn your answers into a 90-day distribution plan.

Which social platforms best match our buyers and our goals, and which will we stop using?

Which content formats (posts, short video, carousels, articles, live video) work best for our audience?

What is our hub piece for the next quarter, and what will it become on each platform?

How will we adapt content for each platform without losing its value or our voice?

Which communities, groups and forums do our buyers use, and what questions can we answer there?

Which partners, influencers or customers could help us reach new audiences, and how will we approach them?

How will we encourage and use customer photos, videos and reviews, with permission?

Which profiles and listings (Google Business Profile, review sites, directories, BBB) do buyers check, and are they complete and current?

How often will we post on each platform, and who owns the schedule?

Who responds to comments and messages, how quickly, and who handles a crisis?

What tools will we use to plan, schedule and repurpose content, including AI, and who reviews AI drafts?

Which metrics will we track each month, and how will we know distribution is working?

AI TIP

Turn your answers into a 90-day distribution plan

```
Context: Here are our answers to the distribution questions: [paste answers]. Our social media
assessment average was [score], and our two lowest areas were [list].

Role: Act as a social media and distribution strategist building a plan for a small team.

Ask: Turn our answers into a 90-day distribution plan.

Format: (1) A one-paragraph summary. (2) Our platforms, with posting frequency and owner for each. (3)
A weekly rhythm (create, repurpose, schedule, engage, review). (4) The first month's plan for our hub
piece, week by week. (5) The three metrics we'll review at day 90.

Tighten: Keep it realistic for our team's time. Fix our two lowest assessment areas first. Mark any
assumption so we can check it.
```

↓ Distribution plan template

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CONVERSION

Do visitors take the next step?

In this chapter »

Turn more of the visitors you already have into customers.

— **ANATOMY OF A LANDING PAGE**
What every page needs to turn a visit into an action

— **FIND WHAT'S BROKEN FIRST**
Most conversion problems are not subtle

— **A/B TESTING**
Test one change at a time, and read the result honestly

— **WHO DOES THE WORK**
The conversion resource checklist

— **MEASURING CONVERSION**
Track actions that matter, then build your plan

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
7 AI Tips, from reviewing a landing page like a buyer to planning your next test

Website and Conversion Optimization

Every chapter so far has been about getting the right people to your website. This one is about what happens when they get there.

Conversion rate optimization (CRO) is the work of turning more of those visitors into leads and customers. You study how people use your site, find where they get stuck or leave, fix it and measure the result. It's the discipline that makes every other one pay off, because it improves the return on traffic you already have.

Doubling your traffic is expensive. Doubling your conversion rate gets you the same result, and it's usually cheaper and faster.

The math is simple. Say 1,000 people visit your service page each month and 2% contact you. That's 20 inquiries. To get 40, you can find another 1,000 visitors, through more content, more SEO or more ad spend. Or you can get 4% of the visitors you already have to contact you.

How do you know if your rate is good? Unbounce studied more than 41,000 landing pages and 57 million conversions. The median conversion rate was 6.6%, ranging from 3.8% for software companies to 8.4% for financial services (Unbounce, 2024, via MarketingProfs). Treat that as a rough guide, not a target. Your best benchmark is your own rate last quarter.

One finding from the same study is worth remembering: pages written at a fifth- to seventh-grade reading level converted at a median of 11.1%, compared with 5.3% for pages written at a college level. Plain words sell.

What AI changed

Visitors from AI answers arrive better informed. By the time someone clicks through from ChatGPT or an AI Overview, they've often already compared options and asked follow-up questions. Ahrefs looked at its own site: in one 30-day period in 2025, AI search sent just 0.5% of its visitors but 12.1% of its sign-ups (Ahrefs, 2025). That's one company's data, and the numbers will shift as people get used to AI search, but the lesson holds. Visitors from AI search arrive ready to decide, so your page must answer the last few questions fast: price, proof and what happens next.

AI can watch the recordings for you. Free tools like Microsoft Clarity record how visitors scroll, click and leave, and now use AI to summarize patterns across hundreds of sessions. What took an analyst a week now takes minutes.

AI can draft the variations. New headlines, rewritten forms, simpler copy and alternative layouts can be drafted in minutes. That makes testing easier to start. It doesn't make the results any more reliable, because you still need real visitors to decide which version wins.

The free testing tool went away. Google Optimize, the free A/B testing tool many small businesses used, shut down in September 2023 (Search Engine Land, 2023). Testing now usually means a paid tool or one built into your website platform.

One caution: AI will happily tell you why a page isn't converting, and sound sure about it. It's guessing until real visitor data says otherwise. Use AI to generate ideas worth testing, not to decide what's true.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Two side-by-side paths to 40 inquiries. Same 40 inquiries at the bottom of each.

ANATOMY OF A LANDING PAGE

Anatomy of a Landing Page

A landing page is any page a visitor arrives on with a purpose: from an ad, a search result, an email or an AI answer. Your service pages, location pages and pricing page are all landing pages, whether you call them that or not.

The best ones follow the same pattern. The visitor should understand what you offer, why it's right for them and what to do next before they scroll.

Above the fold: required

- **Headline.** Strong and focused. Say what you do and who it's for, in the buyer's words.
- **Subhead.** One supporting line that adds the key benefit or proof.
- **Hero image or video.** A real photo of your work, your team or your product. It should show the result the buyer wants.
- **Call to action (CTA).** One clear, prominent button.
- **Value.** Your main benefits, in three short points: why they should choose you.
- **Trust.** Reviews, ratings, years in business, guarantees or badges.

Below the fold: supporting

- **More information.** Details that answer the next questions: how it works, what's included, the process.
- **Price or price range.** If you can publish it, do. It answers the Decision-stage question early (Chapter 5).
- **FAQ.** The questions buyers ask most, answered plainly. Good for buyers, search engines and AI answers.
- **Video.** An explainer, a walk-through or a customer story (Chapter 11).
- **Repeat CTA.** The same action again, for people who read everything first.
- **More trust.** A full testimonial, a case study or a short story about a real customer.
- **Secondary CTA.** A smaller next step for people who aren't ready yet: a guide, a checklist or a newsletter.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Anatomy of a landing page, redrawn from the first edition in the new style. A phone-shaped page outline with labeled callouts.

Buttons that say what happens next

The button label should tell visitors exactly what happens when they click it. "Submit" and "Click here" tell them nothing.

IF THE NEXT STEP IS...	THE BUTTON MIGHT SAY...
A newsletter sign-up	Sign up now
A free trial	Try it free
A guide or white paper	Download the guide
A purchase	Buy now
A discount	Claim your discount
A consultation or quote	Book your free consultation

PRO TIP

Make the call to action clear and prominent. Visitors should understand what you want them to do and how to do it within a few seconds. One page, one main action. Every extra choice is another reason to leave.

PRO TIP

Keep forms short. Ask only for what you need to take the next step. Every extra field is a reason to quit. You can learn the rest in the first conversation.

AI TIP

Review a landing page like a buyer

```
Context: Here is the text of our [service/product] landing page: [paste, or attach a screenshot]. Our ideal buyer is [describe]. They usually arrive from [search/ads/email/AI answers] and want to [goal]. The one action we want is [action].

Role: Act as a conversion copywriter and a skeptical buyer, in that order.

Ask: Review the page against the anatomy of a good landing page: headline, subhead, hero image, CTA, value, trust, price, FAQ and repeat CTA.

Format: A table: element, what we have now, what's missing or weak, and a suggested fix. Then the three questions a buyer would still have after reading the page.

Tighten: Be specific and blunt. Don't rewrite the whole page. Suggest only facts we can verify; mark anything we'd need to confirm.
```

Our most important landing page, its one main action, and the three elements it's missing.

FIND WHAT'S BROKEN FIRST

Find What's Broken First

Most conversion problems aren't subtle. Before you test headlines or button colors, find out where visitors actually leave and what stops them. Start with the basics.

Five checks before any test

1. **Does it work?** Fill out every form, click every button and call every phone number on your site, on a phone and on a computer. Confirm each inquiry actually arrives, and arrives at the right inbox.
2. **Is it fast?** Check your key pages with Google's free PageSpeed Insights. Speed matters more than most owners think. In a study Deloitte ran for Google, a 0.1-second improvement in mobile site speed raised retail conversions by 8.4% and travel conversions by 10.1% (Deloitte, 2020).
3. **Where do people leave?** In Google Analytics, look at your top landing pages and the path to your conversion. A page with lots of visits and few next steps is your first target.
4. **What do people do on the page?** Watch session recordings and heatmaps in a tool like Microsoft Clarity or Hotjar. Look for people scrolling past the button, clicking things that aren't links, or quitting halfway through a form.
5. **What do customers say?** Ask your last ten customers what almost stopped them from contacting you. Read your reviews and your competitors' reviews. Ask your sales team which questions come up in every first call.

Fix what you find before you start testing. A broken form or a slow page doesn't need an A/B test. It needs fixing.

PRO TIP

Continuously test and improve the whole experience, not just the words. Page speed, mobile layout, the form and the follow-up all count. Look at your mobile site right now, on your own phone, as a first-time visitor would.

Example: Wild West Custom Pools' contact form

When Wild West Custom Pools launched its new site (Chapter 4), the most important conversion fix had nothing to do with headlines. The contact form took about seven rounds of troubleshooting before every inquiry reliably reached Dan's inbox. After launch, a review found server log files with visitors' personal information that were publicly accessible; they were deleted. When spam started arriving, invisible spam protection was added.

None of that shows up in a conversion rate report. A form that loses one inquiry in five looks like a page that doesn't convert. For a business where one project starts at $90,000, a single lost inquiry could be worth more than a year of advertising.

The site also does the bigger conversion jobs well. It publishes price tiers, answers common questions in an FAQ, explains the consultation process and puts the owner's promise front and center (Chapter 5). Those choices filter out poor-fit leads and give serious buyers what they need to make the call.

AI TIP

Find where visitors drop off

```
Context: Attached is our Google Analytics data for the last [90] days: our top landing pages with sessions, engagement rate and conversions, and our conversion path from [page] to [thank-you page]. We sell [offer] to [buyer]. Our main conversion is [form/call/purchase].

Role: Act as a conversion rate analyst for a small business.

Ask: Find the three pages or steps where we lose the most potential customers, and explain what the data suggests is happening on each.

Format: A table: page or step, visitors, conversion or drop-off rate, likely cause, and the first thing to check. Then rank the three by likely impact.

Tighten: Separate what the data shows from what you're guessing. Don't recommend a test until we've ruled out broken forms, slow pages and tracking errors.
```

AI TIP

Summarize session recordings and heatmaps

```
Context: Here are notes or AI summaries from [number] session recordings and the heatmap for our [page name] page: [paste]. The one action we want visitors to take is [action].

Role: Act as a UX researcher.

Ask: Identify the patterns that are stopping visitors from taking that action.

Format: A list of up to five patterns, each with: what visitors do, how often it appears, the likely reason, and one change to try.

Tighten: Only report patterns that appear in several sessions. Flag anything based on one or two sessions as a hunch.
```

What we found when we tested every form, button and phone number, and what we fixed.

A/B Testing for Best Results

An A/B test shows two versions of a page, or one part of it, to different visitors at the same time and measures which one gets more conversions. It replaces opinions with evidence. The question stops being "Which headline do we like?" and becomes "Which headline gets more people to call?"

Test it, don't guess it. Every change you make to a page is an opinion until your customers vote on it with their clicks, calls and forms. Your instincts tell you what to test. The test tells you whether you were right.

Testing isn't a project you finish. It's how you keep learning what your buyers want, one change at a time.

Answer these questions first

- What is the goal of the page?
- Who is the audience?
- What is our unique value?
- What content does the buyer need to decide?
- How will we measure success?

If you can't answer all five, you're not ready to test. You're ready to fix the page.

How to run a good test

- **Start with a reason.** Base each test on something you saw in the data, recordings or customer feedback, not a hunch. Write it down: "Because visitors don't scroll to the price, moving the price range up will increase inquiries."
- **Test one change at a time.** Change the headline or the form, not both, or you won't know which one made the difference.
- **Test big things first.** The offer, the headline, the form and the page layout move results more than button colors do.
- **Run it long enough.** Run every test for at least two full weeks, so weekdays and weekends both count, and until each version has enough conversions to trust. Most testing tools tell you when a result is reliable. Don't stop a test early because one version is ahead on day three.
- **Keep a log.** Record every test: what you changed, why, the result and what you learned. Losing tests teach you as much as winners.

PRO TIP

When you find a winner, make it the new standard and test again. Conversion work is never finished. Each test builds on the last.

When you don't have enough traffic

Here's the reality for most small businesses: you probably don't have enough traffic for a reliable A/B test. If a page gets 500 visits and 10 conversions a month, it would take many months to know whether a new version is really better.

That doesn't mean you can't improve. It means you use different tools:

- **Fix the obvious.** Broken forms, slow pages, unclear headlines and missing prices don't need a test.
- **Ask real people.** Show the page to five people who match your buyer. Ask them what you offer, who it's for and what they'd do next. If they can't answer in five seconds, the page needs work.
- **Watch recordings.** Twenty recordings of real visitors will show you more than a test you can't finish.
- **Make one change, then watch the trend.** It isn't a controlled test, but tracking your conversion rate for the eight weeks before and after a change still tells you something. Note anything else that changed at the same time, like an ad campaign or the season.
- **Test where the traffic is.** If you run ads, test the ad and the landing page there, where you control the traffic.

AI TIP

Plan your next test

```
Context: Our [page name] page gets about [number] visits and [number] conversions a month. Here's what we've learned from analytics, recordings and customer feedback: [paste findings]. Our main conversion is [action].

Role: Act as a conversion optimization strategist.

Ask: Recommend the next three changes to make, in priority order, and tell us whether each one should be an A/B test or a straight fix based on our traffic.

Format: For each change: the hypothesis ("Because we saw..., changing... will..."), what to change, test or fix, how long to run it, and the result that would tell us it worked.

Tighten: Be realistic about our traffic. If a test would take more than eight weeks to give a reliable answer, say so and suggest another way to learn.
```

AI TIP

Draft variations to test

```
Context: Here is our current [headline/form/offer/CTA section] for the [page name] page: [paste]. Our buyer is [describe]. What we learned: [the problem we're trying to solve].

Role: Act as a conversion copywriter.

Ask: Write three alternative versions that each take a different approach to the problem.

Format: For each version: the new text, the approach it takes, and why it might work better for this buyer.

Tighten: Keep our voice and only use facts from our page. Plain words, short sentences. People will choose which version to test.
```

Our first test or fix: the page, the hypothesis, the change and how we'll measure it.

WHO DOES THE WORK

Who Does the Work: Conversion Resource Checklist

Conversion work needs someone to set the plan, someone to design and build the pages, and someone to read the data. Check who owns each deliverable today.

In = in-house · **Out** = outsourced: agency, freelancer or partner · **Gap** = no one covers it yet

DELIVERABLE	IN	OUT	OWNER
Conversion goals and tracking set up (forms, calls, purchases)	☐	☐	
Conversion audit of key landing pages	☐	☐	
Form, button and phone tests on every device	☐	☐	
Page speed and mobile review	☐	☐	
Session recordings and heatmaps	☐	☐	

DELIVERABLE	IN	OUT	OWNER
Customer and sales feedback on objections	☐	☐	
Landing page copy and design updates	☐	☐	
A/B test plan, set-up and test log	☐	☐	
Monthly conversion report	☐	☐	

The top three roles on your conversion team

- **Conversion strategist.** Sets the goals, defines the path from first visit to sale, chooses what to fix or test next and works with marketing, design, development and sales.
- **UX designer and developer.** Designs and builds pages that are clear, fast and easy to use on a phone. Creates wireframes, runs quick user tests and puts winning changes live.
- **Conversion analyst.** Sets up tracking, analyzes analytics, recordings and test results, and reports what's working.

In a small business, one person may cover all three with help from a web developer. AI can draft copy, summarize recordings and analyze reports, but a person decides what to change and checks that it works.

Our biggest conversion gap and how we'll fill it (hire, train, outsource or use AI with review).

MEASURING CONVERSION

Measuring Conversion

MEASURE	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Conversion rate by page	Which pages turn visitors into leads, and which don't
Conversion rate by source	Whether search, ads, email, social or AI answers bring better buyers
Form starts vs. form completions	Whether the form itself is losing people
Engagement rate	Whether visitors stay and interact, or leave right away (the modern version of bounce rate)
Page speed and Core Web Vitals	Whether slow pages are costing you

MEASURE	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Lead quality	Whether sales wants the leads the page brings in

Track conversions as actions that matter: a completed form, a call longer than a minute, a booked consultation, a purchase. Set them up in Google Analytics, and send them to your ad platforms too (Chapter 12).

PRO TIP

Set up conversion tracking and analytics before you change anything. Without a "before" number, you can't prove the "after" worked.

AI TIP

Write your monthly conversion report

```
Context: Here are this month's and last month's numbers for our key pages: visits, conversions and conversion rate by page and by source, plus form starts and completions: [paste]. Changes we made this month: [list].

Role: Act as a conversion analyst writing for a busy owner.

Ask: Summarize what changed, what likely caused it and what we should do next.

Format: Three short sections: what improved, what got worse, and the next two actions. Under 250 words.

Tighten: Use only our numbers. Say when a change is too small to mean anything. Don't credit a change we made unless the timing and the data support it.
```

YOUR CONVERSION PLAN

Your Conversion Plan

Answer these questions with your team. Then use the AI TIP at the end to turn your answers into a 90-day conversion plan.

How well do our key landing pages turn visitors into leads or customers, and is the rate trending up or down?

Are our calls to action clear, compelling and placed where visitors will see them?

Which pages have the lowest engagement or the highest drop-off, and why?

What path do visitors take to contact us or buy, and where does it break down? (Look back at your customer journey map from Chapter 5.)

YOUR TURN

Are our landing pages easy to use on a phone? Look at your mobile site right now as you answer.

YOUR TURN

Are our forms the right length? What's the least we can ask and still take the next step?

Do our visuals and messaging match what our buyers expect and need?

Are our pages fast enough on mobile and desktop, and what will we fix first?

Are we tracking the right conversions in analytics, and what are we missing?

Do we have enough traffic to A/B test? If not, how will we learn what works instead?

AI TIP

Turn your answers into a 90-day conversion plan

```
Context: Here are our answers to the conversion questions: [paste answers]. Our monthly traffic to key pages is about [number], and our current conversion rate is about [rate].

Role: Act as a conversion optimization strategist building a plan for a small team.

Ask: Turn our answers into a 90-day conversion plan.

Format: (1) A one-paragraph summary. (2) Fixes to make in the first two weeks. (3) A month-by-month list of improvements and tests, each with an owner and a success measure. (4) The three numbers we'll report at day 90.

Tighten: Fix before you test. Be realistic about our traffic and team time. Mark any assumption so we can check it.
```

↓ Conversion plan template

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CRM

Do you know every customer?

In this chapter »

One clean record for every customer. Then let AI put it to work.

— **CHOOSING AND SETTING UP A CRM**
One that fits a small team

— **CLEAN CONTACT DATA**
One record per customer, and keep it that way

— **CONSENT RECORDS**
Who agreed to hear from you, how and when

— **WHERE AI HELPS**
Summaries, lead scores, follow-ups and drifting customers

— **CONNECTING YOUR TOOLS**
Website, email, texting and paid media

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
AI Tips to come in the next draft

Coming in the next draft

This field guide is new to the second edition. It is being written now and will be in the next review draft.

It will cover:

- Choosing and setting up a CRM that fits a small team
- Clean contact data: one record per customer, and how to keep it that way
- Consent records: who agreed to hear from you, how and when
- Where AI helps: summarizing calls and emails, scoring leads, drafting follow-ups and flagging customers who are drifting
- Connecting the CRM to your website, email, texting and paid media
- The numbers to watch, and questions to answer with your team

NURTURE

Do you follow up fast?

In this chapter »

Follow up fast, and keep the conversation going.

— **WHO'S READY?**
Speed to lead, and how to qualify

— **BUILD YOUR NURTURE WORKFLOWS**
Automated emails and texts, with the texting rules

— **TOOLS FOR LEAD NURTURE**
Your CRM and your email platform

— **MEASURING LEAD NURTURE**
The numbers that show what is working

— **YOUR LEAD NURTURE PLAN**
A worked example, then your questions

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
6 AI Tips, including defining your MQL, SQL and lead score and writing your instant response

Lead Nurture

Most people who contact you, download something from you or sign up for your emails aren't ready to buy today. Lead nurture is how you stay helpful and stay in touch until they are.

The first edition called this building your owned audience: a database of prospects and customers you can talk to one-on-one, whenever you choose, without paying a platform for the privilege. Chapter 10 showed you how to grow it. This chapter is about what you do with it.

A lead isn't a sale. It's the start of a conversation.

Done well, lead nurture does three things:

- **Builds trust.** Every useful email, answer and resource shows a buyer what working with you will be like.
- **Keeps you top of mind.** When the buyer is finally ready, you're the business they remember.
- **Tells you who's ready.** The emails people open, the links they click and the pages they revisit show you who to call next.

It's also one of the best returns in marketing. In Litmus's 2025 State of Email survey, most marketers reported earning between $10 and $50 for every $1 spent on email, and 30% reported $36 to $50 (Litmus, 2025). Results vary by industry and by how good the emails are, but few channels come close.

What AI changed

AI writes the first draft. A full nurture sequence, with subject lines, emails and follow-ups for each buyer type, takes minutes to draft instead of weeks.

Personalization is easier. AI tools in most email and CRM platforms can tailor a message to what a person has viewed, downloaded or asked about, at a scale that used to take a large team.

AI can sort and summarize. It can score leads based on behavior, summarize long email threads before a sales call and flag replies that need a person right away.

Inboxes got stricter. Since 2024, Google and Yahoo require bulk senders to authenticate their email, make unsubscribing easy and keep spam complaints low (Google, 2026). Sending more email, faster, with AI makes following those rules more important, not less.

One caution: AI-written nurture emails tend to sound like everyone else's. Buyers notice, and they stop opening. Use AI for structure and first drafts, then make every email sound like you, with your stories, your examples and your opinions. A person approves every sequence before it goes live.

Who's Ready? Speed and Qualification

Not every lead is the same. Someone who fills out your contact form and asks for a quote is raising a hand. Someone who downloads a guide is doing research. Treat them the same, and you'll either lose the hot lead or annoy the curious one.

Respond fast to people who ask

When someone asks to talk, speed wins, and most businesses are slow. In a study published in March 2026, Workato submitted demo requests to 114 B2B companies and timed the replies. Only one company sent a personal email within five minutes. The average email reply took nearly 12 hours, and phone call-backs averaged about 14 and a half hours. Nearly one in five companies never replied by email at all (Workato, 2026).

Fast beats perfect every time.

That's your opening. If your competitors take half a day to answer, a business that answers within the hour stands out.

Here are the standards we recommend for anyone who fills out a form, requests a quote or calls:

- **Right away:** an automatic thank-you that says what happens next and when.
- **Within 15 minutes:** excellent. This is where you win buyers who are contacting several businesses at once.
- **Within one hour, during business hours:** the goal for every business.
- **Same day:** the minimum. A reply tomorrow tells the buyer they're not a priority.

Write your standard down, name who is responsible and measure it. If no one owns the inbox, no one answers it.

Nurture the rest

The opposite mistake is just as costly: calling every person who downloads a guide. The Customer Journey (2019) warned about this. Someone reading a white paper doesn't want a sales call five minutes later. Engagement tells you when they're warming up: people who come back, read more and download again are more likely to buy than someone who downloads once and disappears.

PRO TIP

Let buyers tell you they're ready. Add a simple question to your forms, such as "Would you like us to contact you?" or "When are you hoping to start?" The answer sorts your leads better than any score.

MQLs and SQLs

MQL and SQL are standard terms in sales and marketing. They're built into the lifecycle stages of marketing platforms such as HubSpot, so your team will see them in the tools they use. We covered them in depth in *The Customer Journey* (2019). The terms are standard; the definitions aren't. Each business must decide what makes

a lead marketing qualified or sales qualified. Sales and marketing should define both terms together, write them down and review them every quarter.

Marketing qualified lead (MQL): a lead that's paying attention but isn't ready to buy. They typically:

- Show real engagement on your site, such as several visits or pages
- Have a need, shown by downloading content or filling out a form
- Match one of your best buyer personas
- Meet your basic requirements, such as location, company size or budget range

Sales qualified lead (SQL): a lead that marketing and sales agree is ready for a sales conversation. They typically:

- Came from a channel that converts well for you
- Keep reading your content, open your emails and download more than one resource
- Visited or came back to your pricing page
- Have the authority to decide, or strongly influence the decision

Keep the definitions simple. "Viewed two service pages and downloaded one guide" is a perfectly good MQL definition to start with.

BANT: a quick qualification check

BANT is one of the oldest and best-known qualification checklists in sales. It's widely credited to IBM, which has used it (as Budget, Authority, Need, Timeframe) to qualify sales opportunities, including in the forms its business partners complete to register a deal. We covered it in *The Customer Journey* (2019). It has lasted because it's simple: four questions that tell sales whether a lead is ready.

	QUESTION	WHAT YOU'RE LISTENING FOR
Budget	Can they afford it?	A budget, or a range that fits your price
Authority	Can they decide?	The decision maker, or someone who strongly influences them
Need	Do they have a problem you solve?	A clear need, in their words
Timeline	When do they want to start?	A real date or reason to act

BANT is a starting point. Add anything specific to your business that tells you a buyer is serious.

Score your leads

Lead scoring gives each lead points for who they are (fit) and what they do (engagement). Most CRMs and marketing automation tools can do it automatically. Start simple:

SIGNAL	POINTS (EXAMPLE)
Matches a best-fit persona	+20

SIGNAL	POINTS (EXAMPLE)
Visited the pricing page	+15
Downloaded a guide	+10
Opened three or more emails	+10
Asked to be contacted	+50
Outside your service area or wrong fit	−30

Pick a threshold, such as 50 points, that makes a lead an SQL. Then check it every quarter against who actually bought, and adjust. The companion workbook tab for this chapter does the math.

AI TIP

Define your MQL, SQL and lead score

```
Context: We sell [offer] to [buyer]. Our best customers in the last year looked like this: [describe or paste anonymized data: industry, size, role, location, budget]. Before buying, they usually [pages visited, content downloaded, emails opened, how long it took].

Role: Act as a revenue operations consultant who aligns sales and marketing.

Ask: Draft definitions for our marketing qualified lead and sales qualified lead, and a simple lead scoring model.

Format: (1) MQL definition in one sentence plus a checklist. (2) SQL definition in one sentence plus a checklist. (3) A scoring table: signal, points, and why. (4) A suggested SQL threshold.

Tighten: Base it on the customer patterns I described, not generic benchmarks. Keep it simple enough to run in [our CRM]. Mark assumptions for sales to confirm.
```

Our MQL definition, our SQL definition and who reviews them each quarter.

BUILD YOUR NURTURE WORKFLOWS

Build Your Nurture Workflows

A workflow is a series of emails, and sometimes texts or tasks for your team, that starts automatically when a person does something: fills out a form, downloads a guide, visits your pricing page or goes quiet.

Texting rules. Texts get read, which is why they're regulated more tightly than email. Federal law (the Telephone Consumer Protection Act, or TCPA) applies to marketing texts, and the penalties are per message. Before you add texts to any workflow:

- **Get consent first, in writing.** Marketing texts need the person's prior express written consent: a checked box or a reply that clearly says they agree to receive marketing texts from you. A phone number on a contact form is not consent to market by text.
- **Honor opt-outs fast, however they arrive.** Since April 11, 2025, people can opt out "by any reasonable method," including replying STOP, QUIT, END, CANCEL or UNSUBSCRIBE, or simply telling you. You must honor it within ten business days. You may send one confirmation text within five minutes, with no marketing in it (Kelley Drye, 2025).
- **Keep one do-not-text list across every tool.** An opt-out in your texting tool has to reach your CRM and every other system that sends texts.
- **Respect quiet hours.** Don't send marketing texts before 8 a.m. or after 9 p.m. in the recipient's time zone.
- **Use a business texting platform.** Carriers require business texts to be sent through registered numbers; reputable platforms handle registration and opt-out keywords for you.

This isn't legal advice. Rules on texting change often, and several states add their own. Have your attorney review your consent wording before you send your first marketing text.

Texting as a channel, from building an opt-in list to two-way texting and RCS business messaging, is covered in Chapter 17, SMS and Text Messaging.

Will we text leads or customers? If so, how will we collect written consent, and who owns the do-not-text list?

Get started

- **Define your personas and their journey.** Know who you're writing to and what they need at each stage (Chapter 5).
- **Decide what starts each workflow.** Pick the triggers that matter most: a contact form, a download, a webinar sign-up, a quote request, a past customer's anniversary.
- **Use your data.** Segment your list by persona, interest and stage, so each person gets emails that fit. Use dynamic content to change the subject line, body or call to action based on what you know about them.
- **Automate, then watch.** Set up the workflow, test it with your own email address, then check the results every month.

PRO TIP

Make your triggers specific. If an email should go out when someone downloads a guide, trigger it on the completed download, not the page visit. Then test every trigger regularly to make sure it fires when it should.

The nurture sequence

The first edition laid out three stages. They still work. A typical sequence has five to seven emails over a few weeks, adjusted to your sales cycle.

STAGE	EMAILS	WHAT TO SEND	WHAT NOT TO DO
1. Initial response	1	Say thank you, right away. Deliver what they asked for, plus one useful next resource. A short video works well.	Don't make them wait.
2. Build rapport	3–4	Answer common questions. Share guides, examples, case studies, FAQs and videos. Link to your hub content (Chapter 10).	Don't sell yet. That comes later.
3. Close	1–2	If they're still opening, they're interested. Share specific product or service details, pricing and terms, and a video that walks through your process. Ask for a meeting or the sale.	Don't be vague about the next step.

After the sequence, move people who didn't buy into your regular newsletter, so you stay in touch without pushing.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

The three-stage nurture sequence as a horizontal path.

Write emails people open

- **Subject lines:** specific and honest. Say what's inside. Test two versions when your list is big enough.
- **One idea per email.** One topic, one call to action.
- **Write like a person.** Send from a real name. Short paragraphs. Plain words.
- **Make it easy to reply.** Some of your best leads will just hit reply and ask a question.

Get to the inbox

Great emails don't matter if they land in spam. Google's sender guidelines now require bulk senders to authenticate their email (SPF, DKIM and DMARC), offer one-click unsubscribe and keep spam complaint rates low (Google, 2026). Most email platforms handle the technical setup, but someone on your team must confirm it's done. Only email people who asked to hear from you, and remove people who haven't opened in months.

PRO TIP

Ask your email platform for a deliverability check before you launch a new workflow. One misconfigured setting can send every email to spam.

Practice: write a six-email workflow

Pick one trigger, such as a guide download or a quote request. For each email, write the subject line, the headline and a short summary.

EMAIL	TIMING	SUBJECT LINE	HEADLINE	SUMMARY
1	Right away			
2	Day 2			
3	Day 5			
4	Day 9			
5	Day 14			
6	Day 21			

AI TIP

Draft a nurture sequence

```
Context: We are [business]. This workflow starts when someone [trigger, e.g., downloads our guide to X]. They're usually [persona] at the [stage] stage. Our sales cycle is about [length]. Resources we can link to: [list]. Our voice: [describe, or paste two of our emails].

Role: Act as an email marketing strategist and copywriter.

Ask: Draft a six-email nurture sequence using three stages: initial response, build rapport, close.

Format: For each email: send day, subject line (under 50 characters), preview text, the main message in 100 to 150 words, and one call to action.

Tighten: No selling until the close stage. Use only facts and resources I listed. Write like a person, not a brand. Mark anything we need to verify.
```

AI TIP

Personalize by persona

```
Context: Here is one email from our nurture sequence: [paste]. Our personas are [persona 1: description], [persona 2: description] and [persona 3: description].

Role: Act as an email copywriter who personalizes without sounding creepy.

Ask: Rewrite the email for each persona, changing only what needs to change.

Format: For each persona: subject line, opening line, the one example or proof point that fits them best, and the call to action.

Tighten: Keep the same core message and length. Don't reference personal data the person didn't knowingly give us.
```

Our first workflow: the trigger, the persona, the number of emails and who owns it.

TOOLS FOR LEAD NURTURE

Tools for Lead Nurture

You need two things: a place to keep your contacts and their history (a CRM), and a way to send automated emails. Many tools do both. There are free and paid options depending on the size of your list and how often you send. Popular choices include HubSpot, Mailchimp, ActiveCampaign, Klaviyo, Constant Contact, Brevo and Salesforce. Pick one your team will actually use, that connects to your website forms and that can send leads to sales automatically.

PRO TIP

Connect your forms, your email tool and your CRM before you write a single email. If leads have to be copied by hand from one system to another, some will get lost.

Measuring Lead Nurture

MEASURE	WHAT IT TELLS YOU	WATCH FOR
Response time to hand-raisers	How fast you answer people who ask	Anything over an hour in business hours
Click rate	Whether the content is useful	Emails nobody clicks
Reply rate	Whether people want to talk	A sudden drop, which can mean spam folders
Unsubscribe and spam complaint rates	Whether you're sending too much or to the wrong people	Spam complaints creeping up
MQL to SQL rate	Whether nurture warms leads up	Leads stuck at MQL
SQL to customer rate and time to close	Whether sales agrees the leads are ready	Sales ignoring marketing's leads
Revenue from nurtured leads	Whether it pays	The number that justifies the work

Treat open rates with care. Some email apps open messages automatically to load images, which inflates them. Clicks, replies and sales tell you more.

AI TIP

Review your nurture results

```
Context: Here are last month's results for our nurture workflows: emails sent, clicks, replies, unsubscribes and spam complaints by email, plus MQLs, SQLs and closed deals: [paste]. Our goals were [goals].

Role: Act as an email marketing analyst.

Ask: Find which emails and workflows are working, which aren't, and what to change first.

Format: (1) Three findings, each with the numbers behind it. (2) The two emails to rewrite or cut. (3) One test to run next month.

Tighten: Don't rely on open rates; focus on clicks, replies and conversions. Use only my data, and say when numbers are too small to draw conclusions.
```

EXAMPLE

Example: Wild West Custom Pools

A custom pool is a long, careful decision, and Wild West's lead nurture reflects that. The promise starts with access: one of the search ads says "Call the Owner Directly. Always." (Chapter 12). When a buyer reaches out, they talk to Dan, not a call center. That's the speed-to-lead lesson built into the brand.

What happens next takes time. The lead Dan is working now has met with him a couple of times, and they're discussing sample project plans and timelines (Chapter 4). That's nurture, too: each meeting and each plan answers the buyer's next question.

The opportunity is in what happens between conversations. A buyer who isn't ready this season may be ready next spring. A simple nurture sequence could keep them close, with a thank-you after the first call, the price guide and FAQ, a project story with photos, an explanation of the design process, and an invitation to talk when they're ready. Dan already posts almost daily during a build (Chapter 13). Those posts could become a monthly email that shows a pool taking shape.

What a buyer receives from us between their first contact and their decision to buy.

YOUR LEAD NURTURE PLAN

Your Lead Nurture Plan

Answer these questions with your team. Then use the AI TIPs to write your first response and turn your answers into a 90-day plan.

How will we capture leads' contact information, and which forms and offers will we use on our website and other channels?

Which email platform and CRM will we use, and are they connected to our forms?

How quickly will we respond to people who ask to talk, and who is responsible?

How do we define an MQL and an SQL, and when will sales and marketing review those definitions together?

Will we use lead scoring? If so, which signals and what threshold?

Which workflows will we build first, and what triggers each one?

How will we tailor our emails to each persona's needs and questions?

What content will we use in our emails (guides, case studies, videos, FAQs, webinars)?

How often will we email, and how will we keep people engaged after a sequence ends?

Is our email authenticated and set up for deliverability, and who checks it?

Which metrics will we track to measure whether lead nurture is working?

AI TIP

Write your instant response

```
Context: Someone just [filled out our contact form / requested a quote / downloaded our guide to X].
We are [business]. What happens next in our process: [describe]. Who they'll hear from and when:
[name, time frame].

Role: Act as a customer experience writer.

Ask: Write the automatic email they receive right away.

Format: Subject line, a short thank-you, what happens next and when, one useful resource with a link,
and a way to reach a person now.

Tighten: Under 120 words. Warm and plain. Promise only what we can deliver. Signed by a real person.
```

AI TIP

Turn your answers into a 90-day lead nurture plan

```
Context: Here are our answers to the lead nurture questions: [paste answers]. Our current lead volume
is about [number] a month, and our sales cycle is about [length].

Role: Act as a marketing automation strategist building a plan for a small team.

Ask: Turn our answers into a 90-day lead nurture plan.

Format: (1) A one-paragraph summary. (2) Setup tasks for the first two weeks (connections,
authentication, definitions). (3) The workflows to build in months one to three, each with its
trigger, number of emails and owner. (4) The three numbers we'll report at day 90.

Tighten: Start with the workflow closest to revenue. Be realistic about our team's time. Mark any
assumption so we can check it.
```

↓ Lead nurture plan template

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TEXTING

Do your texts get answered?

In this chapter »

The fastest channel you have. Use it with permission.

— **WHEN TEXTING WORKS**
And when it annoys people

— **PERMISSION FIRST**
Consent, opt-outs and quiet hours

— **GETTING DELIVERED**
Register your business number with the carriers

— **TEXTS THAT FEEL PERSONAL**
Two-way texting, reminders and follow-ups

— **WHERE AI HELPS**
Drafting short messages and replying faster

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
AI Tips to come in the next draft

Coming in the next draft

This field guide is new to the second edition. It is being written now and will be in the next review draft.

It will cover:

- When texting works, and when it annoys people
- Getting permission first: consent, opt-outs and quiet hours
- Registering your business number with the carriers so your texts get delivered
- Two-way texting, appointment reminders and follow-ups that feel personal
- Where AI helps: drafting short messages, replying faster and keeping your voice
- The numbers to watch, and questions to answer with your team

RETENTION

Do your customers come back?

In this chapter »

Keep the customers you win. Then turn them into referrals.

— **WHY KEEPING CUSTOMERS PAYS**
Repeat and one-time businesses, and why referrals win

— **AFTER THE SALE**
Onboard, check in and win back

— **LOYALTY PROGRAMS**
Five types, when not to do one, and the math first

— **REFERRAL PROGRAMS**
Five design decisions, the rules and partner referrals

— **MEASURING RETENTION**
Six numbers, including customer lifetime value

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
5 AI Tips, including finding customers who are drifting and designing your referral program

Why Keeping Customers Pays

Most marketing budgets go to finding new customers. Most profit comes from the ones you already have.

That isn't a new idea. In 2001, Bain & Company's Fred Reichheld wrote that in financial services, "a 5% increase in customer retention produces more than a 25% increase in profit." That's old research from one industry, so use it as a direction, not a forecast for your business. The reason behind it still holds. A customer who stays doesn't cost you acquisition money again. They buy with less hand-holding. They tell other people about you.

Referrals are the clearest proof. A Wharton-led study published in the *Journal of Marketing* in 2011 tracked nearly 10,000 customers at a German bank. Referred customers were worth at least 16% more than other customers. Their churn rate was 18% lower. That's one bank and the data is more than a decade old. Still, it is one of the few studies that followed real customers over time instead of asking about intentions.

People still trust people. In Nielsen's 2021 Trust in Advertising study, recommendations from people they know were the most trusted channel, at 89%. Trust in online reviews is slipping by comparison. BrightLocal's 2025 survey found that 42% of U.S. consumers trust reviews as much as personal recommendations, down from 79% in 2020. Reviews still matter. But a word from a friend matters more.

Repeat businesses and one-time businesses

Not every business has the same retention game. Know which one you're in.

- **Repeat-purchase businesses** (restaurants, salons, retail, SaaS, agencies on retainer, home services like lawn care) live on return visits and renewals. Retention is the main event.
- **Low-repeat or one-time businesses** (custom pool builders, roofers, wedding venues, real estate agents) may serve a customer once a decade. Their "retention" is mostly about referrals, reviews and staying memorable for the next time.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Two-column card.

Wild West Custom Pools is a good example of the second kind (planned, illustrative). The company only builds 12 pools a year. A happy customer probably won't buy a second pool. That customer can still send a neighbor, post a review or introduce a landscape designer. For a business like this, a referral program and a steady review habit do more than any loyalty program would.

Referrals are your cheapest lead source

A referred lead arrives already warm. Someone they trust has done part of your selling. You pay no click cost and no agency fee. If you pay a reward at all, you pay it only when the referral turns into a customer.

PRO TIP

Ask your best customers where they found you. Then ask your last ten new customers the same question. If "a friend told me" shows up often and you have no referral program, you're leaving your best channel to chance.

How AI changed this

Two things are different now.

First, personal follow-up is possible at small-business scale. Big brands have always sent birthday notes, "time to reorder" reminders and personal check-ins. A five-person business didn't have the time. Now AI can draft those messages, segment your list and flag customers who have gone quiet. Customers notice. Salesforce's 2026 State of the AI Connected Customer report found that 73% of customers say companies treat them as individuals rather than numbers, up from 39% in 2023. The bar has gone up.

Second, AI answers lean on what's said about you. When someone asks ChatGPT, Gemini or Perplexity for "the best pool builder near Round Rock," the answer comes from somewhere. Yext analyzed 6.8 million AI citations in 2025. It found that 86% came from sources brands manage, such as websites and listings. Reviews and social made up 8% overall and 13.3% in food service. BrightLocal's 2025 research found Yelp was a source in 33% of its local AI searches. Your listings, your reviews and your customers' mentions now feed both search results and AI answers. Happy customers who talk about you are part of your AI search visibility. (See Local SEO and Reviews, Ch 8, and SEO and AI Search, Ch 6.)

AI ground rules apply to everything in this guide. People approve everything that goes out. Verify facts. Remove personal details before you paste customer data into an AI tool, unless your company's AI policy and the tool's settings allow it. Keep your voice. A thank-you note that sounds like a robot does more harm than no note.

AFTER THE SALE

After the Sale: Onboard, Check In, Win Back

The sale is the start of the relationship. Most small businesses go quiet right after it. That gap is where customers start to drift.

Here's a simple six-step lifecycle. It extends the Retention and Advocacy stages from Customer Journey (Ch 5).

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Horizontal loop of six rounded cards.

1. **Welcome and onboarding.** Thank them. Tell them what happens next and who to contact. Set expectations in writing.
2. **First-value check-in.** Contact them right after they first get value from what they bought. Ask how it's going. Fix small problems before they turn into big ones.
3. **Ongoing value.** Share tips, maintenance reminders and useful content. Don't only send offers.
4. **Renewal or repeat triggers.** Know when they'll likely need you again. Reach out just before then.
5. **At-risk signals.** Watch for warning signs: missed visits, fewer logins, a complaint, a late payment, a drop in order size.
6. **Win-back.** Reach out to lapsed customers with a reason to return. Ask why they left. Listen.

Lifecycle by business type

STEP	REPEAT BUSINESS (SALON, CAFÉ, RETAIL)	SERVICE ON RETAINER (AGENCY, SAAS, IT)	LOW-REPEAT BUSINESS (POOL BUILDER, ROOFER)
Welcome	Thank-you email or text; join the list	Kickoff call; welcome packet; named contact	Thank-you note; project timeline; owner intro
First value	"How was your first visit?" within 2 days	30-day check-in call	Check-in at key milestones and at handoff
Ongoing value	Tips, new arrivals, member perks	Monthly report with plain-English insights	Seasonal care tips; one-year anniversary note
Renew or repeat	Reminder at the usual visit interval	60–90 days before renewal	Maintenance, upgrades, add-on projects
At-risk signals	Missed usual interval by 50%	Fewer logins; slow replies; new decision-maker	Unresolved warranty issue; complaint
Win-back	"We miss you" offer after 2x usual interval	Exit interview; return offer	Fix the issue first; then ask for feedback
Referral and review moment	After a great visit	After a strong result is reported	At handoff and at the one-year mark

For Wild West Custom Pools (planned, illustrative), the strongest moment is first swim. The owner is on-site from excavation to first swim. That's when the family is happiest. It's the natural time for a thank-you, a photo (with permission) and an honest review request. The same request goes to every customer, not only the happiest ones. A one-year "pool birthday" check-in could follow, with seasonal care tips.

Pick the right channel

CHANNEL	BEST FOR	WATCH OUT FOR
Email	Onboarding sequences, tips, renewal reminders	Generic blasts; see Lead Nurture (Ch 16)
Text (SMS)	Appointment reminders, short check-ins, time-sensitive offers	Requires prior written consent; see "Marketing Within the Rules" (Ch 23)
Phone call	At-risk customers, high-value accounts, win-back	Don't script it so tightly it sounds canned
Handwritten note	Thank-yous, milestones, referrals received	Nothing; people keep these
Paid media	Customer-list audiences for repeat offers; excluding current customers from acquisition ads; lookalike audiences built from best customers	Upload only lists you have the right to use; follow each platform's customer-list policy
In person	Service businesses, local retail	Train staff on what to ask

Texting needs consent. Get clear permission before you send marketing texts, record it and honor opt-outs quickly. The "Marketing Within the Rules" guide (Ch 23) covers the details. Don't guess.

PRO TIP

Paid media has a retention job too. Exclude current customers from your acquisition campaigns so you stop paying to win people you already have. Then run a small, separate campaign to past customers for repeat offers. Those two steps often pay for themselves fast.

PRO TIP

The person who delivered the work should make the check-in call, not the salesperson. Customers tell the person who did the job the truth.

AI TIP

Draft your post-sale sequence

```
Context: I run [business type] in [location]. Customers buy [product/service] and usually [buy again every X / buy once]. Today I send [nothing / a receipt / a thank-you email] after the sale.

Role: Act as a customer retention specialist who writes in a warm, plain, local-business voice.

Ask: Draft a post-sale sequence covering welcome, first-value check-in, one ongoing-value message and a repeat or referral prompt, with timing for each.

Format: A table with columns for timing, channel (email, text or call script), subject line or opener, and message under 120 words.

Tighten: Use my voice from this sample: [paste a past email]. No discounts in the first two messages. No hype. Flag any message that needs text-message consent.
```

AI TIP

Find customers who are drifting

```
Context: Here is an export of my customers with personal details removed: [customer ID, last purchase date, number of purchases, average order value, any complaint Y/N]. Our typical customer buys every [X weeks/months].

Role: Act as a retention analyst for a small business.

Ask: Identify at-risk and lapsed customers using simple rules, group them into segments, and suggest one win-back action per segment.

Format: A short rules list, a segment table (segment, rule, count, suggested action, channel), then three win-back message drafts under 80 words each.

Tighten: Show your rules so I can check them. Don't invent data. Mark any assumption with [ASSUMPTION]. Suggest a phone call, not an email, for any customer with an open complaint.
```

Verify the AI's counts against your own data before you act. Then re-attach the names on your side, not inside the AI tool. The "AI and Your CRM" field guide (Ch 15) shows how to set this up so it runs on its own.

LOYALTY PROGRAMS THAT FIT A SMALL BUSINESS

Loyalty Programs That Fit a Small Business

Most small businesses don't have a loyalty program. SumUp surveyed 617 U.S. micro and small business owners in November 2025. It found that 73.2% had no formal program. The most common reason was the belief that their customer base was "too small to justify a program." Of the owners who did run one, 69.1% reported major or moderate sales increases. That figure is self-reported and from a vendor that sells loyalty tools, so read it as a signal, not a guarantee.

The real question isn't "Should I have a loyalty program?" It's "What would make my best customers come back more often, and can I afford it?"

Five types to consider

TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	FITS	COST AND EFFORT
Points or punch card	Earn per visit or dollar; redeem for a reward	Cafés, salons, car washes, retail	Low; most POS systems include it
Tiers	Spend more, unlock better perks	Retail and services with a wide spend range	Medium; needs tracking and clear rules
Paid membership	Customers pay a fee for ongoing benefits	Maintenance plans, gyms, HVAC, car care, pool service	Medium; you must deliver every month
Surprise and delight	Unannounced thank-yous: a free add-on, a note, an upgrade	Any business; strongest for low-repeat businesses	Low; needs a habit, not software
Community	Events, members-only groups, early access, classes	Hobby, fitness, specialty retail, B2B peer groups	Low cash, high time

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Five rounded cards in a row.

When not to do one

Skip a formal program if:

- Customers buy once or rarely. Use surprise-and-delight and a referral program instead.
- Your margins can't absorb the reward cost.
- You can't track it reliably. A program that forgets points makes customers angry.

- Your service has problems. Fix those first. A loyalty program won't save a bad experience.
- You're mainly trying to discount. That trains customers to wait for deals.

PRO TIP

The best loyalty program for most small businesses is to remember the customer. Use their name. Remember their last order. Ask about the thing they mentioned last time. That costs nothing, and no competitor can copy it.

Do the math first

Run the numbers before you launch.

LINE	EXAMPLE (ILLUSTRATIVE)	YOUR NUMBE
Average order value	$40	☐
Gross margin	60% ($24 per order)	☐
Current visits per customer per year	6	☐
Expected visits with program	7	☐
Extra gross profit per member per year	1 x $24 = $24	☐
Reward cost per member per year	$8 (one free item at cost)	☐
Software or card cost per member per year	$2	☐
Net gain per member per year	$24 - $8 - $2 = $14	☐

If the net gain is zero or negative, change the reward or skip the program. Watch the "expected visits" line closely. It's a guess until you test it. Run a 90-day pilot and measure the real change before you roll it out.

↓ Loyalty Program Cost Calculator

What do your best customers value most: savings, status, convenience, recognition or belonging?

Which loyalty type fits your business, and why?

What reward could you offer that costs you little but means a lot to the customer?

What is your estimated net gain per member per year from the cost table?

AI TIP

Stress-test a loyalty idea

```
Context: I run [business type]. Average order is [$X], gross margin is [Y%], and customers buy about
[Z times per year]. I'm considering a [points / tier / membership / surprise-and-delight / community]
program offering [reward].

Role: Act as a skeptical small-business finance advisor with loyalty program experience.

Ask: Check whether this program is likely to pay off, list the risks, and suggest two lower-cost
alternatives.

Format: A break-even calculation shown step by step, a risk list of up to five items, and a two-row
alternatives table.

Tighten: Use only my numbers. Label any assumption. Tell me plainly if I shouldn't run a program at
all.
```

REFERRAL PROGRAMS

Referral Programs

Most businesses get referrals by accident. A referral program makes them happen on purpose.

Design: five decisions

1. Who to ask. Start with customers who are clearly happy: repeat buyers, people who've praised you, people who've already referred someone. Partners are a second group. More on them below. (This is for referrals only. Review requests go to every customer. See The rules, below.)

2. When to ask. Ask at a high point, such as right after a great result, a finished project or a thank-you from the customer. Don't ask in the first email after the sale, before they've gotten any value.

3. What to offer. Match the reward to your price point and margin. A café might offer a free drink. A home-service company might offer a service credit. Some customers don't want a reward at all. They want to help a friend. Give them an easy way to do that.

4. Two-sided rewards. Reward both the referrer and the new customer. "Give $50, get $50" feels like a favor to a friend, not a sales pitch. It also gives the new customer a reason to act now.

5. Tracking. Give each referrer a unique code or link. Ask every new customer "How did you hear about us?" and record the answer in your CRM. You can't thank people, or measure the program, if you can't see who referred whom.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

A person sends it."

The rules

Referral rewards are allowed. Mixing them with reviews is where businesses get in trouble.

- **Don't tie referral rewards to reviews.** The FTC's rule on consumer reviews, announced in August 2024, bans incentives conditioned on reviews expressing a particular sentiment. Google's policy goes further. It prohibits offering incentives "in exchange for posting any review," and bans selectively soliciting positive reviews. Keep your referral program and your review requests completely separate. Local SEO and Reviews (Ch 8) covers the review rules in full, including FTC enforcement.
- **Disclose when customers promote you publicly.** If a customer posts about you on social media and gets a reward for it, the FTC's Endorsement Guides apply. The FTC's FAQ says to tell customers in advance that they should disclose what they received. A clear "#ad" or "I get a credit if you sign up" works. Burying it in a comment doesn't.
- **Texting referral invites needs consent** from the person receiving them. Don't load a customer's contact list into your texting tool. See "Marketing Within the Rules" (Ch 23).
- **Check your industry.** Some regulated fields, such as healthcare, legal, real estate and financial services, limit referral payments. "Marketing Within the Rules" (Ch 23) lists what to check before you launch.

PRO TIP

Always say thank you for a referral, even if the referred person doesn't buy. A handwritten note to someone who sent you a lead gets you the next one.

Partner referrals

Some of your best referrals come from businesses that serve your customers before or after you do. A bookkeeper refers clients to a tax preparer. A wedding venue refers clients to a florist. Partner referrals work in any business type, and they matter most for low-repeat businesses.

For Wild West Custom Pools (planned, illustrative), natural partners include landscape designers, outdoor-kitchen builders, home builders and realtors working with luxury buyers in the Austin metro. The planned approach is personal: a lunch, a tour of a finished project and a simple way to send introductions. Any referral fees would need to be checked against Texas rules for each partner's profession before launch.

PARTNER TYPE	WHAT THEY GET	WHAT YOU GIVE	HOW YOU TRACK
[Business that serves customers before you]	☐	☐	[Code, link or intro email]
[Business that serves customers after you]	☐	☐	☐
[Business with the same customer, different need]	☐	☐	☐

↓ Referral Program Planner and Partner Tracker

AI TIP

Design your referral program

```
Context: I run [business type] in [location]. Average sale is [$X] with [Y%] margin. Customers buy
[often / rarely]. My happiest customers are [describe]. Possible partners: [list].

Role: Act as a referral marketing strategist who knows FTC endorsement rules and Google's review
policy.

Ask: Design a simple two-sided customer referral program and a partner referral approach, including
when to ask, the reward, tracking and the thank-you step.

Format: A one-page plan with headings, a reward table showing cost per referred customer, and three
short referral-ask messages (email, in person, text).

Tighten: Keep referral rewards fully separate from review requests. Include disclosure language for
customers who post publicly. Flag any part that may need legal review in my industry. Plain language,
no hype.
```

Have a person review the plan before launch. If you're in a regulated industry, have your attorney review the rewards.

MEASURING RETENTION

Measuring Retention

You can't improve what you don't measure. These six numbers tell you whether customers are staying, spending and talking. They plug into the dashboard you build in Measurement (Ch 19).

METRIC	SIMPLE FORMULA	GOOD FOR	WHERE TO FIND THE DATA
Repeat purchase rate	Customers with 2+ purchases ÷ total customers, over a set period	Repeat businesses	POS, e-commerce platform, CRM

METRIC	SIMPLE FORMULA	GOOD FOR	WHERE TO FIND THE DATA
Churn rate	Customers lost in period ÷ customers at start of period	Subscriptions, retainers, memberships	Billing system, CRM
Customer lifetime value (CLV)	Average order value × purchases per year × years as a customer × gross margin	All businesses	Accounting, POS, CRM
Net Promoter Score (NPS)	% promoters (9–10) minus % detractors (0–6)	Tracking sentiment over time	Survey tool, email platform
Referral rate	New customers from referrals ÷ total new customers	All; most important for low-repeat businesses	"How did you hear about us?" field in CRM; referral codes
Review rate	New reviews ÷ completed jobs or orders, over a set period	Local and service businesses	Google Business Profile, review platforms, job records

A CLV example

A salon customer spends $60 a visit, comes 8 times a year, stays about 4 years and the salon keeps a 50% gross margin.

$60 × 8 × 4 × 50% = **$960 in gross profit over the customer's life.**

That number tells you what a customer is worth. It also tells you what you can afford to spend to win one, or to win one back. If your paid media cost per new customer is $150 and CLV is $960, you have room. If CLV is $200, you don't.

For a low-repeat business, CLV should include referral value. One pool customer who refers one more client over a few years has doubled their value to the business. Track it.

NPS and its limits

NPS is useful, but it is a single question. Know the limits:

- It tells you how people feel, not why. Always add one open question: "What's the main reason for your score?"
- Small samples swing wildly. With 20 responses, two people can move your score by 10 points.
- Watch the trend, not one result.
- **Never use NPS to decide who gets a review request.** Sending only promoters to Google is selective solicitation, which Google's policy bans. Ask every customer for an honest review. Use NPS to find and fix problems with detractors.

PRO TIP

Pick two retention numbers and review them monthly. A repeat business should watch repeat purchase rate and CLV. A low-repeat business should watch referral rate and review rate. Add more only once those two are a habit.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Repeat rate, CLV, referral rate, review rate.

Retention Metrics and CLV Calculator

RETENTION QUESTIONS

Retention Questions

Answer these with your own numbers and your own customers. The templates are a structure, not a strategy.

1. Is yours a repeat-purchase business or a low-repeat business? What does that mean for where you focus: retention, referrals or both?

2. What happens today in the first 30 days after someone buys from you? List every touchpoint.

3. When does a customer first get real value from what you sell? When will you check in?

4. What are your top three at-risk signals? How will you spot them?

5. What is your win-back plan for customers who have gone quiet? Who makes the call or sends the message?

6. What is your estimated customer lifetime value? Show the formula with your numbers.

7. Does a loyalty program make sense for you? If yes, which type? If no, what will you do instead?

8. Who are your five best referral sources today, including customers and partners? How will you thank each one this month?

9. What referral reward will you offer? How will you track it? How will you keep it separate from review requests?

10. How will you use paid media for retention (customer-list audiences, exclusions, lookalikes)? Which two retention metrics will you report monthly in your Measurement (Ch 19) dashboard?

AI TIP

Turn your answers into a 90-day retention and referral plan

```
Context: Here are my answers to the Retention Questions, with personal and customer details removed:
[paste answers 1–10]. My team is [size and roles] and my monthly budget for this work is [$X].

Role: Act as an experienced agency strategist who builds practical retention and referral plans for
small businesses.

Ask: Build a 90-day plan that sets up my post-sale sequence, at-risk and win-back process, loyalty
decision, referral program and two monthly metrics.

Format: Three 30-day phases, each with a task table (task, owner, channel, due week, success measure),
then a one-paragraph summary I can share with my team.

Tighten: Use only my inputs and mark any assumption with [ASSUMPTION]. Keep referral rewards separate
from reviews. Flag any text-message step that needs consent. Put paid media steps in their own rows.
Keep it realistic for a team of my size.
```

You think, AI drafts, you decide. Review the plan with the people who will do the work. Change what doesn't fit. Then put the first week's tasks on the calendar.

↓ 90-Day Retention and Referral Plan template

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MEASURE

Do you know what's working?

In this chapter »

Measure what matters. Then decide what to do next.

— **THE FOUR PILLARS OF MEASUREMENT**
What to measure, and why

— **ATTRIBUTION**
Which touchpoints deserve credit?

— **DASHBOARDS AND REPORTING**
Only useful if someone makes a decision

— **WHO DOES THE WORK**
The measurement resource checklist

— **YOUR MEASUREMENT PLAN**
Answer the questions with your team

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
5 AI Tips, from choosing your KPIs to writing your monthly report

MEASUREMENT AND ANALYTICS

Measurement and Analytics

Every chapter in this book ends with ways to measure results. This chapter brings them together. Measurement is how you know whether your transformation is working, where to spend more, what to stop and what to try next.

Within the data is the answer to the question, "What do we do next?"

Most small businesses don't have a data problem. They have plenty of data, spread across Google Analytics, Search Console, ad platforms, email tools, social accounts, the CRM and the sales team's memory. What's missing is a clear set of goals, a few measures that match them and a regular habit of looking at them together and deciding what to do.

What AI changed

You can ask your data questions in plain language. Analytics and ad platforms now include AI assistants that answer questions like "Which channel brought the most leads last month?" and surface unusual changes on their own. Google introduced Ask Advisor in May 2026, an AI agent that works across Google Ads, Google Analytics and its other marketing tools (Google, 2026).

Analysis that needed a data scientist doesn't anymore. Spotting trends, forecasting and grouping customers by behavior used to need specialists and expensive software. AI tools can now do a first pass on an exported report in minutes.

More of the journey happens where you can't see it. Buyers research in AI answers, private messages, podcasts and conversations with friends. None of that shows up in your analytics. A buyer who asks ChatGPT for a recommendation and then types your name into Google looks like "direct" or "branded search" traffic. That makes asking customers how they found you more important than ever.

One caution: AI tools will confidently analyze numbers they misread, and sometimes invent numbers that aren't in your data. Always check AI-generated figures against the source report before you share them or make a decision. Give AI the data, ask it to show its work, and treat its conclusions as a draft for a person to verify.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

"What you can see vs. A bridge between them labeled "How did you hear about us?"

THE FOUR PILLARS OF MEASUREMENT

The Four Pillars of Measurement

The first edition named four pillars. They still hold up.

1. Set clear objectives and the right metrics. Start with the goals from your strategy (Chapter 2) and your KPIs (Chapter 1). For each goal, choose the few measures that show progress. If a number won't change a decision, don't report it.

2. Collect and connect your data. Your data lives in many places: Google Analytics, Search Console, ad platforms, social accounts, your email tool and your CRM. Connect them so you can follow a buyer from first visit to sale. At minimum, make sure every lead in your CRM records where it came from, and every sale records which lead it came from.

3. Analyze it, with AI's help. The first edition called this "advanced analytics": forecasting, finding patterns and visualizing data. AI now makes all three practical for a small team. Export a report, ask AI what changed and why, check its answer against the data, and put the result in a simple chart.

4. Build a data-driven culture. Tools don't change decisions. People do. Share results openly with marketing, sales and leadership. Celebrate learning from tests that failed, not just ones that worked. Make "What does the data say?" a normal question in every meeting.

PRO TIP

Set clear goals and KPIs for every campaign before it starts. Make them specific, measurable, attainable, relevant and time-bound (SMART). Without them, you can't tell success from noise.

PRO TIP

Use simple visuals. Charts, graphs and dashboards make trends and patterns easier to see, and they make your findings easier to explain to people who don't live in the data.

The KPIs that matter, discipline by discipline

Here are the measures from Chapters 6 through 16 in one place. Don't track all of them. Pick one or two for each discipline you're actively working on.

DISCIPLINE	KEY MEASURES	CHAPTER
Strategy	Progress on your one-year goals; revenue and leads from marketing	1, 2
Content	Engaged visits, conversions from content, content that gets cited or linked	9, 10
SEO and AI search	Impressions, clicks and position for priority searches; AI mentions and citations	6, 7
Paid media	Cost per lead, cost per sale, return on ad spend, lead quality	12
Social media	Engagement rate, clicks to site, leads from social	13
Email and marketing automation	Click and reply rates, MQL to SQL rate, revenue from nurtured leads	16

DISCIPLINE	KEY MEASURES	CHAPTER
Video	Play rate, average percent watched, conversions after viewing	11
Website and conversion optimization	Conversion rate by page and source, form completion rate, page speed	14
Local SEO and reviews	Google Business Profile calls and directions, review count and rating	8
Analytics	Share of leads with a known source; time from data to decision	19

And across all of them, the business numbers that matter most:

- **Cost per acquisition (CPA):** what it costs to win a customer.
- **Average order or project value (AOV):** what a typical sale is worth.
- **Customer lifetime value (LTV):** what a customer is worth over the whole relationship.
- **Return on ad spend (ROAS) and return on marketing investment:** what you get back for what you spend.

AI TIP

Choose your KPIs

```
Context: Our one-year goals are [goals from Chapter 2]. We're actively working on these disciplines:
[list]. Our tools are [Google Analytics, Search Console, ad platforms, email tool, CRM].

Role: Act as a marketing analytics consultant for a small business.

Ask: Recommend the KPIs we should track, with no more than two per discipline, plus the business
numbers that tie them to revenue.

Format: A table: goal, discipline, KPI, where to find it, target for the next 90 days, and who owns
it.

Tighten: Only recommend KPIs we can actually measure with our tools. No vanity metrics. Leave targets
blank where we need our own baseline first.
```

ATTRIBUTION

Attribution: Which Touchpoints Deserve Credit?

Buyers rarely take a straight line to a sale. The Customer Journey (2019) used this example from Google: a customer finds your site by clicking an ad. A week later, she comes back from a social post. The same day, she clicks through from your email. A few hours later, she comes back directly and buys. Which of those deserves credit for the sale?

Attribution is the practice of assigning value to the touchpoints that led to a sale. It answers the question every budget meeting asks: where should we spend more, and what should we stop?

Attribution helps you:

- Find spending that isn't paying off
- Find channels and keywords that deserve more investment
- Make the case to leadership for the tactics that drive sales

Attribution in Google Analytics today

The 2019 book described several attribution models: first click, last click, linear and others. Google Analytics 4 has simplified this. It retired the first-click, linear, time decay and position-based models in November 2023. Today it offers data-driven attribution (the default, which uses your own data to share credit across touchpoints) and two last-click options (Loves Data, 2025).

For most small businesses, that's fine. Use data-driven attribution, make sure your conversions are set up correctly (Chapter 14), and link Google Analytics to Search Console and Google Ads so the data connects.

What the software can't see

Attribution software only credits what it can track: clicks on your ads, visits to your site, emails opened. It can't see a recommendation from a friend, a Reddit thread, a podcast, an AI answer or a profile on a review site. For many small businesses, those are where the decision gets made. Add three simple tools:

- **Ask every lead.** Add "How did you hear about us?" to every form and every first call, as an open text box rather than a drop-down. Record the answers in your CRM. Self-reported answers aren't perfect, but they reveal the channels software misses.
- **Pause and compare.** To see whether a channel really drives sales, pause it for a few weeks in one area or time period and watch total leads, not just that channel's leads. Chapter 12 shows this test for brand search ads.
- **Model the mix when you're bigger.** Marketing mix models use statistics to estimate how each channel, including offline ones like radio and direct mail, contributes to sales over time, without tracking individuals. They need a couple of years of weekly data and some analytics skill. Google made its own model, Meridian, free and open source to all marketers in January 2025 (Google, 2025).

PRO TIP

Traditional media isn't dead, and digital didn't kill it. Radio didn't kill print, and TV didn't kill radio. Connect your offline channels to your data with unique web addresses, QR codes and call tracking (Chapter 12), and measure them alongside everything else.

Example: what the software missed at Wild West Custom Pools

In Chapter 4, Dan's latest lead looked at his Better Business Bureau profile first, then visited the new website. Google Analytics would record that visit as a referral from the BBB site, or as direct traffic, depending on how the buyer got there. It can't record why the buyer trusted Dan enough to keep looking. We know the full story only because Dan knows his buyer, and it shows that a profile most owners wouldn't call marketing is doing real work. That's the case for asking every lead how they found you.

AI TIP

Make sense of "How did you hear about us?"

```
Context: Here are the answers to "How did you hear about us?" from our last [number] leads, with
whether each became a customer and the sale value: [paste, with names removed]. Our analytics shows
these channels for the same period: [paste channel report].

Role: Act as a marketing analyst.

Ask: Group the answers into channels, compare them with what our analytics shows, and tell us which
channels may be getting too much or too little credit.

Format: (1) A table: channel, leads (self-reported), leads (analytics), customers, revenue. (2) The
three biggest differences and what might explain them. (3) One budget change to consider.

Tighten: Use only our data. Note when numbers are too small to rely on. Don't merge answers that might
be different channels.
```

Where we'll ask "How did you hear about us?" and where we'll record the answers.

DASHBOARDS AND REPORTING

Dashboards and Reporting

A dashboard is only useful if someone looks at it and makes a decision. Keep it short and set a rhythm.

HOW OFTEN	WHAT TO LOOK AT	WHO	THE DECISION
Weekly (15 minutes)	Leads, ad spend, broken forms or tracking, anything unusual	Marketing owner	Fix problems now
Monthly (1 hour)	KPIs by discipline, cost per lead, lead quality from sales, top and bottom pages	Marketing and sales	Shift budget and effort
Quarterly (half day)	Progress on goals, attribution, what worked, what didn't	Leadership, marketing, sales	Reset priorities (the quarterly business review in Chapter 1)

Put your dashboard in one place everyone can see. Free tools like Google's Looker Studio can pull Google Analytics, Search Console and Google Ads into one view. Many CRMs and email tools have dashboards built in.

PRO TIP

Report decisions, not just numbers. Every report should end with "What we'll do next." If the report doesn't change anything, either the report or the strategy needs work.

To see a scorecard that measures a whole transformation at three points (savings at 180 days, results at 12 months and return on investment at 24 months), read Loren's case study at the end of Chapter 21, "The Competition Was Eating Their Lunch."

AI TIP

Write your monthly marketing report

```
Context: Here are this month's and last month's numbers for our KPIs: [paste]. Changes we made this month: [list]. Our goals for the quarter are [goals].

Role: Act as a marketing analyst writing for a busy owner.

Ask: Write our monthly marketing report.

Format: (1) Three headlines: what improved, what got worse, what surprised us. (2) A short table of KPIs vs. target. (3) What we'll do next month, in three bullets.

Tighten: Under 300 words. Use only my numbers and show the math for any percentages. Say when a change is too small to mean anything.
```

AI TIP

Find what changed and why

```
Context: Attached is our [Google Analytics/ad platform/CRM] export for the last [period], compared
with the period before: [attach]. Something changed: [describe, e.g., leads dropped 30%].

Role: Act as a data analyst.

Ask: Find the most likely explanations for the change, using only the data.

Format: (1) What changed, with the numbers. (2) Three possible explanations ranked by the evidence for
each. (3) What else we should check to confirm.

Tighten: Separate what the data shows from what you're inferring. If tracking might be broken, say so
first. Don't invent numbers.
```

WHO DOES THE WORK

Who Does the Work: Measurement Resource Checklist

In = in-house · **Out** = outsourced: agency, freelancer or partner · **Gap** = no one covers it yet

DELIVERABLE	IN	OUT	OWNER
Goals and KPIs for each discipline	☐	☐	
Google Analytics and Search Console set up, linked and tested	☐	☐	
Conversion tracking (forms, calls, purchases)	☐	☐	
Lead source recorded in the CRM, including "How did you hear about us?"	☐	☐	
Dashboard	☐	☐	
Monthly report and quarterly review	☐	☐	
Attribution review and tests	☐	☐	

The top three roles on your analytics team

- **Data analyst.** Collects, cleans and analyzes data from your tools, finds trends and turns them into recommendations.

- **Digital marketing strategist.** Knows the business goals and the marketing landscape, uses the analysis to decide what to change and holds each discipline to its KPIs.
- **Data engineer or technical specialist.** Sets up and maintains tracking, connections between tools and the dashboard. In a small business, this is often a part-time contractor or your web developer.

In a small business, one person may do all three with AI's help and an outside specialist for setup. What matters is that someone owns the numbers.

Who owns our data, our dashboard and our monthly report.

YOUR MEASUREMENT PLAN

Your Measurement Plan

Answer these questions with your team. Then use the AI TIP at the end to turn your answers into a 90-day measurement plan.

Which KPIs will we track to measure whether our digital marketing strategy is working?

What is our average order or project value, and how can we increase it?

What is our cost per acquisition for each customer, and how can we reduce it?

What is the lifetime value of our customers, and how can we increase it through retention, repeat business and referrals?

What is our return on ad spend, and how can we improve it?

Which small actions ("micro-conversions") should we track to understand how buyers move toward a sale?

Are our tools connected so we can follow a lead from first visit to sale? What's missing?

How will we give credit to the channels that lead to a sale, including the ones our analytics can't see?

What will we review weekly, monthly and quarterly, and who will be in the room?

How will we use AI to analyze our data, and how will we check its work?

AI TIP

Turn your answers into a 90-day measurement plan

```
Context: Here are our answers to the measurement questions: [paste answers]. Our tools are [list]. Our goals for the year are [goals].

Role: Act as a marketing analytics consultant building a plan for a small team.

Ask: Turn our answers into a 90-day measurement plan.

Format: (1) A one-paragraph summary. (2) Tracking fixes and connections to make in the first month. (3) Our KPI list with owners. (4) The dashboard and reporting rhythm. (5) The first attribution test to run.

Tighten: Start with the gaps that hide the most revenue. Keep it realistic for our team. Mark any assumption so we can check it.
```

↓ Measurement plan template

SOURCES

Sources

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PRIORITIES

What comes first?

In this chapter »

Score every idea. Do the best ones first.

— RANKED SCORING
More ideas than time? Score them

— HOW TO DO THE EXERCISE
Start with your goals, then score every tactic

— YOUR RANKED PRIORITIES
Turn the scores into decisions

— AI IN THIS CHAPTER
3 AI Tips, including a first-pass score and a second opinion

RANKED SCORING

Ranked Scoring: Prioritize Your Action Items

By now you have more ideas than time. Every chapter added tactics: new pages, ad campaigns, videos, email workflows, tests and AI tools. You can't do them all at once, and you shouldn't try.

A ranked scoring exercise helps you decide what to do first. You score each tactic against the same criteria, weight the criteria by what matters most to your business, and let the math rank the list. Then your team reviews the ranking and makes the final call.

If everything is a priority, nothing is.

It works because it turns opinions into a shared conversation. Instead of the loudest voice winning, everyone argues about the scores, and the scores are visible. It also forces trade-offs into the open: a tactic with big potential that's expensive and risky may rank below a smaller, faster win.

What AI changed

More tactics to choose from. AI made many tactics faster and cheaper, so your list is longer than it used to be. That makes ranking more important.

AI can do the first pass. Give AI your goals, your list and your criteria, and it can draft scores with its reasoning in minutes. That's a useful starting point and a good way to spot tactics you've overrated.

AI tactics need scoring too. Adding an AI tool or an AI agent to a workflow is a tactic like any other. Score it on the same criteria, including cost, risk and the effort it takes your team to learn it.

One caution: AI doesn't know your team, your customers or your cash flow. It will score confidently anyway. Use its scores as a draft to argue with, never as the answer. The team scores, and the team decides.

HOW TO DO THE EXERCISE

How to Do the Exercise

1. **Start with your goals.** Bring the one-year goals from your strategy (Chapter 2). Every tactic is scored on how well it serves them.
2. **List your tactics.** Pull them from the plans you built in each chapter. Write each one as a specific action: "Launch Google Search ads for our top service" rather than "paid media." Include AI tactics.
3. **Choose your criteria.** Use the six from the first edition, or adapt them. Three measure benefit: revenue growth, strategic value and customer value. Three measure cost: money, risk and effort.
4. **Weight the criteria.** Give each a percentage, so the six add up to 100%. If cash is tight, weight cost higher. If growth is the goal, weight revenue higher.
5. **Score each tactic from 1 to 5 on each criterion.** For benefits, 5 means the biggest benefit. For costs, 5 means the lowest cost, lowest risk or least effort, so a high score is always good.

6 **Calculate the weighted score.** Multiply each score by its weight, add them up and divide by 5. The result is a score out of 100. The companion workbook does the math.

7 **Rank the list and talk about it.** The ranking is a starting point. Your team may know about a risk or a dependency the numbers don't show. Move items if there's a good reason, and write the reason down.

8 **Turn the top of the list into an action plan.** For the top five, name an owner, a start date, the resources needed and the measure of success. That's the input for your transformation plan in Chapter 21.

PRO TIP

Define your criteria before you start. Agree on what "revenue growth" or "high risk" means for your business, so everyone scores the same way.

PRO TIP

Involve key people from across the business, and use a neutral facilitator. Sales, operations, finance and customer service all see risks and opportunities marketing doesn't. But setting priorities can be hard: people may hold on to the budgets, projects and areas they own, and a leader who runs the session can't easily stay neutral. This is one of the moments where an outsider can help (see Decide who runs the room, Chapter 1). A neutral facilitator keeps the discussion fair and moving, and lets everyone, including the boss, take part as a participant.

PRO TIP

Use weights to show what matters. If cost is your biggest constraint this year, weight it more heavily than ease of implementation. Revisit the weights each year as your business changes.

Worked example

Here's how the math works, using sample scores for a fictional local service business. Weights: revenue growth 25%, strategic value 15%, customer value 15%, cost 20%, risk 15%, effort 10%.

TACTIC	REVENUE (25%)	STRATEGIC (15%)	CUSTOMER (15%)	COST (20%)	RISK (15%)	EFFORT (10%)	WEIGHTED SCORE	RANK
Complete Google Business Profile and ask for reviews	4	4	4	5	5	4	87	1
Build an email nurture workflow	4	4	4	4	4	3	78	2
Launch a short FAQ video series	3	4	4	3	4	2	67	3

TACTIC	REVENUE (25%)	STRATEGIC (15%)	CUSTOMER (15%)	COST (20%)	RISK (15%)	EFFORT (10%)	WEIGHTED SCORE	RANK
Launch Google Search ads	5	3	3	2	3	3	66	4
Add an AI chat assistant to the website	2	3	2	4	2	3	53	5

The math for the first row: (4 × 25 + 4 × 15 + 4 × 15 + 5 × 20 + 5 × 15 + 4 × 10) ÷ 5 = 435 ÷ 5 = 87.

Notice what happened. Search ads have the highest revenue potential, but their cost pulls them down to fourth. The team might still move them up if they need leads fast and have the budget. That's exactly the conversation the exercise is meant to start.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

The ranked list as five horizontal bars, longest at top.

Our criteria and weights (must add up to 100%).

Our scoring matrix: up to 15 tactics, scored 1 to 5 on each criterion.

AI TIP

Build your tactic list from the field guide

```
Context: Here are the plans and answers we wrote in each chapter of this field guide: [paste the key answers or 90-day plans]. Our one-year goals are [goals].

Role: Act as a marketing strategist helping a small team prioritize.

Ask: Turn our plans into a single list of specific tactics, removing duplicates and combining items that belong together.

Format: A numbered list of up to 20 tactics, each written as a specific action, with the discipline it belongs to and the goal it serves.

Tighten: Don't add tactics we didn't mention. Flag any tactic that doesn't connect to a goal.
```

AI TIP

Get a first-pass score, and a second opinion

```
Context: Our goals are [goals]. Our criteria and weights are [criteria and weights]. Our tactic list is [list]. What we know about our budget, team and customers: [describe].

Role: Act as a skeptical advisor who has seen many small businesses overcommit.

Ask: Score each tactic from 1 to 5 on each criterion (5 is always best), explain each score in one line, and then challenge our three highest-ranked tactics.

Format: (1) A scoring table with reasons. (2) For our top three: the strongest argument against each one.

Tighten: Base scores on what I told you. Mark any score that's a guess. This is a draft for our team to debate, not a decision.
```

AI TIP

Turn the ranking into an action plan

```
Context: Here is our final ranked list of tactics, with weighted scores: [paste]. Our team and budget: [describe].

Role: Act as a project manager for a small marketing team.

Ask: Turn the top five tactics into an action plan for the next two quarters.

Format: A table: tactic, owner, start date, first three steps, resources needed, success measure, review date.

Tighten: Don't schedule more than our team can do at once; stagger start dates if needed. Mark dependencies between tactics.
```

YOUR RANKED PRIORITIES

Your Ranked Priorities

Answer these questions with your team after you've completed the scoring matrix.

Who took part in the exercise, and who facilitated it?

Which criteria and weights did we use, and why?

What are our top five tactics, and what is each one's weighted score?

Did we move any tactic up or down from its score? What was the reason?

Which high-scoring tactics depend on something else being done first?

What are we deliberately not doing this year, and when will we revisit it?

Who owns each of the top five, and when does each one start?

When will we repeat this exercise? (We recommend at least once a year, and at every quarterly review if things change quickly.)

YOUR TURN

The answers to these questions, with your ranked list, are the starting point for Chapter 21, where you'll turn them into a transformation plan across the six stages.

TRANSFORM

Is your plan ready to run?

In this chapter »

Put it all together in a plan your team can run.

— PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER
Everything you built, in one plan

— THE TRANSFORMATION MATRIX
Every tactic by journey stage

— EFFORT VS. IMPACT
Do the high-impact, low-effort work first

— YOUR SIX-STAGE ROADMAP
Place each tactic on the timeline

— YOUR TRANSFORMATION PLAN
Answer the questions with your team

— AI IN THIS CHAPTER
4 AI Tips, including pressure-testing your plan and writing your one-page transformation plan

Transformation: Putting It All Together

You've done the audits and assessments, mapped the journey, answered the questions and filled in the forms. You have a strategy, a set of plans for each discipline and a ranked list of priorities. Now it's time to turn all of it into one plan your team can carry out.

Strategy is what you do with your head. Tactics are what you do with your hands.

This chapter uses four tools, in order:

1. **The transformation matrix** places your tactics on the customer journey, so you can see where you're strong and where the gaps are.
2. **The effort vs. impact grid** shows which tactics to do now, which to plan for and which to drop.
3. **The six stages** from Chapter 1 sequence the work across six quarters.
4. **The Three Horizons** keep part of your effort on the future, not just this quarter.

Bring your ranked list from Chapter 20. Everything here builds on it.

What AI changed

AI belongs in the plan, not beside it. In the first edition, technology was a list of tools. Now every stage of the transformation has an AI layer: AI drafts the content, analyzes the data, personalizes the email and runs much of the ad buying. Your plan should say where AI helps in each stage, and who checks its work.

AI fluency is a milestone. Chapter 3 introduced the AI fluency ladder: Level 1, not started; Level 2, experimenting; Level 3, using AI regularly; Level 4, AI integrated into your workflows. Reaching Level 4 is the goal of this book. Build it into your plan the same way you'd build in a new website or a new channel.

AI agents come after Level 4. AI agents are tools that carry out multi-step tasks on their own, such as researching, drafting, posting or updating records. They're powerful, and they're arriving fast. But they only work well for teams that already use AI every day, with clear processes, good data and people who review the output. Put agents in your later stages, not your first.

One caution: It's tempting to let AI write the whole plan. It will produce something that looks complete and confident. Use the AI TIPs in this chapter to draft and pressure-test your plan, but the decisions, the priorities and the commitments must come from your team. A plan nobody helped write is a plan nobody follows.

The Transformation Matrix

The matrix shows every tactic you're using or planning, arranged by the stage of the customer journey it serves (Chapter 5). When it's done, you can see at a glance where you're investing and where buyers are falling through the gaps.

Tactics by journey stage

Use these lists for ideas. They're not a checklist; no business needs all of them.

STAGE	MARKETING TACTICS	WHERE AI HELPS
Awareness	SEO and AI search content, social media content, video, paid search and social ads, display and video ads, guest articles and PR, podcasts, influencer partnerships, local listings and Google Business Profile	Drafting and repurposing content; finding questions buyers ask; building ad variations
Consideration	Hub and spoke content, comparison and "best of" pages, webinars, interactive tools and quizzes, retargeting ads, lead nurture emails, case studies, FAQ pages, social engagement	Personalizing emails; summarizing reviews; drafting comparison pages
Decision	Pricing pages, optimized landing pages, clear calls to action, reviews and testimonials, demos and walk-through videos, live chat, offers, fast follow-up and sales handoff (Chapter 16)	Scoring leads; answering common questions; preparing sales for calls
Retention	Onboarding resources, thank-you and check-in emails, newsletters, customer support, training, loyalty and VIP programs, upsell and cross-sell, renewal reminders	Answering support questions; flagging customers at risk; personalizing offers
Advocacy	Review requests, referral programs, customer stories, user-generated content, community building, customer events, surveys	Drafting review requests and timing them so every customer is asked (never only the happy ones); turning feedback into themes; spotting happy customers for referrals and case studies

The whiteboard exercise

The first edition's best advice still works: do this on a whiteboard, with sticky notes, as a team.

1. Draw five columns, one for each journey stage.
2. Write one tactic per sticky note, using a different color for each type: one color for tactics you're doing now, one for new tactics from your ranked list, one for AI-powered tactics and one for tactics you plan to stop.
3. Place every note in the column it serves.
4. Step back. Which columns are crowded? Which are empty? As Chapter 5 noted, many businesses are heavy in Awareness and light in Retention and Advocacy.
5. Group, prioritize and assign. Every note that stays on the board gets an owner and a deadline.

Take a photo when you're done. It's the visual version of your plan.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

The transformation matrix: five columns (Awareness, Consideration, Decision, Retention, Advocacy) with sample sticky notes in four colors.

↓ Transformation matrix

Our matrix: the tactics in each stage, marked as current, new, AI or stop.

EFFORT VS. IMPACT

Effort vs. Impact

The effort vs. impact grid sorts your tactics by two questions: How much will this move revenue? How much time, money and skill will it take? Place each tactic from your matrix in one of four boxes.

	LOW EFFORT	HIGH EFFORT
High impact	**Quick wins.** Do these first.	**Transformational.** Plan and resource these next.
Low impact	**Momentum.** Fit these in to keep the team moving.	**Derailers.** Avoid or postpone.

Quick wins have high impact and need little effort. They're the low-hanging fruit that builds momentum and proves the plan is working. Examples:

- Compress oversized images to speed up key pages (Chapter 14)
- Fix broken forms and add clear calls to action to landing pages
- Complete your Google Business Profile and start asking for reviews

- Set up a simple automated thank-you and follow-up email for new leads (Chapter 16)

Transformational tactics have high impact but need significant effort and resources. They change how you market for years. Examples:

- Build a content strategy around your buyers' questions (Chapters 7 and 9)
- Redesign your website for speed, clarity and conversion
- Launch paid search and social campaigns with proper tracking (Chapter 12)
- Integrate AI into your team's daily workflows (reaching Level 4 on the AI fluency ladder)

Momentum tactics have low impact but need little effort. They keep the team engaged and the channels active. Examples:

- Share relevant content on social media
- Post timely updates on a trending topic in your industry
- Run a short customer survey

Derailers have low impact and need significant effort. They drain resources and distract the team. Examples:

- Building a mobile app when your buyers are happy with your website
- Launching a podcast without a clear strategy, audience or purpose
- Adding an AI chatbot or AI agent that doesn't match what customers need, or that your team isn't ready to manage

PRO TIP

Focus on quick wins and transformational tactics. They deliver the most impact for the effort. Momentum tactics are useful to keep the team motivated, but they shouldn't crowd out the high-impact work. Derailers should be dropped or postponed.

PRO TIP

Consider resources and time, not just difficulty. Some tactics are easy but take a long time to pay off. Some need outside help, such as an agency, a freelancer or a new hire. Be honest about what your team can do.

If you completed the ranked scoring exercise in Chapter 20, the grid should mostly agree with it. Your highest-ranked tactics will usually be quick wins or transformational. Where the two disagree, talk about why.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

The effort vs. An arrow labeled "Start here" points to Quick Wins.

Our quick wins, transformational tactics, momentum tactics and derailers.

YOUR SIX-STAGE ROADMAP

Your Six-Stage Roadmap

Chapter 1 laid out the six stages of a transformation. Now place your tactics in them. Quick wins usually go in the first two stages. Transformational tactics start early but take several stages to pay off. Don't put every discipline in every stage; put each one where it matters most.

STAGE	FOCUS	AI FLUENCY MILESTONE	OUR TOP TACTICS
Q1: Foundation	Audience, goals, brand, website, tracking, Google Business Profile	AI ground rules agreed; team experimenting (Level 2)	
Q2: Deployment	Launch paid media, email workflows and conversion fixes; track everything	A shared prompt library in use	
Q3: Traction	Reviews and referrals, video, content that builds on what's working	AI used every week in core tasks (Level 3)	
Q4: Acceleration	Marketing automation, retargeting, scaling the channels that pay	AI built into documented workflows (Level 4)	
Q5: Expansion	New audiences, platforms and markets	Test one AI agent on a well-defined task, with review	
Q6 and beyond	Quarterly reviews, refresh, repeat the ranked scoring	Review AI tools and policies each quarter	

PRO TIP

Hold a quarterly business review at the end of each stage (Chapter 1). Ask three questions: What's working? What isn't? What do we change? Don't move to the next stage until the milestone for this one is in sight. Once a year, have someone from outside the team run the review (see Decide who runs the room, Chapter 1). A fresh set of eyes asks the questions the team has stopped asking.

The Three Horizons challenge

Most plans focus on this month, this quarter and this year. The Three Horizons model pushes the view further out, so you build tomorrow's growth while you run today's business. It comes from *The Alchemy of Growth* (Baghai, Coley and White, 1999) and was made widely known by McKinsey (McKinsey, 2009). The key idea: work on all three horizons at the same time, not one after another.

- **Horizon 1: improve the core.** Make your current products, services and marketing perform better. This is where quick wins live: conversion fixes, email workflows, better ad targeting.

- **Horizon 2: build what's emerging.** Develop new services, channels and partnerships that are starting to show promise, such as a new service line, a content program in a new topic or a partnership that opens a new market.
- **Horizon 3: explore the future.** Experiment with ideas that could become new businesses: a new market, a new kind of offer or a new way of using AI to serve customers.

A common rule of thumb is to put about 70% of your effort into Horizon 1, 20% into Horizon 2 and 10% into Horizon 3. Adjust it to your situation. A business that's struggling may need to put nearly everything into Horizon 1 for a while.

Speed changed the model. The horizons were first drawn as distances in time, with Horizon 3 ideas taking years to pay off. In 2019, Steve Blank argued in *Harvard Business Review* that this no longer holds: new ideas built on existing technology can reach the market as fast as improvements to the core (Blank, 2019). AI has sped things up again. Treat the horizons as types of work, not dates on a calendar, and revisit them at every quarterly review.

AI now has three horizons of its own. In 2026, McKinsey published a separate three-horizon model for AI transformation (De Smet et al., 2026):

- **Enablement.** People use general AI tools to help with parts of their existing jobs, such as drafting and summarizing.
- **Automation.** AI runs and improves whole workflows that cross teams.
- **Reinvention.** Roles, workflows and the operating model are redesigned around what AI makes possible.

Each builds on the one before. In McKinsey's survey of 750 employees, collected in early 2026, nearly 90% of organizations were still in the first two. Of the leaders whose organizations had reached reinvention, 48% reported measurable value from AI, compared with 24% in automation and 13% in enablement. And leaders were 5.3 times more likely to report that value when they had redesigned their workflows instead of leaving them as they were.

Putting the two together

Use the growth horizons to decide *what* to build. Use the AI horizons to decide *how* AI changes the work. They don't line up one to one, but they fit together like this:

HORIZON	WHAT YOU BUILD	AI'S ROLE
1: Improve the core	Better performance from today's products, services and marketing	Enablement, then automation: AI speeds up today's tasks, then runs the workflows that keep the core going
2: Build what's emerging	New services, channels and partnerships	Build AI in from day one, instead of adding it later
3: Explore the future	New markets, offers and business models	Reinvention: test offers, roles and ways of working that only make sense with AI

The AI horizons also match the AI fluency ladder from Chapter 3. Enablement is Levels 2 and 3. Automation is Level 4, the goal of this book. Reinvention, including AI agents, comes after Level 4.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Headline: "Build tomorrow while you run today."

PRO TIP

Get buy-in from everyone who matters before you start. Each horizon needs a named owner, and the plan needs regular review as conditions change. The model is meant to change as you learn.

PRO TIP

Don't skip the workflow redesign. Giving everyone an AI tool is the easy part, and it's where most businesses stop. The value shows up when you change how the work gets done.

People make the plan work

Every transformation is a change for the people doing the work, and AI makes that change feel bigger. Chapter 1 drew on Loren Ankarlo's change-management work to show how to lead it. Three of those principles matter most now, as the plan becomes real:

- **Tell the truth about roles.** Say clearly how jobs will change, which tasks AI will take over and what new skills people will need.
- **Invest in people alongside tools.** For every dollar on new software, budget time and training to help people use it well (Chapter 3).
- **Involve the team.** The people closest to the work know where AI will help and where it won't. Ask them, and let them help shape the plan.

A plan can be right on paper and still fail with people. Loren's case study in Chapter 22, "The Suits Are Stealing Our Freedom!", shows a company with a sound SWOT and a justified investment that nearly faced a walkout, and how listening, WIIFM and an employee design team turned resistance into ownership. Read it before you announce your plan.

Example: Wild West Custom Pools' roadmap

Here's how Wild West Custom Pools' work so far maps to the six stages, using what's in Chapters 4, 5, 12 and 13:

- **Foundation (June 2026):** competitor research, a new boutique position, a SWOT analysis and a new website with published prices, an FAQ and a tested contact form (Chapter 4). Search Console set up to track results.
- **Deployment (next):** the advertising playbook: Google Business Profile first, then Google Search ads as the main paid channel, then Facebook and Instagram (Chapter 12).
- **Traction (planned):** turn each finished pool into proof: photos, a project story, a review request and a referral in the neighborhood (Chapters 5 and 13).
- **Later stages:** Nextdoor once finished pools are visible in neighborhoods, and a nurture sequence for buyers who aren't ready this season (Chapters 12 and 16).

It's a small business with a small budget, and the plan reflects that: one stage at a time, with the most money going where buyers already search.

AI TIP

Place your tactics on the grid and the roadmap

Context: Here is our ranked list of tactics from the scoring exercise: **[paste]**. Our team: **[size and skills]**. Our budget: **[amount]**. Our AI fluency level today: **[1–4]**.

Role: Act as a digital marketing strategist building a transformation roadmap.

Ask: Place each tactic on the effort vs. impact grid, then sequence the tactics into the six stages (Foundation, Deployment, Traction, Acceleration, Expansion, Ongoing).

Format: (1) A grid table: tactic, impact (high/low), effort (high/low), box. (2) A roadmap table: stage, three to five tactics, AI fluency milestone, owner.

Tighten: Be realistic about what a team our size can do each quarter. Put quick wins first. Flag any derailers and any tactic that depends on another.

AI TIP

Pressure-test your plan

Context: Here is our draft transformation plan: **[paste]**. Our goals are **[goals]**. Our biggest constraints are **[time, budget, skills]**.

Role: Act as an experienced, skeptical advisor reviewing a small business's marketing plan.

Ask: Find the weaknesses before we commit.

Format: (1) The three biggest risks, with why. (2) Anything we're trying to do too soon. (3) Anything important that's missing. (4) The one change that would most improve the plan.

Tighten: Be direct. Base your review on what's in the plan and our constraints, not generic advice.

AI TIP

Plan your Three Horizons

```
Context: Our business today: [products/services, customers, markets]. Our one-year goals: [goals].
Ideas we've talked about but not acted on: [list]. How we use AI today: [tools, tasks and any
automated workflows]. Our AI fluency level: [1–4].

Role: Act as a growth strategist who uses the Three Horizons of growth and McKinsey's three horizons
of AI transformation (enablement, automation, reinvention).

Ask: Sort our current work and ideas into Horizons 1, 2 and 3. For each initiative, say what role AI
should play: enablement, automation or reinvention. Then suggest how to split our effort.

Format: A table for each horizon: initiative, why it belongs there, AI's role, first step, owner, and
what success looks like in 12 months. Then a suggested effort split with reasons, and the one workflow
we should redesign first.

Tighten: Keep Horizon 3 ideas grounded in our customers and strengths. Don't suggest reinvention or AI
agents for work we haven't automated yet. Mark any idea that needs more research before we commit.
```

CASE STUDY

The Competition Was Eating Their Lunch

How shared vision and two employee design teams renewed a national health and beauty company.

A composite example based on Loren Ankarlo's consulting engagements. The company isn't named, and the figures are illustrative. The original work came before today's AI tools; the AI uses shown are how the same teams would apply AI now.

A strategy becomes real when employees understand the vision, help design the future and see what they gain from it.

The business case

A Midwestern health and beauty supplies wholesaler and retailer had built an $800 million business across stores, wholesale accounts and online stores nationwide. Its product knowledge and customer relationships were still valuable. Its competitive position was slipping.

Leadership had underestimated how fast buying was moving online. Competitors were winning customers with personalized offers, coordinated inventory and faster responses. The company had online stores, but its departments weren't connected well enough to give customers one experience.

The competition was eating their lunch.

A SWOT analysis, a competitive assessment and an end-to-end operational review set two priorities: grow profitable digital sales, and cut the cost of delivering them.

Leadership sets the vision

Top leadership set the destination: **become the health and beauty supplier customers can confidently choose wherever they shop, supported by connected operations, capable employees and a more efficient business.**

Executives explained why it mattered and what success would look like, and made three commitments:

- Connect stores, wholesale and online channels around customer needs.
- Equip employees with useful technology, training and real influence.
- Cut waste while protecting service, quality and the capacity to grow.

Then they formed two employee design teams: one for digital growth, one for cost improvement. The vision supplied the direction. The teams would turn it into decisions.



Every area had a voice

Both teams were cross-functional and multilevel, with members from every area of the company: frontline employees, supervisors, specialists, managers and executives, from manufacturing and private label to stores, distribution, finance, HR and IT. They refined the vision, translated it into improvements for each work area, gathered feedback and showed people how their input shaped decisions.

Naïve listening

The consultants started with naïve listening in stores, distribution centers, production areas and offices. They asked where people lost time, what frustrated customers, which processes created waste and what employees feared losing. Questions like these came up (reconstructed from the engagement):

- "Will new technology replace my job?"
- "Does cost reduction mean fewer people doing more work?"
- "Will online growth weaken our stores?"
- "Who will train us?"
- "If we help improve results, how will employees benefit?"

Employees described scattered information, repeated data entry, unreliable inventory visibility and poorly coordinated promotions. Past initiatives had added work without taking any away. These findings became design requirements: the transformation had to make everyday work easier while it improved financial performance.

Team one: digital growth

Working with the digital marketing department, the first team mapped the customer journey from discovery through purchase, delivery, service and repeat business, and designed a stronger online experience. Today, the same team would also decide where AI fits, area by area:

COMPANY AREA	HOW AI HELPS TODAY
Manufacturing and private label	Demand forecasting, scheduling and quality analysis
Purchasing and merchandising	Replenishment, supplier comparisons, assortment planning and slow-moving inventory
Wholesale sales	Account priorities, proposal drafts, reorder reminders and product recommendations
Retail stores	Inventory visibility, product location, and coordinated pickup and returns
Digital marketing and e-commerce	Search, product content, segmented campaigns, personalization and conversion analysis
Customer service	Drafted responses, order status, knowledge lookup and escalation
Distribution and logistics	Fulfillment planning, picking priorities, freight comparisons and error reduction

COMPANY AREA	HOW AI HELPS TODAY
Accounting and finance	Invoice matching, reconciliation, exception detection and forecasting
HR and training	Onboarding, role-specific learning and training support
IT and administration	Integration, data quality, access controls and evaluating AI tools

Employees test every pilot and judge whether a tool actually removes an obstacle. People stay in charge of product claims, financial exceptions, sensitive information and any decision with real consequences.

Team two: cut costs 7% in 180 days

The second team got a measurable assignment: cut company-wide operating expenses by 7% within 180 days while protecting quality, customer service and growth. Every department took part, but not every department had to cut the same amount.

The team looked at purchasing, freight, inventory handling, subscriptions, payment processing, marketing spend, rework, duplicate administration and avoidable overtime. Employees proposed practical fixes: combine overlapping services, renegotiate vendor contracts, reduce fulfillment errors, end duplicate data entry, improve replenishment and redirect marketing spend that wasn't working. Finance separated recurring savings from deferred spending, one-time cuts and costs that simply moved elsewhere.

By day 180, the team had cut annualized operating expenses by 8.4% against the agreed baseline: $61.8 million a year in recurring savings on a $736 million cost base. That's the yearly rate of savings, not cash already saved in six months.

WIIFM and one shared vision

Leadership and both teams kept answering WIIFM: What's in it for me? Better inventory information meant fewer frustrated customers. Better scheduling meant fewer disruptions. Automation removed repetitive work. Stronger performance supported development, recognition and job security. People also needed clear expectations about training, workload, accountability and how gains would be shared.

The two teams reviewed decisions together. Savings that hurt fulfillment would damage online growth. Online sales with thin margins would hurt profit. Technology that moved errors into another department would erase its own benefit. Through the first 180 days and beyond, small-group conversations, demonstrations, training and progress reports kept the vision visible. Pilots that worked expanded; the rest were fixed or dropped.

The results

CASE STUDY · THE RESULTS

Growth and savings, together.

Baseline to 12 months, and the return on the investment over 24 months.

Annual revenue $800M → **$896M** Up 12%	Annual online revenue $120M → **$192M** Up 60%; 15.0% → 21.4% of revenue	EBITDA margin 8.0% → **13.4%** EBITDA $64M → $120M
Operating expenses at day 180 −7% target → **−8.4%** $61.8M a year in recurring savings	Employee satisfaction (1–5) 3.8 → **4.7** Five-point scale	Annual employee retention 82% → **91%** Up 9 points

Return on investment, 24 months



($72M benefits − $24M investment) ÷ $24M investment = **200% net return**

Composite example based on Loren Ankarlo's consulting engagements. Figures are illustrative.

Cost savings are measured at day 180, business and employee results at 12 months, and the return on investment at 24 months. Online growth is included in total revenue. Finance validated what the transformation could take credit for, to avoid counting the same gain twice. Revenue growth shows the business expanded; it isn't proof of market share. Satisfaction and retention comparisons need the same measurement method before and after.

Five principles

1. **Leadership must set a clear vision.** Employees need to understand the destination, its purpose and the commitments behind it.
2. **Representative teams make the vision practical.** People from every area and level bring knowledge no plan has.
3. **Listening improves the design.** Employee concerns reveal barriers and perceived losses that strategy alone misses.
4. **Growth and savings need coordination.** Efficiency must protect what brings in profitable business.
5. **Participation and visible gains build ownership.** People commit when their input shapes decisions and improves their daily work.

Employees committed because the exchange was credible: better work, real influence, new skills and a stronger future.

What this looks like with 15 people

You don't need an $800 million company to use this. The same steps work at small-business scale:

- **Write the vision in one sentence,** and repeat it at every team meeting.
- **Make everyone the design team,** or one person from each role: sales, service, operations and the owner.
- **Run two short tracks:** one growth project (often your website, Google Business Profile or follow-up) and one savings project (a tool you pay for twice, ad spend that doesn't convert, work done by hand).
- **Set a 90-day target for each,** with a number, and check it at your quarterly business review.
- **Listen first.** Ask each person where they lose time and what they'd hate to lose.
- **Share the gains** in a way that fits your size: time back, training, a bonus or recognition.

AI TIP

Find growth and savings opportunities, area by area

```
Context: Our business: [what we sell, to whom, where]. Our team and roles: [list]. Our one-year goal: [goal]. Where people say they lose time: [list from your listening sessions]. Our biggest costs: [list the largest expense lines].

Role: Act as an operations and marketing consultant to a small business.

Ask: Find our best opportunities to grow and to save, area by area.

Format: (1) A table: area, one growth opportunity, one savings opportunity, where AI could help, and what a person must still check. (2) The three opportunities to try first in the next 90 days, each with a measurable target. (3) Any idea that could save money but hurt customers or growth.

Tighten: Use only what we've told you, and mark your assumptions. Flag any idea that changes someone's job, so we can talk with them first.
```

Your case study questions

Can everyone on our team explain our vision, and what it means for their work?

Does our design team include every area and every level?

What do our people fear losing, and what real gains can we deliver?

Which digital and AI uses would solve a problem we can measure?

Could any of our planned savings weaken service or profitable growth?

How will we verify the results, and how will we share the benefits?

Can our people answer "Why?", "Why here?", "Why us?" and "Why now?" for this change?

↓ Transformation Revealed: Loren Ankarlo's case studies

YOUR TRANSFORMATION PLAN

Your Transformation Plan

Answer these questions with your team. Your answers, the matrix, the grid and the roadmap together are your transformation plan.

What are our goals for the next 18 months, and how will we know we've reached them?

Where are the gaps in our transformation matrix, and which stage of the journey needs the most attention?

What are our quick wins, and when will each one be done?

Which transformational tactics will we commit to, and what resources do they need?

What are we going to stop doing?

What goes in each of the six stages, and what milestone tells us we're ready for the next one?

Where is our team on the AI fluency ladder today, and when will we reach Level 4?

How will we split our effort across the Three Horizons, and what role will AI play in each: enablement, automation or reinvention?

How will we involve our team and support them through the change?

Who owns the plan, and when is our first quarterly review?

AI TIP

Write your one-page transformation plan

```
Context: Here are our answers to the transformation questions, our ranked tactics, our effort vs.
impact grid and our six-stage roadmap: [paste]. Our strategy on a page from Chapter 2: [paste].

Role: Act as a strategy consultant writing a one-page plan for a leadership team.

Ask: Turn all of this into a one-page transformation plan.

Format: Headline goal; three to five priorities; the six stages with two or three tactics each; the AI
fluency milestones; owners; how we'll measure progress; the date of our first quarterly review.

Tighten: One page. Plain words. Use only what we decided. Flag anything that's missing an owner or a
date.
```

↓ Transformation plan template

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- Wild West Custom Pools: Chapters 4, 5, 12 and 13 of this book.

LEADERSHIP

Is your team ready for change?

In this chapter »

Lead your people through the change.

— **LEADING THROUGH THE AI REVOLUTION**
Tell the truth about roles and invest in people

— **CHANGE STYLES**
A self-assessment for how each person handles change

— **MEETINGS AND TEAMS**
Run effective meetings and build the team you need

— **BIAS, CONFLICT AND A CASE STUDY**
The Johari Window, conflict resolution and "The suits are stealing our freedom!"

— **YOUR AI USAGE POLICY AND AI AGENTS**
Set the rules, then take the next step

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
12 AI Tips, from planning your listening sessions to drafting your AI usage policy

BUSINESS TOOLS

Business Tools: Leading People Through Change

The previous chapters of this book helped you plan the marketing. This chapter helps you lead the people who do it. A transformation changes how people work, who they work with and what's expected of them. AI makes that change bigger and faster. If the team doesn't come along, the plan stays on paper.

Tools don't transform a business. People do.

The business communication tools in this chapter come from Loren Ankarlo. Loren has spent more than 35 years as a speaker, consultant, corporate trainer and business owner, working with Fortune 50 companies, all five branches of the U.S. military, government agencies, nonprofits and small businesses. He is the author of *Implementing Self-Directed Work Teams*, *The Nine Traits of Highly Successful Work Teams* and *Managing Today's Nonprofit Organization*. His focus is teams and change, which is exactly where most transformations get stuck.

This chapter gives you seven tools:

1. **The change styles self-assessment** shows how each person on your team reacts to change.
2. **Effective meetings** and an agenda template keep the work moving without wasting hours.
3. **The four stages of team development** tell you what your team needs from you right now.
4. **The Johari Window** helps people see their blind spots and share what's hidden.
5. **Conflict resolution** gives your team a common way to work through disagreements.
6. **A case study from Loren's consulting work** shows how one company turned "The suits are stealing our freedom!" into shared ownership, and what it means for your AI rollout.
7. **An AI usage policy** sets the rules for how your team uses AI.
8. **A guide to AI agents** helps you decide when you're ready for them.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Seven rounded cards, one per tool, each with a two- or three-word label.

What AI changed

AI is a change your team is already going through. In Microsoft and LinkedIn's 2024 Work Trend Index, 75% of knowledge workers said they use generative AI at work, and 78% of those AI users said they bring their own AI tools rather than waiting for their employer to provide them. Whether you planned it or not, AI is already in your team's work. The question is whether it's managed.

Change equals loss to most people. Loren's point from Chapter 1 matters more with AI than with any other change. People worry about their jobs, their skills and their status. Some will say so. Many won't, and it shows up as resistance, missed deadlines or quiet pushback. The answer is the same three principles: tell the truth about roles, invest in people alongside tools and involve the team in the decisions.

AI can help you prepare. It can't lead. Throughout this chapter, the AI TIPs help you plan meetings, prepare for hard conversations, draft policies and think through team problems. The leading still happens person to person.

One caution: Don't let AI do the talking in moments that matter. A performance conversation, a conflict or an announcement about roles that reads like it was written by AI tells people you didn't care enough to write it yourself. Use AI to prepare, then say it in your own words.

Leading Through the AI Revolution

[Draft for Loren's review, Oct 6.]

A transformation rises or falls on how its leaders behave, not on the plan. Your team watches what you do far more closely than what you say. Six habits make the difference.

Lead from the point of friction

Leaders often ask whether they should lead from the front or step back and let the team execute. Leif Babin, a former Navy SEAL officer and co-author of *Extreme Ownership* with Jocko Willink, says it's the wrong question. The best leaders don't hold a fixed position. They move to where the team needs them most.

[QUOTE A] "A fixed position is a vulnerable position, on the battlefield and in business." — Leif Babin

In a transformation, both fixed positions fail. A leader who stays at the back, reading reports, makes decisions about the plan instead of what's happening. A leader who stays at the front, doing everything personally, becomes the bottleneck. The team waits for direction instead of moving.

So watch for friction, and go there. In a marketing transformation, it usually shows up in a few places:

- **A stalled initiative.** The new website, the first ad campaign or the AI pilot that was due a month ago.
- **A silo.** Sales and marketing, or two people who should be talking and aren't.
- **A process that's breaking.** Approvals that take a week, or content that sits waiting for review.
- **Fear.** The person who has gone quiet since the AI announcement.

Move close enough to understand the problem. Then clear the obstacle, make the decision the team is waiting on or find the resource they need. Don't take over. Help them get moving, then step back.

> **PRO TIP**
>
> At every QBR, ask one question: where is our point of friction right now? Then decide who, starting with you, will go there this quarter.

Where is our biggest point of friction right now, and what will I do about it this month? [FORM FIELD]

Own the outcome

The core idea of *Extreme Ownership* is that leaders own everything in their world, including the failures. When something goes wrong, the first question is "What could I have done differently?" not "Who dropped the ball?"

In a transformation, that means if the team didn't adopt the new process, ask whether you explained it, trained people on it and gave them the time to do it. This is how you get through the blame phase in From Frustration to Success (Field Guide 01) instead of getting stuck there.

Go first with AI

If you ask the team to use AI but never use it yourself, you're sending a mixed message. Use it where they can see it. Share a prompt that worked and one that didn't. Follow the same ground rules you set for everyone: a person approves everything public, and no customer data goes into unapproved tools.

Tell the truth, early

People can handle hard news. What they can't handle is silence, or a promise that turns out to be false. Announce the change before the work starts, answer the hard questions in an FAQ, and when you haven't decided something, say so and say when you will. The AI TIP for the announcement and FAQ is in Field Guide 01.

Help people see what change means for them

Loren Ankarlo puts it this way: "Change equals loss. People resist loss. Demonstrate WIIFM equals gain."

Change often feels like loss. People may resist because they fear losing something they value: security, competence, status or control.

Address that reluctance by answering **WIIFM: "What's in it for me?"** Show the benefits from their point of view. Show how the change can solve their problems, support their goals or make their work easier, and acknowledge what they may lose.

Decide, then adjust

Waiting for perfect information stalls a team. Use the OODA loop (Field Guide 04): decide with what you know, set a date to review the decision, and adjust. A good decision made this week usually beats a perfect one made next quarter.

Protect the time

Learning new tools takes hours. If the calendar doesn't change, nothing changes. Block time for training and practice, and for every new task you add, take an old one away.

Your leadership rhythm

HOW OFTEN	WHAT TO DO
Weekly	Go to the point of friction for 15 minutes. Review one AI-assisted piece of work with the person who made it.
Monthly	Run an AI show-and-tell (Field Guide 03). Check the FAQ for new questions and answer them.

HOW OFTEN	WHAT TO DO
Quarterly	Hold the QBR. Name the next point of friction. Recognize the people who moved the work forward.

Leadership self-check

Rate yourself from 1 (rarely) to 5 (always). Then ask two people on your team to rate you too, and compare.

STATEMENT	RATING (1–5)
I know where the team is stuck right now.	
I help clear obstacles without taking over the work.	
When something goes wrong, I look at my part first.	
I use AI myself, and my team has seen me use it.	
I've told the team the truth about how roles will change.	
I make decisions on time, even without perfect information.	
I've protected time for the team to learn.	

PRO TIP

Your lowest score is your next leadership goal. Pick one habit, practice it for a quarter, then rate yourself again.

AI TIP

Find your point of friction

```
Context: Our transformation roadmap and where each initiative stands: [paste]. Last month's KPIs
against target: [paste]. Notes from team meetings, with names removed: [paste].

Role: Act as a chief of staff helping a leader decide where to spend their time.

Ask: Identify the three biggest points of friction in our transformation right now.

Format: A table: the friction point, the evidence, who is stuck, and what a leader could do this month
to help without taking over.

Tighten: Base it only on what I've given you. Flag where you'd need more information before acting.
```

Where do I need to lead differently this quarter, and what will I do about it? [FORM FIELD]

Change Styles Self-Assessment

People don't resist change in the same way, and they don't embrace it in the same way either. Some want to try every new tool the day it launches. Others want proof before they move. Neither is wrong. A team needs both, and a leader needs to know who is who.

This self-assessment helps each person find their preferred change style. There are no right or wrong answers. Answer based on how you behave at work, not how you think you should.

The five change styles

- **Radical:** embraces change and enjoys exploring new and untested ideas.
- **Progressive:** prefers early change, but adapts it and rolls it out in steps.
- **Pragmatic:** focuses on practical solutions with a clear purpose and clear benefits.
- **Conservative:** cautious about new ideas; prefers proven methods and tries new ones step by step.
- **Traditionalist:** values stability and established principles; prefers to keep what works.

Rate each statement

Rate each statement from 1 to 5: 1 = strongly disagree, 2 = disagree, 3 = neutral, 4 = agree, 5 = strongly agree.

#	STATEMENT	RATING (1–5)
1	When it comes to change, I engineer new ideas and enjoy exploring innovative approaches.	
2	I am open to testing new marketing strategies and techniques, even if they haven't been proven yet.	
3	I focus on practical solutions and prefer changes that have a clear purpose, a balanced approach and tangible benefits.	
4	I am generally cautious about new ideas, but I will try them one step at a time.	
5	I value stability and prefer to stick with time-tested, proven marketing strategies rather than experiment with new approaches.	
6	I like change and will help make it happen.	
7	I am always willing to adapt and learn new marketing tools and technologies to improve our team's performance.	
8	When our team faces a major change in its marketing approach, I analyze the practical pros and cons before I fully commit.	

#	STATEMENT	RATING (1–5)
9	I prefer gradual, proven, phased changes to sudden and disruptive ones.	
10	Our organization's structure and values are strong, and I prefer that our marketing follows our established principles.	

Score it

Each style has two statements. Add the two ratings for each style. Each style scores between 2 and 10.

CHANGE STYLE	STATEMENTS	YOUR SCORE (2–10)
Radical	1 + 6	
Progressive	2 + 7	
Pragmatic	3 + 8	
Conservative	4 + 9	
Traditionalist	5 + 10	

Your highest score is your home style. If two styles tie, you lean between them; adjacent styles (such as Progressive and Pragmatic) often go together. If your scores are close across the board, you're flexible and adapt your style to the situation.

- **Radical:** You enjoy new ideas, taking risks and challenging the status quo. You thrive where creativity and disruption are welcome. Watch for: starting more than the team can finish.
- **Progressive:** You value innovation but also think about practicality and benefits. You like to try new approaches early and roll them out in steps. Watch for: moving before others are ready.
- **Pragmatic:** You weigh the pros and cons before committing. You prefer changes with a clear purpose and a balanced approach. Watch for: waiting for more proof than the decision needs.
- **Conservative:** You're cautious about new ideas and prefer time-tested strategies. You'll change when there's strong evidence. Watch for: missing the window while others move.
- **Traditionalist:** You value structure, established principles and stability. You protect what already works. Watch for: resisting change that the business needs.

This is a snapshot, not a label. Change styles are complex and can shift with the situation. Use your result as a starting point for reflection and team discussion.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

A marker shows "Your home style."

↓ Change styles self-assessment

Use it with your team

Ask everyone on the team to take the assessment privately, then share their home style. Plot the team on the scale. Most teams find a mix, and that's healthy: Radicals and Progressives start things, Pragmatics make them work, and Conservatives and Traditionalists protect what already works.

The mix also tells you how AI will land. Radicals may already be using AI tools you don't know about. Traditionalists may be the most worried about what AI means for their role. Each style needs something different from you:

CHANGE STYLE	HOW THEY MAY REACT TO AI	WHAT HELPS
Radical	Already experimenting; may move faster than your rules	Clear ground rules; a role leading pilots and sharing what works
Progressive	Eager, but wants a plan	A phased rollout with early wins they can own
Pragmatic	"Show me what it saves"	Real before-and-after examples from your own work
Conservative	Cautious; wants proof it's safe	Small tests, the AI usage policy and time to learn
Traditionalist	Worried about quality, values and jobs	The truth about roles, a voice in the decisions and training

PRO TIP

Don't build an AI rollout around the Radicals alone. They'll love it, and everyone else will feel left behind. Pair a Radical with a Conservative on the first AI pilot. The Radical pushes it forward; the Conservative catches the risks. Both learn from each other.

AI TIP

Plan an AI rollout for your team's change styles

```
Context: We are bringing AI into our marketing team's daily work. Our team's change styles are: [list each role and home style, e.g., "content lead: Progressive"]. Our first AI uses will be: [tasks]. Concerns we've heard: [list].

Role: Act as a change-management advisor who helps small teams adopt new tools.

Ask: Help me plan how to introduce AI to this team so that every change style comes along.

Format: (1) A short rollout plan in three phases. (2) For each change style on our team: what they're likely to need, what to say and what to avoid. (3) Three questions to ask the team before we start.

Tighten: Plain language. No hype. Assume people are worried about their jobs, and address it directly. Don't promise anything about roles that we haven't decided.
```

My home change style, and what it means for how I lead change.

Our team's change styles mix, and how we'll use it in our AI rollout.

CONDUCTING EFFECTIVE MEETINGS

Conducting Effective Meetings

Most people have sat through a meeting where notes were taken and an hour was lost. A transformation adds meetings: planning sessions, reviews, workshops. Each one must earn its time. Loren's three-part method makes that happen: plan, do, review.

Part I: Plan

1. **Invite the right people, well in advance,** and confirm they're coming.
2. **Think about how people feel.** Change equals loss to most people. If this meeting is about change, some people will feel they're losing something, and they may act out without knowing why. Plan for it.
3. **Prepare the agenda** (template below) and send it ahead, with anything people should read first.
4. **Prepare the room or the video call.** Test the screen, the link and the tools before people arrive. Start on time.

Part II: Do

1. **Bond the team.** However well people know each other, today it's a new team with a new purpose. Introductions may be enough. If the group doesn't know each other well, use a short icebreaker. McGraw-Hill's *Games Trainers Play* series (Newstrom and Scannell) is one source.
2. **Define the purpose.** What specific result do you want by the end? For example: "Agree on our three priorities from the SWOT analysis." Write it where everyone can see it for the whole meeting.
3. **Assign three roles for this meeting.** Rotate them in future meetings.
   - **Facilitator:** keeps the discussion moving, gets everyone's input and stops anyone from dominating. The facilitator stays neutral, so it shouldn't be the subject expert.
   - **Notetaker:** takes notes where everyone can see and correct them in real time, then sends them to participants and stakeholders within 24 hours.
   - **Timekeeper:** tracks the time, calls out time for breaks and group work, and keeps the agenda moving.
4. **Conduct the meeting.**
5. **Summarize the results** with the notetaker: decisions, action items, owners and dates.

Part III: Review

1. **Assess the meeting.** Before people leave, ask: What went well? What should we change next time? The notetaker records it and brings it to the next meeting.
2. **Send the notes** to participants and stakeholders. Remove anything confidential first.
3. **Celebrate** when it's earned. All work and no play makes meetings no fun.

Meeting agenda template

ITEM	DETAILS
Meeting purpose (the result we want)	
Date and time	
Location (or video link and call-in details)	
Attendees	
Facilitator	
Timekeeper	
Notetaker	
Please read or review before the meeting	

ITEM	DETAILS
Please bring	
Old business (with time for each item)	
New business (with time for each item)	
Action items: what, who, by when	
Meeting review: what went well, what to change	

Meeting agenda template

PRO TIP

Start on time. Don't reward people who are late by giving them attention and repeating what they missed. It disrespects everyone who was on time.

PRO TIP

The meeting invitation should come from, or be endorsed by, someone with recognized authority. People show up for meetings their leaders care about.

PRO TIP

Keep regular meetings at a regular time and place. Hold the occasional creative workshop or celebration somewhere different. A new setting helps people think differently.

PRO TIP

The room matters. Good light, fresh air, working technology, light refreshments and no distractions.

AI in meetings

AI can take on much of the work around a meeting: drafting the agenda, transcribing the discussion, summarizing decisions and drafting the follow-up email. Video platforms such as Zoom, Microsoft Teams and Google Meet now offer built-in AI note-takers, and there are many standalone tools.

Used well, an AI note-taker frees the notetaker to listen and check the notes rather than type them. But the AI ground rules still apply:

- **Tell people, and get consent.** Announce that the meeting is being recorded or transcribed. Some U.S. states require everyone's consent to record a conversation. Check the rules where your attendees are.

- **Protect data.** Don't record client, financial or personnel discussions with a tool your organization hasn't approved (see the AI usage policy later in this chapter).
- **Verify before you send.** AI summaries can miss nuance, attribute a comment to the wrong person or state a maybe as a decision. The human notetaker reviews and corrects the notes before they go out.
- **People own the decisions.** AI can record and summarize. The team decides, and the action items have human owners.

One caution: Some people speak less freely when they know every word is being recorded. For sensitive conversations, such as conflict, feedback or anything about roles, turn the recorder off and take notes the traditional way.

AI TIP

Build a meeting agenda

```
Context: I'm planning a [length] meeting with [attendees and roles]. The purpose is [the result we want]. Background: [what's happened so far, any open issues or tensions].

Role: Act as an experienced meeting facilitator.

Ask: Draft an agenda that will get us to that result in the time we have.

Format: Use this structure: purpose; pre-reading; old business; new business; decisions needed; action items; meeting review. Give each item a time and an owner. Add two or three questions the facilitator can use to get everyone's input.

Tighten: Be realistic about time. Put decisions early, while people are fresh. Flag any item that should be its own meeting.
```

AI TIP

Turn meeting notes into action items

```
Context: Here are the notes or transcript from our meeting about [topic]: [paste]. Attendees: [names and roles].

Role: Act as the meeting notetaker.

Ask: Turn these notes into a clear summary I can send to the team.

Format: (1) Decisions made. (2) Action items in a table: task, owner, due date. (3) Open questions. (4) Feedback on the meeting itself.

Tighten: Use only what's in the notes. Don't turn a suggestion into a decision. If an action item has no owner or date, mark it [NEEDS OWNER] or [NEEDS DATE]. Leave out anything personal or confidential.
```

Our meeting ground rules, including how we will and won't use AI note-takers.

BUILDING AND LEADING YOUR TEAM

Building and Leading Your Team

Working as a team brings more ideas, more perspectives and better problem-solving than any one person can manage alone. But teams don't start out that way. They develop, and they go through predictable stages on the way.

Psychologist Bruce Tuckman described four stages of team development in 1965: Forming, Storming, Norming and Performing. In 1977, Tuckman and Mary Ann Jensen added a fifth, Adjourning, for when a team finishes its work and disbands. Loren uses the first four to show leaders what their team needs at each stage.

The four stages

STAGE	KEY MARKERS	HOW THE TEAM MAKES DECISIONS
Forming	Uncertainty, excitement, surface politeness, building trust, seeking direction, uneven commitment	Unsure; looks to the manager, the coach or the loudest voice
Storming	Confusion, conflict, wasted time, power struggles, resistance to change, lack of cohesion	By faction; some push their own way, some lobby, some go along too easily
Norming	Shared expectations, shared habits, effective meetings, clearer roles, agreed norms	Values different opinions and styles; understands compromise and moves toward consensus where it matters; may still ignore other departments
Performing	Efficient, effective, lateral thinking, mutual accountability; includes other departments and customers as part of the team	Picks the right decision method for the moment: trusts one member to decide quickly when that fits, reaches quick compromise often, takes time for true consensus when needed

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

One word under each: Direction, Vision, Challenge, Autonomy (what the team seeks).

What your team needs from you at each stage

At first, a manager leads the team with a clear vision, measurable objectives, defined boundaries and agreed rules of the road. The leader coaches the team through the conflict of Storming, assigning responsibilities at first for the team and later with the team. As the team develops, it works more across departments and becomes more self-managing around its vision, metrics and boundaries.

Forming: envisioning and managing. Goals are fuzzy, roles are unclear and boundaries are messy. People are polite on the surface, excited and afraid at the same time.

COACHING TIP: The team seeks direction. Don't do for the team what the team can do for itself. Set goals, roles and protocols (the rules of the road) with the team, not for the team.

Storming: building consensus and confronting conflict. Confusion, conflict, false starts, changes in who's on the team, power struggles, barriers between departments and passive resistance to direction, goals and roles.

COACHING TIP: The team seeks vision. Paint the picture of what the transformation will look like for your organization, at every opportunity. It gives the struggle meaning.

Norming: challenging processes and building relationships. The team settles down and builds trust, respect and good habits. Meetings work. People learn new skills, cross-train and think more broadly. Watch for an "us against them" attitude toward people outside the team.

COACHING TIP: The team seeks challenges. Challenge the team to challenge the process. Groups find new ways to do old things; real teams find new ways to do new things. Help break down the barriers between departments.

Performing: coaching and mentoring. The team reaches its goals and recognizes its members. Trust, respect, creative problem-solving and both compromise and true consensus. The team produces breakthroughs and revenue, and its celebrations get noticed.

COACHING TIP: The team seeks autonomy. Hold the team accountable to its metrics, budget, industry benchmarks and vision, and otherwise let it run.

AI resets the stages

Any big change can send a team back a stage, and AI is a big change. A Performing team that adds AI to its workflows may find itself Storming again: roles are less clear, some people move faster than others, and there are new arguments about quality and what "done" means.

That's normal. Name it for the team. Then do what works at each stage: set the AI ground rules and roles together (Forming), keep painting the picture of where you're going (Storming), build shared prompt libraries and habits (Norming) and hold the team to its metrics (Performing).

PRO TIP

When you add AI to a team's work, add it to the team's rules of the road too. Agree on what AI can draft, what people must check and who approves anything that goes public. Write it down. It turns a source of conflict into a shared norm.

AI TIP

Diagnose your team's stage

```
Context: Our marketing team has [number] people and has worked together for [time]. Here's what I'm seeing: [describe behavior in meetings, how decisions get made, conflicts, deadlines, how people talk about AI or other changes].

Role: Act as a team development coach who uses Tuckman's stages (Forming, Storming, Norming, Performing).

Ask: Help me understand which stage my team is in and what to do next.

Format: (1) The most likely stage, with the evidence from what I described. (2) What the team needs from me now. (3) Three specific actions for the next 30 days. (4) Signs that we're moving to the next stage.

Tighten: Base your answer on what I described, not on general advice. If the evidence points to more than one stage, say so. Ask me questions if you need more information.
```

Which stage is our team in now, and what does it need from its leader?

BIAS AND THE JOHARI WINDOW

Bias and the Johari Window

Everyone has biases, conscious and unconscious. Some things we're happy to talk about. Some things we keep to ourselves. And some things we do that we don't even notice, but everyone around us does: the messy desk, the disorganized files, the emails that leave people off, the habit of interrupting, the missed deadlines.

The Johari Window is a simple visual model for seeing these things. Psychologists Joseph Luft and Harrington Ingham created it in 1955 and named it by combining their first names. It works for individuals and for teams.

The four windows

	KNOWN TO ME	NOT KNOWN TO ME
Known to others	**Open:** what I and others both know about me	**Blind spot:** what others see but I don't
Not known to others	**Hidden:** what I know but keep to myself	**Unknown:** what no one knows yet

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

The Johari Window as four rounded squares in a 2×2 grid. Arrows show the Open window growing through feedback (into the Blind spot) and sharing (into the Hidden window).

The goal is to grow the Open window. Two things make it grow:

- **Feedback** from others shrinks your blind spot.
- **Sharing** with others shrinks your hidden area.

The Johari Window also gives a team a way to say up front what's not open for discussion, whether for personal or organizational reasons. At the start of a sensitive meeting, name the topics that are closed. It builds trust, because people know where the boundaries are.

PRO TIP

Feedback grows the Open window. Facilitators can use questions like these to help team members share more:

- What are your strongest skills, knowledge or areas of expertise for this team?
- Do you have hidden talents, skills or connections that could help the team?
- Where do you need support or development to thrive on this team?
- How would you describe your communication style?
- What's one thing you enjoy about teamwork, and one thing you don't?
- What would you like to learn during this project?
- Tell us about a successful project team you've been on that used your skills.

Case study: the Johari Window resolves team conflict

This is an illustrative scenario from Loren's work with teams. The details are general so that no one can be identified.

The situation. A diverse, cross-functional team has been meeting three times a week for two months. Its marketing objective is to increase revenue, expand into new markets and improve life for employees by launching new products and services. Chris, a dynamic account manager, is the team's biggest contributor to revenue. But his blind spots and hidden areas are causing friction: he's late, he misses commitments, he's disorganized and he takes on too much.

Chris's Open window. Everyone, including Chris, knows he's a strong revenue generator who creates a friendly atmosphere. He often brings treats and event tickets.

Chris's Blind spot. Chris doesn't see how much his disorganization disrupts the team. Bringing this into the open matters for his growth and for the team.

Chris's Hidden area. Chris struggles with time management, overcommits and can't finish his assignments on time. He keeps this to himself. Only he knows why, and sharing it could explain much of the friction.

What the team tried. The team discussed its rules of the road and team agreements. That helped a little, but tension kept building. The stakes were high: team members were committed to the organization's mission, and there were shared bonuses, advancement and leadership approval on the line.

Solutions using the Johari Window:

1. **Build awareness (Blind spot to Open).** For several weeks, end each team meeting with a "Do more, do less" round robin. First, each member gives feedback on the team as a whole. A few weeks later, each member gives feedback to each person individually. This brings Chris's blind spot into the open, and the team can help him become less disruptive.
2. **Build shared understanding (Hidden to Open).** Create psychological safety so Chris feels able to share what he's struggling with. For several weeks, end team meetings with a 10-minute open forum where the facilitator asks each member, "What can we as a team do to support you?" The key is targeted support for overcommitting, people-pleasing and time management.
3. **Balance the window.** Pair Chris with a teammate for 30 to 60 days, someone whose strengths complement his weaknesses. They do their assignments as a pair and hold each other accountable.

The result. With the team's support and Chris's willingness to engage, the Johari Window can lead to growth for Chris, better team dynamics and progress on the team's marketing objectives. Chris can become a better teammate, and the team a stronger one.

Johari Window for me or my team: what's in each of the four windows, and one step to grow the Open window.

↓ Johari Window worksheet

Where AI fits

AI can help you prepare for feedback: drafting round-robin questions, planning how to raise a sensitive topic or practicing what you'll say. It can't give the feedback for you, and it can't replace what your teammates see.

One caution: Don't paste named feedback about colleagues into an AI tool your organization hasn't approved. Personnel information is sensitive data. Describe the situation without names or identifying details, and keep the real conversation between people.

AI TIP

Prepare for a feedback conversation

```
Context: I need to give feedback to a team member. Without names: their role is [role]; their strengths are [strengths]; the behavior I need to address is [specific behavior and its effect on the team]; past attempts to address it: [what we've tried].

Role: Act as an experienced team coach who uses the Johari Window.

Ask: Help me prepare for this conversation so it grows trust instead of damaging it.

Format: (1) How to open the conversation. (2) How to describe the behavior and its impact, specifically and without judgment. (3) Two or three questions that invite them to share what's going on. (4) Ways the team could support them. (5) How to agree on next steps.

Tighten: Plain, warm language. Focus on behavior, not personality. Help me prepare. Don't write a script for me to read.
```

AI TIP

Plan a Johari Window session for your team

```
Context: Our team: [size, roles, how long we've worked together, stage of development]. Our challenge: [what's getting in the way, described without names].

Role: Act as a facilitator experienced with the Johari Window.

Ask: Design a session that helps the team grow its Open window.

Format: (1) A 45-minute agenda. (2) Ground rules, including topics that are closed for discussion. (3) Feedback questions for each part of the session. (4) Follow-up actions for the next four weeks.

Tighten: Build psychological safety first. Start with low-risk sharing before moving to individual feedback.
```

CONFLICT RESOLUTION

Conflict Resolution: Working Together in Harmony

Conflict is part of every transformation. People disagree about priorities, budgets, roles and, more and more, about AI: whether its work is good enough, who gets credit and whose job it changes. Handled well, conflict leads to better decisions and stronger relationships. Avoided, it festers.

- Conflict is inevitable.
- Most groups avoid it.
- When it's avoided, it festers.

- High-performing teams learn to resolve conflict cleanly.
- Learning to do that takes effort and persistence over time.
- Teams that learn it transform their organizations, have more fun and produce more revenue.

Five ways people handle conflict

Loren's conflict grid is adapted from the Thomas-Kilmann model, developed by Kenneth Thomas and Ralph Kilmann in the 1970s. Their model places five conflict-handling modes on two scales: assertiveness and cooperativeness. Loren calls the scales self-determined (pushing your own agenda) and compliant (going along with others' agendas).

MODE	OUTCOME	IN A PHRASE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Compete	Win/lose	"I'm right; you're wrong."	You pursue your own interests at the expense of others. I speak up; others don't get a chance.
Accommodate	Lose/win	"You're right; I'm wrong."	You set aside your own interests to satisfy others. I don't speak up; others walk over me.
Avoid	Lose/lose	"Nobody wins."	You sidestep the conflict, so the issue never gets dealt with. The lights are on, but nobody's home.
Compromise	Partial win for each	"Let's find the middle ground."	You look for an answer that partly satisfies everyone. Win a little, lose a little; it's fair and fast.
Collaborate	Win/win	"Everybody wins."	You work together to find an answer that fully satisfies everyone, even beyond the immediate team. It takes the most time and gives the best result.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

The conflict grid: vertical axis "Self-determined," horizontal axis "Compliant." Compete top left, Collaborate top right, Avoid bottom left, Accommodate bottom right, Compromise in the center.

Know your home base

The point isn't to change anyone's personality overnight. It's to become aware of your options when conflict comes up, and to be more open to feedback from your team.

- Each of us has a preferred mode, our home base, when conflict comes up.

- Every mode has its time and place. Compete when a fast decision is essential. Accommodate when the issue matters more to the other person. Avoid when the issue is trivial or emotions need time to cool. Compromise when time is short. Collaborate when the decision is important and the relationship matters.
- Any mode is the wrong one in the wrong situation.
- We can learn which mode fits which situation.
- Feedback from teammates helps. It moves what's in our blind spot and hidden area into the Open window (see the Johari Window above).

Conflict self-reflection

Rate how often you use each mode at work: 1 = rarely, 5 = almost always. Then note when it works for you and when it doesn't.

MODE	HOW OFTEN I USE IT (1–5)	WHEN IT WORKS FOR ME	WHEN IT DOESN'T
Compete			
Accommodate			
Avoid			
Compromise			
Collaborate			

Your highest rating is likely your home base. Ask a trusted teammate whether they see it the same way.

↓ Conflict self-reflection and conflict resolution template

Steps to address conflict

1. **Address the issue, without emotion.** Describe the problem, not the person.
2. **Listen to feedback, without emotion.** Let each person explain how they see it.
3. **Agree on the issue.** Do you all agree on what the problem is? If not, go back to step 1. If you still can't agree, take it to the next level of authority.
4. **Explore possible solutions.** Look for options that serve everyone's interests before you settle on one.
5. **Review and agree on an action plan:** what will change, who does what and when you'll check in.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

A flowchart: Address the issue → Listen to feedback → Agree on the issue? Yes → Explore solutions → Agree on an action plan.

PRO TIP

Most conflict on a team isn't about the issue people are arguing over. It's about something underneath: a loss of status, a fear about their role, a feeling of not being heard. Step 2 is where you find it. Don't rush it. If you're part of the conflict, or sides have already formed, bring in someone neutral to run the conversation. This is one of the moments where an outsider can help (see Decide who runs the room, Chapter 1). People will tell a neutral party things they won't say to each other.

AI TIP

Prepare for a conflict resolution session

```
Context: Two [or more] people on our team disagree about [issue]. Without names: [Person A's role and position], [Person B's role and position]. What's at stake: [deadlines, budget, relationships]. What's been tried: [list].

Role: Act as a neutral facilitator trained in the Thomas-Kilmann conflict modes.

Ask: Help me prepare to facilitate a conversation that resolves this.

Format: (1) The likely interests behind each position. (2) Which conflict mode each person seems to be using. (3) An agenda that follows these steps: address the issue, listen, agree on the issue, explore solutions, agree on an action plan. (4) Questions to ask at each step. (5) Three possible solutions that could serve both sides.

Tighten: Stay neutral. Don't decide who's right. Flag anything that should go to the next level of authority, such as HR or legal issues.
```

My home base for handling conflict, and one situation where a different mode would work better.

CASE STUDY

The Suits Are Stealing Our Freedom!

A new plant, a threatened walkout, and the lessons every AI rollout needs.

From Loren Ankarlo's change management consulting. The company isn't named.

Sometimes the greatest barrier to progress is not what people actually stand to lose, but what they believe they will lose.

The business case

A major Midwestern media conglomerate had done its homework. A SWOT analysis, a competitive assessment and an end-to-end operational plan all pointed the same way: its aging newspaper packaging and distribution facilities were becoming inefficient, costly and competitively vulnerable. Old equipment, too much work in progress, recurring downtime, poor material flow and safety concerns threatened long-term profitability.

The answer seemed simple: build a modern packaging and distribution center near the existing operation. It promised higher productivity, lower costs, better quality, safer conditions and more capacity.

A design-build architectural firm produced a $10,000 scale model, and leadership displayed it in the newspaper's lobby. To the executives, it meant progress. To the architects, innovation. To the financial planners, better performance and long-term viability.

To many employees, it meant a threat.

The crisis

As employees gathered around the model, the reaction wasn't excitement. It was resentment, suspicion and hostility. One accusation kept coming up: "The suits are stealing our freedom!"

What management saw as an extraordinary investment in employees' futures, employees saw as an assault on their way of life. Rumblings of organized resistance, and a potentially crippling walkout, began to surface.

Leadership had solved the engineering and financial problems. It hadn't solved the human problem.

Listen before you lead

Loren didn't start with presentations, directives or persuasion. He started with naïve listening: curiosity, with nothing to defend. He stood near the model listening to people's spontaneous reactions, and talked informally with employees in their actual work areas. The questions were open-ended:

- "What concerns you most about this new facility?"
- "What will you miss about the way things work today?"
- "What do you believe management doesn't understand?"
- "What freedoms or conveniences might disappear?"
- "How might this change affect your relationships with coworkers?"
- "What would make this new operation better for you personally?"
- "What would you need to see before you could support this project?"

The answers revealed what the operational analysis had missed. Employees weren't against modern equipment, safer work or higher productivity. They were afraid of losing control.

The old facility gave them familiar routines, established friendships, informal breaks, easy access to the parking lot and the freedom to move between work areas. Some of those informal practices included activities management might not have approved, including questionable substances and other behaviors in or around the parking lot. Appropriate or not, they had become part of the workplace's unwritten culture.

The new facility threatened all of it: restricted movement, tighter supervision, lost connections, new break patterns, higher production demands and possibly job losses. The model wasn't just a building. It symbolized the loss of autonomy.

People don't judge a change only by what the organization gains. They judge it by what they believe they personally stand to lose, and possibly gain.

From loss to exchange

The team changed the question. Not "How do we convince employees to accept the new facility?" but "How do we show that what employees gain is substantially greater than what they fear losing?"

That became a three-month vision-casting and engagement effort. Instead of executive announcements or mass meetings, the change team worked through small groups, existing work teams and conversations on the floor. The talk moved from corporate benefits to personal ones:

- **Greater financial security.** Better performance could help protect jobs and the company's future.
- **Greater earning potential.** Pay-for-performance opportunities could let employees share in the company's success.
- **Safer working conditions.** Modern equipment and better workflows could reduce injuries and hazards.
- **Less frustration.** Fewer breakdowns and less downtime.
- **A better work life.** Better layouts and material handling could make the work less physically and emotionally demanding.
- **A stronger future.** The investment showed the company meant to compete and grow, not slowly decline.

The change was no longer something being done to employees. It could be something accomplished with them, and ultimately for them.

WIIFM: What's in it for me?

Executives spoke in capital investment, throughput, margins and EBITDA. Employees thought about paychecks, freedom, daily frustrations, friendships, job security and quality of life. Neither view was wrong, but nothing would move until someone connected the two. So the team translated the business case:

- Not "The new plant will reduce downtime," but "How would your workday improve if you spent less time fighting broken equipment?"
- Not "The new operation will improve profitability," but "What would stronger earnings mean for job security, performance pay and the future of your team?"
- Not celebrating the architectural design, but asking "What should this facility include to make your working life better?"

These weren't rhetorical questions. They were invitations to take part. Fears were acknowledged, objections explored and rumors surfaced. The goal wasn't to silence resistance. It was to turn resistance into informed participation.

Employee ownership: the design team

Early in the project, leadership set up a cross-functional employee design team drawn from the work areas most affected. It wasn't a symbolic committee. Members worked with the architects, contractors, consultants and leadership, and spotted bottlenecks, workflow frustrations, equipment placement problems and safety issues that outside designers would have missed.

They also became trusted messengers. They shared updates with coworkers, gathered more feedback and showed people how their input was shaping the building. Employees were no longer future occupants of a building designed by strangers. They were co-creators of their own workplace. Participation created influence. Influence created credibility. Credibility built trust.

On groundbreaking day, members of the design team stood with the executives, architects and dignitaries, and appeared in the photos and videos shared across the company. The project no longer belonged only to "the suits."

The long year in between

Construction took about another year, and the gap between promise and reality is one of the riskiest times in any change. Leadership and the change team kept the vision alive with work-area conversations, project updates and steady reminders of what the new facility would mean for people. As the building rose, the future became something employees could see. The model that once stood for stolen freedom became a reminder of what they had built together.

The outcome

By opening day, the mood had changed. The project once greeted with accusations was now greeted with pride. The modernized operation improved efficiency and operating performance, contributing to stronger EBITDA, and employees benefited through performance-related pay. Workers saw their ideas in the finished facility, and gained a more modern workplace and renewed confidence in the company's future.

- **The company** gained better operating performance, stronger competitive capability and better financial prospects.
- **Employees** gained a voice, better working conditions, potential financial rewards and pride in a shared achievement.
- **The community** gained a more competitive, sustainable media company that could keep serving its market.

Eight principles of transformation

1. **Strategic logic doesn't automatically produce human acceptance.** A sound SWOT and a justified investment explain why change is needed. They don't explain why employees should embrace it.
2. **Resistance is information before it is opposition.** Objections reveal cultural, social, emotional and operational factors that formal planning misses.
3. **Perceived loss can outweigh better benefits.** People resist a better future when the transition threatens their autonomy, identity, relationships or security.
4. **Naïve listening reveals what executive presentations conceal.** The most valuable early step was discovery, not persuasion.

5. **WIIFM turns strategy into personal relevance.** People support change when they see how it affects their daily lives, pay and future.
6. **Participation creates ownership.** Meaningful involvement is more persuasive than ceremonial consultation.
7. **Reinforce the vision until the future becomes tangible.** It took months of credible communication, not one announcement.
8. **Shared gains make transformation last.** The strongest results come when company performance is visibly tied to employee well-being, recognition and opportunity.

Transformation succeeds not simply when people accept change, but when they begin to own it.

↓ The full Transformation Revealed case study

For a whole-company version of the same approach, with two employee design teams and a 180-day cost target, see Loren's second case study at the end of Chapter 21, "The Competition Was Eating Their Lunch."

Today it's "AI is stealing our jobs."

Swap the new plant for a new AI tool, and this story plays out in marketing teams today. Leadership sees speed and savings. The team hears "AI is coming for our jobs." The same principles apply:

- **Listen first.** Before you announce a tool, ask what people fear losing: their craft, their voice, their role or the parts of the work they enjoy.
- **Answer WIIFM truthfully.** Less busywork, faster first drafts, new skills. Don't promise what you can't keep about roles. See "Tell the truth, early," earlier in this chapter.
- **Build a design team.** Let the people who do the work choose the first AI workflows and help write your AI usage policy, later in this chapter.
- **Make progress visible.** Share early wins and hours saved at every QBR.
- **Share the gains.** Put time saved back into training and better work, and recognize the people who make it work.

AI TIP

Plan your listening sessions before an AI rollout

```
Context: We're introducing [AI tool or workflow] to [team or roles]. Our goal: [what we want it to do]. What we've heard so far: [concerns, questions, rumors].

Role: Act as a change management advisor who uses naïve listening.

Ask: Help me plan small-group listening sessions before we roll this out.

Format: (1) Eight open-ended questions, adapted to our team, about what people fear losing and what would make this better for them. (2) A WIIFM table: each group, what they may fear losing, what they could gain, and the proof we can show them. (3) Who should be on an employee design team, and which decisions they should own.

Tighten: Don't write answers to persuade people out of their objections. The goal is to understand first. Flag any promise about jobs or pay that leadership must approve before anyone says it out loud.
```

Your case study questions

Use Loren's questions for leadership before your next big change, AI or otherwise.

What are our people really afraid of losing? Beyond the stated objections, what freedoms, routines, relationships or sources of identity might this change threaten?

Are we listening to understand, or listening to rebut? How would our discovery change if we approached resistance with real curiosity?

Can every affected person answer WIIFM? Have we translated the financial, operational and strategic benefits into outcomes that matter to each group?

Who has a real voice in the design? Are the people doing the work shaping the future, or just being told about decisions already made?

What proof will people see, and when? What visible milestones and measurable improvements will show that our promises are becoming real?

How will we share the gains? How will people share, financially, professionally and emotionally, in what the change creates?

What would ignoring the human side cost us? How much productivity, trust, knowledge and money could we lose to resistance we could have avoided?

YOUR AI USAGE POLICY

Your AI Usage Policy

If most of your team is already using AI, and many are bringing their own tools, then you already have an AI policy. It's just unwritten, and everyone is following a different one. A written policy protects your customers, your data and your brand. It also protects your people: it tells them what's allowed, so they can use AI with confidence instead of in secret.

The policy doesn't need to be long. One or two pages is enough for most small businesses and teams. Build it on the five AI ground rules this book has used since Chapter 1:

1. **People approve everything public.**
2. **Verify facts.**

3 **Protect data.**

4 **Keep your voice.**

5 **Add what AI can't.**

AI usage policy template

Fill in each section. The example language is a starting point; change it to fit your business.

SECTION	WHAT TO DECIDE	EXAMPLE LANGUAGE	OUR POLICY
1. Purpose and scope	Why the policy exists and who it covers	"This policy covers everyone who creates work for [company], including employees, contractors and agencies."	
2. Approved tools	Which AI tools are approved, on which plans, and how to request a new one	"Use only the tools on the approved list, on company accounts. Ask [owner] before using a new tool for company work."	
3. Approved uses	What AI can help with	"Research, first drafts, outlines, summaries, data analysis, ad variations, image concepts and editing."	
4. Off-limits uses	What AI must not do	"No fake reviews or testimonials. No impersonating real people. No final decisions on hiring, pricing or personnel by AI alone."	
5. Data protection	What must never go into an AI tool, or only into approved tools	"Never enter passwords, payment details, customer personal information, personnel information or confidential client material into a tool that isn't approved for it."	
6. Review and approval	Who checks AI-assisted work before it goes out	"A person reviews and approves everything published or sent to customers. Check every fact, statistic, quote, link and claim against a source."	

SECTION	WHAT TO DECIDE	EXAMPLE LANGUAGE	OUR POLICY
7. Voice and brand	How AI output is edited to sound like you	"Edit AI drafts to match our brand voice guide. If it doesn't sound like us, it doesn't go out."	
8. Disclosure	When you tell people AI was involved	"We disclose AI use when a customer asks, when AI generates an image of something that isn't real, and wherever a platform or law requires it."	
9. Copyright and ownership	How you avoid using others' work	"Don't ask AI to copy or imitate a specific creator's work, logo or brand. Use licensed or original images."	
10. Accountability	Who's responsible when something goes wrong	"The person who publishes or sends the work is responsible for it, whether or not AI helped."	
11. People and roles	What you commit to your team	"We'll be open about how roles change, provide training on approved tools and involve the team in decisions about AI."	
12. Review schedule	How often you update the policy	"We review this policy and the approved tools list every quarter."	
Owner and sign-off	Who owns the policy; who has read it	"Owner: [name]. Every team member signs to confirm they've read it."	

↓ AI usage policy template

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Headline: "Five rules. One page."

● PRO TIP

Write the policy with your team, not for them. Ask the people already using AI what they use it for and what worries them. You'll get a better policy, and people will follow rules they helped write.

PRO TIP

Keep an approved tools list separate from the policy. Tools change every few months. The policy's rules shouldn't.

One caution: Fake reviews are a legal risk, not just an ethical one. In 2024, the U.S. Federal Trade Commission finalized a rule banning fake consumer reviews and testimonials, including ones generated by AI. Make this a hard line in your policy.

This template is a starting point, not legal advice. Have your attorney or HR advisor review your final policy, especially the sections on data, disclosure and personnel.

AI TIP

Draft your AI usage policy

```
Context: We're a [type of business] with [number] people. We use AI for [current uses]. Our team uses these tools: [list]. We handle this kind of sensitive data: [customer, financial, health, client information]. Our biggest concerns are [list]. Our five AI ground rules: people approve everything public; verify facts; protect data; keep our voice; add what AI can't.

Role: Act as an operations advisor who writes clear, practical policies for small businesses.

Ask: Draft a one- to two-page AI usage policy for our team.

Format: Use these sections: purpose and scope; approved tools; approved uses; off-limits uses; data protection; review and approval; voice and brand; disclosure; copyright; accountability; people and roles; review schedule; sign-off. Short sentences. Plain language.

Tighten: Make it practical, not legalistic. Use examples from our business. Flag anything our attorney or HR advisor should review. Don't invent legal requirements; where a law may apply, say "check with counsel."
```

Who will own our AI usage policy, and when will we finish and review it?

AI AGENTS

AI Agents: What Comes After Level 4

Most of this book uses AI as an assistant. You ask, it drafts, you decide. An AI agent goes a step further. You give it a goal, and it works through the steps on its own: searching, reading, using other software, updating records and drafting the result. A chatbot answers. An agent acts.

Agents are arriving in the tools you already use: AI assistants that can research and build files on your computer, CRM and email platforms that can route and follow up with leads, and ad platforms that run more of the campaign for you.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Under them, the AI fluency ladder, with "Level 4" marked as the doorway to agents.

Why agents come after Level 4

An agent automates a process. If your process is clear and documented, and your team already checks AI's work every day, an agent can save real time. If the process is messy, an agent just does the mess faster, and with less supervision.

That's why the AI fluency ladder puts agents after Level 4. The skills from Levels 1 to 4 are the skills you need to manage an agent: writing clear instructions (CRAFT), knowing what good output looks like, checking facts and protecting data.

The risk of jumping in too soon is real. In June 2025, Gartner predicted that over 40% of agentic AI projects will be canceled by the end of 2027, because of escalating costs, unclear business value or inadequate risk controls. Gartner also warned about "agent washing": existing products relabeled as agents. Of the thousands of vendors claiming agentic AI, Gartner estimated only about 130 are real.

Good first jobs for an agent

Start with a task that is frequent, well defined and low-risk if it goes wrong. For example:

- **Competitor monitoring:** check competitor websites, ads and reviews each week and send a short summary.
- **Reporting:** pull the numbers from your analytics, ad and email platforms into your monthly report (Chapter 19), ready for a person to review.
- **Content repurposing:** turn an approved article or video into draft social posts, an email and a short summary, for a person to review.
- **Lead routing:** sort new inquiries, update the CRM and draft a reply for a salesperson to send (Chapter 16).
- **Paid media checks:** watch ad accounts for budget overspend, disapproved ads or sudden drops in performance, and alert a person.

The Wild West Custom Pools work in Chapter 4 shows the pattern. It was done in Cowork, an agentic AI tool that researched competitors and built a working website, with a person reviewing and deciding at every step.

One caution: An agent with access to your email, ad accounts or customer records can do damage quickly. Give it only the access the task needs. Never let an agent publish, send to customers or spend money without a person's approval. Keep a log of what it did.

Your first agent checklist

CHECK	YES / NO / NOTES
Our team is at Level 4: AI is built into our documented workflows.	

CHECK	YES / NO / NOTES
The task is written down step by step, with clear inputs and outputs.	
The task is low-risk if the agent gets it wrong.	
The agent has only the access it needs, and no access to payments or passwords.	
A person approves anything public, anything sent to customers and any spending.	
The agent keeps a log we can review.	
We know how we'll measure success: time saved, errors, results.	
One person owns the agent and checks its work every week.	
We know when we'll stop or change course if it isn't working.	
We've told the team what the agent will do and how it affects their work.	

First agent checklist

PRO TIP

Run the task by hand with AI first. Do it as a normal AI-assisted task for a few weeks, writing down each step and each check. That document becomes the agent's instructions, and you'll already know what good output looks like.

Agents and your team

Agents raise the job question more sharply than any other AI tool, because they take on whole tasks rather than parts of them. Apply Loren's principles. Tell the truth about which tasks the agent will take over and what that means for each role. Invest in the skills people need to manage agents: setting goals, writing instructions, checking work. And involve the people who do the work now. They know where the process breaks and what the agent will miss.

AI TIP

Scope your first AI agent

Context: We're a **[type of business]** with **[number]** people. Our team is at Level **[1–4]** on the AI fluency ladder. Tasks that take a lot of our time: **[list with hours per week]**. Tools we use: **[CRM, email platform, analytics, ad platforms]**.

Role: Act as a cautious AI operations advisor for small businesses.

Ask: Help me choose and scope our first AI agent, or tell me if we're not ready.

Format: (1) Whether we're ready, and why. (2) The best first task from my list, with reasons. (3) The steps the agent would follow. (4) The access it needs, and what it must not have. (5) Where a person must approve. (6) How we'll measure success after 30 days.

Tighten: Favor low-risk, frequent, well-defined tasks. Don't recommend a specific vendor. Flag any step that touches customer data, money or public content.

AI TIP

Write your agent's instructions

Context: We're setting up an AI agent to **[task]**. Here's how we do this task today, step by step: **[paste your written process]**. Examples of good output: **[paste or describe]**.

Role: Act as an operations writer who turns processes into clear instructions for an AI agent.

Ask: Write the agent's standing instructions.

Format: Goal; inputs; steps in order; rules (what it must always and never do); when to stop and ask a person; what the output should look like; what to log.

Tighten: Be specific enough that a new employee could follow it. Include our AI ground rules. Require a person's approval before anything is published, sent to customers or paid for.

Our first agent candidate, its owner and when we'll be ready to test it.

Leading Your Team Through Change: Questions

Answer these questions with your leadership team. Together, your answers are the people side of your transformation plan from Chapter 21.

What are the change styles on our team, and how will we bring each style along?

What are the truthful answers to the questions our people are asking about AI and their roles?

What will we invest in training, and for whom, alongside new AI tools?

Which meetings will we keep, change or stop, and who will play the facilitator, timekeeper and notetaker roles?

What stage is our team in (Forming, Storming, Norming or Performing), and what does it need from us now?

What blind spots or hidden issues are getting in the way of our team, and how will we bring them into the open?

What conflicts do we need to address, and what process will we use?

Who owns our AI usage policy, and when will it be finished and shared with the team?

Are we ready for an AI agent? If not, what must happen first? If so, what's the first task?

↓ Business tools

SOURCES

Sources

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THE RULES

Is your marketing within them?

In this chapter »

Faster marketing. Same rules.

— **WHY COMPLIANCE IS A MARKETING SKILL**
AI scales your reach and your risk

— **EMAIL, TEXTS AND CALLS**
CAN-SPAM, inbox sender rules, consent and opt-outs

— **PRIVACY, COOKIES AND CONSENT**
State laws, paid media and consent mode

— **REVIEWS, ENDORSEMENTS AND CLAIMS**
The FTC rules, influencers and truth in advertising

— **AI, COPYRIGHT AND ACCESSIBILITY**
Who owns AI content, and your checklist

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
5 AI Tips, including auditing your sign-up forms and checking ad claims before launch

Why Compliance Is Now a Marketing Skill

Read this first: this guide is practical guidance, not legal advice. We're marketers, not lawyers. Use it to spot what applies to you and fix the basics. When a decision carries real risk, check with your attorney.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Hero graphic. Headline: "Faster marketing.

Compliance used to be something a big company's legal team handled. That has changed.

With AI, a two-person team can write 40 emails, 200 text variations and a month of ads in one afternoon. That's the promise of this book. The catch is that every one of those messages has to follow the rules. When one bad template goes out to 10,000 people, you have 10,000 problems.

Here's the math. CAN-SPAM penalties run up to $53,088 for each separate email that breaks the law. Under the TCPA, a consumer can sue for $500 per unlawful call or text. A court can triple that if the violation was willful. Small mistakes multiply fast.

The good news: most of the rules come down to a few habits. Get permission. Tell the truth. Make it easy to say no. Honor no quickly. Protect the data people give you.

Who owns compliance: name one person as your **compliance owner**. In a small business, that's usually the owner or the marketing lead. In an agency, it's the account director for each client. This person keeps the checklist, runs the quarterly review and decides when to call the attorney. Staff and AI tools should never be the ones deciding legal questions.

One-page rules map

CHANNEL	MAIN RULE	WHAT TO DO	WHERE IN THIS BOOK
Email	CAN-SPAM; Gmail, Yahoo and Microsoft sender rules	Honest headers and subject lines, a postal address and a working unsubscribe. Authenticate your domain.	Ch 16 Lead Nurture
Texts and calls	TCPA; FCC opt-out rules; carrier 10DLC registration	Get written consent first. Honor opt-outs fast. Text only from 8 a.m. to 9 p.m. Register your number.	Ch 16 (texting box), this guide
Paid media	FTC Act (truth in advertising); platform rules for customer lists and retargeting	Back up every claim before the ad runs. Upload only first-party data you're allowed to share. Respect consent signals.	Ch 12 Paid Media

CHANNEL	MAIN RULE	WHAT TO DO	WHERE IN THIS BOOK
Social media and influencers	FTC Endorsement Guides	Disclose every paid or free-product relationship in the post itself.	Ch 13 Social Media
Reviews	FTC Consumer Reviews and Testimonials Rule	No fake, bought or insider reviews. Don't suppress negative reviews. Ask every customer.	Ch 8 Local SEO and Reviews
Website	State privacy laws; cookie consent; ADA	Post a privacy notice and honor opt-outs (including GPC where required). Build to WCAG 2.2.	Ch 14 Website and Conversion
Analytics	State privacy laws; Google consent mode for EEA traffic	Know what your tags collect. Set up consent mode if you serve EEA users.	Ch 19 Measurement
AI tools	Privacy promises; copyright; EU AI Act	Keep personal data out of consumer AI plans. Have a human edit and approve. Label AI content where required.	Ch 22 AI usage policy

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

The table above as a clean one-page grid.

PRO TIP

Compliance problems almost never start as decisions. They start as shortcuts. Someone buys a list, copies a competitor's claim or "temporarily" skips the opt-out link. Your process exists to catch shortcuts before they ship.

EMAIL

Email

CAN-SPAM: the federal baseline

CAN-SPAM covers commercial email, and that includes B2B email. The FTC is clear: "The law makes no exception for business-to-business email." Its compliance guide lists seven requirements:

1. Don't use false or misleading header information.
2. Don't use deceptive subject lines.
3. Identify the message as an ad.
4. Tell recipients where you're located with a valid postal address.
5. Tell recipients how to opt out.

6 Honor opt-out requests promptly, within 10 business days.

7 Monitor what others do on your behalf.

That last one matters for agencies and anyone using a vendor. The FTC says you "can't contract away your legal responsibility." If your email platform or agency breaks the rules, you're still on the hook.

The inbox providers' rules: stricter than the law

CAN-SPAM is the legal floor. Gmail, Yahoo and Microsoft set a higher bar. If you miss it, your email doesn't get delivered.

REQUIREMENT	GMAIL	YAHOO	MICROSOFT (OUTLOOK.COM, HOTMAIL, LIVE)
Who it applies to	Bulk senders: about 5,000+ messages a day to personal Gmail accounts	Bulk senders	High-volume senders: 5,000+ emails a day
Authentication	SPF and DKIM, plus DMARC	SPF and DKIM, plus DMARC (at least p=none) that passes	SPF, DKIM and DMARC (at least p=none)
Unsubscribe	One-click unsubscribe plus a visible link in the body	One-click (RFC 8058 recommended)	One-click unsubscribe expected
Spam rate	Below 0.3% in Postmaster Tools	Below 0.3%	
Unsubscribe timing	Within 48 hours	Within 2 days	
Enforcement	Required since February 1, 2024. Stronger enforcement, including rejections, began November 2025.	In place	Enforced since May 5, 2025. Non-compliant mail is rejected.

Two details trip people up. First, Gmail counts all mail from the same primary domain toward the 5,000. Second, once Gmail labels you a bulk sender, that status doesn't expire.

Even if you send less than 5,000 a day, set up SPF, DKIM and DMARC anyway. It's cheap insurance for deliverability. See Ch 16 Lead Nurture for list hygiene and cadence.

PRO TIP

Never buy or rent an email list. It breaks the sender rules in practice even when it's technically legal. Spam complaints from strangers will sink your domain reputation for everyone, including your real customers.

AI TIP

Audit your sign-up forms for consent wording

```
Context: I run [business type] and collect emails and phone numbers on [list forms: website pop-up, checkout, landing pages, event sign-up]. Here is the exact wording of each form: [paste].

Role: You are a careful email and SMS marketing operations reviewer, not a lawyer.

Ask: Check each form for clear disclosure of what people will receive, how often, separate consent for texts, a link to the privacy notice, and how to opt out.

Format: A table with Form | What's missing or unclear | Suggested plain-English rewrite | Question for my attorney.

Tighten: Flag anything you're unsure about rather than guessing, keep rewrites under 40 words, and remind me to have an attorney approve final consent language.
```

TEXTS AND CALLS

Texts and Calls

Texting gets the best response rates of any channel. It also carries the highest legal risk. The TCPA lets consumers sue directly, and class actions are common.

Consent comes first

Under the FCC's rules, a "call" includes a text message. To send marketing texts or calls that use an autodialer or a prerecorded voice to a cell phone, you need **prior express written consent**. That means:

- A written agreement signed by the person (e-signatures and website checkboxes can count).
- It clearly authorizes you to send marketing messages.
- It states that signing isn't a condition of buying anything.

Most business texting platforms count as automated. Assume your marketing texts need written consent.

Quiet hours

Don't send telephone solicitations before 8 a.m. or after 9 p.m., local time where the recipient is. Some states set narrower windows.

Opt-outs: the 2025 rules and the 2026 change

These FCC rules took effect April 11, 2025:

- People can revoke consent in any reasonable way. Words like "stop," "quit," "end," "revoke," "opt out," "cancel" and "unsubscribe" count automatically.
- You must honor the request within a reasonable time, no more than 10 business days.

- You may send one confirmation text. If it goes out within five minutes, it's presumed compliant. It can't include marketing.

The FCC also wrote a "revoke-all" rule. Under it, a "stop" to one type of message would end all your robocalls and robotexts. That rule was delayed twice. Then, on September 30, 2026, the FCC narrowed it. The same order lets senders name one approved opt-out method, as long as they disclose it clearly in every text or call. The approved methods are a "STOP"-style text reply, an automated key-press or voice option, or a website or phone number you provide. An opt-out from marketing messages still stops all your marketing messages.

The order takes effect 30 days after Federal Register publication. The FCC is also asking for comment on shortening the 10-business-day window, possibly to seven days.

Our advice doesn't change: honor any clear "stop" the same day, however it arrives. That's good practice under any version of the rule.

Register your number: A2P 10DLC

If you text customers from a regular 10-digit business number, carriers require A2P 10DLC registration. You register your brand and campaign through your texting provider. Twilio, for example, says unregistered messages to US numbers have been blocked since September 1, 2023. Check with your provider.

PRO TIP

Your CRM is your consent record. For every contact, store when and where they opted in, the exact wording they saw and when they opted out. If you can't prove consent, you don't have it. The planned "AI and Your CRM" guide (Chapter 15) covers the setup.

AI TIP

Build a do-not-contact process

```
Context: We send marketing by [email, text, phone, paid media retargeting] using [list tools: CRM, email platform, SMS platform, ad accounts]. Opt-outs reach us through [list: STOP replies, unsubscribe links, phone, email, front desk, social DMs].

Role: You are an operations consultant who designs simple, reliable processes for small marketing teams.

Ask: Design a do-not-contact process that captures every opt-out, updates all tools (including ad-platform customer lists), and is finished well within 10 business days.

Format: A numbered workflow with owner role, tool, time limit for each step, plus a one-paragraph staff script for opt-outs received by phone or in person.

Tighten: Use the same-day standard wherever possible, don't invent tool features, and note that our attorney must review the final process.
```

Privacy, Cookies and Consent

State privacy laws: you may or may not be covered

There's still no comprehensive federal privacy law. States filled the gap. As of 2026, trackers count 19 or 20 states with comprehensive consumer privacy laws. Indiana, Kentucky and Rhode Island took effect January 1, 2026.

These laws generally give consumers the right to:

- Know what personal data you collect and get a copy.
- Correct and delete it.
- Opt out of the sale of their data, targeted advertising and certain profiling.

They generally require businesses to post a clear privacy notice and respond to those requests.

Many small businesses aren't covered. Most of these laws apply only above certain thresholds. California is the best-known example. The CCPA applies to for-profit businesses that do business in California and meet at least one test:

- Annual gross revenue of $26.625 million or more (adjusted January 1, 2025).
- Buying, selling or sharing personal information of 100,000 or more California consumers or households.
- Getting 50% or more of revenue from selling or sharing California consumers' personal information.

California fines are up to $2,663 per violation, or $7,988 if intentional or involving minors.

Some small businesses are covered anyway. Texas exempts small businesses as the SBA defines them, with one exception: they must get consent before selling sensitive data. And a business with modest revenue can still hit a consumer-count threshold through a busy website and ad tracking.

Global Privacy Control (GPC). GPC is a browser setting that signals "don't sell or share my data." California requires covered businesses to treat it as a valid opt-out. A law-firm review lists Colorado, Connecticut, Maryland, Delaware, Montana, Nebraska, New Hampshire, New Jersey, Oregon, Texas and Minnesota as requiring universal opt-out signals too. California, Colorado and Connecticut have run a joint sweep of businesses that ignore GPC.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Your attorney decides."

Which states and thresholds apply to you is a legal question. Bring your revenue, your customer locations and a list of your tracking tools to your attorney.

Paid media: retargeting and customer lists

Paid media is where privacy and marketing collide most often.

- **Retargeting pixels** collect data about your site visitors. Under several state laws, that can count as "sharing" for targeted advertising. That's why opt-outs and GPC matter.
- **Customer-list uploads** (Google Customer Match, Meta Custom Audiences) have their own rules. Google allows only first-party data you collected yourself. Your privacy policy must say you share data with third parties for services, and you must get consent where the law requires it.

Read each platform's customer-list terms before every new upload. See Ch 12 Paid Media.

Cookies and Google consent mode

US law generally doesn't require a cookie banner the way European law does. You still need to disclose tracking in your privacy notice and honor opt-outs where state law applies.

If you serve users in the European Economic Area, Google requires you to collect consent and pass it to Google through consent mode. Two signals matter: ad_user_data and ad_personalization. Without valid consent signals, remarketing, ad personalization and some measurement stop working for that traffic. See Ch 19 Measurement.

Serving EU or UK customers?

European rules are stricter. In the UK, PECR requires you to tell people about cookies, explain what they do and get consent before setting non-essential ones. Only strictly necessary cookies are exempt. Advertising and tracking cookies need clear consent. EU rules are similar. If Europe is a real market for you, talk to an attorney who knows GDPR.

Marketing to children under 13

COPPA applies if your website or online service is directed to children under 13, or you knowingly collect their personal information. The FTC's amended rule had a compliance deadline of April 22, 2026. It requires separate verifiable parental consent before sharing children's data with third parties, including for targeted advertising. It also adds data retention limits. If kids are any part of your audience, call your attorney before you collect anything.

AI TIP

Draft a plain-English privacy notice for attorney review

```
Context: My business is [type] in [states], with about [revenue range] in revenue and customers in
[states/countries]. We collect [list data] through [forms, checkout, cookies, pixels, CRM] and share
it with [list vendors and ad platforms].

Role: You are a plain-language writer who helps small businesses turn data practices into clear
notices.

Ask: Draft a privacy notice that explains what we collect, why, who we share it with, how to opt out
of sale and targeted ads, how we handle Global Privacy Control, and how to contact us.

Format: Short sections with headings, sentences under 20 words, and a separate list of questions for
my attorney about which state laws apply.

Tighten: Don't claim compliance with any specific law, flag every assumption in [brackets], and label
the draft "For attorney review — not final."
```

Reviews, Endorsements and Advertising Claims

The Consumer Reviews and Testimonials Rule

The FTC's rule took effect October 21, 2024. It prohibits:

- Fake or false reviews, including reviews from people who never used the product. AI-written fake reviews are included.
- Paying for reviews when the payment is tied to a positive (or negative) sentiment.
- Undisclosed reviews from insiders, like employees, managers or their relatives.
- Company-controlled "independent" review sites.
- Suppressing negative reviews through threats, intimidation or false accusations.
- Buying or selling fake social media indicators, like bot followers or views.

Under the FTC rule, you can offer an incentive for a review as long as you don't require or imply it has to be positive. Google is stricter: its policy bans incentives for any review on Google. Civil penalties under the FTC rule run up to $53,088 per violation. On December 22, 2025, the FTC sent warning letters to 10 companies about possible violations.

On review gating: the FTC rule doesn't explicitly ban asking only happy customers for reviews. The FTC warns it can still be illegal, though, if it skews your reviews. Google's policy bans selectively asking for positive reviews outright. The safe practice: ask every customer the same way. See Ch 8 Local SEO and Reviews.

PRO TIP

Make the review request part of your process for every finished job, not just the ones that went well. Your average may drop a little. Your credibility goes up, and you stay on the right side of the FTC and Google.

Endorsements and influencers

The FTC's Endorsement Guides apply to influencers, employees, affiliates and customers you reward. The key points:

- Disclose any material connection: payment, free products, employment, or a family or personal relationship.
- Put the disclosure in the post itself. A bio or a "see more" link isn't enough.
- In video, disclose in both the audio and the visuals. Repeat it during livestreams.
- Use plain words: "Ad," "Sponsored," "#ad" or "Thanks to [brand] for the free product." Avoid vague tags like "sp" or "collab."
- Platform disclosure tools help but may not be enough on their own.

You're responsible for what influencers say on your behalf. The FTC says: "Your company is ultimately responsible for what others do on your behalf." Train them, review their posts and act when something's wrong. Employees who post about your products must disclose that they work for you. See Ch 13 Social Media.

Referral programs

Referral rewards are allowed, but keep them fully separate from review requests, and tell customers who promote you publicly to disclose the reward. Some regulated fields, such as healthcare, legal, real estate and financial services, limit referral payments. Check with your attorney or licensing board before you launch. See the "Keep, Grow and Get Referred" guide.

Truth in advertising

The FTC's basic standard has three parts. Ads must be truthful and not deceptive. You must have evidence for your claims. Ads can't be unfair. "The law requires that advertisers have proof before the ad runs." Health and safety claims need competent and reliable scientific evidence. Customer testimonials alone usually aren't enough.

This applies to every paid media ad, landing page, email and social post.

AI claims get special attention

In September 2024, the FTC announced Operation AI Comply: five actions against deceptive AI claims and schemes. Then-Chair Lina Khan said, "There is no AI exemption from the laws on the books." The cases included DoNotPay's "AI lawyer" claims and Rytr, an AI tool used to generate fake reviews.

In January 2025, accessiBe agreed to pay $1 million over claims that its AI tool could make any website WCAG compliant. If you market "AI-powered" services, you need proof for each claim, just like any other claim.

AI TIP

Check ad, landing page and influencer claims before launch

```
Context: We're launching [campaign] for [product/service] on [channels: Google Ads, Meta, landing page, email, influencer posts]. Here is the copy and the influencer brief: [paste]. Here is the evidence we have: [list data, tests, certifications, reviews].

Role: You are a skeptical ad reviewer who checks marketing for unsupported claims and missing disclosures.

Ask: List every objective claim, match it to our evidence, and flag claims without support, implied claims, missing influencer disclosures, and any review or testimonial issues.

Format: A table with Claim | Where it appears | Evidence we have | Risk (High/Medium/Low) | Safer wording, then a short list of questions for our attorney.

Tighten: Treat "best," "guaranteed," results numbers, health and AI capability claims as high risk; don't invent evidence; remind me that an attorney must clear high-risk claims.
```

AI, Copyright and Accessibility

Who owns AI-generated content?

The US Copyright Office's January 2025 report concludes that AI output is protected only where a human author determined enough of the expressive elements. Prompts alone aren't enough. Purely AI-generated material isn't protected. Human contributions can be: your own writing, creative selection and arrangement, and meaningful edits.

For marketers, that means two things. Competitors may be able to copy purely AI-generated content. And human editing isn't just about quality; it's part of what makes your work yours. This supports the field guide loop: you think, AI drafts, you decide.

Keep customer data out of consumer AI plans

Check how your AI tool uses what you type into it. For example:

- OpenAI says consumer ChatGPT content is used for training by default, with an opt-out. Its business products aren't trained on by default.
- Anthropic says Claude Free, Pro and Max users choose whether their chats are used for training. Its commercial services aren't covered by that change.

The rule of thumb: don't paste customer names, emails, phone numbers or other personal data into a consumer AI plan. Use a business plan with training turned off, and strip out identifying details. Put this in your AI usage policy (Ch 22).

Serving EU customers: the AI Act

If you serve people in the EU, check the AI Act. Its Article 50 transparency duties have applied since August 2, 2026. Deployers must disclose deepfakes and certain AI-generated text published to inform the public about matters of public interest. AI systems that talk directly with people, like chatbots, must let them know they're talking to AI. Ask your attorney whether any of this applies to your chatbot or content.

Website accessibility

ADA Title III covers businesses open to the public. The DOJ says those businesses must make what they offer accessible to people with disabilities, including what they offer online. DOJ hasn't set a required technical standard for private businesses. It points to WCAG and Section 508 as helpful guidance.

Lawsuits are the real pressure. Seyfarth counted 3,117 federal website accessibility lawsuits in 2025, up 27% from 2024. Its count excludes state court suits.

One source of confusion: DOJ's 2024 web rule (WCAG 2.1 AA) applies to state and local governments, not private businesses. In 2026, DOJ moved those deadlines to April 26, 2027 for large governments and April 26, 2028 for smaller ones.

For private businesses, WCAG 2.2 is the practical standard. It became a W3C Recommendation in October 2023, with nine new success criteria. The ones marketers touch most are target size (at least 24 by 24 CSS pixels), focus not obscured and accessible authentication. Don't rely on an overlay widget to "make you compliant."

Remember accessiBe. See Ch 14 Website and Conversion.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Three rounded cards.

PRO TIP

Add an accessibility check to every launch checklist. Fixing a landing page before it goes live takes minutes. Fixing it after a demand letter costs far more.

YOUR COMPLIANCE CHECKLIST

Your Compliance Checklist

Owner: your compliance owner (see "Why Compliance Is Now a Marketing Skill"). One person, named in writing.

Rhythm: a quarterly review, plus a check before any new channel, list upload, campaign type or AI tool. Put the quarterly review on the calendar now.

Escalation rule: if a question involves which laws apply, children's data, health claims, sensitive data or a complaint from a regulator, the owner calls the attorney. Staff don't decide it.

AREA	CHECK	DONE?	NOTES
Email	Every commercial email has a postal address, an honest subject line and a working unsubscribe	☐	
Email	SPF, DKIM and DMARC set up; spam rate under 0.3%	☐	
Email	Unsubscribes processed within 2 days	☐	
Texts	Written consent captured and stored for every marketing text contact	☐	
Texts	10DLC brand and campaign registered	☐	
Texts	Quiet hours (8 a.m.–9 p.m. recipient time) set in the platform	☐	
All channels	Do-not-contact process tested end to end, including ad-platform lists	☐	

AREA	CHECK	DONE?	NOTES
Privacy	Attorney has confirmed which state laws apply	☐	
Privacy	Privacy notice is current and matches actual tools and vendors	☐	
Privacy	Opt-out of sale and targeted ads works; GPC honored where required	☐	
Paid media	Customer-list uploads use first-party data only; privacy notice discloses sharing	☐	
Paid media	Consent mode set up for EEA traffic (if applicable)	☐	
Paid media	Every ad claim has evidence on file before launch	☐	
Reviews	Every customer gets the same review request; no fake, bought or insider reviews	☐	
Referrals	Referral rewards kept separate from review requests; industry limits checked	☐	
Social	Influencer and employee disclosures required in briefs and checked in posts	☐	
Children	Confirmed no data is collected from children under 13, or attorney engaged	☐	
AI	No personal data goes into consumer AI plans; AI usage policy signed (Ch 22)	☐	
AI	A human edits and approves all published AI content	☐	
Accessibility	Key pages checked against WCAG 2.2 AA	☐	
Review	Quarterly review completed and dated	☐	

- One-page Compliance Checklist
- Do-Not-Contact Process template
- Consent record fields for your CRM

COMPLIANCE QUESTIONS

Compliance Questions

1. Who is your compliance owner, and who is your attorney for marketing questions?

2. Which channels do you use today? List email, text, phone, paid media, social, influencers, reviews and website forms, with the tool for each.

3. How many marketing emails do you send in a peak day, and are SPF, DKIM and DMARC set up for your sending domain?

4. Where do you capture consent for texts, and can you produce a consent record for any contact today?

5. How do opt-outs reach you, and how many days does it take to update every tool, including ad-platform customer lists?

6. In which states and countries are your customers? What are your annual revenue and the approximate number of consumers whose data you handle each year? (Bring this to your attorney.)

7. Which tracking pixels, analytics tags and customer-list uploads do you use for paid media, and does your privacy notice describe them?

8. How do you ask for reviews, and does every customer get the same request?

9. List your top five advertising claims. What evidence do you have on file for each?

10. Which AI tools does your team use, on which plans, and is customer data ever pasted into them?

AI TIP

Turn your answers into a prioritized fix list for attorney review

```
Context: Here are my answers to the Compliance Questions in "Marketing Within the Rules": [paste answers 1–10]. My business is [type] with [team size] people.

Role: You are a marketing operations advisor who helps small teams prioritize compliance fixes; you are not a lawyer.

Ask: Turn my answers into a prioritized fix list, ranking each item by risk and effort, and separate what my team can fix now from what needs my attorney's decision.

Format: Two tables — "Fix now" (Item | Why it matters | Owner role | Due date) and "Ask the attorney" (Question | Context to bring) — then a 90-day plan in five bullets.

Tighten: Don't state legal conclusions, flag gaps in my answers in [brackets], and put "For attorney review" at the top of the output.
```

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GET STARTED

What happens in your first 90 days?

In this chapter »

Your first 90 days start now.

› **— GETTING STARTED**
You've done the work. Now act on it

› **— YOUR FIRST 90 DAYS**
The Foundation stage, week by week

› **— THE BLUEPRINT**
The whole book on one page

› **— KEEP GOING**
A transformation doesn't have an end date

› **— AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
2 AI Tips: build your 90-day plan, and review your whole field guide

GETTING STARTED

Getting Started

You've done the work. You've assessed your skills, mapped your customer journey, built a plan for each discipline, ranked your priorities and sequenced them into six stages. You've used AI to draft, analyze and pressure-test along the way.

Now comes the part no book can do for you: starting.

A plan you start this week beats a perfect plan you start next quarter.

The businesses that get results from a transformation aren't the ones with the best plan. They're the ones that take consistent action, measure what happens and adjust. Here are six things to keep in front of you.

Six things that matter most

1. **Start with your strategy.** Don't move forward without one. Your strategy on a page from Chapter 2 is the filter for every decision: what you'll do, and what you won't.
2. **Build your internal and external team.** Fill the gaps you found in Chapter 3. Train the people you have, hire for the skills you can't build and outsource what you can't do well. Every discipline needs an owner, including paid media.
3. **Let the data decide.** Track what matters (Chapter 19). Use the numbers to decide what to do next, where to spend and what to stop.
4. **Make room to experiment.** Test new channels, new offers and new tools. Hold a small share of your effort for Horizon 3 ideas (Chapter 21). Expect some tests to fail; that's how you find the ones that work.
5. **Stay connected with your audience.** Publish regularly in the channels your buyers use, answer their questions and ask for reviews (Chapters 5 through 16).
6. **Reach Level 4 on the AI fluency ladder.** Make AI part of how your team works every day, with the ground rules in place (Chapters 1, 3 and 22).

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

Six rounded cards, one per item, with a two-word label each: Strategy first, Build the team, Let data decide, Experiment, Stay connected, Reach Level 4.

YOUR FIRST 90 DAYS

Your First 90 Days

Your first 90 days are the Foundation stage from Chapter 1. The goal isn't to do everything. It's to build momentum, prove the plan works and set up the habits that carry you through the next five stages.

WHEN	FOCUS	WHAT TO DO
Weeks 1–2	Set up	Share the one-page plan from Chapter 21 with the team. Name an owner for each discipline and each priority. Agree on your AI ground rules and start your AI usage policy (Chapter 22). Record your starting numbers (Chapter 19).
Weeks 3–4	Quick wins	Complete two or three quick wins from your effort vs. impact grid: for example, your Google Business Profile, broken forms, clear calls to action, tracking that works.
Month 2	First moves	Launch the first transformational tactic in your plan. Start a shared prompt library with the AI TIPs your team uses most. Hold a 30-minute weekly check-in: what's done, what's next, what's stuck.
Month 3	Measure and review	Compare your numbers to your starting point. Hold your first quarterly business review (Chapter 1): What's working? What isn't? What do we change? Retake the AI fluency assessment from Chapter 3.

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

A horizontal timeline of four rounded cards: Set up, Quick wins, First moves, Measure and review.

PRO TIP

Put the first quarterly review on the calendar today, with everyone who owns part of the plan. A review date turns a plan into a commitment.

PRO TIP

Celebrate the quick wins. Tell the team, and tell your leadership, what changed and what it did. Early proof builds support for the harder work that follows.

AI TIP

Build your 90-day plan

```
Context: Here is our one-page transformation plan: [paste]. Our quick wins: [list]. Our first
transformational tactic: [name]. Our team: [names or roles and hours available per week]. Our AI
fluency level today: [1–4].

Role: Act as a project manager helping a small marketing team start a transformation.

Ask: Turn our plan into a 90-day action plan.

Format: A table by week for the first four weeks, then by month for months 2 and 3: task, owner,
hours, done when. Then a list of the three things most likely to slow us down, with how to prevent
each one.

Tighten: Be realistic about the hours we have. No more than three priorities at a time. Include
setting up our AI ground rules in the first two weeks and our first quarterly review at the end.
```

Our first 90 days: quick wins, first transformational tactic, owners and the date of our first quarterly review.

First 90 days planner

THE BLUEPRINT

The Blueprint

Here is the whole book on one page: the blueprint for building a business with digital marketing and AI. Use it as a checklist when you start, and come back to it at every quarterly review.

#	STEP	WHAT IT MEANS	CHAPTER
1	**Offer something worth buying**	A product or service that solves a specific problem and stands out from the alternatives. Marketing can't fix a weak offer.	2, 4
2	**Know your audience**	Who benefits most from what you sell: their needs, their questions, where they spend time online and how they decide.	2, 5

#	STEP	WHAT IT MEANS	CHAPTER
3	**Understand their pain points**	The challenges, frustrations and obstacles that send them looking for help.	5
4	**Understand what motivates them**	Their goals and what success looks like to them, so you can position your offer as the way to get there.	5
5	**Answer their questions**	Content that answers what buyers ask, in the words they use, at every stage of the journey.	7, 9, 10
6	**Be found in search and in AI answers**	Pages that rank, a complete Google Business Profile, steady reviews and content clear enough for AI tools to cite.	6, 7
7	**Show your work**	Case studies, project stories, videos, reviews and testimonials that prove you solve the problem.	9, 11
8	**Make offers worth acting on**	A clear next step for each stage: a guide, a consultation, a quote, a trial.	14, 16
9	**Promote what works**	Paid media, social media and email to put your best content and offers in front of the right people.	12, 13, 16
10	**Convert and follow up**	Pages that turn visitors into leads, and fast, helpful follow-up that turns leads into customers.	14, 16
11	**Measure and adjust**	Track what matters, learn what's working and move your time and budget to it.	19, 20
12	**Bring your people along**	A team with the skills, the tools, the AI ground rules and the support to make the change.	3, 22

GRAPHIC IN FINAL LAYOUT

People decide."

The Blueprint

KEEP GOING

Keep Going

A transformation isn't a project with an end date. Buyers change how they search. Platforms change their rules. AI tools get better every few months. The plan you built in this book is a starting point, and the habits you build around it matter more than the plan itself: review every quarter, measure what matters, keep learning and keep your team involved.

Keep the loop that runs through this whole book: **you think, AI drafts, you decide.** AI will keep getting faster and more capable. Your judgment, your experience and your knowledge of your customers are what make the work yours.

And most of all, have fun. The work is better when you enjoy it, and your team will notice.

The templates, the workbook and a current list of AI tools are on the book's page: mikehuber.com/book. We update them as the tools change. You can sign up there for the monthly newsletter, too, so the updates come to you.

Getting Started: Questions

What is the first thing we'll do this week?

Which of the six things that matter most is our biggest gap, and what will we do about it?

Who owns our 90-day plan, and when is our first weekly check-in?

Which steps of the blueprint are we strongest in, and which are we weakest in?

What will we celebrate at the end of the first 90 days?

AI TIP

Review your whole field guide

```
Context: Here are my answers from the Business Transformation field guide: [paste or attach your completed field guide]. Our business: [one-paragraph description]. Our goals: [goals].

Role: Act as an experienced digital marketing strategist reviewing a client's completed field guide.

Ask: Review my answers as a whole and tell me what's strong, what's weak and what doesn't fit together.

Format: (1) The three strongest parts of the plan. (2) The three biggest gaps or contradictions, such as goals with no tactics, tactics with no owner, or channels with no budget. (3) Any of the twelve blueprint steps we've skipped. (4) The five actions that matter most in the next 90 days, in order.

Tighten: Base your review only on what's in my answers. Be direct. Where you're unsure, ask me instead of assuming.
```

The complete resource bundle: workbook

AI SYSTEM

Ready to go further?

In this chapter »

Stop writing prompts. Start building a system.

— **FROM PROMPTS TO A SYSTEM**
The five parts of an AI marketing system

— **KNOWLEDGE BASE AND INSTRUCTIONS**
Write it down once, set the rules once

— **SKILLS AND WORKFLOWS**
Turn your best prompts into skills, then chain them

— **PEOPLE IN CHARGE**
Keep people at the checkpoints, then measure and maintain

— **WHEN YOU ARE READY FOR AGENTS**
What comes after Level 4

— **AI IN THIS CHAPTER**
3 AI Tips, including turning a prompt you already use into a skill

FROM PROMPTS TO A SYSTEM

From Prompts to a System

Stop writing prompts. Start building a system.

If your team is at Level 4, AI is already a written step in your workflows, and a person approves what it produces. That's the goal of this book, and most teams never get there.

But look closely at how Level 4 teams work, and you'll see the same thing happen over and over. Someone opens an AI tool. They paste in the persona again. They explain the brand voice again. They rewrite the prompt that worked last month, from memory, a little worse. Every task starts from zero.

A system fixes that. You write down what AI needs to know about your business once. You turn your best prompts into small tools that do one job well. You connect those tools into workflows, with a person signing off at the points that matter. Then you measure it and improve it every quarter, the same way you manage everything else.

The answers you wrote in the other field guides are the raw material. Your goals, customers, competitors, voice and numbers are already on paper. This guide shows you how to put them to work.

Who this guide is for. Teams at Level 4 on the AI fluency ladder (Guide 03). If you're at Level 2 or 3, start with the AI Tips in the guides for your focus areas, and come back when AI is part of how your team works every week.

For a picture of where AI fits across a whole company, from purchasing to customer service to finance, see the department-by-department table in Loren's case study at the end of Chapter 21.

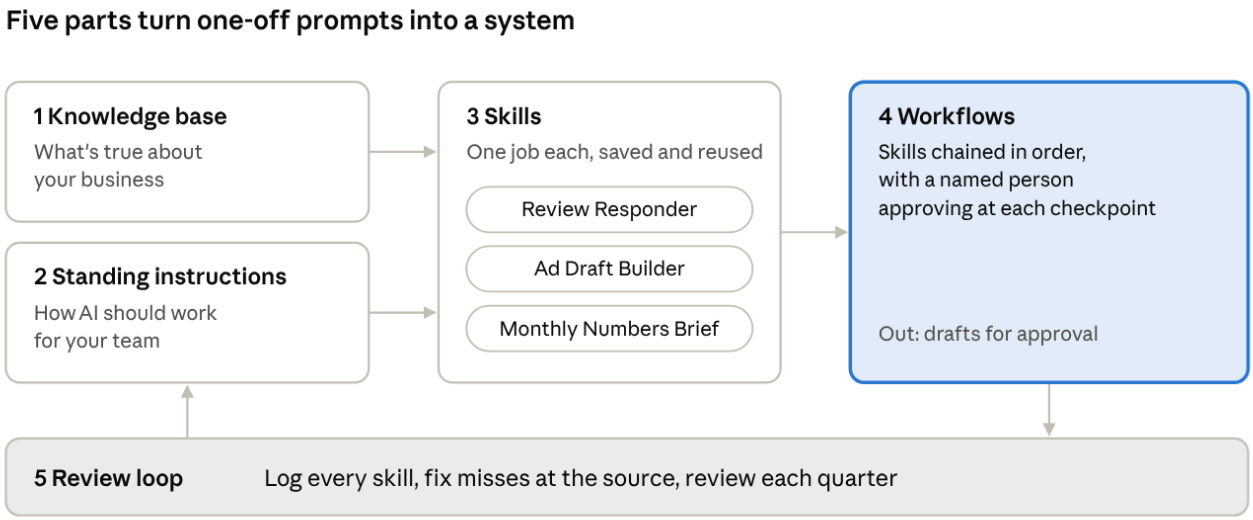
PRO TIP

Build the system around work you already do. The best first skill is the task someone on your team does every week and complains about.

THE FIVE PARTS OF AN AI MARKETING SYSTEM

The Five Parts of an AI Marketing System

Five parts. Each one makes the others work.



your AI marketing system · 5 parts

The knowledge base and standing instructions feed every skill. Skills chain into workflows, with a person approving at each checkpoint. The review loop keeps the whole thing current. [VISUAL: final print version, orange for the AI parts.]

You build them in that order, one step at a time. The rest of this guide walks through each one.

STEP 1

Step 1: Build Your Knowledge Base

Write it down once. Use it everywhere.

Your knowledge base is a small set of documents that tells AI who you are. Every skill and workflow draws on it, so nobody has to paste the persona in again.

You've already written most of it. Pull it from your field guide answers:

DOCUMENT	WHAT GOES IN IT	WHERE IT COMES FROM
Business basics	What you sell, to whom, where, at what price; your one-year goal and KPIs	Guides 01 and 02
Customers	Personas, the questions buyers ask at each stage, the words they use	Guides 02 and 05
Competitors	Who they are, what they promise, where they're weak	Guide 04

DOCUMENT	WHAT GOES IN IT	WHERE IT COMES FROM
Voice	How you sound, words you use and avoid, two or three samples of your best writing	Guide 08
Proof	Results, reviews, case studies and facts you can stand behind, each with its source	Guides 07, 08 and 12
Offers and channels	Services, current offers, the paid media, social and email channels you use and what each is for	Guides 10, 11 and 14
Rules	Your AI usage policy: what data AI may see, what people must approve	Guides 01 and 19

Keep each document short, one to three pages. AI works better with clear, current facts than with everything you've ever written.

Where it lives. Most AI tools let you save files once and reuse them in every conversation. Claude and ChatGPT call these Projects, and Gemini uses Gems (Bootstrap Creative, 2026). Names change. What matters is that your knowledge base lives in one place your whole team uses, on a company account.

PRO TIP

Date every document and give it an owner. A knowledge base that's six months out of date will confidently tell customers about last year's prices.

↓ Knowledge base starter kit: seven document templates

AI TIP

Turn your field guide answers into knowledge base documents

```
Context: These are our answers from the Business Transformation field guides: [paste the answers for one document, such as your personas and buyer questions].

Role: Act as an editor building a reference document an AI assistant will read before every task.

Ask: Turn these answers into a one- to two-page [document name] for our knowledge base.

Format: Short sections with plain headings. Facts and lists, not marketing copy. Add a line at the top with today's date and "Owner: [name]."

Tighten: Use only what's in my answers. Where something is missing or vague, list it under "Questions for the owner" instead of filling it in.
```

STEP 2

Step 2: Write Standing Instructions

Tell AI the rules once, not every time.

Standing instructions are a short set of rules your AI tool follows in every conversation. Your knowledge base says what's true. Your standing instructions say how to work.

Most tools have a place for them: Custom Instructions in ChatGPT, Preferences and Styles in Claude, Saved Info in Gemini (Bootstrap Creative, 2026). Projects and Gems can also carry their own instructions, so one team's rules don't leak into another's work.

Good standing instructions cover five things. They're the AI ground rules from Guide 01, turned into instructions AI can follow:

1. **Who we are.** One paragraph: the business, the customer, the goal. Point to the knowledge base for the rest.
2. **How we sound.** Your voice in three or four rules ("short sentences," "no hype," "say 'clients,' not 'customers'").
3. **What's true.** "Use only facts from the knowledge base or that I give you. If you're not sure, say so and ask. Never invent statistics, quotes or results."
4. **What stays private.** Which data AI may not see or repeat, from your AI usage policy.
5. **What comes back to a person.** "Mark anything that will be published, sent to a customer or spent as money as DRAFT FOR APPROVAL."

Keep them under a page. Short, clear rules are easier for AI to follow and easier for you to check.

Our standing instructions (five short sections).

PRO TIP

Test your instructions on a task you know well. Ask for something you've written yourself, then compare. Where the draft misses, add a rule.

STEP 3

Step 3: Turn Your Best Prompts into Skills

One skill. One job. Done the same way every time.

A skill is a saved, reusable set of instructions for one task. Write a review reply. Draft a search ad. Summarize last month's numbers. Instead of rewriting the prompt each time, you call the skill, give it today's details, and get a consistent first draft.

The idea is simple and it scales. One LinkedIn post we saw broke a single job, B2B outbound sales, into 20 small skills: one to define the ideal customer, one to research an account, one to write the first message, one to sort replies, and so on. [Credit: author, post, date.] No single skill is impressive. Together they're a system.

Tools package skills differently. Claude has Skills. ChatGPT has custom GPTs. Gemini has Gems (Bootstrap Creative, 2026). A shared document of tested prompts works too. Start there if your tool doesn't support skills yet.

The skill card

Write every skill on one card before you build it. If you can't fill in the card, the skill isn't ready.

PART	WHAT TO WRITE
Name	A verb and a thing: "Review Responder," "Ad Draft Builder"
Job	The one task it does, in one sentence
Inputs	What a person gives it each time (a review, a keyword, last month's numbers)
Uses	Which knowledge base documents it reads
Steps	The prompt, built with CRAFT: Context, Role, Ask, Format, Tighten
Output	Exactly what comes back, and in what format
Checkpoint	Who approves the output before it's used, and what they check
Owner	Who maintains the skill and updates it when it misses

Our first skill card.

↓ Skill card template and skills library tracker

Starter skills by discipline

You don't need 20 skills. Start with three: the tasks your team repeats most. Here's one place to start in each of the ten disciplines:

DISCIPLINE	STARTER SKILL	WHAT IT DOES
Strategy	Goal Checker	Tests a new idea against your one-year goal and KPIs
Content	Brief Builder	Turns a buyer question into a content brief in your voice
SEO and AI search	Answer Checker	Runs your buyer questions through AI assistants and logs whether you're cited
Paid media	Ad Draft Builder	Drafts search and social ad variations from an offer, within your rules
Social media	Post Repurposer	Turns one article or video into posts for each platform you use
Email and marketing automation	Follow-Up Writer	Drafts the next email in a sequence from a lead's stage and question
Video	Script Outliner	Turns a buyer question into a two-minute video outline
Website and conversion optimization	Page Reviewer	Checks a landing page against the five checks in Guide 12
Local SEO and reviews	Review Responder	Drafts a reply to a review in your voice, flags anything that needs the owner
Analytics	Monthly Numbers Brief	Turns last month's exports into a one-page KPI summary

AI TIP

Turn a prompt you already use into a skill

```
Context: Here is a prompt our team uses often: [paste it]. Here are two outputs we liked and one we
didn't: [paste them]. Our knowledge base includes: [list the documents].

Role: Act as an AI workflow designer helping a small marketing team.

Ask: Turn this prompt into a reusable skill.

Format: A completed skill card (name, job, inputs, uses, steps, output, checkpoint, owner), then the
final instructions, ready to save in [your AI tool].

Tighten: Keep the instructions under 300 words. List anything a person must check before the output is
used.
```

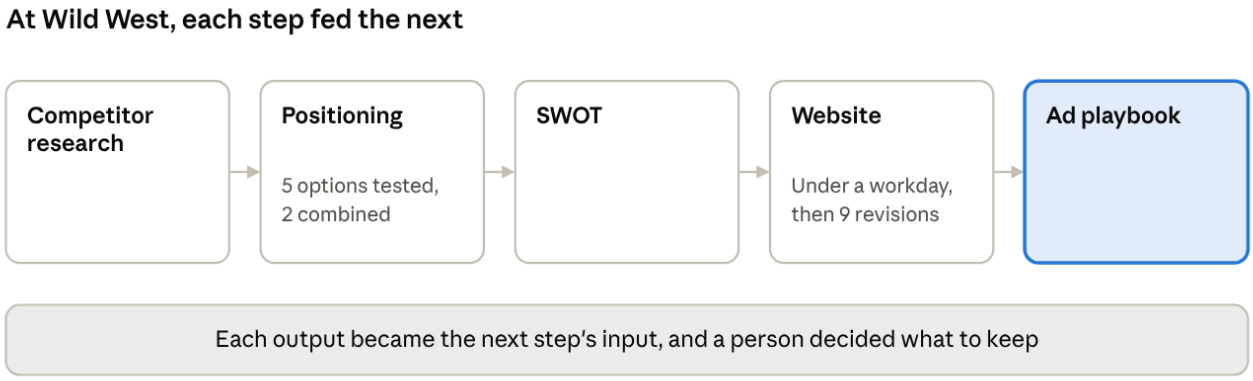
STEP 4

Step 4: Chain Skills into Workflows

A workflow is skills in order, with people at the checkpoints.

One skill saves minutes. A workflow saves the project. It connects skills so the output of one becomes the input of the next, and it names the person who checks the work before it moves on.

You've seen one already. When we applied this book to Wild West Custom Pools in June 2026 (Guide 04), the work ran as a chain in Claude Cowork:



Wild West Custom Pools, June 2026 · 5 steps

The competitor research shaped the positioning. The positioning shaped the SWOT. All three shaped the website and the ad playbook. Nothing had to be explained twice, because each step started from the last one's output.

Build your first workflow in four moves:

1. **Pick work that repeats.** A monthly report, a new-service launch, every new review, every new lead.
2. **List the steps a person takes today**, in order. Mark which ones AI could draft.
3. **Assign a skill to each AI step**, and a named person to each checkpoint (Step 5).
4. **Run it by hand three times** before you call it a workflow. Fix the skills that miss.

WORKFLOW	SKILLS IN ORDER	CHECKPOINT
New review	Review Responder	Owner approves the reply before it posts
Monthly report	Monthly Numbers Brief, Goal Checker	Marketing lead checks the numbers against the source reports
New service launch	Brief Builder, Page Reviewer, Ad Draft Builder, Post Repurposer	Owner approves the offer, the page and any ad spend

PRO TIP

Draw the workflow on one page before you build it. If it doesn't fit on a page, it's two workflows.

STEP 5

Step 5: Keep People in Charge

The system drafts. People decide.

The more AI does, the more your checkpoints matter. Every workflow needs a named person at each point where a mistake would cost you money, trust or a customer. Use the AI ground rules from Guide 01:

GROUND RULE	WHERE THE CHECKPOINT GOES
People approve everything public	Before anything is published, sent to a customer or posted
Verify facts	Before any number, claim or quote leaves the building
Protect data	Before customer or financial data goes into any skill
Keep your voice	Before a draft becomes the final version
Add what AI can't	At the start of each workflow: the judgment, the story, the decision

And one more, for systems: **spend needs a signature.** No skill or workflow should change an ad budget, a price or an offer without a person approving it.

Be honest with your team about roles. When work moves into skills and workflows, jobs change. Some tasks disappear. New ones appear: someone owns the knowledge base, someone maintains the skills, someone approves at each checkpoint. Tell people what's changing and why, train them for the new work, and involve them in designing the system. The people who do the work today know where the skills will break. To come: Loren: a line from your change-management work on redesigning roles, or a pointer to Guide 19.

STEP 6

Step 6: Measure and Maintain

A system you don't maintain gets worse.

Prices change. Offers end. A skill that worked in March drifts by June. Give the system the same attention you give your marketing:

- **Log each skill.** Keep a simple list: the skill, its owner, how often it's used, what it saves and when it last missed. [DOWNLOAD] (companion workbook tab: Skills Library.)

- **Fix misses at the source.** When a draft is wrong, don't just correct the draft. Fix the skill or the knowledge base so it doesn't happen again.
- **Review every quarter.** Add the system to your quarterly business review (Guide 01). Retire skills nobody uses. Update the knowledge base. Pick the next workflow to build.
- **Measure what matters.** Time saved is a start. The real test is your KPIs (Guide 17): more leads, faster follow-up, lower cost per lead.

PRO TIP

Track one number for the whole system: hours a week your team gets back. Then decide, on purpose, what those hours go to.

WHEN YOU'RE READY FOR AGENTS

When You're Ready for Agents

Agents run the workflow. Your system is what they run on.

An AI agent doesn't just draft. It takes steps on its own: it opens a browser, pulls a report, fills in a form, moves to the next task. Most major AI tools now offer some form of agent (Bootstrap Creative, 2026). Guide 19 covers what agents are and the risks.

Here's the point for this guide: an agent is only as good as the system underneath it. Without a knowledge base, it guesses. Without standing instructions, it doesn't know your rules. Without tested skills and named checkpoints, nobody knows what it did or whether it was right.

You're ready to try an agent on a workflow when you can answer yes to all five:

- ☐ The workflow has run by hand, with skills, for at least a quarter.
- ☐ Every skill in it has an owner and a log, and misses are rare.
- ☐ The knowledge base it reads is current and dated.
- ☐ Every checkpoint has a named person, and the agent stops and waits for them.
- ☐ The agent can't spend money, publish or contact a customer without approval.

Start with a workflow that's low risk and easy to check, like the monthly numbers brief. Keep a person watching closely until it has earned your trust. Then expand, one workflow at a time.

PRO TIP

Automate the work, not the judgment. If you can't write down how a person decides, an agent can't make that decision for you.

BUILD YOUR SYSTEM

Build Your System

Answer these as a team. Then use the AI TIP below to turn your answers into a 90-day build plan.

1. Where is your team on the AI fluency ladder today, honestly? What would have to be true to call it Level 4? [FORM FIELD]
2. Which three tasks does your team repeat most often with AI? Who does each one, and how long does it take? [FORM FIELD]
3. Which knowledge base documents can you build from your field guide answers this month, and who will own each one? [FORM FIELD]
4. Write your five standing instructions: who we are, how we sound, what's true, what stays private, what comes back to a person. [FORM FIELD]
5. Fill in a skill card for your first skill. [FORM FIELD]
6. Which workflow will you build first? List its steps, the skill for each and the checkpoint owner. [FORM FIELD]
7. How will you measure the system: hours saved, and which KPI should move? [FORM FIELD]
8. Who owns the system as a whole, and when will you review it next? [FORM FIELD]

AI TIP

Turn your answers into a 90-day plan

```
Context: Our answers to the Build Your System questions: [paste them]. Our team: [size and roles]. Our AI tools: [list them, and whether they support projects, skills or agents].

Role: Act as an AI operations lead helping a small marketing team build its first AI marketing system.

Ask: Build a 90-day plan to set up our knowledge base, standing instructions, first three skills and first workflow.

Format: A table by two-week sprint: what we build, who owns it, the checkpoint and how we'll know it works. Then the three biggest risks and how to avoid them.

Tighten: Be realistic for a team our size. Keep a person approving anything public, any spend and any customer contact.
```

SOURCES

Sources

- Bootstrap Creative, "ChatGPT vs Claude vs Gemini: Feature & Terminology Map (2026)", accessed Oct 5, 2026. Product names change; check the book's website for the current list.
- [LinkedIn post: "20 Claude Skills for B2B Outbound," Claude Fable. Author, URL and date to add.]

CHOOSING AI

Which tool fits the task?

In this appendix »

Start with the task, not the tool.

— **START WITH THE TASK, NOT THE TOOL**
How to pick AI tools, and the questions to ask

— **KEPT CURRENT ONLINE**
A current list of tools is kept on the book website

Appendix A: Choosing the Right AI

AI tools change every few months. New ones launch, prices change and yesterday's leader falls behind. That's why this appendix doesn't tell you which tool to buy. It tells you how to choose, and the book's page keeps a current list: mikehuber.com/book.

Start with the task, not the tool

Before you compare tools, list the tasks you want help with: drafting blog posts, analyzing campaign data, writing ad variations, summarizing meetings. The right tool is the one that does your tasks well, safely and at a price you can sustain.

Three kinds of AI tools

KIND	WHAT IT DOES	EXAMPLES (AS OF [DATE])
General AI assistants	Research, writing, analysis, planning and most of the AI TIPs in this book	ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Microsoft Copilot
AI built into tools you already use	AI features inside your ad platforms, email and CRM, design and website tools	Google Ads and Meta's AI campaign tools; AI features in HubSpot, Canva and website builders
Specialized tools	One job done well: images, video, voice, transcription, SEO research	Image and video generators, AI note-takers, SEO platforms with AI features

Most small businesses and teams need one general assistant on a business plan, plus the AI already built into the tools they pay for. Start there. Add specialized tools only when a real task calls for one.

Seven questions to ask before you choose

1. **Does it do our tasks well?** Test it on your own work, not the vendor's demo.
2. **What happens to our data?** Does the plan use your inputs to train its models? Where is data stored, and who can see it? Many business plans exclude your data from training by default; check the terms of the plan you're buying.
3. **Does it work for a team?** Shared workspaces, user management, admin controls and the ability to remove someone's access when they leave.
4. **Does it connect to what we use?** Your email, documents, CRM, analytics and ad accounts.
5. **What does it really cost?** Price per user, usage limits and what happens when you hit them.
6. **Can we check its work?** Does it show sources, so you can verify facts?
7. **Can we use what it makes?** Check the terms for commercial use of outputs, and how the vendor handles copyright questions.

Run a bake-off

Pick three real tasks. Run the same CRAFT prompt in two or three tools. Have the people who'll use the tool score the results.

TASK	TOOL	ACCURACY (1–5)	SOUNDS LIKE US (1–5)	EDITS NEEDED (1 = MANY, 5 = FEW)	TIME SAVED (1–5)	TOTAL
[Task 1]	[Tool A]					
[Task 1]	[Tool B]					
[Task 2]	[Tool A]					
[Task 2]	[Tool B]					
[Task 3]	[Tool A]					
[Task 3]	[Tool B]					

↓ AI tool bake-off

PRO TIP

Don't buy ten tools. Every tool adds a login, a bill, a data risk and something else to learn. One good assistant that your whole team uses well beats ten that nobody has mastered.

PRO TIP

Review your tools every quarter, when you review your AI usage policy (Chapter 22). Drop what nobody uses. Test what's new against what you have.

AI TIP

Plan an AI tool test

```
Context: We're a [type of business] with [number] people. We want AI help with: [list of tasks]. We're considering: [tools]. Our sensitive data: [types]. Our budget: [amount per user per month].

Role: Act as a practical technology advisor for small businesses.

Ask: Help me design a fair two-week test of these tools.

Format: (1) Three test tasks drawn from my list, each with a CRAFT prompt we can run in every tool. (2) A scoring table. (3) The data and terms questions to check for each tool before we test. (4) How to decide.

Tighten: Don't recommend a tool. Help me test them fairly. Flag any task that shouldn't use real customer data during the test.
```

GLOSSARY

Glossary.

Terms used in this book, with the chapter where each is covered. AI terms are marked AI.

A/B testing: Comparing two versions of a page, email or ad to see which performs better. Also called split testing. (Ch 14)

ABM (account-based marketing): Targeting specific companies or accounts rather than a broad audience.

AEO (answer engine optimization): AI. Making your content easy for AI tools and search features to find, understand and quote as an answer. See also GEO. (Ch 6)

AI agent: AI. An AI tool that works through a multi-step task on its own toward a goal you set, using other software along the way. (Ch 22)

AI fluency ladder: AI. The book's four levels of AI use: Level 1, not started; Level 2, experimenting; Level 3, using regularly; Level 4, integrated into workflows. (Ch 3)

AI ground rules: AI. The book's five rules: people approve everything public; verify facts; protect data; keep your voice; add what AI can't. (Ch 1)

AI Overviews: AI. AI-generated summaries that appear at the top of some Google search results, with links to sources. (Ch 6)

AI usage policy: AI. A written policy that sets how a team may use AI tools. (Ch 22)

Analytics: Collecting, measuring and interpreting data to make better decisions. (Ch 19)

AOV (average order value): Total revenue divided by the number of orders. (Ch 19)

API (application programming interface): A set of rules that lets different software applications exchange data.

Attribution: Assigning credit for a conversion to the channels and touchpoints that contributed to it. (Ch 19)

B2B / B2C: Business-to-business and business-to-consumer.

BANT: A lead qualification checklist: budget, authority, need, timing. (Ch 16)

Behavioral targeting: Using data about people's online behavior to show them relevant content or ads.

Brand voice: The consistent personality and tone in everything a business writes and says. (Ch 2)

Buyer persona: A semi-fictional profile of an ideal customer, based on research and data, used to guide marketing. (Ch 5)

Call to action (CTA): A specific prompt to take the next step, such as "Request a quote." (Ch 14)

Churn rate: The share of customers who stop buying or cancel in a given period.

CLV (customer lifetime value): The profit a business expects from a customer over the whole relationship. (Ch 19)

CMS (content management system): Software for creating and publishing website content.

Content calendar: A schedule of topics, formats and publishing dates. (Ch 9)

Content marketing: Creating and sharing useful content to attract and keep customers. (Ch 9)

Conversion rate: The percentage of visitors who take a desired action, such as buying or filling out a form. (Ch 14)

CPA, CPC, CPM: Cost per acquisition (or action), cost per click and cost per thousand impressions. (Ch 12)

CRAFT: AI. The book's prompt framework: Context, Role, Ask, Format, Tighten. (Ch 1)

CRM (customer relationship management): Software for managing contacts, leads and customer interactions. (Ch 16)

CRO (conversion rate optimization): Systematically improving pages to raise conversion rates. (Ch 14)

CTR (click-through rate): Clicks divided by impressions. (Ch 7, 12)

Customer journey: The stages a buyer moves through: Awareness, Consideration, Decision, Retention and Advocacy. (Ch 5)

E-E-A-T: Experience, expertise, authoritativeness and trustworthiness: qualities Google's guidelines use to describe helpful, reliable content. (Ch 6)

Effort vs. impact grid: A four-box tool that sorts tactics into quick wins, transformational, momentum and derailers. (Ch 21)

First-party data: Data you collect directly from your customers and visitors, such as email lists and purchase history. (Ch 12, 19)

GA4 (Google Analytics 4): Google's current web analytics platform. (Ch 19)

Generative AI: AI. AI that creates new text, images, audio or video from a prompt.

GEO (generative engine optimization): AI. Improving the chance that AI tools mention and cite your business in their answers. See also AEO. (Ch 6)

Google Business Profile: Your free business listing on Google Search and Maps. (Ch 8)

Google Search Console: Google's free tool that shows how your site performs in search, including queries, clicks and positions. (Ch 6, 7)

Hallucination: AI. When an AI tool states something false as if it were true, including invented facts, quotes or sources. (Ch 1)

Hub and spoke: A content model with one in-depth hub piece and many shorter spokes that link to it. (Ch 10)

Influencer marketing: Working with creators who have an engaged audience to promote your products or services. (Ch 13)

Johari Window: A model of what you and others know about you: Open, Blind spot, Hidden and Unknown. (Ch 22)

KPI (key performance indicator): A measure that shows progress toward a specific goal. (Ch 19)

Landing page: A page built for one campaign, with one focus and one clear call to action. (Ch 14)

Lead generation: Attracting potential customers and capturing their contact information. (Ch 16)

Lead scoring: Assigning points to leads based on fit and behavior to decide who is ready for sales. (Ch 16)

LLM (large language model): AI. The type of AI model behind most AI assistants, trained on large amounts of text to understand and generate language.

Marketing automation: Software that automates repetitive marketing tasks, such as sending emails based on what a lead does. (Ch 16)

MQL / SQL: Marketing qualified lead and sales qualified lead: leads judged ready for more marketing, or ready for a salesperson. (Ch 16)

Native advertising: Paid ads that match the look of the content around them.

OODA loop: Observe, orient, decide, act: a decision cycle for responding quickly to change. (Ch 4)

Organic traffic: Visits from search engines and other sources that you didn't pay for. (Ch 6)

Paid media: Advertising you pay for, such as search, social, display and video ads. (Ch 12)

PPC (pay-per-click): An ad model where you pay each time someone clicks your ad. (Ch 12)

Prompt: AI. The instructions you give an AI tool. (Ch 1)

Prompt library: AI. A shared collection of a team's tested prompts. (Ch 25)

Ranked scoring: A weighted scoring method for prioritizing tactics. (Ch 20)

Remarketing (retargeting): Showing ads to people who have already visited your site or engaged with your brand. (Ch 12)

Responsive design: A website design that adapts to any screen size.

ROAS (return on ad spend): Revenue from ads divided by what you spent on them. (Ch 12, 19)

ROI (return on investment): The gain or loss from an investment relative to its cost. (Ch 19)

Schema markup: Code that labels the content on a page (such as a business, product, review or FAQ) so search engines and AI tools understand it. (Ch 6)

SEO (search engine optimization): Improving your site and content to earn visibility in search results. (Ch 6)

Social media marketing: Using social platforms to reach, engage and build relationships with your audience. (Ch 13)

Striking distance: Keywords where you rank in positions 4 to 20: close enough that improving the page can move you up. (Ch 7)

SWOT analysis: A review of strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats. (Ch 4)

Target audience: The specific group of people a business wants to reach. (Ch 2, 5)

Three Horizons: A model for balancing today's business, emerging opportunities and future bets, made widely known by McKinsey. McKinsey's 2026 three horizons of AI transformation (enablement, automation, reinvention) describe how deeply AI changes the work. (Ch 21)

UX (user experience): How easy and satisfying a website, app or product is to use. (Ch 14)

Video marketing: Using video to promote, educate and build trust. (Ch 11)

Zero-click search: A search that ends without a click to any website, because the answer appears on the results page. (Ch 6)

RESOURCES

Every tool, kept current.

Tools change faster than print, so the Resources guide lives online.

The tools we've referred to in this book, organized by discipline, are listed on the book's page. Most offer a free version or a free trial. We don't receive anything for listing them. Tools change, so we keep the list online, where it stays current: mikehuber.com/book.

Get the complete resource bundle free at mikehuber.com/book: the companion workbook, templates and printables from every chapter, plus the Resources guide. Fill in a short form and the download is yours. [DOWNLOAD: resource bundle, hosted on mikehuber.com behind the form]

↓ **Resources guide and resource bundle at mikehuber.com/book**

WORK WITH US

Need help with your transformation?

Do it yourself, or bring in help for the parts that matter most.

This book is built so you can do the work yourself. Some teams want help along the way: someone to run the planning sessions, train the team or work alongside them through the first stages.

Mike Huber and Loren Ankarlo combine marketing strategy with the human dynamics of change. Bring them in for strategic planning and alignment, AI adoption and skills training, team coaching, customer journey and sales alignment, search, content and paid media strategy, performance measurement, or support through your first 90 days. Facilitated sessions and consulting turn the tools in this field guide into priorities, clear responsibilities and a plan your team can carry out.

Choose a focused workshop, a facilitated planning session or a consulting engagement. Mike brings marketing strategy and execution; Loren brings organizational change, facilitation and team development.

01

Turn your strategy into a roadmap for growth

Facilitated strategy and planning. Align leaders on goals, use SWOT and the OODA loop to pressure-test decisions, and rank the work by effort and impact. Take away a strategy on a page, a prioritized roadmap and named owners. Chapters 2, 4, 20 and 21.

02

Turn AI resistance into team confidence

Change management and leadership coaching. Surface concerns about roles and quality, explore change styles, and involve people in redesigning the work. Take away a communication plan, a learning plan and clear adoption milestones. Chapters 1 and 22.

03

Put AI to work for your marketing team

Practical AI marketing workshops. Assess fluency, practice the CRAFT prompt framework on real assignments, and define how people review the output. Take away tested prompts, a shared prompt library, draft AI usage rules and a marketing compliance checklist. Chapters 1, 3, 22 and 23.

04

Build a team that delivers

Team development and executive facilitation. Clarify roles, strengthen feedback, work through conflict and improve meetings. Take away a team working agreement, a decision process and a meeting rhythm with visible accountability. Chapter 22.

05

Turn buyer interest into sales opportunities

Customer journey, retention and sales alignment. Connect awareness, consideration and decision to retention, referrals and advocacy; improve lead nurture and sales handoffs. Take away a journey map, a handoff agreement and a prioritized conversion plan. Chapters 5, 14, 15, 16, 18 and 21.

06

Get found and build trust where buyers look

Search, content and paid media strategy. Connect buyer questions to SEO, AI search, local visibility, paid media, useful content and video. Take away a topic map, a publishing and promotion plan and a quality checklist your team can use. Chapters 6 through 12.

07

Make every marketing dollar work harder

Marketing performance consulting. Choose meaningful measures across paid media and every other channel, score competing initiatives and review what to continue, change or stop. Take away a KPI scorecard, a ranked investment list and a quarterly review agenda. Chapters 12, 19 and 20.

08

Build momentum in your first 90 days

Implementation coaching and fractional consulting. Translate the roadmap into weekly commitments, remove roadblocks and coach the people responsible for delivery. Take away a 90-day action plan, progress checkpoints and the next quarter's priorities. Chapters 21 and 24.

Start a conversation: marketingfieldguide.ai/contact.

Stay current. AI tools and platforms change every month. Sign up for the monthly newsletter at mikehuber.com/book for updates to the AI tools list, new examples and what's changed since this book went to print.

The book's page: mikehuber.com/book. The companion workbook and resource bundle (free with a short form), the current AI tools list, the Resources guide and the newsletter sign-up are all there.

BACK COVER (DRAFT)

Business Transformation Through AI-Powered Marketing

The Field Guide for Small Businesses and Marketing Teams

You think. AI drafts. You decide.

Most small businesses and marketing teams have tried AI. Few have built it into the way they work. This book closes that gap.

It's a field guide, not a lecture. Each chapter covers one part of your marketing: strategy, content, SEO and AI search, paid media, social media, email and marketing automation, video, website conversion, local SEO and reviews, and analytics. You read it, fill in the forms, then use ready-to-run AI prompts to turn your answers into a plan your team can act on.

Inside:

- 112 AI prompts built on the CRAFT framework, ready to copy with your details
- SWOT, ranked scoring and a six-stage roadmap to decide what to do first
- How to get found, and cited, in AI search
- An AI usage policy template and tools to lead your team through change
- A real case study: a boutique pool builder repositioned, rebuilt and relaunched with AI
- A free companion workbook that does the math: mikehuber.com/book

Mike Huber has more than 25 years of experience in marketing and advertising and is the lead author of *The Customer Journey*. **Loren Ankarlo** To come: has 35+ years of experience leading organizational change and has worked with 37 of the Fortune 50. Loren to confirm.

To come: endorsement from Colonel (Ret.) Mike Santacroce, USMC